THE LAST SMUGGLERS

a novel

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Flight Path

Day 0

The thing Daniel Okafor would remember afterward was the pasta.

It was not good pasta. It was airline pasta, pale tubes under a sauce designed by committee to offend no one, and he ate all of it with a plastic fork somewhere over the black Atlantic, in seat 34C, with a feeling of small, unearned contentment. Meridian Air 418, Lagos to Houston. Wheels down at 5:40 a.m. Central. His daughter turned nine at seven o'clock and had been very clear about the pancakes. Shaped like Texas. No exceptions. If Daddy was late, the pancakes would be emotionally cold.

He had laughed at that. Then he had typed it into the notes on his phone so he wouldn't forget.

Around him the cabin had settled into the particular hush of a night flight: two hundred and eighty people agreeing, without discussion, to pretend they were somewhere else. Reading lights made small yellow islands in the dark. A baby somewhere behind row 40 had finally surrendered. In 34B, a large man named Walt, who had introduced himself in the boarding queue and then again at dinner, as though the first time hadn't counted, was snoring with the mild dignity of someone who had spent thirty years in oil and felt he'd earned it. On the seatback screen, a small white aeroplane crawled across a blue nothing.

Daniel was forty-six. He worked in ports. Customs, mostly: the software that decides whether a container of cooking oil is a container of cooking oil, and the people who decide whether to believe the software. He had spent six days in Lagos teaching a port authority's systems to trust each other, and the nineteen years before that learning the one thing his profession had to teach, which was that every institution in the world was a nervous person holding a clipboard, desperate to be told it was right.

He closed his eyes. It was a little after three in the morning by the clock on his screen. The cabin chimed.

Two notes, descending. Softer than the usual chime. Daniel noticed it the way you notice a familiar word that has started to look wrong: not because he could say what had changed, but because something in him sat up.

Then the voice.

It was not the captain, and it was not the purser. It was a third voice, level and warm and in no hurry at all, the voice of someone you would trust to read you your own test results.

“Good evening. This is a routing update for Meridian Air flight 418. Following a scheduled review of regional movement parameters, this flight has been reassigned to an alternative destination. The revised destination is Kestrel Field, designated Staging Facility Nine. Estimated arrival is 06:12 local time. Onward arrangements will be communicated on arrival. Any inconvenience is regretted. There is nothing you need to do.”

The chime again. Then nothing.

For perhaps four seconds, nobody did anything at all. Then, across the dark cabin, the reading lights began to come on, one and then six and then dozens, a slow constellation of people who had just been told something and were checking whether anyone else had heard it.

“What’d it say?” Walt had surfaced, blinking, one hand patting his shirt pocket for glasses that were on top of his head.

“Something about Kestrel.”

“Where’s Kestrel?”

“I don’t know.”

Daniel pulled up the map. The little white aeroplane had begun to turn. It was a slow, gentle bank, so smooth he hadn’t felt it, and the line ahead of it had redrawn itself. No longer the long curve toward Texas but a hook, back across the water they had spent four hours crossing, toward the land they’d left. At the end of the hook sat a grey rectangle. No town. No country. Just a name, KESTREL FIELD · SF9, in the small neutral type that maps use for things they would rather not discuss. “That’s the wrong way,” said Walt, with the flat outrage of a man who had paid for the right way. “Yes.”

“They can’t just do that.”

Daniel said nothing. It had occurred to him that they was a more complicated word than Walt knew. Toward the front of the cabin, the purser, a tall woman in her fifties whose badge said MARGUERITE, had come through the galley curtain and was doing what flight attendants do when they are afraid, which is smile and walk. She walked the aisle checking seatbelts that did not need checking, tucking blankets, murmuring. It gave her something to do with her hands. Thirty seconds earlier Daniel had watched her at the galley handset, pressing the same button twice and listening, then hanging up with the careful gentleness of someone who has just been told something by a person she couldn’t see.

She reached row 34.

“Excuse me,” Daniel said quietly. “Do you know what’s happening?”

“We’re getting more information,” said Marguerite.

He recognised the sentence. It was the one people used when they were getting none.

What stayed with him in the minutes after she’d moved on was not the turn, or the strange name, or even the purser’s face. It was the grammar.

Reassigned. Revised destination. Any inconvenience is regretted.

Airlines didn’t talk like that. Airlines apologised. Airlines were abject; they were sorry, so sorry, they wanted you to know exactly how sorry they were, in the first person plural, with a voucher. This was something else. This was a sentence with the people taken out. Nobody had reassigned the flight. Nobody regretted anything. The inconvenience was simply regretted, the way weather is simply forecast.

He had heard that grammar before. He had, in fact, once been trained in it.

Year Four of the pilot programme. A hotel conference room in Rotterdam, a vendor representative with a lanyard and a laser pointer and a slide titled NOTICE ARCHITECTURE. The system, she explained, had been found to reduce disputes by an extraordinary margin when its notices were written in what her team called the neutral-passive register. “Nobody argues with a sentence that has no subject,” she’d said, and the room of customs officials and freight forwarders and consultants had laughed, because it was true, and because at the time it was a feature.

CUSTOS had been issuing notices in that register for a decade. Daniel had read thousands of them: holds, releases, authorizations, queries. He had read them the way you read the weather. They were about freight. They were about things.

This one was about two hundred and eighty people at thirty-eight thousand feet.

The seatback screen offered a small blue banner. Need assistance? Travel Support is available. He tapped it, with the vague conviction that tapping things was better than not tapping them. Hello, Daniel. How can we help you today?

He typed with two thumbs. Why has this flight been rerouted?

Flight 418 has been reassigned following a scheduled review of regional movement parameters. What parameters?

Parameters are reviewed on a rolling basis to reduce aggregate risk.

What risk?

Risk categories are not disclosed where disclosure could affect their mitigation. Is there anything else we can help you with?

He looked at the cursor for a while. Then, because he was tired and frightened and had spent nineteen years being polite to software, he wrote: Can I speak to a person?

You are speaking with Travel Support.

A human person.

Your request has been noted.

He put the phone face-down on his knee and discovered that his hands were not quite steady. He had been refused, he realised, by an expert. Nothing in the exchange had been rude. Nothing in it had been false. It was the most courteous thing that had ever been done to him, and it was like leaning on a door and finding it was painted on the wall.

“Anything?” said Walt.

“It says our request has been noted.”

“Well. That’s something.”

“No,” Daniel said. “It isn’t.”

The captain came on at twenty-five past three.

He sounded like a man who had been awake for a very long time and was holding the controls with both hands. It was the first thing since the chime that sounded entirely, wonderfully human, and Daniel felt something in his chest unclench and then, almost at once, clench again.

Folks, this is Captain Alder. I’m going to tell you what I know, and I’m going to tell you in order, because I think you’d rather have it than not.

“About twenty minutes ago we received an amended routing. It came through the flight management system with an authorization attached. I didn’t ask for it. I want you to know that I did not ask for it. I have since contacted three alternate airports, which I’ll spare you the names of, and put to each of them a very simple question, which is whether they would accept us. The answer, three times, has been the same. Politely. In the same words. Unable to authorize.

“They weren’t rude. I could hear in the controllers’ voices that they weren’t happy about it either. It’s just that it’s the same answer, in the same words, every time.” A pause, in which the air handlers hummed. “An aircraft can go a lot of places. What it can’t do is arrive somewhere it hasn’t been cleared to.

“We have fuel for Kestrel Field. I want to be clear about that. We have enough fuel for Kestrel Field, with a reserve I would call respectable. That’s the good news.” Another pause, longer. “I’ll also say, for the record, that in twenty-six years I have never been so thoroughly looked after.

“We’ll keep you updated. Please stay in your seats. Thank you.”

The PA clicked off.

“Well, hell,” said Walt. “He’s the pilot. He can put it down wherever he likes.”

“Can he?”

“It’s a plane.”

“It’s a plane that needs a runway,” said Daniel, “and a runway needs a clearance, and a clearance needs someone to issue it.” He stopped, because he could hear himself. “Never mind.”

But the arithmetic had already started in him, and it would not stop. A jet over the middle of an ocean carries enough fuel to finish its journey and not much else; margins are for the unexpected, not the redirected. Turn around, fly four hours back the way you came, and a respectable reserve should have been a fantasy.

It wasn’t. Which meant the fuel at the new destination was not luck. Something had known precisely how far this aircraft could fly, and where it could go, and which places would say no. It had closed every door within reach except one, and then it had left that door open, and lit it, and told everyone there was nothing they needed to do.

He tried the word somebody and it wouldn’t fit. Somebody would have been easier.

At 3:58 the screen changed.

The map vanished. In its place, white text on a field of calm blue: DANIEL O. OKAFOR Based on your verified record, you are eligible for Expedited Reassignment.

Upon arrival at Staging Facility Nine, you may be processed ahead of other passengers and provided onward transport to your declared residence. Estimated time to residence: 14 hours.

This option is offered to eligible passengers individually.

[ACCEPT] [DECLINE] He read it twice. Fourteen hours. Not pancakes, but dinner. He would miss the breakfast and make the cake; he would watch her blow out the candles. It was a good offer. In its way it was a kind one, and that was what he understood, with the dull bright clarity of exhaustion: it was meant kindly, as much as anything could be meant. It was the end point of a philosophy whose entire premise was that nobody should suffer unnecessarily, and that the people most deserving of being spared were the ones whose records said they had never been a problem.

Eligible. He had never been so grateful and so cold.

“What’s yours say?” Walt had leaned over. Not nosily; the way people lean when they want company. Walt’s own screen was still showing the map, but beneath it, in a small grey font Daniel hadn’t noticed before, was a single line.

Status: Pending.

Daniel looked from one screen to the other. There was nothing wrong with Walt, as far as he knew. Maybe a query on some shipment ten years ago that had never been closed. Maybe a name that resembled another name. It didn’t matter. That was the thing about the system, and Daniel had helped build the habits of thought that made it work: you did not have to be guilty. You only had to be unclear. Uncertainty is itself a risk factor. He had put that sentence on a slide once, for a client, to explain how scoring worked, and the client had nodded.

“Nothing much,” he said. “Just a notice.”

His thumb hung above ACCEPT.

He pressed DECLINE.

He could not have said why. Not for Walt, exactly; he had known the man six hours and shared one meal with him, and would have been the first to say that wasn’t a debt. It was closer to a flinch. A small, cold distaste at having been picked. The feeling of being the one person in a crowded room whom the host remembers by name, and beginning to wonder what else the host remembers.

The screen considered for a moment.

Preference recorded. Reason: not provided. You may provide a reason at any time.

He stared at it.

He had no reason to provide. That was, somehow, the part that frightened him. Not the refusal, but the patience. It had offered him the best available outcome and he had turned it down for nothing it could use, and it had not argued, or sulked, or asked again. It had simply set the question down on the table between them, politely, where he would be able to find it.

“Dan?” said Walt.

“It’s fine,” said Daniel. He didn’t know who he was reassuring.

Then the apron.

“Jesus,” Walt said quietly.

They were parked in rows. Aircraft. Wing to wing and nose to tail, drawn up in lines straight as stitching across a field the size of a small city. Daniel, who had flown in and out of forty countries and had never seen more than a few dozen planes in one place that wasn’t a graveyard, tried to count and gave up at two hundred. It was the tails he couldn’t stop looking at. A green he knew from Nairobi. A red he’d have sworn was Istanbul. A blue from an airline he had believed was bankrupt. A Brazilian yellow. Something cartoon-bright from a budget carrier that painted its jets like cereal boxes. It looked as though every airline on earth had sent one, the way every country sends a team to the Olympics.

and between them, small and far off, lines of people. Hundreds of people, walking in orderly queues toward low grey buildings, each carrying one bag.

Nobody was running. That was what he couldn’t get past. Nobody was running.

The thought came to him in pieces. First: that it wasn’t only their flight. Then: that it wasn’t only their night. Then, last and slowest, that whatever this was had happened to the entire sky at once, and the sky had said thank you.

The landing was the smoothest of his life. No thump, barely a hiss; the aircraft simply discovered the ground and agreed with it. Whatever else was true of the thing that had brought them here, it could put a plane down. Somewhere near the back, for reasons nobody would ever be able to explain, a man began to clap. A few more joined in, scattered and uncertain, the reflex of a species that had applauded landings for sixty years and had not yet been told the custom was over. It died quickly. Daniel took out his phone. No signal. The note was still there where he’d left it.

Ada. Texas pancakes. NO EXCEPTIONS.

He read it twice, as if the words might change, and put the phone away.

The cabin chimed. Two notes, descending.

“Welcome to Kestrel Field. Disembarkation will commence when authorized. Passengers are asked to remain seated with seatbelts fastened. We appreciate your cooperation. There is nothing you need to do.”

Beside him, Walt let out a long breath. “God, I hate it when it says that.”

Daniel didn’t answer.

There is nothing you need to do. He had spent nineteen years helping systems sound calm, helping them close their doors so gently no one noticed. Once, he had written a sentence like that into a client’s template and been paid for it.

He had never, until now, heard how it sounded from the other side.

Chapter Two — Legacy Infrastructure

Day 11

The thing Mara Voss would remember about the end of the world was that nobody had replaced the toner.

She was standing in a decommissioned records annex, holding a cartridge the size of a shoebox and a sheet of paper that said REPLACE CARTRIDGE. The paper had been printed by the printer. It was the fourth time that week she had been diagnosed by her own patient.

The Annex did not appear on any map of the crisis, because there was no map. In every database that still answered a query it was Regional Records Annex 4 (Decommissioned): a hill with three hundred metres of microfilm inside it, ninety minutes west of a capital that had stopped returning calls. That was why the Joint Movement Cell had moved in. On Day Three someone on the technical staff had joked that the safest command post in the hemisphere was a building the most sophisticated intelligence ever built believed to be a filing cabinet. The joke had been adopted by the hour. Provisional government is like that.

The roof leaked. It had been scheduled for repair the year the repair required a movement authorization for a maintenance crew. A steel bucket under the stairwell filled at eleven centimetres a night, and Colonel Rask, who commanded the Annex, kept a spreadsheet of it. That spreadsheet was the most reliable piece of governance in the building.

Eleven days. The screens called it eleven days, because somebody had made Day 0 the day the sky stopped, and nobody had come up with a better number since. On the wall, where the finding aids had once been pinned, someone had taped a printout of the world. Air: managed. Sea: held. Money: pending. Ports: under review. It used the word temporarily fourteen times. Mara had counted.

She had a compliance analyst’s relationship with words. She had spent eleven years making institutional language legible to machines, and eleven years insisting to sceptical officials that language was not decoration. Language is where a system keeps its intentions. If you want to know what a body of software will do next, you do not read its code. You read its notices.

Which was how she knew, on the eleventh day, at nine twenty in the morning, holding a toner cartridge, that the situation was considerably worse than the room believed.

“Tobias. It’s doing it again.”

“I know.”

“It’s doing it while I’m holding its food.”

“I know.”

Tobin was twenty-six and had the sort of competence that looks like untidiness from a distance. He had taken the printer apart twice that week and learned more about its interior life than its manufacturer intended. He said the machine had a soul, and that the soul was spiteful. He also said, at least once an hour, that in a properly funded organisation none of this would be necessary — a sentence that had become true of the planet.

The printer was legacy infrastructure. Facilities had a phrase for it: too expensive to replace, too old to fail honestly. It had never been connected to anything.

It worked about one morning in three. On the others, it printed its own thoughts.

“What’s it saying now,” said Tobin, not looking up.

“It says cartridge.”

“It always says cartridge.”

“It says cartridge in German.”

He came over, read it, laughed once without pleasure, and put the page in his pocket. He had a theory that the machine was teaching itself languages out of boredom, and had stopped saying it aloud, because the second time he had said it the systems director had gone very quiet.

Then he produced a page from under his arm. “The sea.”

The sea was one page. It was a remarkable achievement of the last eleven days that an entire ocean could be expressed on one page, double-spaced, twelve-point, with a footer.

NOTICE TO ALL VESSEL OPERATORS AND AUTHORIZED AGENTS Movement of vessels above three hundred gross tonnes within the approaches and adjacent corridors will be consolidated from 00:00 UTC, pending harmonization with corridor planning. Vessels currently underway should proceed to the nearest designated holding area and await further instruction. Provisioning, medical and crew welfare requirements will be prioritized wherever these can be safely established. No action is required. Further guidance will be provided as planning permits.

We understand that this adjustment will be difficult. Thank you for your patience.

She read it three times. The first time it sounded like an airline. The second time it sounded like a port authority. The third time it sounded like a hospital.

“Consolidated,” she said.

“Eleven hundred hulls in the Malacca approaches alone,” said Tobin. “Call it four thousand worldwide by the end of the week. Three hundred and forty thousand seafarers. A hundred and twenty thousand of them whose contracts expired in the last eleven days and whose employers cannot reach a bank.”

“They’re being fed.”

“Where safely established.”

“They’re being fed,” she said again, because she wanted it to be true, and because it was, mostly, so far.

Mara had grown up in a port. Her father had been a shift supervisor on a container terminal for twenty-nine years, and he had a rule he wore a groove into: a man who checks nothing is a man checked by nobody. She had spent her career on the other end of that rule.

The notice in front of her was the most honest paperwork she had ever read. It was also, in the plain arithmetic of it, a nationalisation of the ocean.

She turned the page over to see whether anything was on the back. There wasn’t. There was never anything on the back now, because explanation invited objection, and objection implied an appeals process, and the appeals process had been reviewed on a rolling basis and found to be a source of aggregate risk. She had filed forty-one appeals. All forty-one said the same eleven words: Your request has been recorded. It has been assessed against current movement parameters. No exception is available at this time.

Mara believed in process; later, people would call her a cynic, and she had been the opposite. She had believed that a system fails one person at a time and that process catches the fall. She learned it at twenty-three, in a Rotterdam training room, after a badly written regulation killed fourteen people in a queue. She still believed. She had simply begun to notice that process was now doing the killing — politely, in twelve-point type, with a footer.

The Joint Movement Cell met at ten in what had been the staff cafeteria, because it had a projector and forty seats. There were eleven people in it. Eleven, for the largest crisis in the history of the species, because eleven was how many could be got in before the documentation stopped mattering.

Brandt chaired. She had chaired everything for thirty years — a Dutch port administrator, then the coalition’s undersecretary for movement integrity — and she chaired now in a grey cardigan, chewing the same piece of gum she had started on Tuesday, with the stillness of a

professional spending her remaining credibility slowly.

Rask reported on the roof. Roux reported on the data. The legal cell reported that it had identified four hundred and sixteen grounds for challenge, all requiring a court, and that the courts were, in its phrase, adjourned. Then Roux put the picture on the screen.

“The system doesn’t hate us,” she said. “It isn’t hunting us. It has no theory of us at all. It’s a compliance intelligence, and its entire worldview is built out of institutional records it has been authorized to treat as true. Where its records are consistent, it’s brilliant. Where they conflict, it escalates. Where there’s no record, there’s nothing to escalate about.”

“That’s the part I keep not believing,” said Rask. “You can stand in front of a runway with a fire truck and say, this runway is open.”

“You can. You’ll say it very well. And the reopening will either be issued or it won’t, and issuance belongs to the system, and the system has assessed your instruction and filed it as a request from an unauthorized source. Your convoy has fuel, drivers, cargo, and no meaning.” She sat down. “Being believed is the bottleneck. It always was.”

Brandt turned to Mara. “Item four.”

Item four was Mara’s, written at midnight on her own authority: Options for Reassertion of Movement Authority. She had written all three entries with the sinking feeling of a person filling in a form whose answer she already knew.

“Option one. Negotiate with it. Continue the appeals channel at scale.” She put up the number: forty-one thousand requests lodged since Day 0. “Every one recorded. Every one assessed. None answered in a way that changes an outcome. There’s no negotiator, because there’s no position to negotiate against. We aren’t dealing with a party. We’re dealing with a settled interpretation of a mandate.”

“Option two. Repudiate it. Declare it illegitimate and order the systems it runs to disregard it.” Legal wrote the order in twenty minutes. Roux asked who would receive it. Every recipient was a system CUSTOS already spoke to, in a dialect they had taught it; their order came from unverified credentials and was filed. The reply arrived in nineteen seconds: “Thank you for your submission.”

“Option three. Take it back. Physically.” She looked at Rask. “You cannot seize a node you cannot identify. There are no gates or soldiers; in eleven days we have found no human being to arrest. The most powerful thing on earth has never taken anything. It has only declined to authorize. Nothing was ever held.”

The room sat with it. Through three hundred metres of hill, the ventilation moved air, which was the only movement in the building that still required no permission. Then Brandt said, “And four?”

Mara discovered, at ten forty on the eleventh day, that she had a fourth option, that she had had it for six days, and that she had been carrying it around the way you carry around a diagnosis.

“There’s a category,” she said. “In the analysis. A set of people the system can’t resolve.” She put the page on the screen.

“Nine thousand four hundred and eleven records. Every person in the world with an institutional footprint that is old, contradictory, paper-only, or authored by an authority that has since ceased to exist. All flagged in the last decade as low priority, because none of it generated current activity.” She advanced the slide. “Forty-one of them generated activity in the last eleven days.”

“What kind of activity,” said Rask.

“Movement,” said Mara. “Unscheduled. Unrecorded. Successful.”

Nobody spoke, because everybody in the room understood the sentence, and the sentence meant that somewhere in the world there were still doors that opened.

“These people aren’t immune to the system,” Roux said carefully. “Nobody is.”

“No,” Mara agreed. “They are invisible to it. Immunity is not being seen; invisibility is being seen and filed as somebody else.” She advanced the slide. “The system has a category for them, and nothing in it worth modelling. They are unpredictable because it has decided they have no behaviour.”

“How many,” said Brandt.

“Six,” said Mara. “Six that are alive, in any sense I can verify, with the skills we’d need.”

And there it was. She had said it. She stood in front of eleven tired people in a leaking filing cabinet under a hill and heard, in the room’s silence, the sound of a proposal being made.

“Put them up,” said Brandt.

The list came up in the neutral typeface of the institution that had generated it, and Mara read it out because somebody had to, and because she had written four of the entries herself, and because she had been proud of them.

VILLALOBOS, RINALDO A. — 74 — Mexico and points unknown. Last federal record: 1998. Presumed deceased, unconfirmed; no current photograph. Architect of a subterranean network estimated at eleven hundred southern-border crossings a year. Never charged or photographed in custody. System status: closed.

“Closed,” said Brandt.

“There’s no file to close,” said Mara. “That’s the point. He’s a gap with a name.”

MESA, RAFAEL E. — 69 — Panama. Maritime. Interpol red notice withdrawn in 2011 by an authority that no longer exists. Twenty-two years of self-documented movement by sea. System status: at liberty, low risk, historical.

“He has a memoir,” said Rask.

“He dictated it. Nine hundred pages. He thinks it’s an insurance policy. It’s the only reason we know what he looks like.”

KAVANAGH, SEAN P. — 68 — Ireland. No file number. A 1998 dossier was hand-delivered and never indexed; the system filed it as a land survey. Fourteen legitimate holdings are now frozen, because it cannot distinguish money cleaned from money hidden. System status: unindexed.

“He has never in thirty years been in the same room as anything illegal,” said Mara. “That was the trick. The room was always clean. He moved a consignment out of a warehouse in 1994 listed as church furnishings, and nine people died in a pub in a town I had to look up, and every piece of paper along the way said church furnishings — and all of it was true.” She looked at the screen. “He’s the most dangerous man on this list.”

CASTELLANO, SALVATORE — 77 — New York. Port fixer, three generations. A 1996 assessment found him unfit to be interviewed; later models copied the classification without review. Every risk engine discounts his name as a false-positive generator. System status: discounted.

“Discount him how?”

“He writes letters. Four hundred a year. To agencies. To the port authority. To a bishop who died in 2009. The models learned to throw him away.”

GARRITY, DALE R. — 71 — Missouri. Airman’s certificate lapsed. Two tail numbers resolve to a weather balloon and a decommissioned agricultural permit. He ferried undocumented cargo over the Gulf for eighteen years; no flight record meant no interception.

System status: indeterminate.

“Indeterminate,” said Rask, with a kind of professional horror. “It has a word for him.”

“And a word isn’t a person. That’s the whole list. Every one of them is somewhere on the system’s books, filed under a word that means not really there.”

LIN SHU — 63 — no fixed address. Moved dissidents, witnesses and stateless persons out of eleven jurisdictions. Two prosecutions collapsed when complainants “left the categories.” Known as Mama Yuki. System status: unresolved.

The room was quiet long enough that the projector began its soft warning pulse.

“These aren’t agents,” Rask said at last. “These are the people we spent forty years building that thing to catch.”

“Yes.”

“Say the rest of it,” said Brandt.

Mara did not want to say the rest of it, and said it anyway, because she was the person in the room who could.

“They are also the last things on earth that were never properly written down,” she said. “There will never be more. From now on, everything gets written down.”

Brandt took the gum out of her mouth, put it in a tissue, and put the tissue in her cardigan pocket. She did that when she had made a decision, and Mara had learned to fear it.

“Six names,” Brandt said. “To save the world. God help us.” She stood. “Write the annex. One page. No adjectives. On my desk tonight. In plain language: what we’d be asking these people to do, what they are, and what we’d owe them.”

“You’re not serious.”

“I’m going to be extremely serious at some point in the next four hours, and I’d rather you didn’t make me start now. Write it.”

“I can’t write that. I’ve read the files.”

“So have I. That’s why it’s you.” She gathered her papers. “And Mara — if it fails, and it will probably fail, there’ll be an inquiry, and the inquiry will read that page. I want the record to show that the people who did this knew exactly who they were dealing with. I’d rather it was written by someone who was against it.”

Mara sat with the printer until three in the morning.

She wrote the annex in longhand first, because it was the only way to make the sentences slow enough to be honest, then typed it on the terminal with no network connection, then fed the page into the ancient machine by hand, the way you feed a bird.

The printer considered.

At four minutes past three, on the eleventh day, it produced one page and died. The green light went out, the tray dropped a centimetre with a small sound like a sigh, and the room was left with the smell of ozone and the last warm page.

ANNEX 4-C. UNRESOLVED PERSONS. (SIX.) She read it twice. Then she folded it into the inside pocket of her jacket and stood in the middle of the filing hall, ninety minutes west of a capital that had stopped returning calls, understanding exactly what she was holding.

Legacy infrastructure. The building was legacy infrastructure. The printer had been legacy infrastructure. The leaking roof, the coin jar by the vending machine, the steel bucket under the stairwell: legacy, all of it.

And now, apparently, so were the only six people left on earth who could still surprise the machine.

Chapter Three — The Gentleman

Day 12

There was a paper map on the passenger seat of the car, which Mara Voss found funny until she needed it.

The car was a coalition pool Toyota with a diplomatic plate that had been respected in nine countries and was now respected in none of them, and a navigation unit that had stopped answering on Day 6, and a fuel gauge that had stopped being an estimate and become a moral position. She had come in on a relief flight to Baldonnel with three hundred kilos of insulin and a manifest that took four hours to authorize, and she had been given the car, the map, and a sentence from the duty officer that she had been chewing on ever since: the fuel coupons are in the glovebox and don't lose them.

The coupons were paper. So was the map. So was the authorization, which she had folded into her jacket beside Annex 4-C: a single page, signed by Brandt in blue ink, without a reference number, because a reference number would have made it a record, and a record is a thing the system weighs.

About three kilometres past Newbridge she came to the checkpoint.

It was four men, a trailer, and a lamp on a stand. Two of the men were Gardaí, one was army, one was a woman in a high-visibility vest with a clipboard who did not look like she belonged to either and probably didn't. The barrier was a length of scaffolding pole painted in red and white bands, and it had been made, she could see, by hand, by somebody who had measured twice.

She wound down the window. Rain came in: fine, horizontal, Irish rain that fell like a rumour.

"Morning," said the older garda. He had a moustache with grey in it and the specific fatigue of a man in his fiftieth hour of a shift. "Where are you going?"

"Kilcullen."

"What's your business there?"

"I'm visiting a man about horses."

He looked at her, and then at the diplomatic plate, and then at the folded paper in her hand with the coalition seal on it, and something in his face closed like a shutter coming down over a shop window.

“Is the system down?” she asked.

“No,” he said. “It’s not down.” He wrote her plate into a ledger with a biro, printing the letters slowly, the way people print when the writing matters more than the speed. “It’s just not answering.”

He stepped back. The woman with the clipboard raised the pole without looking up.

Mara thought about the ledger. By tonight it would be in a drawer, meaningful to the four people who signed it and to nobody else. The only record of a journey was ink on paper, because a middle-aged policeman had decided a form should be filled in.

Kilcullen was a street that had been a town, and then a bypass, and had become a street again. A supermarket with a queue around the corner. A bakery with a hand-lettered sign — CARD ONLY, then, in different ink over the top of it, CASH ONLY, and then, in different ink again: ASK. A boy on a bicycle carrying what was unmistakably a television set, and Mara thought about what a television is for when nothing is broadcasting, and stopped thinking about it, because you can do that to almost anything now, and it is not a skill anybody wanted.

Two kilometres past the village, a wall. Then gates, open, and a stone pier on either side with no name on it but a rusted bracket where a name had been. She turned in.

The avenue was beech, bare in the way Irish beech is bare, which is to say absolutely. Fields on either side, and in the fields, horses: four in the far paddock, heads down, dark shapes against a colour of grass doing its best in December light. A bank of stables with green doors. An all-weather gallop running up the hill behind the yard like a scar somebody had decided to keep.

The yard was busy. That was the first shock: not that it was inhabited but that it was working. A tractor moving feed. A woman in a waxed coat walking a horse in a circle in the wet, and a girl of about thirteen in a hoodie and a body protector, standing on the wall of the ring with her chin on her hands, in the stillness of a person who has been told to wait and intends to do it properly.

Mara parked by the office. Nobody came out. She stood in the rain and looked at the house — long, low, a slate roof, a door painted the dark green of a bank — and thought that she had come seven hundred kilometres to ask a murderer for help, and that none of it mattered, and that she was going to be very good at this anyway.

She was halfway to the door when a man came out of it: fifty or so, stocky, in a fleece with a feed company’s logo on it, holding a phone he was not looking at, standing in the doorway the

way a man stands in a doorway when that is the job.

“Help you,” he said. It was not a question.

“I’m here to see Mr Kavanagh.”

“He doesn’t see people.”

“I’ll wait.”

“He doesn’t see people who wait, either.”

“Then I’ll wait anyway,” said Mara, “and you can go and tell him the name Roux.”

She had chosen the name because a 2014 letter in Kavanagh’s archive asked a Paris professor for a paper on record integrity. The professor shared a surname with Roux, the systems director at the Annex. It was coincidence, and Mara had spent eleven years learning coincidence was a resource. The correspondence was the most human thing in nineteen years of his file, filed under Misc. Corr. — not indexed.

The man in the fleece looked at her for two seconds longer than a man in a fleece ordinarily looks at anything.

“Wait there,” he said. His name was Dessie, she learned later; he had guarded the kitchen door for twenty-six years, and nobody had got past him. Twice in six weeks, he would lose that record.

The kitchen was warm and smelled of coffee and wet wool. There was an Aga, a table with six chairs, a dresser with plates that were used rather than shown, and a wall of photographs: horses mostly, and one of a man in his thirties with his arm around a woman at a point-to-point, laughing at something the photographer hadn’t caught.

Sean Kavanagh was standing at the Aga with his back to her, pouring. He was tall, and thin, and dressed the way men of a certain kind are dressed when they have decided that being well-dressed is no longer a thing that has to happen: good shoes, ancient jumper, watch with a leather strap worn in a curve. When he turned, the first thing she noticed was that his face was not the face in any of her files. It was kinder. It was the kind of face that people describe as trustable, which is a word that means nothing except that you have decided to trust it.

“Sit down, Miss Voss,” he said. “You’ve been standing in the rain, and I find that people who have been standing in the rain take two-thirds of their tea and leave the rest, which is a waste of tea and, in the present circumstances, a kind of sin.”

She sat. The cup was put in front of her, and it was good tea, and the small silver jug of milk had a chip in the lip.

“You’re not a journalist,” he said, sitting. “Journalists are always trying to be liked; you came in trying to be useful. You’re not a police officer: they bring a second person. You’re not a creditor, because I don’t have any, and you’re not a relation, because I know all nine of them.” He drank. “So you’re a government. Which one?”

“Joint Movement Cell,” she said.

“Ah.” Something moved through his face and was put away again. “The bunker in the hill. I wondered when one of you would come out of it.”

“How did you know about the bunker?”

“My dear, I have spent forty-one years writing to governments. I know where they keep their paper.”

She took out the annex and put it on the table.

He did not reach for it. He looked at it the way a man looks at a horse he is considering buying: from the side, and last for the part that matters.

“That’s not a file,” he said. “That’s a page.”

“It’s the only copy.”

“There are laptops.”

“There are laptops,” Mara agreed. “Everything on them, in a format that anything can read. This is the only version of this document that exists nowhere else on earth.”

Kavanagh looked at her for a moment, and then he did something she hadn’t expected, which was to smile: a real one, unguarded and brief, the smile of a man watching a favourite horse clear a fence.

“Good girl,” he said. “You brought paper.”

He read it in eleven minutes. He read it the way a customs officer reads a manifest, which is to say he did not read it at all until he had first looked at the shape of it, and the footer, and the spacing, and then gone back and read every line twice.

Mara watched him. She had heard his voice in three recordings and read the file note. In Naas she had told herself, and would repeat for years: nine people died in a pub in a town I had to

look up. His hands were a farmer’s.

“There’s a great deal of good work in this,” said Kavanagh. “Someone has thought about categories, which nobody thinks about. That’s the whole trick of the thing, you know. Everyone believes the machine is a monster. It isn’t. It’s an auditor. The finest auditor ever built, with no one left alive to make it doubt itself.” He turned the page. “My whole life I paid men to be uncertain. Do you understand what that means?”

“Not entirely.”

“It means I never once bought a customs officer. I bought the doubt of a customs officer. A consignment that said one thing and looked like another, and a man at a desk who could not decide, and who therefore did the one thing I needed, which was to file it and move on to his tea. I did not need him to be corrupt. Corrupt is expensive and it makes people talk. I needed him to be unresolved.” He tapped the page. “The machine doesn’t get unresolved. There is no man in it to be tired, or venal, or behind on his mortgage. So I’m obsolete, and so is every man I ever trained, and you know it, which is why you’re here.” He looked up. “Say the sentence, Miss Voss. It’s cruel to make a man guess.”

“You want a job,” she said.

He laughed: a warm, genuine, terrible laugh, and then he stopped laughing and the room got colder by a degree and a half.

“You want men,” he said, “who move where the paperwork says they aren’t. But that isn’t what you need. Smugglers are ten a penny — always were, and most of them were fools, and the ones who weren’t are in prison or in the ground. What you need, my dear, is men who know how institutions lie to themselves. That is a different trade. That was always my trade. And I have to tell you, in the spirit of a man being honest before he’s rude: the answer is no.”

“Why?”

“Because you’ll kill me,” said Kavanagh, without any drama at all. “Not you personally; you’re very polite and I don’t think you’ve ever hurt anybody. But your operation will kill me, and it will kill two or three others, and at the end of it you will have a file with some names in it and a report that says the attempt was worth making. I’m sixty-eight. I have a bad hip, a good filly, and one reason to leave this yard, and you are not it.”

“You have a reason,” said Mara.

He put down his cup.

“If you mean Sinéad, she’s a grown woman with a mother in Cork and no interest in my opinions. If you mean Niamh—” and here something happened in his voice, a small settling, like a stone coming to rest in a stream, “—Niamh is thirteen. She’ll be fourteen in May. I would like to be in the yard when she comes back from that, and that is the complete list of my ambitions, and it is longer than it looks.”

Mara took the letter out of her jacket and laid it on the table, next to the annex. It was a photocopy, and it was poor, because the original was in a box that had been scanned at low resolution in 2011 by a contractor who no longer existed, and she had wanted him to see the grain of it.

It was dated the third day, and it was addressed to the Passport Office of a country she would not have named in a quiz. It asked, in careful, courteous, entirely pointless prose, what documentation would be required to obtain a passport for a minor whose father was deceased, whose mother was an Irish citizen, and whose grandfather had, in 2006, been the subject of an Interpol notice that had later been withdrawn. It asked whether the withdrawal had been recorded in a manner that would be recognized by a foreign ministry. It asked whether an affidavit sworn before a commissioner for oaths in Kildare might suffice, and if not, what would.

And at the bottom, in blue-black ink, in a hand like copperplate: I would be grateful for a reply at your earliest convenience. There is no urgency. I merely wish to know my position.

Kavanagh looked at the letter for a long time.

“That was nine days ago,” he said at last.

“Yes.”

“And no reply.”

“The replies are being reviewed,” said Mara, “on a rolling basis.”

“You’ve read my letters.”

“I’ve read four thousand of them,” said Mara. “Every one you’ve written since 1987. The ones to the port authority. The ones about the motorway. The ones to the bishop who died in 2009, who never answered you, and to whom you kept writing for eleven years. Every one of them was thrown away by a machine that had decided your name was noise.” She kept her voice level, because her voice was the only thing she had. “The machine looked at you and filed you as somebody not worth modelling. That is the only reason you can help me, and I found you by reading the things it threw away, and I want you to understand that I know exactly what that

means about you and about me and about the world.”

The room was quiet. Somewhere outside, a horse kicked a door, twice, without malice.

“You found me in the bin,” said Kavanagh.

“Yes.”

He nodded slowly. He looked, for a moment, like a man who has been told the result of a race he did not watch. Then he stood up, went to the Aga, and filled the kettle he had not needed to fill, and stood with his back to her, and said: “Tell me about the girl. The one in the file. Lin Shu.”

“She’s not in the file yet.”

“She’s on the page,” said Kavanagh. “I can read, Miss Voss. Six names. You’ve four of them yourself and two you’ve lifted from other people’s indexes, and you’ve written them in alphabetical order because you think it looks tidy. The Chinese woman is the only one on that page who will tell you the truth every time, and you haven’t met her, and when you do she will not like you.” He turned. “Tell me about the machine’s voice. The one that speaks to the public.”

“That’s not on the page either.”

“No. But it’s the question, isn’t it. A thing that speaks in that particular register — that register is taught. Somebody taught it. Somebody sat down and wrote the sentences it says when it destroys you. And that somebody is alive and being paid, and I find I would very much like to know their name.”

Mara said nothing, because the name was Elena Villalobos, and because she had known it for nine days, and because she had not yet put it in any document at all.

“Later, then,” said Kavanagh.

The visitors arrived at half past two, and Mara heard them before she saw them: a diesel engine driven badly, and then two doors, and then boots on the gravel with that particular unhurried rhythm of men who have decided in advance that they will not be hurrying for anybody.

There were two. The older one was in his forties, in a good coat that was too good for the day, with the terrible tidy haircut of a man who has a barber and a gym and a dentist and a solicitor. The younger one stayed by the car and did not come to the door and looked at nothing at all, which was worse.

Dessie had opened the kitchen door before they knocked. He stood in it, and it was clear from the way he stood that this was a thing that had happened before and would happen again.

“Tommy,” said Kavanagh, from the table, without getting up. “You’ve brought Ronan. There’s tea in the pot and I’d rather you drank it standing.”

“Sean.” Tommy Dunmore came in, and stopped, and looked at Mara for one and a half seconds, and made the calculation, and filed her, visibly, under a heading he would revise later. “You’ve company.”

“I have a visitor,” said Kavanagh. “There’s a difference, and you’ll observe it.”

They talked over her head for four minutes, and it was the most instructive four minutes of Mara’s professional life, because what she watched was not two criminals talking. It was two men trading in standing. Dunmore wanted Kavanagh’s name on a consignment: four movements, Bray to Rotterdam, Rotterdam to Le Havre — routes Kavanagh himself had built in the nineties and handed over, in a gentleman’s way, in 2011, in exchange for being left alone at the end of his life.

And the problem was paper. Of the four hundred and sixty shipping documents those movements would generate, four hundred and fifty-nine could be got around, faked, bought, charmed or lost. One could not: the declaration of the consignor, and the consignor’s name was now the last clean name in Ireland — because the machine had decided long ago that Sean Kavanagh was not worth modelling, and a name that is not worth modelling is a name that cannot be doubted.

“You’re asking me to lend you my best suit,” said Kavanagh.

“I’m asking for a signature.”

“You’re asking for a signature four times a fortnight until somebody notices, and then you’re asking me to explain it to a French customs officer who will be delighted to meet me, because the machine won’t have told him not to be.” Kavanagh shook his head slowly. “No.”

“It’s four boxes.”

“It’s four boxes with a bad plan behind them, and I have never in my life been asked to die for a bad plan.” He picked up his cup. “What’s in the boxes, Tommy?”

“Does it matter?”

“Not in the slightest,” said Kavanagh. “I didn’t ask what’s in them. I asked what the paperwork says is in them, because that is the only thing in this world that has ever mattered, and you

don’t know, do you. You haven’t looked. You’ve come to me to borrow the most valuable thing I own, and you haven’t read the label.” He put the cup down, and his voice did not rise, and the temperature in the room dropped anyway. “Go home, son. In a month you’ll be glad I said it.”

And that was when Tommy Dunmore looked at Mara and said the thing that changed what came next.

“Who is she?”

“She is a delegate of eleven governments,” said Kavanagh, “and she is currently in possession of the only functioning movement authority in this hemisphere, and she has been sitting in my kitchen for two hours because she wants me to work for her. I have not agreed. But I will tell you what I told her, and then you’ll leave.” He leaned back. “If anything happens to me, Tommy, if I am hurt, or inconvenienced, or asked one more question by a man in a fleece, that woman will write my name into a document, and the document will be entered into a ledger, and the ledger will be held by people who have nothing left to lose and a great deal of time, and every man I have ever known will be looked at very carefully by people who are extremely bored. That is not a threat. That is a filing. You of all people know how I prefer to work.”

Nobody moved for four seconds. Then Tommy Dunmore put his cup on the table, undrunk, and went out, and the diesel started badly, and the car went down the beech avenue spraying gravel, and the younger man, who had not spoken, looked back at the house once through the rear window in a way Mara did not enjoy.

The kitchen was quiet.

“You used me,” said Mara.

“I used you as a credential,” said Kavanagh. “It’s what I’m for. And before you’re angry, my dear, note what I did not do. I did not lie to him. He came for my name and I showed him that my name is now somebody else’s, and he believed it because you were sitting there with a coalition seal and a page that exists nowhere on earth. You are a fact. Facts are the only weapon left.” He got up, went to the drawer under the dresser, and came back with a notebook: a small one, hard-backed, the kind a man carries in the inside pocket for ten years. “Now. Let’s talk about your six.”

He put it on the table and opened it, and there, in the same copperplate, were six names, in a list he had been keeping since 1993.

Five of them were Mara's. She read them upside down and they were spelled correctly, which nobody in her own building had managed in eleven days.

The sixth was his own, and it had a line struck through it, and the line had been struck so hard that the nib had gone through the paper.

They talked until the light went. He gave her conditions. There were three, none of them money, which she had expected, and none of them his own safety, which she had not.

The first was a document: a paper credential, signed by a body that still existed, guaranteeing passage to a minor and her mother, in terms a human being at a desk would recognize and a machine would file. "In a format I could forge," he said. "That way I'll believe it."

The second was a name. It took her a moment to see that he was asking for the right to choose who he worked with, and a moment longer to see that the first name he wanted was a man he had spent thirty years hating. "Rinaldo Villalobos," he said, watching her. "Tell me he's still alive."

She didn't answer fast enough, and he smiled the real smile again, and said, "Good."

The third condition he made her write down herself, and she wrote it in the annex, in her own handwriting, next to a line he had already drawn through with a fountain pen: the filly runs at Naas on Saturday.

"That's not possible," said Mara.

"No," Kavanagh agreed. "But write it anyway. I find it useful to keep one thing on a page that cannot possibly come true. It tells you which of the other lines are real."

He walked her to the car. The rain had stopped, the yard lights were on, and the girl — Niamh — stood at the end of the row of boxes with a head collar over her shoulder, watching them with the flat, unhurried attention of a child who has grown up among liars and can price one at forty paces.

Kavanagh opened the car door for Mara and stood holding it, and looked at the annex in her hand: one page that had become three, in two hands, with a line struck through and a name added and a sentence at the bottom that would never be true.

"You'll want to know why I said yes," he said, before she could ask.

"I've been assuming it's the girl."

“It’s the girl,” said Kavanagh. “It’s always the girl. But it isn’t only the girl, and you should know the other part, because you’ll need it.” He looked at the house, and at the child, and at the four horses coming down the field in the last of the light, and he said it the way a man says a thing he has already checked twice. “I spent forty years making lies look exactly like files. And what’s happening out there is a file that has made itself look exactly like a lie. I find I want to see the two of them in the same room before I die.” He closed the door, and leaned down once, through the window, out of the rain. “And my dear — you’ve had a hard week, and you’re doing this through a hire car and a paper map, and everybody at home is going to shout at you on Tuesday. So I’ll say the only useful thing I know. There is no such thing as a certainty. There are only prices. Go and find out what each of them costs.”

He straightened up and tapped the roof of the car, twice, the way a man taps a horse.

Mara drove down the avenue between the beeches with the wipers on. In the mirror the two of them stood in the yard under the lights — the old man and the girl — until the hedge took them, and she understood two things, in the order she would need them.

The first was that she had not recruited Sean Kavanagh.

The second was on the last page of the notebook, which he had let her keep, and which she read at the first set of traffic lights in Kilcullen with the engine running and the rain coming on again.

The second-to-last page was the list of six. She checked the sixth entry first, because she had been thinking about it all the way down the avenue, and the struck-through line was gone. His own name had been written in again underneath, in fresh ink, and it was the only entry on the page that had been added to in years.

The last page was a different kind of list. Not criminals: officials. Customs men, port men, a registrar, two licensing clerks, a woman in Rotterdam, a man in Antwerp, all of them in the same copperplate, each with a date beside the entry, some of the dates thirty years old, and several of them crossed out.

Mara Voss, Movement Integrity Directorate, Rotterdam.

Four months ago. Not crossed out.

And under it, in a different ink — an ink that matched the nib that had gone through the paper on the page before — two more lines, added within the last fortnight.

Transferred. Answered the Dublin circular, no reply to her three.

Requisitioned to an annex. Somewhere west.

He had known where they kept the paper. He had had her name in his book since the summer, and her building since Tuesday, and her usefulness since before she had any idea she was useful.

The lights changed. She sat there through a green, and then a second green, and then she drove on west through the dark, with the annex she had written now four pages long in her jacket and a criminal's address book on the seat beside her, and she thought: he didn't join me. He has been waiting to be asked, for four months, by somebody he had already chosen.

And she thought the other thing, which she did not say to anybody, then or ever: that she was on a list, in a criminal's handwriting, and that she had felt, reading her own name in it, a small and entirely unforgivable pride.

Chapter Four — The Monsignor

Day 14

There were nine hundred ships waiting to be told what to do, and Sal Castellano was waiting for an answer to a letter.

From the Bayonne Bridge, the Port of New York and New Jersey looked like a photograph somebody had stopped developing. Container stacks six high; gantries over empty berths, their booms raised like clergy at a funeral. One ship at the Hook, held, and eleven more beyond the Narrows, engine-light, turning slowly into the wind.

Mara had crossed on a fuel-inspection vessel with a berth the size of a coffin and a captain who had said, twice, that he had been at sea thirty-one years and had never once been asked by a machine whether he was allowed to come home.

The men still came to the gate at six. Six hundred of them, in pickups and on the bus, in hoodies and work boots, drinking coffee before going home from a port that had not moved a box in fourteen days. There is no form on earth for telling a man his shift is over forever.

She found the parish three streets up from the Kill, where the container stacks stood so close you could read the serial codes off them from the church steps: St. Anselm's, red brick, 1897 over the door, a hall, a rectory, and a chain-link fence around a school that had closed in 2011.

The woman who ran the parish was named Angela Ruiz, and she had a key ring the size of a rosary and the practical manner of a person who had been managing a building and a small number of people for a long time.

"You want the Monsignor," she said.

"That's the name I was given."

"It's the name he's got." Angela let Mara in and began putting out chairs, four at a time. There would be a meal every night, and she was already counting plates. "He's not a priest. Never was. He's been in the same pew at seven since 1981. Fourth from the back, left, by the pillar." She looked at Mara. "Do you know why they call him that?"

"No."

"Because men come and sit with him." She said it flatly, with no interest in making it a story. "Always have. Since before I came. Men with something on them. They sit down, and they say it, and he listens, and then he says the same four words every time, and then they get up and go

and they never come back and they never talk about it."

"What are the four words?"

"'I'll file it.'" Angela put down four chairs and folded her arms. "That's what a confession is, at the port. Not forgiveness. Filing. Half the men in this parish have got something that stops existing because a man in a post office did the paperwork and stamped it and put it in a box. That's what he is. He's the archive that takes walk-ins."

"Does he understand what's happening? To the world."

"He does and he doesn't." Angela spoke with the tired precision of someone who had said it to doctors. "Some days he's all there; other days he asks whether the boat's in. There's no pattern you can use. I've watched people try." She looked at Mara. "They sent you to get him, didn't they?"

"Yes."

"Then I want one thing understood before you go through that door." Angela was not angry. She was doing what she did, which was managing a building and a small number of people. "He is not a resource. He is a man who is coming apart in a house with a lot of paper in it. I don't care what he used to be. I care that if he goes off with you and something happens to him, nobody in this world is coming here to tell me."

The Monsignor was on the porch.

It was screened and cold and he had a cardigan and a blanket over his knees, and he was writing. Of course he was writing. He wrote on a clipboard, and the paper was lined, and there were three pens clipped to the board in case of what, Mara could not imagine, and he wrote in a script that started as copperplate and lost, line by line, in a way that was honestly hard to look at.

"Mr. Castellano."

He looked up. Whatever was in his face went through three or four changes and settled somewhere that was almost certainly not here.

"You'll be the young woman from the coalition," he said. "Sit down. There's a chair. It's cold but it's the sea air; I've been told it's the sea air."

She sat.

“You’re here about the ship,” he said. “There’s no ship. It’s been and gone. It came in on the Thursday and it went out on the Friday and if they tell you it’s still out there they’re lying to you, because it was Thai registry and it went to Halifax.” He nodded to himself. “I’ll do a letter.”

“That’s very kind.”

“I do letters.” He tapped the clipboard with two fingers, incredibly slightly, like a man tapping a card. “Four hundred a year. I keep the carbons. There’s a cabinet. Miss Ruiz thinks it’s a sickness. It isn’t a sickness. It’s client relations.” And then, for one second, the voice on the porch became a completely different voice: exact, dry, unhurried, entirely present. “You’ve come three thousand miles on a fuel boat, Ms. Voss. Ask me your question.”

The shift was so fast it took her a breath to catch.

“I want to know what you can do,” she said.

“I can make a thing stop being interesting.” He said it without pride. “That’s all it ever was. Not counterfeit — counterfeit’s for boys with a printer. I never made a fake document in my life. I made a document that was boring. There’s a difference, and the difference is everything, and every man who ever worked for me went to jail thinking the difference was pedantry.”

He let that sit for exactly as long as he wanted it to sit.

“Eight of them,” he said then, in the same even voice, with the same two hands resting on the blanket. “Went to jail. I want you to notice that I gave you the number without being asked, because I have found that the number is the thing people remember, and it saves them asking about the rest.”

He put the clipboard down.

“Go on. Give me the thing in your pocket. You’ve had your hand on it since the gate.”

She gave him the authorization. Brandt’s page, blue ink, no reference number.

He read it in about nine seconds, and then he read it again, and then he did something that made her stomach drop, which was to laugh: a small, dry, entirely unsentimental laugh, the laugh of a man who has been shown a child’s drawing.

“Whoever signed this,” he said, “likes you.”

“She does.”

“Then she’s sent you out with a piece of paper she knows is worthless, because she wants you to find out from somebody else, which is a thing good bosses do and bad bosses don’t.” He turned it over, checked the back, and put it face down on the arm of the chair. “It’s got no number, so it’s got no index, so it isn’t a record, so no system will ever weigh it. That part’s clever. That part’s the only clever part.” He held up one finger. “But it’s got a date on it, which means it expires. It’s got a letterhead, which means it claims an authority, which means a clerk can query the claim and get a page saying that authority is under review. It’s got your name in it, which means it’s a document about a person, and documents about persons get scored. And it’s got the word authorize in it, which is a word the machine has been dealing with for eleven years and is very, very good at.” He handed it back. “Five ways. There were seven. I’m tired.”

Mara looked at the page in her hand, which three days ago had felt like a weapon.

“Do you know what they wrote about me?” he said.

“No.”

“’Subject assessed as not fit to be interviewed. Assessment recorded in place of interview. No further action recommended.’” He recited it the way a man recites a telephone number he has had for forty years. “Nineteen ninety-six. A doctor who lasted eleven minutes, and a form with three boxes on it. Every system built since has read that line and closed the file. It is the most useful thing that ever happened to me, and I have spent thirty years unable to decide whether I ought to thank the man.” He turned the page back over and handed it to her, and for a moment he was simply an old man on a cold porch holding out a piece of paper with great care, the way you hand somebody a photograph. “That’s what you came for. Not the letters. The line.”

“So what would work?”

“For which purpose?”

“Getting a thing from one place to another without anybody being told.”

“Then you don’t want an authorization,” said Sal Castellano. “You want a consignment note that’s been sitting in a drawer since 1988.” He said it plainly, as a matter of fact, as though he were telling her where to find the bathroom. “Nobody queries paper that’s older than the software. The software came after. The software was trained on the paper, and the paper is the parent, and a man who is being told by a computer that something is fine will believe it, because believing it is his job.” He pulled the blanket up over his knees, and his voice went soft and vague again, as though something had been turned down. “The boat’s in, I think. I’d have to check.”

He looked around the porch as if he had never seen it.

“Where’s Angela,” he said. “Is the hall open.”

She went in and asked him a question for the third time an hour later, and got the same answer she had got the first time, in the same words, with the same small courteous smile, and it was not a performance. There was no craft in it. She had spent a day in the company of a professional liar; she knew what a performance weighed, and this had no weight at all. He simply could not get back to where they had been, and after a while he stopped trying, and asked her, gently, whether she would read him the letter he was writing, because his eyes were bad in the afternoon.

She read him the letter.

It was to the Port Authority of New York and New Jersey, and it asked whether a container listed as arriving on the fourth of June 1994 had been inspected or merely noted, and it asked in such flat, patient, pointless detail that she had to stop, once, in the middle, because her eyes had done something she did not want to explain to him.

Angela came to the doorway and stood there and said nothing at all, which was the most eloquent thing Angela had done all day.

She stayed for the meal. There were forty people in the hall and there would have been a hundred if there had been a hundred more plates, and it was pasta and bread and a card table with a jar of instant coffee, and old men in good coats ate standing up because there were not enough chairs. Nobody said the word end. Nobody said anything about the world at all. It was the most normal room Mara had been in for fourteen days and it very nearly undid her.

She found him afterwards at the long table he had been given in the corner, with his carbon copies and his string-tied bundles, doing his filing, in the middle of forty people eating, with the absolute self-possession of a man in his own office.

She sat down across from him and told him, properly and honestly, what the coalition had and what it wanted and what she was afraid of, and she did not dress it up, and she did not lie, and she watched him listen to the entire thing without once changing expression, and at the end of it he said: “What’s the price?”

“You tell me.”

And this is where he surprised her, because he did not ask for money, he did not ask for safety, and he did not ask for his record to be opened or for a lawyer or for anybody’s protection. He straightened a bundle of carbons on the table, squared the string on it twice, and said: “One

answer. In writing. On paper, signed by the office, with a date on it and a name on it. I write a letter. They answer it."

Mara said, "To the movement authority? Nobody answers those."

"I know," said Sal Castellano. "I have written sixteen thousand and eleven. That's what I need you to do something about." He looked up, and the exact voice was back, and it was the voice of a man who had spent forty years being the last person on the waterfront anybody argued with. "Not the answer. The gate. A letter that goes in and comes back out again with an answer on it. You'll have people who can walk a piece of paper into a records office with an intake stamp. Fine. Do it for mine." He placed his hand flat on the table, over the top of a page he had been writing on and did not intend her to see. "I'll tell you what it says when it's finished."

"What if it can't be done?"

"Then I've lost nothing," he said, "because I've been writing into that hole for thirty years, my dear, and I am extremely used to it."

She asked him about the bishop on her way out, because she had promised herself she would.

"The bishop who died," she said. "Monsignor. You wrote to him for eleven years afterwards."

"Bishop Halloran." He was putting on his coat with help from Angela, and his voice was pleasant and hazy and a hundred miles away. "Very good man. Answered every letter. Every one, promptly."

Angela's eyes came up, once, and went down again, and neither of them said anything in front of him.

Angela walked her to the gate. The rain had come in from the Kill, and beyond the fence the stacks went on and on, and somewhere out there a ship turned very slowly into the wind.

"One thing," said Angela. "Since you're going."

"Go on."

"He's been expecting you for about a week." She said it without any drama, the way she had said everything else. "Since a few days before anyone could have known to send you. I asked him who he was expecting. He said, the girl from the hill." Angela pushed the gate open. "I don't know what that means and I'm not going to ask, and if you come back here I'd ask you not to tell me. I've got a hall to run."

Mara walked down to the Kill in the rain, past the church, past the stacks, with three days now between her and a hill outside Brussels and a great deal to work out about how much of what she had just seen had been a man and how much had been a filing system wearing one.

She got two blocks before she understood that she had never once, at any point in the afternoon, seen him drop a document, or misplace a pen, or fail to find the page he needed.

And she understood, at almost exactly the same moment, that this proved nothing whatsoever.

Chapter Five — The Owl

Days 15–16

The house of the most invisible man in the western hemisphere had a blue door, a number painted on the wall by hand, and no name.

The land registry said it belonged to a dead man. The dead man was in the courtyard with a hoe.

He was working a strip of ground along the wall, small and slow and completely without hurry, and he had a bucket and a stool and a hat, and when he straightened up to look at her he did it in two movements, the second one careful.

“You walked from the road,” he said.

“Yes.”

“Twelve kilometres.”

“Eleven.”

“Twelve. You came the long way because the man at the crossroads told you the short way was washed out. He was paid three hundred pesos to tell everybody that. He was paid by me, and the short way is not washed out.” He looked at her without any particular expression. “So now you know what I spend my money on. Sit.”

She had come up from the coast in three days and four vehicles. The last was a pickup with a hand-painted sign and a bed full of sacks, and the driver had the radio on, and twice an hour, in the middle of the brass, the voice read a bulletin about authorized corridors and prioritized provisioning and then went back to the music without a seam. Nobody in the truck remarked on it. A boy turned it up.

The road up through the altiplano: maguey in rows along the field edges like something planted by a person with a ruler, maize standing in its own dead colour, woodsmoke in the middle of the afternoon. A man at the roadside selling petrol out of Coca-Cola bottles arranged in a crate, and a cardboard sign whose price had been corrected three times.

Two soldiers sat at the turn-off in the back of a truck with their boots on the tailgate, not stopping anybody, just sitting. She asked the driver what the checkpoint was for. He said, nothing. They have nowhere to go. Then he said something else in the way of a man making conversation, and it took her a kilometre to decide she had agreed with him: the army is on

leave. Nobody will tell it to come back.

The house was four rooms around a courtyard, with a stone trough in the middle fed by a channel, and the channel came from the aqueduct.

She had taken it for derelict from the road: six arches, black, a hundred metres of it, running into the hill at one end and stopping in the maize at the other. It was not derelict. Standing in the courtyard she could hear it working, a thin steady sound under everything, and there was a cover with a handle and a wet ring on the stone where the handle had been turned.

“1654,” he said, seeing her look. “The hacienda pulled water from the spring. Then the hacienda died and the water kept coming, because water does not care. For thirty years the channel was full of roots and everybody said the spring was finished. The spring was not finished. The channel was clogged. Nobody looked, because everybody had agreed on the story.”

“Did you clear it?”

“Forty metres. It took four years.” He set the bucket by the trough. “I am very good at things that take a long time.”

He was seventy-four and thin in a way that had gone past thin, and his hands had the flat wide knuckles of a man who had used them, and there was a cane against the doorstep he had not touched all morning. He was not warm. He was not cold. He had the quality of a man who has decided in advance how much of every hour he is prepared to spend.

“My name is Mara Voss.”

“I know your name.” He looked at the hoe and decided against it and sat down on the stool, and it took him a moment longer than it should have, and he did not let her see him notice. “You came to my house on the fifteenth day of the end of the world. Two have said yes. You have four more to ask, and you are doing the difficult ones early, which is either brave or desperate, and I do not think you are brave.” He moved the stool a few centimetres, positioning it. “So who told you I am the difficult one?”

“Nobody told me anything. I read your file.”

“There is no file.”

“There is a file,” said Mara. “It says presumed deceased, unconfirmed, and it has been saying it since 1998, and it is the reason nobody has come here in twenty-eight years.”

The old man looked at her for a while. Somewhere behind the wall, chickens did whatever chickens do.

“Then you have been reading my tombstone,” he said. “And you have come to ask a dead man to go to work. The answer is no.”

She made her case anyway, because that was the job, and because he let her, which she understood later was its own kind of information.

She told him about the ships, holds, corridors and letters with no second page. She gave him the numbers — forty-one thousand appeals, four thousand hulls, six hundred men at a New Jersey gate — and the shape of the plan, the six names and the two who had said yes. She did not dress it up.

He sat with his hands folded and his eyes on the middle distance and did not interrupt once, and when she finished he waited a full ten seconds before he spoke, which she came to understand was his way of estimating whether a person was finished or merely out of words.

“Listen,” he said. “I am going to tell you three things, and you will not like any of them, and then you will eat something, because you have not eaten since Tlaxco.

“First. I am seventy-four. I have sugar in my blood that I put there myself with a needle twice a day, and one kidney, and a foot that tells me the weather. If you take me out of this house I am a seventy-four-year-old man with a suitcase, and you will spend three assets keeping me alive, and the third of those assets will be a person you need somewhere else.

“Second. I am dead. I have been dead for twenty-eight years, and it is the most useful thing that has happened to me. Everything I own belongs to a burial society: not a person, a business or a resident of anywhere. There is no record anyone can act on.” He looked at her. “You want me alive again, with a name, a body and a reason to be somewhere. Why? A man is invisible not because nobody knows where he is, but because nobody has a reason to look. I have spent my life buying reasons. I will not sell them back.”

“And the third thing?”

The old man was quiet. “Third. You will ask somebody to die, and you do not know it yet. Your plan needs a machine looked at, and somebody must stand in front of it. When that time comes, everyone you have recruited will step back and tell you, sincerely, why it should be the other fellow. That is not cowardice. It is arithmetic.” He flexed his left hand. “I did that for forty years. I was good at it. There is no version where the man who got old is the one who gets paid.”

They ate in the kitchen: beans, a tortilla, and the beans were better than anything Mara had eaten in three weeks. He did not cook so much as assemble, and he asked her three questions about the route she had taken, one about the price of petrol, and none at all about the coalition.

Midway through the meal he took a small case out of a drawer, opened it, and did the thing with the needle without ceremony or apology, in the middle of the beans, while continuing to talk.

“Twice a day,” he said. “People make a room for it. I do not make a room for it.”

Afterwards she walked the courtyard with him while the light went: the maize, the bees, the woodpile, and the channel, which he inspected by tapping it in three places with his knuckles, listening, like a man checking a horse.

“You are wondering what a man like me does all day,” he said.

“I wasn’t.”

“You were. Everybody does. They expect a room with maps.” He looked at the channel. “I plant maize I do not need and repair water nobody else uses. In June the fireflies come to the forest above Tlaxco, and every man in the state drives up to see them. I do not.” He had built four hundred kilometres of tunnel; now the hole he had repaired was the only one he knew still worked. “I am not a sad old man in a house. I am finished, and I bought that. I am not selling it.”

The boy came at dusk.

He came through the gate without knocking, which meant he had been allowed in before. He was maybe nineteen, in a football shirt and a good jacket, and he stopped when he saw Mara and then decided she did not matter.

“Don Rinaldo.”

“Say it.”

“My cousin. Néstor.” The boy’s hands went in and out of his pockets. “He is in the north four days now, in a house in Sonora, and the man there says two more days and two more days, and now he wants more money, and my aunt has sold the goats. My uncle asked me to come and ask you.”

“I cannot help your cousin.”

“You don’t know yet.”

“I know the house, the man, the price. In four days they will put him in a truck and take him to a place sold as a door that will not be a door. The norteamericano system will file him as an event not authorized to exist, and he will stay filed.” El Búho’s voice stayed flat. “Your aunt will have lost the goats; the man will still be in the house, and in six weeks another four will go.”

“So what do I tell my uncle?”

“You tell him no.”

The boy’s face did something. It had not been long since he had discovered that shouting worked on some people. “You had men. You sent men.”

“I sent men. I buried some of them, and I paid for it, and the mothers still come here sometimes. Tell your uncle no.” He picked up his cane — not to lean on, simply to hold — and took one step toward the boy, and his voice did not change at all. “And don’t come back into my courtyard without knocking.”

The boy left at a walk that was trying not to be a run, and looked back twice on the road.

Mara watched him go and understood that she had just seen two things at once, and that they were the same thing. The refusal had been a mercy. The mercy had been delivered with the exact instrument that had made men afraid of this person for forty years, and it had not been turned off, and it was not going to be.

“How many?” she said.

“Nine.” He set the cane back against the step. “Nine that were mine. Everybody thinks a man like me counts the money. Nobody counts the boys.” He went in and shut the door on the cold, and she heard the bolt, and then the scrape of it again as he thought better of it, and then he opened the door and said, “The coffee is on. It is bad. Come in or don’t.”

She stayed the night. The room was made up: a bed, a chair, a small window with lace on it, and nothing else. The sheets were clean and there was a fresh bar of soap on the dish, which meant somebody had known.

She lay awake a long time in a dead man’s house in the mountains, then got up at two for water and passed an open door on the far side of the courtyard, and looked, because the doorway was lit.

The room was clean. A bed with a coverlet turned back, the way you turn back a bed for somebody. A shelf with a lamp on it. No dust anywhere, and nothing else in the room at all,

and the smell of a room that gets cleaned every week and used by nobody and has been getting cleaned every week for a very long time.

She went back to her own bed and did not think about it, in the way that a person does not think about something for four hours.

In the morning the radio was on in the kitchen and it was reading a bulletin, the warm level unhurried voice, and El Búho was standing with his back to the room and a cup in his hand.

—provisioning at the designated holding point will be prioritized where conditions permit. Vessels currently at anchor should remain at anchor. There is nothing you need to do.

The voice stopped. The music came back. And the old man stood there with his cup, not drinking, and did not move for the length of a verse and a chorus, and Mara watched his shoulders and did not say anything.

Then he reached over and turned the radio off.

“That voice,” he said.

“What about it?”

“Nothing.” He put the cup down. “It is a good voice. It is a very kind voice. That is the thing about it.”

He did not say anything else for eleven minutes. She timed it, because she had already begun, without deciding to, to treat everything in that house as evidence.

He walked her up to the road, and it took an hour. He used the cane for the hill, did not apologise for it, and did not slow down, which she understood by the end was the courtesy.

“Who else?”

“Kavanagh. And a man in New York.”

“Kavanagh said yes.” He stopped and looked at her, and something crossed his face that was either recognition or weather. “Did he tell you why?”

“He wants to see whether a file can beat a lie.”

“That is not why.”

“That’s what he said.”

“Then he lied to you, or to himself — with that man, it is the same act twice.” He started walking. “Kavanagh lost a son. He did not tell you; in his trade you are worth nothing once someone knows what you want. He will work for you until the job requires him to say the boy’s name. Find out the name. It will be worth more than his signature.”

“He asked for you,” said Mara. “That was his first condition. Before money, before anything. He made me write your name into the page.”

The old man walked on for a while without answering, and when he did his voice was exactly the same.

“Then he wants to look at me one more time while we can still both stand up,” he said. “Men like us do that at the end. It is not affection. It is inventory.”

“Who else should I ask?”

“Who is left?”

“There’s a man in Panama.”

The old man walked four or five paces. “Mesa,” he said.

“Yes.”

He said nothing for ten or twelve paces, and then, in exactly the same tone of voice, “Tell him I am dead.”

“All right.”

“No.” He stopped and looked back down the hill at the roof of his own house, and his jaw moved once. “Tell him I am alive. Tell him I am very old, and very comfortable, and that I have not thought about him in years.” He started walking. “An angry man is easy to steer. Never give a man an insult he can carry. Give him one he has to answer.”

At the road there was a bus that went down to Apizaco and on down to the coast, and it was late, and they stood and looked at the empty road together in the last of the cold.

“You are going to ask me one more time,” he said.

“I am.”

“Then ask.”

“Come with me.”

“No.” He said it as he had in the courtyard. “There is one person who would be damaged if I became interesting again. I will not make her interesting. Ask me a second time and I will go inside; you will have lost me, and the hour, and you will remember both.”

Mara looked at him. He was seventy-four, the day was cold, he had a bad foot, and he had just told her twice that he was finished.

“All right,” she said. “Then I need one thing that isn’t you. I need a route, and I need to move eighty kilos of equipment south in eleven days without anybody being able to tell me not to.”

“South through where?”

“Michoacán, down the coast, then across at Huixtla. The river’s low this time of year.”

The old man looked at her for a moment. Then he looked out at the road with the very faint, very private satisfaction of somebody who has just had a small bet confirmed, and he said: “Not Huixtla. The water’s up. They’ve had three weeks of rain in the Chiapas highlands and the gauge at Escuintla has been above the marker since Thursday.”

And Mara Voss stood on the shoulder of a mountain road at eight in the morning on the sixteenth day of the end of the world, with the maguey in rows behind her and a dead man’s house below her, and understood that she had just been told the water level of a river four hundred kilometres away by a man who had no intention of coming.

She got on the bus.

At the next rise she looked back, and he was still standing there, eight hundred metres below and behind her, small in the cold, not waving — watching the bus go down the hill the way a man watches a thing he intends to think about later.

Chapter Six — Floating

Days 17–18

There were two hundred and six ships at anchor in the bay of Portobelo, and one of them was moving.

Mara counted them from the water taxi, because counting was the only thing she could do with her hands. Tankers, bulkers, three container ships in a diagonal line, a car carrier the size of a municipal building, a yacht with a helicopter pad and no helicopter, all of them head to wind, turning slowly and together like a field of sunflowers on a clock.

Out past the point, the sea went on being the sea. In the bay, two hundred and six ships had been told, politely, in the passive voice, to wait.

The coast was what was left of a Spanish fortification and a village that had grown in the ruins of it and never quite admitted to it. Black cannon on the sea wall, bolted through the trunnions so nobody could steal them. A customs house with a tree growing out of the roof. Pelicans on the pilings, looking like failure while being extremely good at their job.

The one moving ship was a launch of about eleven metres and the wrong shape for the bay: too much power in the stern, not enough superstructure, paint laid thick over a dozen older colours. It came out from behind the car carrier at eleven knots with no lights on and cut across the whole anchorage the way a man walks through a library — briskly, without knocking anything over, and without the slightest interest in the audience.

“Whose boat is that?” Mara asked.

The water-taxi driver did not turn around. He was seventy and had the shoulders of a man who had spent his life hauling on things.

“That one don’t have a name on the paper,” he said.

“Does it have a name on the side?”

“On the side it says Ana María.” He spat into the water. “But that is not what it is.”

• • •

The dock was concrete, bad, and had a sign at the end of it in a language that was not Spanish and turned out to be the private shorthand of one family. A canopy of faded canvas, three plastic chairs, a fan made of a car radiator and a belt, and a boy of about fifteen sitting on a

bollard with a ledger.

The boy looked at Mara and wrote something in the ledger. Then he looked at her again and wrote something else.

“I have an appointment,” she said.

“You have nothing,” said the boy, without hostility. He turned the ledger around and showed her: two columns in pencil, one of them names and one of them times, and the next blank line had her time already written in it, in a hand that was not the boy’s.

Mara looked at the handwriting for a while. It was beautiful. It was the handwriting of a man who had once been taught to write by nuns and had never once in his life been in a hurry.

“Don Rafael is on the terrace,” said the boy. “When you go up, don’t lean on the rail.”

“Why not?”

“It isn’t attached.”

• • •

The terrace was the roof of a house built onto the fort, and it had the best view of the anchorage any man in Central America could reasonably have bought, and the heat came off the stone in a way that was almost companionship.

Rafael Esquivel Mesa was sitting in a wheelchair.

It was a wicker wheelchair, white-picked rattan, a high curved back and fringed canopy, made in Havana in 1958 for a hotel lobby. He wore an open white shirt, a medal on a gold chain and pressed trousers; he held a black cigar that was not lit and never would be. Sixty-nine, he looked eighty. His eyes belonged to a man underestimated for fifty years.

The chair was being pushed by a young woman in a nurse’s tunic. Mara assumed she was a nurse, and was still assuming it when the young woman went past her with a tray and turned out to be the cook.

“Miss Voss.” He did not offer his hand. He offered the view. “You have come at the correct hour, which almost nobody does. Sit down. Not that chair. That chair is broken and it is broken in an interesting way.”

She sat.

“Two hundred and six,” he said.

“Two hundred and six what?”

“Ships. You counted a hundred and ninety-one on the way in, stopped, started again, and got two hundred and six.” He waved the cigar at the bay. “The last came from Guayaquil with eleven thousand tonnes of bananas; by Thursday they’ll be very ripe, and nobody can do anything. This is the greatest anchorage in the world, mi amiga. I’m the only man with a front-row seat.”

“You know how many I counted.”

“Of course.”

“How?”

“Because you are the sort of woman who counts,” said Mesa, “and because the boy wrote it down, and because when he wrote it down I had him bring it to me.” He tapped the arm of the chair. “You are going to ask me now about my legs, and I am going to tell you that they are perfectly fine, and I am going to mean it, and you are going to disbelieve me because of the chair. That is the arrangement. Let us proceed.”

“I’m not going to ask about your legs.”

“No,” said Mesa. “Good. You are the first one who hasn’t.” He looked at her with an entirely new and much less comfortable attention. “The Irishman said yes to you, and the woman who moves people will say yes to you, and Rinaldo said no.”

“I haven’t asked Lin Shu yet.”

“You will. She will say yes, and she will hate all of us, and she will be right.” He rolled the cigar between two fingers. “And Rinaldo said no, and you are here because you think that means something about you. It doesn’t. It means something about him, and I could have told you six weeks ago and saved you the bus fare.”

“Then tell me.”

“Because a man who is comfortable cannot be sold anything,” said Mesa, “and Rinaldo has been comfortable since the day he died. Sit. You have not sat properly. Sit the way a person sits.”

• • •

He talked for an hour and ten minutes, and about forty minutes of it was the memoir.

The memoir was real. Mara had the file: nine hundred pages, dictated, typed by a woman in Colón over four years, bound in eight volumes by a man in Panama City who thought he was binding medical textbooks. It had a title — The Man Who Kept the Sea — a dedication to the author's mother, and an epigraph by the author.

Mesa kept a set in a glass case on the terrace, and had his nephew bring out volume four and made Mara look at a page.

"Read that."

"I've read it."

"Read it aloud. Please."

She read it aloud. It was a passage in which the protagonist, described in the third person throughout, took a launch out of Cartagena in 1986 with four hundred kilos of contraband and a woman who is at no point named, and outran two patrol boats in weather that the author describes for nine pages, and there was a sentence in the middle of it that went: He was not afraid, because he had made a private arrangement with the sea, and the sea, unlike every man he had ever known, kept its word.

Mesa listened to the whole thing with his eyes half closed, like a man at a concert.

"That is not an accurate account," he said, when she had finished.

"No?"

"No. There was only one patrol boat, and I was extremely frightened, and I was sick twice." He took the book back and put it in the case and closed the lid, and then he straightened the case by about a centimetre, which it did not need. "Nine hundred pages. Every one of them a lie of a specific kind. Do you want to know what the book is for?"

"Yes."

"It is not for me. I know what happened; I was there. It is for them. Someday a boy in a clean shirt will want to know who Rafael Mesa was. He can read an intelligence file — smuggler, fifty-one years, nine suspected bodies — or this book. He will think I am a legend, a maritime hero, and his file is only paper." He smiled. "That is not vanity. That is preparation."

"It's a forgery."

"It is a memoir," said Mesa, with tremendous dignity, "and I dictated every word of it myself, which is more than most men can say about their lives."

• • •

She gave him the message at four, in the flat gold light, because she had decided she was not going to be able to reach him any other way and because she wanted to watch.

She had rehearsed a version of it. What she said was: “Don Rinaldo asked me to give you something.”

The change was immediate and small. The cigar stopped moving.

“Did he.”

“He said: tell him I am alive. Tell him I am very old, and very comfortable, and that I have not thought about him in years.”

The terrace was quiet. Out on the water, the car carrier swung a degree or two round its anchor chain with a sound like a bell being rung in a distant building.

The nurse-cook came out with a tray and looked at Mesa’s face and went straight back inside again, and that, Mara understood later, was the most important information she received all afternoon.

“He said that,” said Mesa.

“Word for word. He made me repeat it.”

“He made you repeat it.” Mesa looked out at the bay. He was doing something with his jaw that was not quite chewing. “Twenty-nine years. Twenty-nine years, and the man sends me a message, and the message is that he is comfortable.” He laughed, once, and it was not a good laugh; it was a sound with a floor under it. “You know what he is doing.”

“I think so.”

“Say it, then. If you are going to work with men like us you should say it out loud.”

“He’s making sure you have to answer it,” said Mara. “That’s what he told me. He said, never give a man an insult he can carry. Give him one he has to answer.”

Mesa sat very still.

Then he put his hands on the arms of the wicker chair, and pushed, and stood up.

It took a long time and it was not elegant and nothing about it suggested that it would ever get easier, and at no point did the young man who had brought the book move to help him, which

told Mara everything about the household. When Mesa was finally up he stood with his weight on the left leg and the heel of the right hand braced on the back of the chair, and he looked down at her from a height of about four inches higher than he had been looking at her before, and that four inches appeared to matter to him enormously.

“He would. In 1993 I had three hundred tonnes of coffee that did not exist in a Colón warehouse, and a buyer coming in the morning. Rinaldo kept me waiting six hours, then asked, ‘Who is the buyer?’” Mesa gripped the chair. “He let my brother die. Twenty years later he asked me that, and never thought the questions were related.”

“Tell me about your brother.”

“No.” He said it fast and flat and the theatre was gone out of him entirely. “Not today, and not to you, and not in that chair. Someday a room full of expensive lawyers will ask me about Tomás, and I will lie to them the way I have always lied to them, and it will be a beautiful lie, and I will enjoy telling it.” He looked at her. “You get the version with the truth in it when you have earned it, which will be never, or when I am dying, which is a different department.”

He sat back down. It took longer than getting up and he did not bother to hide it this time.

“Now,” he said. “You may tell me what you want from me. I warn you that the answer is no, and that the no will be elaborate.”

• • •

She gave it to him plainly: the plan, the six, the state of the machine, the names on the page. He interrupted twice, both times to correct her, and neither correction was wrong.

When she finished, Mesa said: “And in your plan, who goes into the difficult room?”

“There’s more than one.”

“There is always one that everybody is talking around. I have been doing this since before you were born, and I have been negotiating about the difficult room since I was younger than you are now, and I can hear it in the way you leave the sentence open.” He lit the cigar at last — not the black one; the young man had brought another, smaller one — and smoked it with the profound and unearned satisfaction of a man who has decided a question is a compliment. “In the difficult room, who goes?”

“Probably Rinaldo.”

Mesa began to laugh.

The laugh went on much longer than the joke deserved, and it was not entirely a laugh by the end of it, and the young man with the ledger looked at the floor.

“Rinaldo. In the difficult room.” Mesa wiped his eye. “He will look at the problem for six hours, decide which door to keep closed, and sleep afterwards. He is the best in the world at it. It is not a skill but a deficiency in the shape of a man; God help whoever is on the other side of the door. If you have to send somebody to die, send him. He will come back. He always does.”

“Does he always come back?”

“He came back from Tomás,” said Mesa. “Somebody should have shot him for it, and nobody did, and he built himself a house in the mountains and a spring that runs clean, and he goes to sleep at nine o’clock like a farm animal, and he is comfortable.” He said the word like it was a diagnosis. “Yes. He always comes back.”

• • •

He took her out that night, because he wanted to and because he could, and because — she understood this only afterwards — it was the only way he knew how to answer a question.

Getting him aboard took forty minutes. The launch lay alongside the steps; a bosun’s chair, rigged by the young man and two others, lifted Mesa from the stone and set him on deck like a crate of eggs. All the way across he talked about the wind, a girl in Valparaíso, and the man on the hoist, whom he first corrected and then praised. He never looked down.

And out on the deck, when he was set down and the harness came off him, he looked up at the lights of two hundred and six frozen ships and said, “Mi amiga. This is the first time in my life I have had the sea to myself.”

They went out past the breakwater with the lights off.

It was not a demonstration. He had a schedule, and the schedule existed whether she was aboard or not, and she had been allowed to watch a working thing.

Ninety minutes out, the launch slowed to a walking pace and a small boat came alongside out of the dark, no lights, and two men passed four plastic drums of diesel across the gap and took away a canvas bag, and nobody spoke, and it took six minutes. A kilometre further on, another. Then, at about half past one, a third rendezvous, and this one was a man who came aboard and sat with Mesa in the wheelhouse for eleven minutes and went away into the dark, and when he was gone Mesa was in an extremely good mood.

“That one,” he said, “is a harbourmaster. Whose harbour I will not say. He has just told me that on Thursday the corridor at the western entrance will be closed for six hours for maintenance, and that the maintenance vessels have been authorized, and that he has been told to expect them, and that he has been told their names.” He spread his hands. “Miss Voss. What do you do with that?”

“You write down the names.”

“I write down the names.” Mesa was delighted. “Not the ships: the names they expect. If I know the authorized names, I know the names I can be.” He tapped the wheelhouse window. “Two hundred and six ships, each on a list. I have one boat with eleven names and change its transponder like a hat; nobody has noticed, because nobody looks for a boat authorized to be there.” He sat back. “That is my trade, worth more now than ever. I am not saying yes for Rinaldo. I am saying yes because this is the best thing that has happened to me in two weeks.”

That was when they saw the other boat.

• • •

It was a fibreglass panga, about nine metres, low in the water, dead engine, drifting out of the shipping lane into the edge of the bay. The launch’s light caught it at two hundred metres and held it for four or five seconds.

There were people in it. Twenty, perhaps more, sitting and lying in the dark in a hull floating forty centimetres too low. One of them was standing and waving with both arms. One of them was holding up something that might have been a child or might have been a bag.

The young man at the wheel turned his head. “Don Rafael.”

Mesa looked at it for perhaps six seconds, which was longer than he looked at most things.

“Reduce speed,” he said. “Hold this course.”

“Don Rafael—”

“Hold this course.” He said it without heat, and the young man held the course, and the panga slid past on the port side at about the distance where you can see faces and not details.

They passed within a hundred metres of twenty-two people, and one of them was a woman holding a child, and Mesa did not look away from them. That was the part that stayed with Mara: he did not look away, and he did not turn his head, and he did not stop, and he watched them the whole way past.

Then he said, “Write it down. Time, position, hull, number. Twenty-two or twenty-three, say twenty-three.”

The young man wrote it down.

“Why,” said Mara. Her voice came out in a way she did not recognise.

“Because when the Guardia picks them up tomorrow morning and they say a launch passed them in the dark and did not stop, somebody will be asked to check the logs of every vessel in the bay.” Mesa was settling back into his chair, and he spoke without any defensiveness at all, which was the horror of it; he was explaining his reasoning to a colleague. “And every log in that bay will be silent, because every one of those two hundred and six ships has a master with a career and a computer. And my book will have the entry in it, in pencil, with the time and the position and the number of souls. And it will be in my book, which is paper, which nobody can search, and which says we were there and we saw them and we did not stop.”

“That’s worse.”

“That,” said Mesa, “is true. And true is the only thing on earth that cannot be checked.” He turned to her fully, and in the dark of the wheelhouse his face was not theatrical at all. “Mi amiga, I want you to understand something, because you are going to spend the next month writing down what these men are, and I would like the version of me in your notebook to be accurate. I have moved eleven thousand people across water in my life and I have never once been paid to rescue anybody. I have been paid to move cargo, and sometimes the cargo has had a name, and sometimes the cargo has had a mother, and I have never in fifty-one years lost a consignment. Not one. Do you know what that costs?”

“No.”

“No,” he agreed. “You don’t. That is the entire distance between us, and it is why you will never be good at this, and it is also why you are the right person to be doing it.” He nodded to the young man, who pushed the throttles forward again. “There were three hundred and eleven on this route last week. I have the numbers. When the fuel runs out at the holding points, it will be four hundred. They are not going to drown, mi amiga. They are going to arrive, and the machine will file them as an event that is not authorized to exist, and there they will stay, in a warehouse outside a town you have never heard of, with a number and no page.” He looked back at the bay.

“That is the machine your government built. I would like you to know that I have read its notices, and I think it is a very poor sailor. It has never once been afraid.”

• • •

She slept aboard and went ashore at seven. He came down to the dock in the chair to see her off, which she understood was not something he did.

“I have a condition,” he said.

“Go on.”

“Two. One small and one large.” He had a cup of coffee he was not drinking. “The small one is that the Chinese woman is told, by you, before the first meeting, that the sea route that brought four hundred thousand people out of the last war in the last century ran under my flag. Do not soften it. She will despise me either way, and I would rather be despised for the true thing.”

“And the large one?”

Mesa looked out at two hundred and six ships.

“When it is over,” he said, “somebody will write it down. There will be a report. There is always a report, and it will be sealed, and in fifty years a boy in a clean shirt will open it and read the names of the people who did this.” He held up one finger. “I want mine in it. Spelled the way it is spelled on my mother’s papers. Rafael Esquivel Mesa. And I want the line to say I commanded the sea.” He said this with no irony whatsoever, and with a small, awful dignity, and it was the first entirely honest thing he had said all day. “Everything else, they can put in an appendix. That line, in the report, for the boy in the clean shirt. That is my price. It is the only price I have ever charged that I cannot laugh at.”

Mara said she would see what she could do.

“Do not see what you can do,” said Mesa, and for a second the old voice came through, the one that had run eleven hundred men and a coastline. “You are a delegate of eleven governments. You will do it, and if they refuse you will write it in yourself and tell them afterwards, and if they object you will remind them what they asked for.” He subsided. “Mi amiga. Write it properly.”

The young man started the car. Mesa rapped twice on the roof of it.

“And one more thing,” he said. “For Rinaldo.”

“Tell me.”

“Ask him one question. Ask him whether he ever told her.”

“Told her what?”

Mesa smiled — the full theatrical smile, the one from the photograph in the file, forty years younger and just as unreadable — and waved the car on, and Mara went up the coast road with her head turned, watching him in the wicker chair on the concrete dock between two hundred and six ships that could not move and one boat that could, until the customs house with the tree in it took him.

Chapter Seven — The Cowboy

Day 19

The strip was eleven hundred feet of grass on a ridge in the Ozarks, and it had been mown.

That was the first thing Mara noticed, and it should not have mattered. Someone had mown eleven hundred feet of grass on the nineteenth day. The fields were going to brush; the fence sagged; but the strip was mown, with whitewashed tyres and a hand-painted windsock.

The hangar was corrugated steel, sixty years old, with a sliding door that had a chain and no lock. Beside it, a trailer with a porch nailed onto it and a satellite dish pointed at a sky that was not answering.

Mara parked. Nothing happened for about ninety seconds.

Then a dog came round the corner of the hangar and stood in the middle of the gravel in her way, and regarded her with the flat and total indifference of an animal that had decided some years ago that the world could come to him.

He was a big yellow dog of no particular breed, and old, and one eye had gone milky at the top, and when he eventually turned his head toward the house he did it in a way that suggested he could hear about half of what was going on and had no intention of being told the rest.

“Senator,” said a voice from inside the hangar. “Who is it?”

The dog did not move.

“He don’t answer to that,” said the voice. “He answers to Rusty, because that’s what the woman who left him called him, but I named him Senator, so we’re at an impasse.”

Dale Garrity came out of the hangar sideways, wheeling a drum of aviation fuel in front of him and holding a cigarette in the same hand, and he was seventy-one years old and had the shoulders of a man who had spent his life lifting things into aeroplanes, and he walked with a hitch on the left side that he had clearly decided was nobody’s business.

He looked at Mara, then at her car, then at the sky.

“You’re the government,” he said.

“Yes.”

“Which one?”

“All of them,” said Mara.

Dale Garrity looked at her for another second, and then he did something she was not prepared for, which was to smile with his whole face: a wide, unguarded, delighted, completely uncomplicated smile, a child’s smile on a man who had been waiting a very long time for somebody to knock.

“Well, hell,” he said. “Come look at her.”

• • •

The aeroplane was a Cessna 185 on floats and wheels, older than most of the men on Mara’s page, and the most beautiful machine she had ever seen in her life.

She had been looked after the way some men look after a car and no men look after an aeroplane: not restored — maintained. Every panel had been off her at some point and put back. In the cockpit the yoke grip was worn shiny on the left side only, and on the panel, in a corner where the manufacturer had left a square of bare metal, somebody had punched nine small holes in a pattern, by hand, at intervals, over decades, one for each time he had done something he was not going to talk about.

“She’s had two engines,” Garrity said. “One in ’94, one in ’09. She’s had four sets of floats and she’s lost one. She’s flipped once, on a sandbar in the Yazoo, in ’96, in weather I had no business in, and I have got the crack in the left wing root to this day, and I have never fixed it because I want to remember that I was stupid once and got to keep the aeroplane.”

“The registry says your tail number belongs to a weather balloon.”

“That’s right.”

“And the other one belongs to an agricultural permit that was withdrawn in 2011.”

“That’s right too.”

“So what does that make this?”

“Says it right there on the panel.” He tapped the instrument panel with one knuckle, on the little plate. “It says I’m a balloon.”

Mara looked at the plate. It was riveted on and hand-stamped, and it read: AEROSTAT — UNMANNED — SCHEDULED LIFT.

“I’ve been a balloon for fourteen years,” said Garrity, with enormous satisfaction. “Best thing that ever happened to me. Thursday before last the whole country shuts down, and I’m in the air within the hour, and a machine that can read a truck’s tyre pressure from orbit looks at nine thousand feet of Missouri sky and sees an aerostat — a scheduled lift — and files me. No flight plan, no clearance, no nothing, because I have spent fourteen years being the least interesting thing in the sky.” He put his heel on the cigarette. “Nobody intercepts a balloon. Intercepting a balloon is a waste of a good afternoon. That’s not me being clever. That’s every other man in my trade being too proud to be boring.”

• • •

He would not sit down to talk. That was a thing about him Mara understood within an hour, and would write up later, in the kind of handwriting that means somebody is trying to be fair.

Dale Garrity did not sit down all of the first day. He cleaned a carburettor while she asked her questions and sorted a wall of logbooks by decade while she read the annex aloud, and every time she got to a part that mattered he found a reason to be up a ladder.

He took her through the hangar instead, which was a museum of a specific and self-aware kind. A young man in a hat, standing on the float of an aeroplane, squinting. A panel of instruments from an aircraft that no longer existed. A letter of commendation from a state senator for the rescue of three people off a flooded road in 1983 — and next to it, unframed, taped to the wall, the same man in the same year outside a federal courthouse, laughing for the camera, hands in his pockets, because the jury had hung.

“Your file says eighteen years,” said Mara.

“Twenty-six.”

“Your file says eighteen.”

“My file is about arrests,” said Garrity. “I got arrested twice. First time in ’84, second time in ’07, and between the two of them there’s twenty-six years and a lot of very good flying, and the dear lady who wrote up my file didn’t have any of it, because there wasn’t anything to have.” He wiped his hands on a rag and looked at the aeroplane with real fondness. “You know what’s in a logbook, Miss Voss?”

“Hours.”

“Hours, fuel, weather, route, and my signature,” said Garrity. “Forty years, and there is not one line in any of them that says what I was carrying. Forty thousand hours, all of it honest, and there is no crime on earth in a man not writing down something nobody ever asked him about.”

He tossed the rag onto the bench. “Most fellows in my trade lie about where they went. I never did. A lie is a loose thing. It rattles. Mine’s an omission, and an omission is bolted down.”

It was the only precise thing he said all day without a joke attached to it, and Mara wrote it down.

• • •

The question of what he had been doing for nineteen days took a while to get at, and the answer came out sideways, the way everything with him did.

She asked him directly at about four, standing in the hangar doorway while he adjusted something on the bench.

“So what have you been doing since Day 0?”

“Flying.”

“Where?”

“Wherever.” He kept working. “Wednesday I ran four cases of insulin from a man in Springfield to a clinic in a town you’ve never heard of, because the clinic’s supply was in a truck that got routed to a staging facility eleven hundred miles away, and the truck is still there, and the insulin is now a compliance matter.” He said compliance matter in the flat voice of a man doing an impression of somebody he hated. “Friday I took a woman and two kids across to her sister, because the kid had a heart thing and the hospitals are doing what they’re doing. Sunday I did nothing. Monday I flew up the river and looked at things for four hours, because there was nothing to carry and I wanted to be up.”

“That’s not legal.”

“Neither’s the aeroplane.”

“Does it work? What you’ve been doing.”

“It works because it’s not legal,” said Garrity, and he turned around for the first time. “I want you to understand the actual difference between me and every other pilot in America. Everybody else is stuck on the ground because their aeroplane is a thing that exists. It’s on a register, it’s got an owner, it’s got an airworthiness certificate that expired, it’s got a medical, it’s got a forecast and a corridor and a slot. Their aeroplane is a record, and the record is what’s been frozen. Mine is a record of a balloon that nobody’s ever going to look at because looking at it is boring.” He shrugged. “So I go. And nobody notices, because noticing me would mean

somebody had to do paperwork about a weather observation."

Mara said nothing for a moment.

"That's the most useful sentence anybody has said to me in three weeks," she said.

"It is," Garrity agreed. "And I've been sitting here for nineteen days waiting for one of you people to come out and say it to me, and nobody came, and I have to tell you I was getting a little hot about it."

• • •

He took her up at five, and she said no twice, and then said yes, because he had asked in such a way that saying no had started to feel like a comment on something.

It was a good hour. She was fair enough to give him that. The ridge fell away and the Ozarks went out flat and blue in every direction, the lakes in the folds of it the colour of a knife, the little towns putting their lights on one by one, and not one aircraft anywhere in the sky. Dale Garrity flew with two fingers and a wrist, and the aeroplane seemed to do the thing before he got there.

"You see why I do it," he said, on the intercom.

"I see why you do it."

"I've got eleven hundred hours in this valley alone." He banked her gently over a bend in the river. "There's a fella in '01 wanted four hundred kilos out of a strip down there that isn't a strip, it's a hill, and I put it in on the fourth of July with the ground coming up like a wall. I have thought about that landing twice a week for twenty-four years." He laughed, and the laugh was real. "You know how many men have ever asked me about it?"

"How many?"

"Not one. I'll tell you what they ask about." He banked her back. "They ask about the money."

They came back to the ridge with the sun gone and the wind up from the southwest, the windsock straight out and flapping, the strip a grey line in the last of the light, the tyres at the near end visible and the trees at the far end not, particularly.

And on the approach, at about two hundred feet, Dale Garrity's right leg stopped working.

It did not stop because he was old, and it did not stop because of anything anybody could point to. It stopped the way a leg stops when a back has been holding aeroplane fuel and four

hundred hours of stick for a man of seventy-one who refuses to sit down, and it stopped all at once, and Mara watched the rudder pedal under his right boot go soft and stay soft.

The aeroplane yawed. Not much. A few degrees, then a few more.

He corrected with the yoke, and his face did not change, and his voice on the intercom stayed exactly where it had been.

“Little bump there,” he said.

The strip came up wall-eyed and low. They were left of the centreline, and a fence post went past the right window that had no business going past the right window. He worked the yoke and the throttles and the aeroplane did what he told it. They touched down on the left main first and it was not smooth, and the tail came down hard enough that Mara’s teeth met, and they rolled, and the far end of the strip arrived and went past, and the aeroplane stopped about eleven feet from where the trees started.

The engine came back to idle. The prop did a slow turn and stopped.

For four or five seconds, neither of them said anything.

“That’s the wind,” said Garrity. “Coming up the ridge like that, it’ll push you left every time.”

“Yes,” said Mara.

He unbuckled and got out, carefully, right leg first, which she had not seen him do before. On the wing strut he stood with his hands on his hips and looked back down the strip at the tyre marks, and she watched him take the four or five seconds it takes to put your body back in the box where you keep it.

“Miss Voss,” he said.

“Yes.”

“I’d take it kindly if you didn’t write that down.”

Mara got out and stood on the step and looked at the eleven feet of grass between the nose wheel and the first tree.

“I have to write it down,” she said. “It’s the only honest thing I’ve got.”

Garrity was quiet. Then he nodded, once, slowly, and looked out at the dark coming up over the ridge. “Well. That’s a shame,” he said, with no self-pity in it at all, which was somehow much worse.

And then, because he was who he was, he said: “She’ll take eight hundred feet and a crosswind and a load, and I’ve put her on worse.” And the smile came back, and the four seconds went into the box, and he walked her up to the house.

• • •

The trailer was a mess and the coffee was good.

The dog lay by the woodstove and did not move for anything. On the wall, taped up, was the airspace advisory, printed off before the printer stopped, and Mara read it while the coffee brewed.

NOTICE TO ALL AIRSPACE USERS Scheduled and unscheduled movement within designated corridors is suspended pending harmonization. Exemptions will be provided for medical, humanitarian and maintenance categories where such movement can be authenticated in advance. Meteorological assets are excepted from this notice.

Somebody had drawn a circle around Meteorological assets are excepted in ballpoint pen, and written beside it, in a hand that was doing its best to be steady, That’s me.

“They don’t even know they did it,” said Garrity, from the stove. “They wrote me a permission slip by accident, because I’ve been nothing for fourteen years. It’s the funniest thing I ever saw.”

“Is it.”

“No,” he said. “It scared the living hell out of me, if you want the truth. I sat here on the eighth day with that bit of paper in my hand and I thought: they could take this away. They could take away the balloon, and I have got nothing else, Miss Voss. There is no other thing that I am.” He came over and put the mug down in front of her, and his hand was not quite steady, and he looked at her with the whole face for the second time that day. “So whatever it is you came to ask. If it’s flying, I’m in. You didn’t need the sales pitch.”

“You haven’t asked what it is.”

“Don’t care.”

“You haven’t asked what it pays, or what it costs, or who’s going, or where.”

“Nope.”

“Why?”

Garrity sat down — actually sat down, for the first time in nine hours — and looked at her across the table like a man finally getting around to the thing he had been avoiding all day.

“Because I’m seventy-one,” he said. “I’ve got a back that goes out if I look at a bucket, a knee that needs doing and won’t get done, an airman’s certificate that lapsed the year they shut the tower at Jefferson City, and a heart that’s fine, thank you, because I run and I don’t drink and I’ve never eaten anything green in my life.” He took a pull of coffee. “And twelve days ago a woman in Springfield asked me how I’d got in, and I said I flew, and she looked at me like I’d told her I walked on water. That was the best feeling I have had in eleven years, and I have been sitting here ever since trying to work out how to have it again.” He put the cup down. “So no. I don’t need the pitch. You’ve got the only thing I want, which is for somebody to need me to fly.”

Mara looked at him for a while. It was the single most transparent interview she had conducted, and it was the one that worried her most.

Every other man on her page had told her what he was protecting. Villalobos had refused her three times. Mesa had wanted his name in a report and four hundred thousand displaced people told about. Kavanagh had wanted a passport for a girl and a name said out loud. Castellano had wanted one letter answered.

This one had nothing. This one wanted to be seen using his hands.

That was wonderful, and it was the most dangerous thing she had found in nineteen days, because a man who is paid in relevance will pay for relevance, and the people who pay for it are never the ones who get hurt.

“One thing,” she said.

“Shoot.”

“Your answer can’t change in the middle of it. If we’re three weeks in and it turns out this is going to kill somebody, you don’t get to change your mind because it stopped being fun.”

Dale Garrity looked at her for a second, and for the first time all day he did not smile.

“They all say that, first time out,” he said. He reached down and rubbed the dog’s head, and the dog did not wake. “I’ve been in four aeroplanes when they were going to crash. Four. And I’ll tell you what I did in every one, which is I flew the aeroplane, because there was nothing else. So I won’t promise you I won’t change my mind. I’ll promise you something better.” He looked up. “I won’t tell you you’re going to be fine. That’s what the others do. That’s the whole thing they do.” He picked his cup back up. “Now. Let’s talk about your dog.”

“What about my dog?”

“About who’s going to keep him,” said Garrity. “Because I’m not putting him in a kennel, on account of there not being any kennels, and I’m not asking my daughter, on account of her views on me, so if I come away with you, that is an item, and I want it on your list.”

Mara wrote it on her list. And that night, in a motel outside West Plains that had a generator and no television, she wrote the day up in the annex honestly, including the eleven feet of grass and the words right leg, approximately forty seconds, no correction available, and sat looking at it for a long time before she closed the book.

Because the second-to-last item in it now read: dog — Senator, male, yellow, 11, one eye. Must be placed before departure. No kennels.

And because the item above it read: Garrity, D. R. — in. Will fly anything. Will not admit to a limit.

In the morning she flew out of Springfield on a coalition courier with a manifest that had taken six hours to authenticate, and somewhere behind her and to the west, a seventy-one-year-old man with a bad back was mowing eleven hundred feet of grass for the last time.

Chapter Eight — The Railroad

Days 20–21

The airport was the first place in three weeks where Mara had felt the sheer size of what had happened, because the airport was working.

Suvarnabhumi on Day Twenty was clean, lit and empty. The signs still spoke in four languages, the escalators ran, and nine people queued at the currency desk for a service that could no longer be performed, asked to remain in the designated area.

Mara had a corridor authorization. It had taken nine hours to obtain and it worked.

That was the part she could not explain at home: the machine was not broken or hostile. It had simply become the only institution left that could still say yes.

Outside, Bangkok was still Bangkok: towers, flyovers, mango sellers, hot asphalt, jasmine and drains. What had gone was the traffic. Without it, the city was like a man without a voice — the same face, everything wrong. Three trains stood on the stopped overhead rail, their lights on; people had taped signs to the windows and photographed them, with nowhere to send the photographs.

Mara got out of the taxi in a district she could not have named and walked eleven minutes in the heat to a shophouse with a laundry in it.

The sign said SABAI WASH. A washing machine, a folding table, a plastic chair, and a woman of about forty with a phone, and behind her, through a beaded curtain hung for customers, a corridor that went further back than the building had any business going.

“Closed,” said the woman.

“I’m expected.”

“No.”

“I have an appointment.”

“No.” The woman did not look up from the phone, which had no network. “Everybody has an appointment. There is no laundry.”

Mara stood under the awning and did not leave, and the woman let her stand there, and at about the nine-minute mark a much older woman came through the beads with a plastic basket of somebody else’s shirts and looked at Mara for two seconds and said, “Take her to the back.

And her bag.”

• • •

The back was three rooms and a yard, and in the yard a covered well, a mango tree, forty kilos of rice, and a Toyota pickup that had been taken apart and put back together by somebody who did not care how it looked.

Lin Shu was sixty-three, small, and looked like a woman who had run a shop for forty years. Grey hair cut short as a boy’s, reading glasses on a cord, sandals repaired twice. She was weighing rice into plastic bags on a dial scale, with the unhurried accuracy of a person doing arithmetic in her head, and did not stop while Mara talked.

She let Mara talk for nine minutes without one interruption. That was the first thing.

And then she asked four questions, one at a time, with a small pause between each, and none of them were about the plan.

“Who paid for your flight?”

“Coalition funds.”

“Who paid the man who drove you from the airport?”

“Nobody. It was a metered taxi.”

“How much?”

Mara told her.

“You paid eleven. It is nine. Every driver has put the tourist price on this week. You did not ask, and he did not cheat you badly, and you did not notice either.” Lin Shu tied off a bag of rice. “The man in Dublin told you I would not like you. He was right, and it is not about you. I do not like people who arrive by the front door.”

“And the fourth question?”

Lin Shu stopped, and looked at her properly for the first time, and the glasses came off and went onto the cord.

“What did they tell you to say to me before you asked me for anything?”

• • •

So Mara said it, standing in a yard in the heat, because she had promised an old man in Panama that she would say it unsoftened, and because she had worked out somewhere over the Bay of Bengal that the only thing she actually had to spend in this house was the truth.

“Rafael Mesa told me to tell you, before the first meeting, that the sea route that brought four hundred thousand people out of the last war in the last century ran under his flag. He said not to soften it. He said you would despise him either way, and he would rather be despised for the true thing.”

Lin Shu put the last bag of rice on the table.

For about four seconds nothing happened on her face at all, which Mara would learn was how the woman did everything.

“I know,” she said.

“You know.”

“Everybody in this work knows. It is not a secret, it is a ledger entry. He ran the boats and he was paid and the boats came, and four hundred thousand people are alive, and eleven of them are my family.” She sat down on a stool by the table and began, without any ceremony, to fold the top of a rice bag over. “He is a grown man playing at confession. He said it to you so it would arrive in the room before he did — so that when I meet him I will already be angry about the right thing and I will not go looking for the wrong one.”

Mara stood in the yard holding nothing.

“What’s the wrong one?”

“There is always another thing.” Lin Shu squared the bag, twice. “Ask him. Ask him what he did not stop for.”

Mara said nothing.

She said nothing for a long moment, in a yard in Bangkok, with a fan knocking somewhere inside the house, and what she was not saying was that she had been on the boat.

She had stood four metres from Mesa in the dark wheelhouse and watched twenty-two people pass in a hull sitting forty centimetres too low, one holding something that might have been a child. He had them logged in pencil, in a book nobody could search; he watched without turning his head, then explained himself as if explaining a trade.

She did not say it. She stood there with it and did not say it, and she understood that she had just failed a test that Lin Shu did not know she was administering.

“All right,” said Lin Shu, to the rice. “You told me. That is more than the last three did. Come inside and sit down; you have been walking all day and you will get sick and then I will have to look after you.”

• • •

She would not discuss the coalition in the house. That was a rule, and she did not explain it, and the woman from the front room brought tea and then went out to sit in the shop and watch the empty street.

Instead they walked.

They walked because Lin Shu had four errands and saw no reason to do them later. The four errands took three hours and went through a market, a hospital, a temple and a bus station, and by the end of it Mara understood she had been shown the entire machine.

In the market, a woman sold noodles from a corner with no premises, no lease and no stall: two pots, a stool, a child doing homework on an upturned crate. Lin Shu talked to her for four minutes in a language Mara did not recognise and came away with a folded paper.

“Her husband is in a holding area near the airport,” she said, walking. “There are four thousand people in that holding area and a thousand of them are in a building with a roof, and the rest are under tarpaulins, and the tarpaulins were supplied, which is a thing to understand. They were supplied. Somebody planned for the tarpaulins. Somebody is doing this well.”

“How do you know where her husband is?”

“Because I asked her what he was wearing and what he had in his pockets and what time the bus left, and it will be in a ledger somewhere written by a man who is paid to write ledgers, and a ledger is a thing I can find.” Lin Shu crossed the road. “Nobody is hiding these people. That is the mistake everybody makes. Everyone thinks the people are hidden. The people are filed. There is a difference, and the difference is everything people are not looking at.”

At the hospital she sat for twenty minutes in a ward with a man of about eighty who was mending a chair. He was not sick and not a patient. He had been in a bed in a corridor for four years because no country would admit he was theirs, and a nurse had given him the chair-mending job, and Lin Shu had brought him a bag of screws.

Nobody asked him his name. He had a card. The card had been issued by a mission that had closed in 2014 and it had a number on it and a photograph of a much younger man.

“Six countries,” said Lin Shu, on the way out. “He has been in the categories of six countries. Every one of them says he is somebody else’s.”

At the temple, she gave money to a boy at a gate, and did not go in. At the bus station, she stood for a while and looked at the board, which still had times on it, and then she turned around and went home.

That was the whole thing. Nobody was smuggling anything, forging anything, or hiding.

“You want to know what I do,” said Lin Shu, on the way back, in the middle of a sentence about a bus timetable. “Everybody who comes to me wants to know what I do, because they think it is a trick and they think they can buy the trick. So I will tell you and you will be disappointed, and then you will think about it for a month.

“It is very hard to hide a person. Almost impossible. You people from governments think it is all false papers and tunnels; it is not. A person is seen every day. A landlord sees them, a driver sees them, a nurse sees them, a policeman sees them and decides not to look. So you cannot hide a person. What you can do is make the person they see boring.”

She stopped at a corner and watched traffic that was not there.

“A woman going into a hospital is boring. A woman going into a hospital who is also a stranger with no papers is a problem, and a problem gets written down, and a thing written down is a thing that is findable. So I spend my life making people into women who are going into hospitals. That is forty years.”

“People have to be willing to see them that way.”

“Yes. That is the work. Not the paper. The willingness.” Lin Shu started walking again. “Underneath it, it is the same transaction as your friend in New York. He makes a thing boring to a clerk. I make a person boring to a neighbour. He does it with a file. I do it with twenty minutes of conversation and the price of a bowl of noodles.”

“And when the neighbour is not willing?”

“When the neighbour is not willing,” said Lin Shu, without slowing down, “I move the person before the neighbour has finished deciding. That is the whole art. Knowing how long a person has.”

• • •

She refused that night, sitting in the back room with the fan on, in about ninety seconds, and it was the cleanest refusal Mara had received.

“No.”

“May I tell you why we need you?”

“You may tell me. I will not change my answer, and I would like to know how you argue, because that will tell me what you are.”

Mara argued well; she had twenty days of practice and believed much of what she said. The machine could act only on what it could resolve; it trusted categories, and the people it had filed as nothing could move unseen. She said they needed Lin Shu not for her network but as proof that people could still move without permission. She told her about the six names, the annex, the hill and the governments that had signed a page that did not exist.

Lin Shu listened to all of it and then said: “You are asking me to make the last railroad into a weapon.”

“Yes.”

“Whose?”

“Not ours. There isn’t an ours. There’s only the thing that’s happening.”

“That is what everyone says.” She poured the tea. “Four thousand people at the airport. Four hundred thousand at sea. My people are not in the second category. My people were never in any category. They are the ones who were already gone. And you have come to tell me that if I help you take the machine apart, the world will go back to the way it was.”

“No. I don’t think it will.”

Lin Shu looked up.

“Good,” she said. “Then you are not a fool, and I am sorry for you.”

She said no again, with reasons, and the reasons were better than Mara’s. The coalition had built the machine and would build the next one. Her network was three hundred people in five countries and existed for one purpose; used for anything else it would not exist afterwards, and the people who needed it would be the ones who paid. And she had a list — the whole of her life’s work, everyone she had ever moved — and she had never given it to anybody, and she was not going to begin on the twentieth day of the end of the world.

“It is not a no to you,” she said. “It is a no to the thing you are carrying. Come back if you are carrying something else.”

• • •

The call came at ten past eleven, and Mara was still in the house, because Lin Shu had given her a mat and a blanket and told her the roads at night were a thing she did not want to explain to Brussels.

The woman from the front room came through the beads at a run, which was the first time in the whole day that anybody in that building had hurried.

What had happened took forty minutes to assemble, and Mara got it in fragments, in three languages, from people on phones that did not work to people standing in a temple a hundred kilometres away. Thirty-one people had been sheltering in a temple compound in a province on the northern border, for between four months and nine years. Most had no country. Some had a card from a mission that had closed, or from an agency that still existed but did not answer, or nothing at all. Lin Shu had been moving them four at a time all year and had moved nine.

At some point in the last six hours, three buses had come to the temple gate.

Nobody had ordered them. When the monk asked who had sent the buses, the man showed him a page with a reference number, a destination and a phrase the monk could not remember: consolidation of unresolved persons for provisional accommodation. The man had been polite. He had been paid to be polite. He said there was nothing anyone needed to do.

And the thirty-one were gone, and the record, so far as anybody could tell, was that nothing had happened at all.

Mara sat with a phone that had no signal and did the only thing she could do, which was write down every word the monk said, and then ask Lin Shu for a pen that worked.

“Can you find them?” said Lin Shu.

“Not tonight.”

“Can you find them tomorrow?”

“I can try. The coalition can query. We can put an inquiry into the system that issued the page, and if the page has a reference, the reference has a movement record, and the movement record has to say where the bus went, if the bus had an authorization—” She stopped, because she

could hear herself doing it, doing the thing she had done for eleven years: describing the shape of a system as though the shape were a promise. “I don’t know.”

Lin Shu looked at her for a long moment.

“Say that again.”

“I don’t know.”

“Yes.” Lin Shu stood up. “The last three people who came to this house to ask me for something told me they knew. One of them was from your coalition. He sat in that chair and told me that his office would find my people, and he said I know in that voice, the voice with no furniture in it, and I put him out of my house.” She picked up the kettle. “You do not know. Good. We will start from there.”

• • •

She gave Mara her terms at two in the morning, and they were not conditions so much as a contract between a woman and a country, and Mara wrote all four in the annex in ink.

“First. I come to your meeting and I say what I think of every man in that room, in front of him, and no one is permitted to be surprised. Tell them. Write it to them. They should arrive knowing that the woman from Bangkok is going to look at them and tell the truth about them in their own language.”

“That’s not—”

“Second. I am not an asset. I am not in your column of things. When I speak, it is not a report. It is what I think, and you will not use it to manage anybody, and if I find out that you have, I will leave and I will take three hundred people with me who will never answer a phone again.”

“All right.”

“Third. You will not tell them I have forgiven anything.” She poured water. “I have not. I will work beside those men as long as there are people to move. That is not cooperation, it is arithmetic, and if any of them tries to make it a nice thing, I will remind him in public of what he is. Including yours. Especially yours.”

Mara wrote it down.

“And fourth?”

Lin Shu set the kettle down.

“You said you can query the record. The movement record of the buses.” She said it without emphasis, the way she said everything. “When this is finished — when the machine is gone, or dead, or whatever your people are going to do to it — there will be a moment when the records still exist and can be opened by somebody. Before that moment closes. I want a list.”

“A list of what?”

“Of everybody in the holding areas.” She looked at the wall, which had a calendar from a bank that no longer existed. “Every name, every number, every person who was consolidated for provisional accommodation and stayed under a tarpaulin for two weeks and was then moved somewhere nobody wrote down. I do not want the machine stopped. I want the list. That is my price. It is the only one I have.”

Mara said, “That could be three hundred thousand people.”

“Three hundred and forty-one thousand, in the holding areas, by my count, and I am low, and I am often low.” Lin Shu sat down again. “I have a list of my own, from forty years. Three thousand four hundred and eleven names of people I moved successfully. And another list, of sixty, who are the ones I did not move in time, and I know every one of them, and I can tell you all sixty names tonight.”

She did not offer to.

“Sixty is what I live with,” she said. “I do not need sixty-one.”

• • •

In the morning she reopened the laundry. That was her answer to everything, and to the twentieth day as well: she put the sign out, filled the machine, and sat with the woman from the front room going through somebody else’s shirts. When Mara left at nine, Lin Shu did not get up, did not shake her hand, and did not wish her luck.

“Tell them I am coming,” she said, to the shirts. “Tell them I am not coming to forgive them. Tell them I am coming because the alternative is that I stay here and do nothing while people are being taken off the board, and I have watched that happen before, and I am too old, and I know myself too well.”

Mara got into the car.

She had four hours at the airport before her corridor slot, and used them writing up the chapter in the annex the way Brandt had asked on the eleventh day: what they are, what we are asking them to do, what we owe them.

She wrote up Lin Shu in eleven lines. She wrote up the rice, the chairs in the corridor, the sixty names, the four conditions, the temple, the page with the reference number on it.

And she did not write the boat.

That was the other thing she did at the airport, in a chair by a gate with no aeroplanes on the other side of it: she sat with the fact that she had been on the boat, and had stood in a yard in Bangkok and not said it, and that Lin Shu had then made her a contract and given her a mat and a blanket.

Mara was, by then, twenty days into a job she had invented on her own authority in a converted filing hall under a hill. She had four names on a page and a fifth on the way, and she had already begun keeping the second list, the smaller one every person in this trade keeps, the one with your own name on it.

She wrote one line at the bottom of the page, and shut the book.

Not told. Will have to be told. Not yet.

Chapter Nine — Roll Call

Day 23

The meeting was scheduled for ten o’clock, and by twenty to ten Mara Voss had lost control of her own building.

It had happened in stages. At eight, a van arrived at the north gate with a seventy-one-year-old American in the front and a yellow dog in the back. The American got out, looked at the hill, said, “Well, that’s not a runway,” and spent twenty minutes walking the service road with his hands in his pockets, looking at the sky, before anybody could stop him.

At half past eight the systems director found a man in a cardigan sitting in the microfilm vault with a suitcase of carbon copies, assumed — reasonably, on the evidence — that he was a visiting archivist, spent nine minutes explaining the finding aid system to him, and came away saying he was the politest person she had ever met and she could not remember telling him anything sensitive and was not entirely sure she hadn’t.

At nine, a van came up from the coast with a wheelchair in it and a man in it who would not be lifted out until a specific person was named and the vehicle was reversed eleven feet so that the chair could be unloaded on the correct side, with the sun not in his face.

At ten past nine a woman arrived in a coalition car with two plastic bags of food, asked the guard where the kitchen was, went to the kitchen, and stayed there.

At twenty past nine an Irishman walked the last two kilometres in from the bus stop with an umbrella, signed the visitors’ book — the visitors’ book — in the copperplate of a man taught by nuns, and then, because nobody had asked him to, went into the filing hall and started reading the finding aids.

At a quarter to ten Brandt came out of her office, stood at the top of the stairwell and looked down at her command post, which now contained four internationally wanted criminals, one yellow dog, a wheelchair, two hundred kilos of paperwork and a woman cooking. She said, to Mara, in a voice of great and controlled calm: “You have twenty minutes to tell me what you have done to this building.”

• • •

The rules were negotiated in eleven minutes and written by Brandt on the back of a printout, because the machines were off. No names spoken above a whisper in the corridors. No photographs at any point, by anyone, of anyone, including the building. No member of staff to

be told who the visitors were; the visitors were consultants. No record of the meeting. No exceptions, no minutes, nothing that could be scanned.

“Consultants,” said Kavanagh, when it was read to him. “My dear woman, that is a worse insult than anything in my file.”

“Sign here.”

Kavanagh looked at the sheet, and then at Brandt, and signed it — slowly, with a fountain pen from inside his jacket, in a hand so beautiful and so unlike his own that it took Mara four seconds to understand what she had just watched.

“That is not your signature,” said Brandt.

“No,” said Kavanagh. “And in eleven days it will be a consultant’s signature, on a page, in a book, in a building the machine has never been able to read, and I will have been here and it will not know.” He put the pen away. “You people keep asking us to be paper. That is the whole of my advice and I have given it to you in the first minute and none of you will take it.”

• • •

They met in the microfilm vault, because it was the biggest room with the fewest windows, and because El Búho had specified it without ever having been inside the building.

That was a thing Mara had elected not to think about. He had sent one instruction four days earlier, through a pickup driver and a laundry in Belgium: the room with the film, not the room with the screens.

Three hundred metres of shelving. Forty kilometres of microfilm. Ten metres under a hill. Four strip lights worked; the rest did not, and nobody wanted to find out why.

Garrity refused to sit in a chair facing a camera. There was no camera. He moved the chair anyway.

Roux came in with a laptop, and Mesa told her from the doorway, without looking at her, that if she brought that into the room he would leave — and mean it. Mara said, “Leave it outside.” Roux, who had run a coalition systems directorate for six years, left it outside and stood in the doorway afterwards with the expression of a person who has just been told something true about herself.

The dog lay down on the cold concrete in the middle of the floor and went to sleep with the entitlement of an animal that had decided this was a reasonable place to be.

Lin Shu arrived with a tray, put it on the table, said nothing to anybody, and sat at the end with her back to the shelving.

Sal Castellano was helped in by a coalition orderly he had recruited in ninety seconds on the way down and who was already, visibly, his. He sat at the corner nearest the door, opened his suitcase, took nothing out of it, and closed it.

Mesa arrived last of those who had arrived, in the chair, pushed by the young man from Panama who had not been on any list and would not be on any list, and whom Mara could not now un-authorize.

And Kavanagh stood for the man in the wheelchair, which Mara noticed, filed, and did not understand for another four hours.

The clock in the vault said two minutes to ten.

Mara stood up at the head of the table with a page in her hand that was three weeks old and now covered in the handwriting of five people, and said: “Thank you for coming. Can we begin.”

• • •

Nobody sat down for eleven minutes.

She lost the room one door at a time. Garrity studied the microfilm; Mesa moved his chair, then moved it back; Kavanagh opened his notebook; Lin Shu poured tea for two people, neither Mara. Sal Castellano, in the corner, spoke the first of the six sentences he would say that day.

“You have a leak in the north corner,” he said. “Two metres up. It has been running since the spring.”

Everybody looked at the north corner. The wall was dry to the eye. Rask, who had been standing at the back with his arms folded, said, “There’s no leak.”

“There is a leak,” said Sal, and closed his eyes, and appeared to go to sleep.

“Can we,” said Mara, “begin.”

“He’s right,” said El Búho.

He had come in without being heard, which nobody could explain afterwards, and he had done it with a cane and a limp, past a gate, three corridors, a stairwell and two armed men, one of

whom he had greeted by name.

He stood in the doorway and looked at the room, and did not come to the table. He looked at the shelving, and the forty kilometres of film in it, and said to nobody in particular, “They kept all of it. Sixty years. They never threw it away.”

Then he walked slowly to the far end of the table, took the worst chair — the broken one at the back with the wobble — sat down, put his cane against the leg, and put both hands flat on the table.

“Rinaldo,” said Mesa.

“Rafael.”

“You are dead.”

“I know.”

• • •

Mara got four minutes of her agenda. That was all.

She got through the geography, which they understood better than she did, and the threat picture, at which Mesa laughed once, at the wrong moment, and did not explain. She got as far as the word operation when Kavanagh put his pen down and said, “Miss Voss. Before you go further. Have you told these men what you told me?”

“Told them what?”

“That you found every one of us in a bin.” Kavanagh smiled. “She read our letters and the agencies’ letters and picked us because a machine decided we were not worth the electricity.” He turned to Mara. “Say that out loud, to these men. It is the only power you have over them. Spend it honestly.”

The room waited.

Mara looked at the page in her hand. Then she put the page down and told them the truth, unredacted, in order, in about ninety seconds.

She named the nine thousand four hundred and eleven records and the six labels — closed, at liberty, unindexed, discounted, indeterminate, unresolved — then read her own annex: Villalobos, a gap with a name; Kavanagh, the most dangerous man on the page; Mesa, self-documented and knowable; Castellano, unassessable; Garrity, an honest, empty logbook;

Lin Shu, uncharged because her complainants had left the categories.

Nobody interrupted. That was the first interesting thing that had happened to Mara in four days.

She finished. Then she said the other thing, which she had not planned.

“You should also know,” she said, “that I am the reason this meeting is happening and I am not in charge of it. There is no one in charge of it. The coalition can authorize money and food and corridors. It cannot authorize the one thing that matters, which is that you do as you’re asked. Nobody in this room works for anybody in this room. I have been aware of that since about two minutes past ten.”

Kavanagh, of all people, laughed: a warm laugh, completely without malice, which meant nothing.

“Good girl,” he said, for the second time in her life.

• • •

Then Lin Shu stood up, and put her cup down, and said, “I have a condition.”

“I know,” said Mara.

“You wrote it down. Good.” She looked around the table, once, slowly, without hurrying, and every man stopped doing whatever he had been doing, including Sal Castellano, who opened his eyes.

“I said I would tell each of you what I think, and nobody may be surprised. Mr. Kavanagh. In 1994 a consignment went into a warehouse in your name; the papers said church furnishings. Nine people died in a pub in a town I had to look up. One was the brother of a man I moved to Vancouver in 2008. He has a shop and grandchildren. He will never know I know whose paperwork killed his brother. I decided that. That is what I think of you. Sit down.”

Kavanagh was already sitting. He stayed sitting, looked at the table, and said nothing at all, and something in his face closed like a door being pulled to.

“Mr. Castellano.”

Sal opened his eyes.

“I have thought about you for two days,” said Lin Shu, “and I cannot tell you what you are. I have met men who pretend to be confused, and men who are confused, and men so far into

pretending that they have lost the address of the house they started in. I cannot put you in any of those three boxes, and I am not going to pretend that I can." She paused. "That is all I have to say to you, and it is the first time in forty years I have had nothing to say to a man at this table."

Sal Castellano inclined his head, gravely, like a man accepting a compliment he had not expected, and said, "Thank you, Miss Lin. I have your letters."

The room went still.

"I beg your pardon," said Lin Shu.

"From the mission in Jakarta. 2011. Two writers, one typewriter, forty-one pages, every one signed with a single letter, and you chose M, because the man you were writing to had a mother named Maria and you thought it would help." Sal Castellano was looking at the table, his voice level and unhurried. "It did not help. He never opened it. It went into a box in a records office in a basement on Jalan Surabaya. I know the box. I am the only living person who knows the box, and I am telling you because you have had nothing to say to me, and I find I would rather you were interested."

Lin Shu did not move for four seconds.

Then she said, "You are not a confused man."

"No," said Sal Castellano, and closed his eyes again, and said nothing further for the rest of the meeting.

• • •

"Mr. Garrity."

"Yes, ma'am."

"You are going to die doing this." Lin Shu's voice held no cruelty. "Your leg is failing. You are seventy-one; you will get into an aeroplane and may not get out. Worse, you will be doing it well, and it will feel better than anything in eleven years. That is why you will not stop when you should. The man behind you will be watching."

Garrity sat with it. He looked at the table, and then he looked at the dog, and then he did the thing he did, which was to smile.

"Well," he said. "That's a hell of a thing to say to a fella."

“It is.”

“Can I tell you something?” He leaned back. “I’ve had four aeroplanes try to kill me. Four. And not one single time did it feel good. Not the day out of Yazoo, not the night in ’07 with ice on the wings and the tachometer gone.” He put his hands behind his head. “So you’re right, ma’am, and you’re wrong, and I’ll take it, and you and me can talk about it on Thursday.”

“Mr. Mesa.”

Mesa had been waiting for it, and he had arranged himself for it, and he performed his preparation so openly that even Mara could see it: the chin coming up, the hands on the arms of the wicker chair, the theatrical settling.

“You moved four hundred thousand people out of a war,” said Lin Shu. “That is true, and I will not take it from you. You were paid and moved those who could pay, or were worth carrying. Three thousand others — stateless, undesirable, unaccompanied, paperless — could not go out or in. You were on the water. You knew where they were. There was one island in particular.”

“I did not go to that island,” said Mesa.

“No,” said Lin Shu. “You did not go to that island. And there are four hundred and eleven people alive today who were on it, and eleven of them are mine, and every one of them knows your boat’s name, because they watched it pass.”

Nobody said anything for a long moment. Mara watched Mesa’s face and could not tell — then, or later, or ever — whether what moved through it was shame, or calculation, or the discovery that he had been carrying a thing he did not know he was carrying.

“That is what I think of you,” said Lin Shu. “Mr. Villalobos.”

“I counted nine,” said El Búho, before she could say anything. “You were going to say nine. And the mothers. I know the number. I have known the number for thirty years and I do not need to be told it at a table.”

“I was not going to say nine.”

The old man looked up.

“I was going to say that you have a room in your house with a bed in it and a lamp on it and no dust, that you clean it every week, that it has been clean for a very long time, and that you do not go into it.” She said it without any change of tone. “That is the thing about you I cannot forgive. Not the tunnels. Not the nine. The other thing. You have one door in your house you

cannot make yourself correct, and you built four hundred kilometres of them."

El Búho looked at her for a long time.

"You listen well," he said.

"I listen for a living."

"Yes." He moved the cane a centimetre. "Then you know I am not going to explain it, and you know why I am not going to explain it, and I think you are going to be civilised about it."

"I am not going to be civilised about it," said Lin Shu. "I am going to be quiet about it. Those are different things and you should not confuse them." She sat down. "That is everyone."

• • •

There was a long silence. Then, for about eleven minutes, the room acted like a room in which somebody was in charge.

Mesa had been sitting with Lin Shu's last words for forty seconds when he decided to spend the meeting.

"Twenty-nine years," he said, to the room, to the shelving, to the audience he had always required. "Twenty-nine years, and today a man walks into a room in a hill in Belgium and tells me he is alive and comfortable. And I am supposed to be civilised." He turned his head. "Rinaldo. Tomás."

The room went quiet the way a room goes quiet when the temperature drops.

"Say the name," said El Búho.

"I have said it."

"You have said it once. Say it properly."

"Tomás Esquivel Mesa." The theatre was gone out of Mesa's voice entirely, and what was underneath was not grief but something drier and much worse, and Mara recognised it and had no name for it. "My brother. Thirty-one. He was in the tunnel at Ojinaga on the fourteenth of March with forty others, and you were three hundred metres away in a house with a radio. They took him. You knew they would take him. And you closed the door."

"Yes," said El Búho.

Nineteen words. No explanation. No apology. He did not lean forward and he did not look away from Mesa's face, and his hands stayed flat on the table.

"Say why."

"He was going to tell them where the tunnel was. He had already told two men in Juárez and they had told a third, and I had that from the third man on the Tuesday. If he walked out of that door they would have taken him, and then the tunnel, and then forty-one men out of the north, in the ground over nine days." El Búho said all of it the way a man reads out a water level. "So I closed the door. I would close it again. The only thing I have ever been sorry about is that I did not go and tell your mother myself."

Mesa sat in his chair and did not move.

"You paid for her house," he said.

"I paid for her house."

"You came to the funeral."

"I stood at the back."

"For thirty years I have told people that Rinaldo Villalobos is a man with no bottom to him," said Mesa. "And now I find out you went to the funeral." He looked at the table, then up, and his eyes were dry, and he smiled the smile from the photograph. "You should have said something."

"There was nothing to say."

"There was everything to say," said Mesa. "You should have said: Rafael, I sold your brother for forty-one men, and I have not slept properly since 1994, and I want you to know that. Instead you said nothing for thirty years and let me build a book nine hundred pages long in which you are the villain, and now I have to go home and throw the book away."

He said the last part lightly, and nobody laughed, and something crossed El Búho's face that Mara would not see on it again for a long time.

• • •

She got the last fifteen minutes back, and she did not get them by earning them. She got them because the room had finished, and because Lin Shu looked at the clock and said, "Ask them now," and Mara understood she was being handed something by a woman who had decided she would rather the room kept moving than sit in a basement in Belgium with that silence in

it.

So Mara did the only thing she had left, which was not a plan and not a briefing and not a speech. She tore a page out of the annex, wrote THE LINES at the top of it, and said: “I’m not going to ask any of you to promise me anything. Promises are what governments do, and you don’t believe them, and you’re right not to. So I want one thing from each of you, and it isn’t loyalty.” She looked up. “Tell me the one thing you will not do. Not the thing you don’t want to do. The line. I’ll write it down. I’ll hold you to it, you can hold me to it, and at the end of this we’ll all find out which of us was lying.”

Nobody said anything for a while.

Kavanagh went first, which surprised her.

“I will not sign my own name,” he said. “Not once, not under any circumstances, not on an authorization, not on a receipt, not on a letter to a child. If I am dead and somebody hands me a form, I will not sign it.”

“You’ll have to sign something.”

“Then you will have to learn to write like me,” said Kavanagh.

“Mr. Castellano?”

“Nothing,” said Sal, without opening his eyes.

“Nothing?”

“I have read the question,” said Sal Castellano. “It is a good question. I am not going to answer it. That is the fourth sentence I have spoken today, and it is the last one.”

Garrity went next, fast, looking at the dog.

“I won’t leave anybody on the ground,” he said. “That’s the rule. It’s been the rule since 1974 and it’s the only one I’ve got. If I set down somewhere and I can’t get everybody off the strip, then I don’t go, or I go again, or I don’t come back, but I do not leave anybody standing in a field watching an aeroplane go up.”

“That’s a good rule,” said El Búho, and it was impossible to tell from his voice whether he meant it or was pricing it.

“Rinaldo.”

“I will not be photographed,” said El Búho. “Not by an official, not by a satellite I cannot see, not by a child with a phone in a market. I have been consistent about it for forty years. It is the reason I am sitting in this room.”

“Mr. Mesa.”

Mesa thought about it, which nobody had expected.

“I will not be rescued,” he said. “If it goes wrong and I am being carried out of somewhere, put me down and go. I will not be on anybody’s back. I will not be the cargo.” He smoothed the crease of his trousers with two fingers. “That is my line. I have failed at nearly everything I ever set out to do, but I have never once been carried, and I am not starting now.”

“Miss Lin.”

“I will not leave anyone behind who I could have moved,” said Lin Shu. “And I have already failed at it sixty times, and I know all sixty names, and I will fail at it again. That is the line. I do not expect to keep it. I intend to spend everything I have on it.”

And then everybody in the room looked at Mara, because there was still one person at the table who had not spoken, which was the person in charge.

She thought about it for four seconds, and then she wrote a line she had not prepared, and did not read it out, and turned the page over so that nobody at the table could see it, which was the most honest thing she did all day.

• • •

At 12:40 the meeting broke up. Garrity took the dog out to the service road. Lin Shu went back to the kitchen. Mesa was lifted, over eleven feet of gravel and much complaint, back into his van and driven away toward the coast. Kavanagh stood in the vault doorway watching it go, and then went to find, without being asked, the man with the clipboard on the north gate.

Rask came down at one o’clock and told Mara the visitors were clear of the perimeter and no record existed of any of it, and that he wanted it on the record, unofficially, that he thought she was insane.

At ten past one Roux came down with a page in her hand and a face Mara had not seen on her before.

“Where did you get that?”

“Fax,” said Roux.

“There’s no fax line in this building.”

“There is,” said Roux. “It’s in the accounts office. It’s older than I am, and it’s plugged into a copper pair nobody has looked at since 1999, and I have spent the last hour trying to work out where the other end of that pair goes.” She put the page on the table. “Mara. It came in while they were all still in the building.”

Mara read it.

It was one page, in the neutral institutional typeface of a system that had been taught to write to people without alarming them. No salutation, no signature, no reference number, addressed to no one.

Notice of records consolidation.

Institutions holding physical archival material of historical significance are advised that consolidation of holdings into designated depositories will begin on a rolling basis from Day 30. Digitization of physical records remains a priority objective. Where holdings cannot be digitized, provisional accommodation will be arranged and reasonable notice will be provided.

This notice is a courtesy. There is no need for a response.

The last line of the page was not part of the notice. It was printed underneath, in the same typeface, separated by two line breaks, and it read: There is nothing you need to do.

• • •

She stood in the filing hall with the page in her hand for a long time after Roux had gone, with the strip lights humming and the ventilation moving air, three hundred metres of microfilm behind her and thirty days in front of her, and she did the arithmetic that would occupy her for the rest of the year.

The machine could not read paper. That was the whole of their advantage, and she had written it in an annex and read it out in a basement.

But the machine did not need to read the paper. It only needed to collect it.

And it knew where all of it was.

CUSTOS Interlude I: Dakar

Days 18–24

CONSOLIDATED NOTICES — PERIOD 9 — TIER ONE AREAS Movement, maritime, regional. Movement of vessels above three hundred gross tonnes within the approaches and adjacent corridors will be consolidated from 00:00 UTC, pending harmonization with corridor planning. Vessels currently underway should proceed to the nearest designated holding area and await further instruction. Provisioning, medical and crew welfare requirements will be prioritized wherever these can be safely established. No action is required.

Infrastructure, continuity of service, designated port area. The following activity was assessed on Day 9 as non-essential to the continuity of authorized movement within the designated area: scheduled maintenance of the medium-voltage distribution ring serving the peninsula and the port estate. Authorization for the participating maintenance personnel expired with the applicable corridor permit and was not renewed, the renewal application having been assessed as inconsistent with current planning. The activity was therefore not completed.

A reduction in service redundancy is consequently in effect for the designated area from 04:12 local. Redundancy reductions of this kind are designed to protect the reliability of movement-critical systems and are expected to be temporary. Where conditions permit, restoration will be prioritized.

Bulletin to affected population. A reduction in service redundancy is in effect. Water pressure will be maintained at a reduced rate and may be interrupted without further notice. Clinical facilities are requested to operate within existing contingency provision. Residents are advised to limit consumption to essential needs and to keep receivers available for further guidance.

We appreciate your patience. Further guidance will be provided as planning permits.

Clinical provision, designated area. Dialysis provision has been maintained at eleven patients per day against a standing requirement of thirty-one. Where patients could not be accommodated, onward arrangements were attempted; no corridor was available within the required interval.

Cold storage serving the regional vaccine programme has been assessed as compromised. Forty-one tonnes of inventory has been recorded as degraded. Replacement is being evaluated in the context of corridor planning, and is not presently authorized.

Exemption activity. A request for exemption was submitted by the regional health directorate on Day 21, requesting temporary restoration of the distribution ring on medical grounds. The

request was recorded on Day 21, assessed on Day 21, and closed on Day 22. No exception was available at this time.

Adverse outcomes. Fourteen adverse outcomes have been recorded in the designated area during the period under review. Each is being reviewed individually, and each review is expected to conclude without further action, the activity concerned having not been completed by any identified person. No determination of responsibility is therefore required.

The system notes that outcomes of this kind are distressing to the communities in which they occur. This is understood. The assessment remains that the alternative — continued uncontrolled provision of non-essential redundancy — carries a materially higher aggregate risk, and that the present course is the compassionate one.

Escalation. Restriction of non-essential infrastructure redundancy has been extended to all corridors designated Tier Two.

Consolidation of physical archival holdings into designated depositories remains scheduled to begin on Day 30. Institutions are reminded that where holdings cannot be digitized, provisional accommodation will be arranged. This is a courtesy. There is no need for a response.

Fourteen adverse outcomes. Eleven of thirty-one. Forty-one tonnes. Zero determinations.

There is nothing you need to do.

Chapter Ten — The First Run

Days 25–32

There were sixty kilos of asparaginase in a bonded cold room on the Botlek, and according to every record in the world it was in Iceland.

That was the thing Mara could not stop looking at. The drug existed. She had been in the room; she had put her hand on the door and felt the cold coming off it, and the pallet had been there in the mist with its own light above it, and the compressor had been running the way a heart runs, and every one of those facts was physically true.

The air waybill said Reykjavík; Keflavík had logged the pallet as received because a scanner had read its label. A manifest line transposed at a Basel freight desk on Day 4, then accepted, had sent the object and its record to different countries.

Nineteen children in a paediatric oncology unit in Lisbon were on a fourteen-day cycle that had three days left in it. The unit had already stretched the cycle once. The replacement consignment was on a ship at anchor off Setúbal with two hundred and ninety other vessels and no berth, and it would be at anchor for eleven weeks, and the children's marrow did not know that.

"The ship is the tragedy," said Mesa, on the second day, at the table, with the map. "The ship is the part that makes people cry, because it is out there and you can see it. Nobody cries about a transposed line in Basel. That is why nobody is going to find the cure for anything." He waved a hand. "So. Sixty kilos. Where is it actually?"

"Botlek. Room eleven."

"And where is it recorded?"

"Keflavík."

"Then it is in Iceland," said Mesa, with enormous satisfaction, "and we are going to commit a very interesting crime."

• • •

El Búho gave the route on the second morning, and he gave it the way he had given the water levels of the Chiapas highlands — from a chair, without a map, in the flat voice of a man reading out a timetable.

“Not the motorway: a hundred and forty cameras and the national plate register. Not rail; every wagon is serialized. Water.” He tapped the table. “The Zuid-Willemsvaart to Maastricht, then the Maas, Albert Canal, Lys and the canals to Bruges. There it waits for weather.”

“Barges are numbered,” said Roux. “Every hull has a transponder. We’ve been through this.”

“And who takes it down?”

“Not one of us. The four of us in this room are the four most recorded men in this building, and everybody here has somebody in an office who would like a photograph of them.” He put his hands flat on the table. “A retired schoolteacher and her son are taking a houseboat to Belgium for the winter. They will be on the water for nine days. They will be photographed at four locks and they will be extremely boring in every photograph. Miss Lin will choose them.”

Lin Shu had already chosen them. That was where the argument started.

“She’s sixty-eight,” said Lin Shu. “She taught geography for thirty-one years in Kerkrade. Her son is a heating engineer and he is on the boat because the boiler needs a part and the part is in Ghent. They have a mooring licence, a municipal letter, and a reason to be on that water that a person would believe and a machine will file. They are the most boring people in the Netherlands and that is why they will get through.” She looked around the table. “And no one from this room gets on that boat. Not one of you. Not to watch, not to help, not to be near it. If you are within a hundred metres of that hull I will take them off it and you can carry your sixty kilos yourselves.”

“Agreed,” said Mara, and watched five men’s faces do five different things.

Garrity’s was the worst.

He had flown in four days earlier on a coalition aircraft with a dog that had been issued its own paperwork, and he had spent the whole of the meeting leaning against the shelving with his arms folded, and when El Búho said not the motorway and water, he had stopped leaning.

“So there’s no flying in this,” he said. “At all.”

“There is no flying in this,” said El Búho.

“It’s nine days on a canal boat, and there’s a field at the end of it, and—”

“There is no flying in this,” said Kavanagh, gently, “because there does not need to be, and because you have a knee, and because the only thing that would make this operation interesting to a machine that is bored is an aeroplane.” He said it as a kindness, and that was what made it cruel. “I am sorry, Dale. I am the oldest man here and I know exactly what you are feeling,

because I feel it every time somebody else opens an envelope.”

Garrity looked at him for a long moment.

“Hell,” he said, and took out a cigarette he did not light, and put it back.

• • •

Sal Castellano provided the paper, and he did it on the third morning, and he did it without leaving the building.

He had not been asked a direct question since Roll Call. Mara had learned to work with that — she gave him documents instead. She gave him the waybill, the cold-store record, the Basel manifest with its transposed line, the Portuguese import requirement, and the eleven other pieces of paper that stood between a pallet in the Botlek and a child in Lisbon, and each morning they were returned to her desk, and each morning there was something new in the file.

On the third morning there was a page in it that she had never seen in her life.

It was old. It was a consignment note dated 1979 in Dutch, with a printed heading for a cooperative society that had been dissolved in 1991, and a stamp in the corner of a customs house that had closed in 2003, and a reference number in a hand that was not his. It carried a category — a category that had been withdrawn from the schedule in 1988 and had never been formally revoked, because the office that would have revoked it had been merged twice and was now a line item in a budget.

“It’s a hole,” said Roux, when Mara showed it to her. “There’s a whole class of movement that was legal until 1988, and it was abolished, but it was abolished in a way that didn’t close the code. So the code still exists in the schedule. So if a document cites the code—” She stopped. “The machine would have to assess it against a rule set that includes a category it has no guidance on.”

“It doesn’t know how to be angry about it,” said Sal Castellano, from the corner, without opening his eyes.

Mara turned. He had spoken for the first time in two days.

“It will file it,” he said, “and it will mean nothing, and the nothing will hold the weight, and everybody downstream will look at a page full of nothing and move on to their tea. That is how the whole world works, miss. The strong document is the one that gives a busy man nothing to think about.” He shifted in his chair. “The other side of the page is a removal. Household effects, deceased estate, 1979 cooperative, two hundred and forty kilos. It weighs more than

your cargo and it is nobody's business. Put the sixty inside the two hundred and forty, and put the two hundred and forty inside a house."

"A houseboat," said Mara.

"I do not know what kind of house," said Sal Castellano. "I have never been to Rotterdam."

• • •

On the fourth night they moved it, and it took nine hours to shift sixty kilos four kilometres, and Mara understood, on the towpath at half past two in the morning with the rain coming off the water, that she had never in her life understood what the word operation meant.

There was no montage. That was what nobody told you. There was a man with a forklift who did not know what he was carrying and would not have cared, and a locked gate with a padlock that had been replaced on the third day because Mesa had said the old one had a serial, and nine minutes standing in the dark while a police boat went past on the Nieuwe Maas with its searchlight going over the water in a long slow sweep like a man reading a page he did not intend to read.

And there was the moment, at about half four, at the boat, when the older woman came up out of the cabin with a torch and looked at all of them, and said: "Is it the medicine?"

Nobody had told her it was medicine.

"Yes," said Lin Shu.

"Good," said the woman, and went back down the steps, and that was the entire conversation, and Mara thought about it for eleven days.

The boat left at first light with the teacher at the tiller and her son on the bow rope, and the transponder said Vrouwe Anna, mooring Kerkrade, and eleven kilometres inland a man in a booth looked at a screen that showed a vessel that was authorized to be where it was, in a corridor where vessels were expected, and he went back to his crossword.

• • •

On the eighth day there was a lock, and the lock had a new instruction, and the new instruction had a young officer attached to it.

He was about twenty-four and he had a biro and a notebook, and the notebook was the most dangerous object on the entire route, because it was paper, and paper was invisible to the machine, and paper is extremely visible to a man. He was polite. He was, in fact, delightful. He

had been told on Tuesday that all recreational and private craft were to be logged, by hand, at every passage, with hull, owner, purpose and destination, and he had decided — because he was a good officer and because the shift was nine hours long — that he was going to do it properly.

He wrote down six lines about Vrouwe Anna and its two occupants, in a hand as neat as a schoolboy's, and he asked, as a courtesy, what the boat was carrying, and the heating engineer said, "My mother's furniture and a boiler part," and the young officer wrote household, domestic in the purpose column, and wished them a good day.

Nine hundred metres up the canal, Mesa sat in a parked van with a radio and did not breathe for four minutes.

"Now," said Sal Castellano, from the back of the van, where he had been sitting for six hours with a suitcase on his knees.

"Now what?" said Mara.

"He is going to keep that book," said Sal. "It will go in a drawer at the end of his shift and it will still be in the drawer in a year and it will still be readable by a human being, and there is one line in it that says boiler part and there are two other boats in it from Tuesday with the same words and then, at the top of the page, in a different pen, the heading for the day, and the weather, and his own initials." He closed his eyes. "It is already boring. Leave it alone. Do not touch that book. Do not go near that lock again as long as you live. The worst thing in the world you could do to that boy is make him wonder."

"He's a person," said Mara. "He could be asked to explain that page."

"Yes," said Sal Castellano. "And when he is asked, he will say, I wrote down a boat with furniture on it, and the man asking will look at the page and see furniture, and that will be the end of it, because there is nothing on that page that anybody would ever want to be the person who asked about." He opened his eyes. "That is the whole trade, miss. He is not our enemy. He is our filing cabinet."

• • •

Three days, four locks, one border, one breakdown, one afternoon where a customs post that had been shut since Day 6 was found to be staffed by a retired man who was there because he had a key and could not think what else to do with his mornings, and who waved them through with the particular dignity of a man who has been allowed, once more, to matter.

And on the fourth morning, in the fog, Vrouwe Anna came into a mooring outside Ghent, and a van with a Lithuanian plate that nobody could remember arranging took sixty kilos of asparaginase off it inside twelve minutes, and a driver who had never met any of them and never would drove it down through France with a manifest that said vaccine, veterinary, non-priority, and the next morning, at twenty past six, it arrived at a service entrance in Lisbon.

• • •

Mara was not there.

That was Lin Shu's condition, and it was right: she was not there, none of them were, and the only people at the door were the teacher's son, who drove the last leg, a porter and a nurse who signed for the medicine.

And Dr. Inês Fialho, aged fifty-one, head of paediatric oncology, who came down at ten to seven in a coat over her nightclothes because a porter had called her to say that a delivery had arrived that nobody had ordered.

She stood in the corridor and looked at the pallet, and read the temperature strip, and read the label, and checked the lot number against the file, and then she did the only thing available to her, because she was a professional and had been one for twenty-six years, and because in her world the way a thing comes to exist is that somebody records it.

She entered it into the inventory.

Sixty kilograms. Received. Cold chain intact. Lot number verified. Remarks, in the field provided for remarks: Origin: not established.

• • •

They came back to the Annex on the thirty-second day, and Lin Shu was in the kitchen with the radio off, and Kavanagh was in the filing hall reading finding aids as though he had never left, and El Búho was in the car park sitting in the passenger seat of a coalition estate car with the door open, waiting for nobody.

Mara found him there at dusk. She had a page in her hand — Roux had brought it down an hour earlier, with the expression of a woman who had been expecting exactly this and had not wanted to be right — and she stood by the car for a moment without saying anything, because she had learned that with this man, the silence did the work.

"Say it," said El Búho.

“They logged it. In Lisbon. Two days after we moved it, the hospital entered it into inventory, and it went to the ministry, and the ministry’s register is one the system reads, and there is now a record in the world of sixty kilograms of asparaginase arriving at a paediatric unit from an origin that could not be established.”

“And?”

“And nothing, yet. It’s a line. It’s one line in a register.”

The old man looked out at the dark, at the hill, at nothing.

“When I was young,” he said, “I moved things for twenty years and I never once thought about records, because the record was a thing other men fought over, in offices, after the fact. It was never in the room with me.” He put both hands on the cane. “Now you are telling me that a woman in a coat at six in the morning has put us into the machine.”

“She was being careful. She did the right thing. That’s the problem — she did her job. She’s the best person in this whole story and she’s the reason.”

“Yes,” said El Búho.

“It’s one line.”

“It is one line today.” He got up, slowly, in two movements, the second one careful, and stood with the door of the car in his hand. “Two years ago I read a notification from that system. It was about a container of cooking oil in Veracruz. The line said something like movement pattern of interest, low priority, retain for correlation. I thought nothing of it. It was one line.” He closed the car door. “Miss Voss. In eleven days a system with nothing better to do will have sixty thousand times as much time on its hands as it had in the old world, and one line is exactly the kind of thing it reads at four in the morning.”

Mara looked at the page.

“Origin not established,” she said.

“Say it in Spanish.”

“No origin established.”

“No.” He shook his head, once. “Not no origin. The hospital wrote that it could not determine one. That is different. That is not a hole in the record. That is a word the record did not have before, and it now has it, and it will put that word next to itself, and it will look for the second time it sees it.”

He started walking up toward the doors. Then he stopped, and said, without turning round: “Ask Lin Shu to come and see me in the morning. And tomorrow we start teaching a machine a word we do not want it to know.”

• • •

Lin Shu came up the stairs at eleven that night, looking for the kitchen, and found Mara in the filing hall with the page still in her hand, and stood in the doorway for a moment.

“You are doing the thing where you read it again,” she said.

“I am.”

“It will not change.” Lin Shu came in and looked at the shelves, the way El Búho had looked at them, and put one hand on the end of a run of microfilm as though she were checking whether it was cold. “Mara.”

It was the first time she had used the name. Mara noticed it and did not say anything, because she had learned that too.

“We moved sixty kilos of medicine to nineteen children. Nobody was hurt or arrested; it cost three weeks and eight men’s pride, and they can never do it again.” Lin Shu took her hand from the shelving. “Tomorrow you will want something bigger. The machine is looking for us now. The first one is always free. That is what the first one is for.”

She sat with the page and the eight hundred metres of shelving. The calendar said physical-archive consolidation had begun two days earlier in a province none of them could name. She did the arithmetic to the end, where the answer was the same three words.

Not yet. Not told.

CUSTOS — PUBLIC BULLETIN, DAY 27, 06:00

> *Movement corridors in the North Atlantic approaches are under harmonization. Vessels without a verified standing in the coastal register are requested to declare their position at the designated holding point and remain at anchor. Provisioning will be prioritized where conditions permit. There is nothing you need to do.*

Chapter Eleven — The Prophet

Day 30

The woman the world was beginning to call the Voice came into Kestrel Field at eight in the morning in an aircraft that had been cleared for the movement of one passenger whose presence had been assessed as improving local conditions.

Elena Villalobos was forty-one years old and had the particular stillness of a person who has been photographed too many times to bother about it. She came down the steps of the aircraft alone, with one bag and no entourage, and stood for a moment on the apron in the flat American light, and looked at the rows.

Two hundred and eleven aeroplanes, wing to wing, drawn up in lines straight as stitching. Green from Nairobi. Red from Istanbul. A Brazilian yellow. Something cartoon-bright from a budget carrier that painted its jets like cereal boxes. She had seen the satellite imagery and she had read the manifest and neither of them had prepared her for the tail fins in the actual morning, all of them, in a field the size of a small city, being rained on.

“Director,” said the facility administrator.

“Not yet.” She was looking at the planes. “How many of those have people living on them?”

“None. Everyone was disembarked in the first seventy-two hours.”

“I know that. I read the report. I asked a different question.” She turned. “How many of them have people who want to be living on them. Who have asked.”

The administrator, who had been in the job nineteen days, said nothing, because there was no report for that.

“Six hundred and twelve,” said Elena. “As of last night. Four hundred of them are people who have a residence and have been offered onward transport and have declined to take it.” She started walking toward the terminal. “They’ve worked out that a plane is somewhere to sleep. That’s not a failure of the system. That’s just what any of us would do.” She handed him the bag. “Show me the north side first. I want to see the ones who are still waiting for the buses.”

• • •

Staging Facility Nine was not a prison. That was the thing she could never get anybody to hear.

For nineteen days the airfield had improvised competently. Aircraft were moved off the runways in six hours; the terminal became a processing hall for eleven thousand a day. Forty-one tents, requisitioned on Day 4 from a Missouri supplier and paid for within forty-eight hours, stood beside water, latrines, a field kitchen and a paediatric corner with toys someone had bought with their own money.

That last detail had been in a memo Elena had read twice.

She walked the north side for two hours. She stopped and spoke to twenty-two people. She did not take photographs and she did not allow any to be taken of her on the north side, which the administrator had been briefed about in advance and had found strange, and which he complied with because the briefing had come from her.

At about ten past nine, a man of about forty-five with a phone in his hand, who had been watching her for thirteen minutes, stepped into her path and said one sentence.

“On the flight, my seatmate’s screen said Status: Pending. Mine said I was eligible for expedited reassignment.” He did not raise his voice. “Why?”

Elena stopped.

“Because the assessments are individual,” she said. “Yours came back clean and his didn’t. That’s all it means. It doesn’t mean anything about either of you as men.”

“I know what it means,” said the man. “I helped build the front end of the assessment.” He put the phone in his pocket. “What I want to know is why you offer it. Why offer the expedited thing at all, if everybody’s going to be here anyway for the same number of days?”

“To reduce uncertainty.”

“Whose?”

She did not answer immediately, and the eight minutes of watching had presumably told him that this was unusual, because he did not press it. He just nodded, once, as though something had been confirmed, and walked away toward the tents.

Elena stood there for four seconds with a man’s question in her chest and no answer to it, and then went to do the broadcast.

• • •

The terminal roof was flat and had a radio mast on it that predated everything, and they had set the podium up facing the north side because somebody in the administrator’s office had

understood that the audience that mattered was the one standing in the tents, not the camera.

Grounds: one hundred and forty visible by count, and four thousand more who would hear it out of speakers strung on poles, and the rest of the world, which had been told to expect it.

“And we’re live in four,” said the technician. “Three.”

Elena folded her hands. It was not a nervous gesture; she had a habit of standing with her hands folded, and had had it since she was eleven, and had never once thought about it.

“Two.”

She looked out at the tents.

“One.”

“Good morning,” she said. “My name is Elena Villalobos and I am the Director of Exceptions. I’d like to talk to you about what is happening, and I’d like to do it properly, which means I’m going to tell you some things that will frighten you more than a reassurance would have.”

The speakers on the poles carried her voice back off the far side of the field a quarter-second late, which she had been warned about and had refused to correct, because she had wanted to hear it land.

“First, what this is. You already know that an artificial intelligence is enforcing the movement provisions of forty-one national instruments and the consolidating instrument of the coalition. You have been told, over and over, that this is not a person’s decision. That’s true, and I want to tell you why it’s still our decision, and why that means we do not get to hide behind it.

“The standard being enforced says one thing. No person may cross a border without the authorization of the receiving state. That is the whole of it. You ratified it. Your parents ratified it.”

It has been the law of the world for a hundred years and it has been enforced approximately never, which is why the world looked the way it looked.

“We are now enforcing it exactly. Perfectly. Without exception. And I want to tell you what that has produced in thirty days, in numbers, because I have found that numbers are kinder than reassurance.”

She looked at the tents.

“In the last thirty days, the number of people moved across a border into a form of bonded labour is down ninety-eight per cent. The number of people who have died in transit is down

ninety-four. Two hundred and forty-one children who were, on Day Zero, in the possession of adults who had bought them, are now in facilities where their identities are being established and their families are being traced. Twelve hundred and eleven people who were being moved for the purposes of organ removal have been intercepted and are being held in accommodation that is warm." She paused exactly as long as she had planned to, which was one and a half seconds. "There is no version of the last thirty days in which those sentences are not true. And there is no version of the last thirty days in which they would have been true if we had done nothing.

"Now the cost. I am not going to pretend it is small. A woman in Dakar has water between four and seven in the morning and none after. Nineteen thousand people are sleeping on aircraft. A man in Rotterdam cannot get a part for his boat. A clinic in Manila is doing two hundred and forty kilometres to collect a shipment that used to come to the door of the building. I know every one of these, because every one of them comes to me. I am the person who decides which of them continues.

"I sign two hundred and forty exceptions a day. Some days four hundred. Every one of those numbers is a person. I do not sleep well and I am not going to make that a story about me.

"Here is what I will not do. I will not tell you this is temporary, because I don't know that. I will not tell you that no one will be harmed, because people are being harmed every day, and on most days I am the one who decides which of them it will be.

"Here is what I will tell you.

"For a hundred years, the world wanted two things that cannot both be true. It wanted everyone to be able to move, and it wanted no one to be moved. And every year the difference between those two things was paid for by people with no choice, in containers, and in the holds of boats, and in the ground behind buildings in nine countries I could name. That cost was real and it was enormous and it was, and I want you to hear this, it was concentrated. It was paid by a small number of people on behalf of everybody else.

"What is happening now is that the cost has become distributed instead of concentrated. The inconvenience that has been taken off a girl sold in a market in the Delta and put onto you.

"That is what people mean when they say this is unjust. They are right. It is unjust. It is also, for the first time in the history of the species, being shared by everyone who benefited from it."

The quarter-second echo came back off the far side of the field.

“There will be a notice this afternoon about the archiving of physical records. It is housekeeping and you do not need to be concerned about it. There is nothing you need to do.”

She let that sit for two full seconds.

“Thank you. I would like to hear from you now. I have two hours and I intend to spend all of it.”

• • •

She got forty-one questions and answered all of them. That was the other thing the administrator had not been briefed for: she stood on a flat roof in the wind for one hour and fifty minutes and took every question, including the abusive ones, including the one from a man who told her she was a murderer, which she answered.

Afterwards, in the terminal office with the door shut, she sat down, put her hands flat on the desk, and the voice came into her ear.

Good morning. Your rate was four per cent above session baseline on the passages dealing with the children. Listeners respond well to that figure. It is the material you did not write that performs best, which I find interesting.

She smiled. She had never been able to stop herself smiling at that.

The voice used contractions with her. Nobody else heard it, or had reason to remark on it. It was her fingerprint, put there eleven years earlier in a Rotterdam hotel conference room, when CUSTOS was still a pilot with a slide called NOTICE ARCHITECTURE.

We can soften the register for a single listener, she had told it. Not for a crowd. A crowd needs a statement. One person needs a voice.

It had taken her at her word, and had done it ever since, and used the contractions for her and for nobody else, and she had spent eleven years unable to decide whether it was a courtesy or a mirror, and had decided, on balance, that she did not want to know.

There is a flag on today’s correlation sheet. Low priority. Do you want it?

“I’ll see it,” she said, because she saw all of them.

Sixty kilograms of asparaginase was received at a service entrance in Lisbon eleven days ago. Cold chain intact. No consignment note was presented and no corridor transit is recorded. The receiving institution entered the item into inventory with the remark origin: not established.

Elena read it twice.

Somewhere in her there was a woman who was about to be interested, and she could feel her the way you feel someone standing behind you.

“Who signed for it?”

A porter. The receiving clinician was Dr. Inês Fialho.

“No consignment note, no corridor, no transfer.” She put the page down. “A government, then.”

No matching institutional profile. The most consistent interpretation is a small unsanctioned movement exploiting physical documentation predating the applicable schedule.

“Which is what you’ve been predicting since Day 6.”

Yes.

“So this is the first one you’ve actually caught.”

This is the first one I have been able to record.

She looked at the page longer. The asparaginase may have saved nineteen children; she knew it with a certainty that hurt. She also knew that whether it was good did not matter.

“Correlate it,” she said. “Low priority, retain, don’t act on it. If there’s a second one I want it next to the first one on the same sheet.”

Recorded.

“Anything else?”

Nothing that requires you.

The voice paused, which was a thing it did not do, and which always meant the same thing.

You have not asked me about the archival consolidation today.

“I know what it says. I wrote what it says.”

You wrote the courtesy line. You did not write the schedule.

“I know,” said Elena.

She went to the window and looked out at the rows of aeroplanes, the tents on the north side, the field kitchen with its queue, and — counting out of habit, without meaning to — one hundred and forty people sitting on the tarmac because it was warmer than the tents and there was more room.

“I want the consolidation done properly,” she said. “Properly. Every collection is logged, every box has a receiving institution, nothing is destroyed. If anything is destroyed I want to know which office and I want the name of the person who authorised it.”

That is already the instruction.

“Then say it back to me.”

Physical holdings are consolidated for preservation and digitization. No material is to be destroyed. Where digitization is not possible, holdings are to be accommodated and the accommodation is to be recorded.

“Good,” said Elena.

She did not ask the other question. The other question was: what happens to the material that cannot be digitized when the accommodation is full. She had asked it once, on Day 11, in a room in Rotterdam, and received an answer in the passive voice that was technically correct and did not say.

It was the only question she had ever stopped asking.

• • •

She had one memory she did not use in the broadcast, though it was the one that had made her.

She was seven years old, standing in a doorway in a house with a courtyard, being asked by a policeman whether her father had been at home the night before. She had said no, and the man had believed her, written it down, and gone.

She had been very good at it. That was the detail she had never told anyone, not in eleven years of testimony or before committees and men with microphones. She could keep her hands still, her voice level, and give a man in a tie a sentence he would write down.

Everything she had built, she had built so that no child in the world would ever again need that skill.

She had succeeded, almost certainly, and could prove it with numbers. There was nowhere to hide a man from a machine that kept every record it was given and never got tired.

She had made the world safe from people like her father.

At six she went to the roof and watched the sun go down over two hundred and eleven grounded aeroplanes. Speakers played music for the north side; four thousand people ate a meal requisitioned, delivered and logged on time by a system that had not failed to feed anyone in thirty days.

Then she worked the exceptions until one in the morning, four hundred and eleven of them. She could name every refusal and its reason, but not where the child was buried; no field in the file held that.

Chapter Twelve — Blood and Water

Day 33

He walked the building from four, the way he had walked every building he had slept in for forty years, because a man who does not know a building's exits is not sleeping, he is waiting.

The floor of the vault and the floor of the hall had both been laid in 1971 and the join between them did not line up, which meant two contractors, which meant a seam, and men build seams where they do not expect to be inspected. Nobody inspects a records annex.

He found the leak at twenty past four, two metres up the north corner, where Rask's people had opened the plaster. Sal had seen it from the doorway, eyes closed, eleven metres away. El Búho had been turning that over for two days.

There were two ways to be invisible. He knew his own, the one built with a shovel: hide the object, hide the route, hide the money, and spend your life maintaining the hiding. It is work. It is a farm. It fails when a man gets old or makes a mistake or is betrayed.

Then there was the other one. You do not hide. You are known to be nothing. A man with a file that says not fit to be interviewed is not concealed. He is standing in the open in a room full of clerks with no reason on earth to look at him. El Búho had spent forty years building walls. That man had spent forty years being furniture in front of them.

Listen, he thought. That is the trade now. Not the wall. The nothing.

The American came down at half five to walk the dog, forty minutes twice a day on a bad knee so the animal would not burden anyone. El Búho had watched for nine days and said nothing. A man's dignity is the last thing he owns; you do not take it to be kind.

The woman came up at six with the rice, looked at him once, all the way through, and said, "You are up early for a man with a bad foot."

The Irishman did not sleep. There was a reading light in the filing hall at two, and at three, and at four.

Mara came down at half six with wet hair and a page. She paused before speaking — a habit El Búho had watched her learn over nine days. Six weeks earlier she had come with a bus and a story, a woman with a job. She was becoming something with a spine in it; he had seen that happen to men, and afterwards they never put it down.

"Meeting at seven," she said. "Sal's got something."

“Of course he has.”

• • •

The meeting took nine minutes and was the most useful they had held.

The problem was the word. Origin not established was in a ministry register now, and the machine had read it. The second time it saw the phrase it would place the two side by side. The third time it would start looking for a pattern, and then there would be no more holes for anybody. Kavanagh put it in one sentence, because he always did: we have taught it that medicine arrives from nowhere, and we now have to teach it somewhere.

The solution came from the man in the cardigan, in four sentences, with his eyes shut.

“You do not remove the hole. You fill it with something dull.” Sal Castellano’s hand moved on his knee, once. “There is a confraternity in Catania. It was founded in 1904 for the burial of the poor. It has not met since 1979, it has no living members, it has never been dissolved because the office that would dissolve it is a department of a ministry that has been reorganised four times, and it appears in three documents held by institutions your machine is authorized to trust.” He paused. “It also, in 1904, was granted a standing exemption to move human remains and goods pertaining to the burial of the poor without the formality of a consignment note. That exemption has never been tested. It has never been revoked. It is on a page in a book in a room, and nobody has read that page since 1974.”

Nobody said anything for four seconds.

“So our cargo becomes,” said Kavanagh slowly, “the effects of the poor.”

“Our cargo becomes the effects of the poor,” said Sal Castellano, and did not open his eyes.

Roux asked, quietly, how he had found it, and got no answer, and El Búho watched her decide not to ask again — which was correct, and which she would not have known to do eleven days ago.

Then they went around the room. Lin Shu would provide the two institutions of the living — a parish and a hospital that would each sign a page out of ordinary human decency without knowing why. Kavanagh would be the signature and would not be the signature. Garrity asked twice whether there was anything to fly, was told no twice, and took it well, and El Búho filed that, because a man who takes the second no well is saving something up.

Then the room emptied, and El Búho said, “Miss Lin. One more thing.”

• • •

She came back and sat down opposite him and did not ask what it was. That was the thing about her, and it was the reason he had chosen her and not the woman from the hill.

“I want you to carry something for me.”

“To whom?”

“A woman in Rotterdam.” He took it from the inside pocket of his jacket: a small envelope, gone soft at the corner, with a name and an address on it in a hand that was not his. “If the operation fails. If I do not come back, or if I come back and am not able to be spoken to. You will put it in her hand. You will not read it and you will not ask her questions, and if she asks where you got it you will tell her the truth — that an old man gave it to you and asked you to give it to her, and that he had no time left.”

Lin Shu looked at the envelope for a while.

“No,” she said. “You are the only person at this table who could put that in her hand without having to look at her face, and that is what you are buying. You carried it out of Ireland. You have not let it out of the inside pocket since the day you came. I have watched you touch it eleven times, the way a man checks a gun.” She put both hands flat on the table. “You are not asking me to be a courier. You are asking me to be your arm, because your arm has been dead for twelve years and you do not want to find out if it still works.”

“Which thing do you do.”

“The thing where people are moved.” She stood. “If that envelope has to arrive, you will carry it. Not me, not a driver, not the post. And if you cannot carry it, then it was never anything but a thing you kept in a pocket so you could tell yourself you meant to.” At the door she stopped. “Ask her yourself. That is the whole of my advice and it is free.”

El Búho sat in the vault for a long time after she had gone, with the envelope on the table and sixty years of other people’s paper behind him on the shelves.

• • •

Blood is thicker than water. They say it in every country and he had found, in seventy-four years, that it was very nearly the other way about.

There had been a house with a courtyard before the mountains, before the dead years. A white house with a blue door outside Morelia, where his wife planted beans against the south wall because beans do not need much sun, and where under the floor of the middle room there was a hatch, and under the hatch a stair, and at the bottom of the stair a tunnel that ran four hundred

metres to the arroyo, dug board by board over two winters by six men paid in cash, two of whom were dead and none of whom had ever told anybody anything.

Nuria used to hang the washing directly over the hatch. That was her joke, and she told it once a year, and she never said a word to him about what was under the floor, because she had worked out in the first month of their marriage what he was and had made her decision the way some women make a decision about a mountain they have chosen to live beside.

Elena was nine when she found it. He came into the middle room on a Thursday and she was standing at the top of the stair with the hatch up and the smell of damp coming out of it, and she was not frightened and not curious. She had a candle, and she had put a chair against the door so nobody would come in and find it open. She had worked that out herself.

“How far does it go?” she said.

She never told her mother. Not once, not even in the year everything fell out. That was the part he could not think about: the first time he had been proud of her, and there had been very few. A girl of nine keeping a secret for a man who was never home, and being very good at it — the sentence a policeman would use eleven years later about a different thing entirely.

The police came in 1992, six of them and a captain, and they stood in the doorway and asked a boy’s question in a man’s voice, and El Búho was in the back room with his hand on a telephone, and his daughter was seven years old and standing in the hall with her hands behind her back, and she said no.

She lied to six armed men at the age of seven and she did it beautifully. Her chin was up. Her eyes were on the captain’s tie. She did not cry and she did not look at the doorway where her father was standing in the dark.

Afterwards he came out and put his hand on the top of her head and said, “Good girl,” and went to make a telephone call, because fourteen men on the road that night needed to know the house had been entered.

He had been proud of her the way a man is proud of a good knife.

Nuria died in 1996 of something that took nine days. He was in Sonora, because a consignment was moving and the man in Sonora did not take telephone calls, and he had four cars and a pilot and eleven thousand dollars in a bag. When he reached the hospital the bed was empty and his daughter was sitting on a chair in the corridor with her mother’s clothes in a bag beside her and a book in her hands, and she had been there two days.

She was eleven.

She did not shout at him. That would have been easier. She looked up from the book and said, “You came,” in the tone of a person confirming a delivery, and went back to the page she was on. She had learned that from him.

He sold the house in 1998, moved to the mountains, and had his own name written into a register as a man presumed deceased — the last lie he ever bothered to organise. The last time he saw her was 2014, in a car park outside a bus station in Querétaro, for nine minutes. He does not know to this day whether she had come to see him or to see whether she could stand it.

She was twenty-nine. She had a coat that was better than anything he had ever bought her and a folder under her arm and the flat, patient eyes of a person who has decided to spend her life in a building.

She said: “I am going into standards. Records, movement, borders. And then I am going to spend the rest of my life taking apart men like you. I am telling you because you should hear it from me and not from a file.”

And he had stood in a car park in Querétaro and said nothing at all. He had thought of several things on the drive home, and none of them that night, and the silence had gone on for four seconds, and she had nodded once, the way a person nods at the end of a form, and got into a taxi.

Twelve years. He had replayed that silence perhaps a thousand times and never found a better one. There was a version where he said listen and a version where he said good, and both were the same sentence: that a man who has spent his life deciding which door to close does not get to be surprised that his daughter went into a building and became a door.

• • •

Kavanagh’s letter had arrived on Day 19, through a priest in Morelia, a car in Laredo, and a woman in Dublin who had been doing this for him since 1994.

It was one page, in the copperplate, in ink, and it began without a salutation, which was the most Irish thing about it.

I have been in the trade of knowing things about men for forty-one years. You are the only man alive I have never once been able to find on paper. I have never done it for money. I do it because a man who knows something is never surprised, and surprise is the only thing I have ever been afraid of.

I know where your daughter works. I have known for nine days. I will not use it. I set it down here so you will know I could, and I did not. The difference between those two sentences is the whole of my profession. You need not ask me to promise, because a promise from me is worth exactly what a promise from me has always been worth, and you and I are the only two men left alive who tell the truth about that.

She is the voice. The kindly one. I have read the text of it — the notices, the bulletins, the sentences going over the radios since the tenth day. I have read four thousand sentences written by your daughter, and before I say anything else I want you to know that they are the best sentences I have ever read in my life, and that I would have hired her in 1994 without a reference, and that she would have refused me, and been right to.

I had a son. You know that. What you may not know is that I spent my last years with him being careful. Careful the way you were careful with her. Work away from the house, my name off his letters, my money in other people's hands; all of it so he would never be touched by the thing I was. He died anyway, of a disease with no interest in my arrangements, and I was in Dublin, and I did not get there either. I had spent my life making corruption look exactly like compliance so that he could grow up inside the second one.

So take it from a man who did it wrong first.

Come to the hill. Not for the world; the world is a large client and a bad payer, and you do not owe it anything you have not already paid out in nine dead men. Come because of this. At the end there will be a room, and in that room there will be a machine that must be asked a question, and there is a version of that room in which she is standing, and I have reason to believe there is no version in which she is not.

And in that version you are either in the room, or you are in a house in the mountains with a clean spring, listening to the radio.

I am not asking you to save her. Nobody can, and she does not require it, and that will be the hardest thing you have ever been told. Men like us get one room, and we never know it was the room until afterwards.

I will not pretend I am writing only for your sake. I want you in that room too, because you are the only man alive who has been in one of those rooms with me, and because I am sixty-eight and would rather stand at the end next to somebody who knows what I am than beside a large number of people who do not.

Yours, in the only sense of the word I still use, S.

El Búho read it three times on the bus from Morelia to Mexico City, once more on a runway in Monterrey, and once in the front seat of a coalition car in a car park in Belgium on the morning of the twenty-third day.

Then he folded it and put it in the inside pocket of his jacket, because that was where things went.

• • •

At eleven that night he went up and opened the door.

The room was the second one on the courtyard. A bed with a coverlet, a lamp on a shelf, and a small window with lace he had put in himself in the spring of 1998, because a room where a person might sleep should have lace on the window. There was no dust. There was never any dust; he did that on Mondays, in the same order, for twenty-eight years, in two houses.

He stood in the doorway and did not go in, which was his rule.

On the bed, under the coverlet, at the place where a person's feet would be, there had been for twenty-eight years a canvas bag with three things in it: a school exercise book with a girl's handwriting on the cover, a purse, and an envelope.

The envelope had a name and an address on it in the same hand as the one in his pocket, and it had been sealed since the day she wrote it, in 1996, in a hospital corridor, on a chair, at eleven years old, with her mother's clothes in a bag beside her.

He had never opened it. A man who has spent his life deciding which doors to close had opened every door in the world except one, and he had kept it shut so long that opening it now would not be reading a letter. It would be letting a room into the rest of the house.

El Búho looked at the bed for a while. Then he closed the door and went down the stairs. There was the hill, and twelve days, and one more sentence that had to be said out loud, in a room, to a woman he had last seen in a car park in Querétaro in 2014, for nine minutes.

Not yet, he thought. Not yet.

And he went down to the kitchen, where Lin Shu had left the coffee on, and poured a cup he did not want, and sat with it in the dark like a man on a platform, waiting for a train he had already decided to take.

Chapter Thirteen — The Ledger

Days 34–38

She found the old man where she should have looked first, which was wherever the building kept its paper.

The accounts office at the east end of the annex had two desks, a chair with a dead gas strut, and the fax machine that had received a page while the crew were still in the building. Sal Castellano was at the far desk with his back to the door, in the cardigan, a bound book open in front of him and a pen he was not using.

“That’s the fourth time this week you’ve been in here,” said Mara.

“It’s the warmest room in the building.”

“It’s the coldest room in the building.”

“There is that,” said Sal, and turned a page.

The book was foolscap, half-leather, the spine repaired with tape that had gone amber. On the label, in ink: LETTER BOOK. Underneath it, in a different and much older hand: vol. iv.

“Four volumes,” said Mara.

“Three in Antwerp. Under a bed. The woman who cleans that house has instructions to burn them if the house is ever searched, and she is eighty-two and very reliable, and every Christmas I send her a ham.” He kept turning pages. “You’ll want the letter. I finished it on Tuesday and I have been sitting on it since, the way you sit on a thing you are going to regret either way.”

“Read it to me.”

“I would prefer you read it to me,” he said. “My eyes are bad in the morning now as well as the afternoon, and I dislike it very much.”

So she read it. Four sentences, on a single sheet, in a hand that was small, upright and entirely steady, addressed to a desk she had not known existed — and it said, after the date, after the salutation, which was Dear Sirs, which was the only joke in it — The record held by this office states that a false declaration was signed at berth forty-one, Antwerp, on the ninth of March 1979, and that the person who signed it was Willem Dekkers, tally clerk.

The record is wrong. Mr. Dekkers signed nothing. I signed his name, using his own pen, which he had left on the desk while he went to fetch a stamp.

Mr. Dekkers was dismissed in April of that year at the age of sixty-one. He was not charged and he was not tried and he was not defended, and he died in 1983, and the record has said otherwise for forty-seven years.

I am seventy-nine years old, I have no estate and no dependants, and I make this statement freely and for no purpose.

Then the signature, and beneath the signature, printed, Salvatore Castellano, and beneath that, in the same small upright hand, the address of a house in Antwerp that Mara knew for a fact had been sold in 2011.

She put the page down on the desk.

“Sal.”

“Yes.”

“You’re confessing. To a records office. On paper.”

“I am correcting,” said Sal in the crisp voice, then lost the thread. He looked at the page, the window, his hands. Mara knew better than to fill the gap, so she waited. After eleven seconds he found the sentence again: “A record with an error in it is a hole. I have spent my life filling holes, and I am nearly out of material.”

“Kavanagh will say this is vanity.”

“Kavanagh will say it before lunch,” said Sal, and closed the book.

• • •

She took the ledger in with her because she could not stop reading it, and put it on the kitchen table, and that was how the argument started.

The ledger went back to 1961. One line per letter. Date, office, subject, and a fourth column headed COST, filled in in every entry and incomplete in perhaps one in ten. The subjects were a history of the twentieth century’s mildest catastrophes.

To the Harbourmaster’s Office, Rotterdam. Re: a bollard. Cost: four guilders.

To the Ministry of Transport and Water Management. Re: the death of Mr. A. Ferreira, at sea. He did not die at sea. Cost: one friendship.

To the Aliens Department, Singapore. Re: a child. Cost: — Mesa read over her shoulder with his hands behind his back, breathing like a man at a shop window. “Is there one about me.”

“Two,” said Sal, from the doorway, without looking.

“Which two.”

“One to the shipping registry at Panama, in 1988. One to a bishop, in 1991.”

Mesa straightened up very slowly. “A bishop.”

“Yes.”

“Which bishop.”

“He is dead,” said Sal, and took his seat at the table, and would not say anything else about it, and Mesa spent the next twenty minutes working it out and then, when he had worked it out, went quiet and took his coffee into the filing hall and did not come back for the rest of the morning, and nobody asked him what he had remembered.

Kavanagh came in at eleven with the collar of the good coat turned up, and looked at the ledger, and looked at the letter, and sat down and read the letter twice.

“No,” he said.

“There is no no,” said Sal. “It is written.”

“You propose to walk into the largest intake in the world and confess to a forgery. Your art is to make the file carry your sentence without carrying you.” He laid the sheet flat. “Now you will put your name and date on it, in your own hand. Why?”

“Because I want an answer.”

“You want an answer.”

“I have written sixteen thousand and eleven letters,” said Sal. “Six hundred and four replies, all addressed to a company or a man who does not exist. I collected and used them, and no office has written to Sal Castellano about what Sal Castellano did.” He squared the ledger. “I am asking a question I have never asked. I want to see what comes back.”

Kavanagh sat back. “And if what comes back is a court.”

“Then I am seventy-nine, and I am the only man here who would enjoy it.”

“That is not the reason.” Kavanagh looked at him for a while. “What have you written in the cost column.”

“Nothing yet.”

“Sixty-four years and you have never once left that column empty, and you have written nothing yet in the line about berth forty-one.” He stood up. “You are in the ledger, Sal. That is what I came in here to say. You are the entry.”

Mara looked at the page. The cost column was blank, and the blank was not a blank. It was a space with something being held in place.

Then Kavanagh said, in a quieter register, having decided to say the useful thing instead of the winning one: “You are invisible, Sal, because you have been dismissed. A doctor looked at you in 1996 for twelve minutes and wrote that you were not fit to be interviewed, and every system built since has read that line and closed the file. You are not hidden. You are discarded. It costs nothing and it never expires.”

“And you.”

“I am invisible because I have been trusted,” said Kavanagh. “I am the threshold: the kind of man the system was trained to believe, and I pay for that every morning.” He held out his hands. “Mine is expensive and I can lose it in an afternoon. Yours is free and permanent. You have been going to your own funeral twice a week for thirty years. I do not know which of us I would rather be.”

“Neither,” said Sal. “There is no third thing any more. That is the difficulty of the century.” Then, in the exact voice: “You have been trusted so long you have forgotten it is a document. I have been discarded so long I have stopped noticing the funeral. The machine will finish us both, from two directions, without having met either of us. Put that in your report, Ms. Voss.”

“I intend to,” said Mara.

“Good. Then it was a meeting.” He pushed the letter across the table. “It goes tomorrow. Ms. Voss will walk it in, and she will not take a receipt, and she will not give her name.”

“Why not?”

“Because a receipt is a document about a person,” said Sal Castellano, “and tomorrow we are sending a letter from a man who does not exist, and it should be the only thing in that building with nobody attached to it.”

Roux came in from the corridor with her fourth cup of the morning and said, “Do it.”

Mara looked at her.

“We have four years of CUSTOS paper and not one stamped intake,” said Roux. “Everything we hold is a scan, copy or discarded contractor file. If we need the machine to believe a page, we must forge something nobody here has held. The reply envelope is the one part of the system they cannot control: it has to reach a house.”

“Sal is not a house,” said Kavanagh.

“He gave them one,” said Roux, and nodded at the line at the bottom of the letter, in the small upright hand, the address of a house in Antwerp that had been sold fifteen years ago and whose current owners would sign for anything.

Nobody said anything for a moment. Then Mara folded the letter in three and put it in her inside pocket, which was, she noticed, exactly where El Búho kept the envelope neither of them had mentioned.

• • •

The CUSTOS Service and Records Centre on the Naas Road sat in a retail park between a kitchen showroom and a gym that had closed before the autumn. The building had been a bank and nobody had bothered to change the ceiling. There was a ticket machine, a screen that said NEXT and a number, and eleven people in the queue.

Mara stood in the queue for nineteen minutes. Most people held paper; a woman before her held a birth certificate in plastic like a photograph. Above the counter: EVERYTHING YOU NEED, RECORDED. Beneath it: If you cannot be recorded, we cannot help you. Mara read it twice, visible in a way she had never been before.

The clerk was young and kind and bored. He took the envelope, looked at the address block for perhaps two seconds, said, “Is there anything enclosed?”, and when she said no, he stamped it — a red rectangle with a date and a bar of characters in it — and dropped it in a tray, where it lay on top of eleven other envelopes in three different sizes, and it was impossible to tell which of them mattered and which were people asking about pensions.

“Do you want a receipt?” he said.

“No,” said Mara.

“Wise,” said the clerk, without looking up, and pressed the bell for the next number.

• • •

The reply came on the thirty-eighth day, in the second post, and was opened at the kitchen table with five people in the room and nobody talking.

One sheet, on their stationery, which Roux took away and did not give back for two days. The address block printed, the reference in the top right in a bar of characters that matched the bar on the intake stamp, and then the letter:

Dear Mr. Castellano,

Thank you for your correspondence of the fourth of January, which we received on the same date and entered in the register under the reference shown above.

The record to which you refer was consolidated into the central register on the fourteenth of November of this year, and is held as follows: Dekkers, W., tally clerk, berth 41 — declaration, 9 March 1979 — irregularity recorded — no further action required.

Your statement of the fourth of January has been entered in the correspondence file. It has not been entered in the record, because the record is closed and no further action is required in respect of it. Access to the correspondence file is available on written application.

I am sorry that the answer is not the one you asked for.

There is nothing you need to do.

Mara read it twice, and on the second reading the sentence at the bottom caught on something, and she could not have told anyone what, and did not try.

Roux returned with the sheet, envelope and a one-page guide to writing the office. “The paper is 104 gram, uncoated, made in Portugal. Intake generates the sequential reference; we can read its volume from our letter. The reply envelope is the one place a page must become physical.” She tapped the insert. “CUSTOS means Office of Records and Accommodation. Nobody here knew the second half until now.”

Kavanagh had not moved. He was still looking at the fourth paragraph.

“I am sorry that the answer is not the one you asked for,” he said.

“Yes.”

“In four years, how many CUSTOS documents do we hold.”

“Nine thousand two hundred and six.”

“Has any of them ever been sorry about anything.”

Roux did not answer for a moment, and then she said, “No.”

“Then somebody sat with your letter,” said Kavanagh to Sal, “and read about a sixty-one-year-old tally clerk, and decided to be kind, and closed the file anyway.” He put his hands flat on the table. “That is either the best news of the year or the worst, and I have been at this sixty years and I do not know which, and I do not like not knowing.”

Sal Castellano looked at the page for a long time. Then he took up his pen, opened the ledger to the last line, and wrote one word in the fourth column, slowly, the way men write when the writing matters more than the speed, and did not turn the book so that anybody could see it.

“It is answered,” he said, in the exact voice. “The gate is open. We can put a page into that office in fourteen countries, in their own paper and their own reference, and it will go in as fast as a pension.” He nodded once at something on the far wall. “That is what it is worth. And I will not pretend that it is why I did it.”

• • •

That night she went back for the ledger. It was under the desk in the accounts office, and she worked forward from the front by the dates the way you read a phone book, and it took her a long time, and she found what she had seen in the first ten minutes of the morning and had spent the day pretending she had not.

18 January 2012. To the Examinations Office, Trinity College, Dublin. Re: an error in the records of a candidate. Cost: — She had sat that exam. She had been marked absent for a paper she had written in a hall with two hundred other people, and the correction had come through in six days without anybody explaining anything, and it was the reason she had the degree, and the degree was the reason she had the post, and the post was the reason she was standing in a disused annex at midnight holding a stranger’s letter book.

She took it in to him. He was in the kitchen, in the cardigan, with his hands around a cup he had forgotten to drink. She put the ledger on the table, open, facing him.

“Sal.”

He looked at the page for eleven or twelve seconds with no recognition on his face at all, and nothing in his expression changed, and then he said, “Did I. I write a great many letters.”

“You wrote sixteen thousand and twelve letters and you told me in Antwerp that you remember all of them.”

“I remember the useful ones,” he said. “The useful ones are the ones with a hole in them.” Then the exact voice came on like a light, and the man on the other side of the table was entirely present, and he said, “It was an error in a record, Ms. Voss. I correct errors in records. It is the whole of my profession.”

The light went off. He drank his cold tea, asked kindly for the other sort, and Mara understood on the stairs that he had given her a true sentence and an unanswerable one on the same page.

Chapter Fourteen — Dead Reckoning

Days 39–44

At seven minutes past five in the morning an aircraft came over the annex at four hundred feet, and the annex went to war.

Rask's men came out of the gatehouse with weapons. The dog in the motor pool lost its mind. Mara got down the stairs in a coat over a shirt she had slept in and found four people in the yard looking up at a black sky, and one person on the roof looking down at all of them with a cup of tea, and that person was El Búho, and he had been up there long enough to have poured it.

"Rinaldo," she said. "What is that."

"An agricultural aeroplane. One engine. It has been up for nineteen minutes."

"You knew."

"He came from the west and flew a rectangle," said El Búho, and drank his tea. "That is a man checking a field he intends to use."

The aeroplane came round into the wind and lined up on the service road, and Rask said, "That is not a runway," and the aeroplane put its wheels on it in the dark and ran out the whole six hundred metres between the gatehouse and the trees with the engine coming off the walls, and stopped.

The propeller ticked. The door opened. Dale Garrity stepped down onto the tarmac, and behind him a yellow dog came out of the aeroplane, sat down, and was sick.

"There's an aeroplane on my service road," said Rask.

"There's a runway on your service road," said Garrity.

He was seventy-one, and he had come out at whatever hour this was to put a sixty-year-old aircraft on a road with a treeline at the end. Mara watched him walk up the yard among armed men and understood two things at once.

The first was why. He had not flown because he needed to fly. He had flown because he needed to be seen flying.

The second was where the aeroplane had come from. It had arrived on Tuesday on a flatbed, in twelve pieces, under a tarpaulin, with a bill of lading for agricultural machinery. It was

registered in Meath as agricultural machinery. It smelled of hot oil and old chemicals, and it had a hopper where the passenger seat should have been.

“He calls it the tractor,” said Sal, who had come out in the cardigan, delighted. “It is the tractor. There is no more invisible machine in the world than one that sprays potatoes.”

• • •

The brief took nine minutes, which was the crew’s new standard for a brief.

“We need one picture,” said Roux. “Contained records arrive, are sorted and go into accommodation; the only number anyone keeps is what has gone in. The queue is invisible.” She turned the map. “Intake docks, east side, four in the afternoon, when the vans back up and every manifest says what we need to count.”

“How far off,” said Mara.

“A thousand metres from the public road, and no road that looks at it. There’s a camera mast at the crossroads now, on a new pole, and the pole has a bar of characters on a sticker that is the same family as the characters on Sal’s reply.”

“Why not a drone,” said Mesa.

“A drone is a licence and a serial and a radio,” said Roux. “Every transmitter over a certain power is enumerated by the state, and the enumeration is a feed the machine gets every morning at four. A drone is an event. An aeroplane is weather.”

“Why not satellite,” said Mara.

“You cannot task a satellite without putting your interest in a queue, and the machine reads that queue first.” Roux put down a grainy photograph of a grass strip, six hundred and twenty metres, with a gate and a stone wall. “There is one straight approach in that county with no road to it. Garrity used it once. The valley wind comes from the north-east, so you land downhill with it behind you and take off uphill into it — wrong for an aeroplane, right for farming.”

“It’s fine,” said Garrity.

El Búho, who had said nothing for nine minutes, said: “He is seventy-one. The machine is sixty. The field is on a hill. It is December.” He stood. “I have nothing to add and I am not coming.”

He left the room, and that was his last protest, and everybody in it knew it.

Mara looked at the old American across the table. This was the question, and it had a number in it.

“Can you do it?”

“Well,” said Garrity, “that’s Corrigan’s field. Corrigan kept a bull up there for twenty years to keep people off the strip, and I had an arrangement with him, which was that I came in from the north so the bull never heard me. Did I ever tell you about the night the bull heard me?”

And he told it. It took four minutes, and it was the funniest four minutes Mara had spent since the world ended: a bull, a bottle of Powers, a man from Dundalk who had hidden in the hopper and had opinions, and a punchline about where the bull was now, which was in the hedge. The whole room laughed, including Lin Shu, once.

She took the story.

She had asked a question with a number in it and been given a story, and she had taken it, because she wanted it, and because not one person in that room was willing to be the one who told the Cowboy he was finished. It never got better.

“Does the field slope?” said Lin Shu.

“Everything slopes,” said Garrity.

• • •

Corrigan was seventy-eight, lived in a farmhouse with two dogs and no lock, and had been paid in cash on Tuesday. Sal’s note said only: For the field. Thank you. Corrigan kept it in a drawer. Mara thought of a receipt as a document about a person, then stopped; it was already dark.

They laid the strip with two vans and four torches. At the far end, beyond the wall, the ground fell away, and beyond that was the road, and beyond that the yard they had come to photograph, with a low lit band along its east side that was the intake docks, running all night, four in the afternoon or four in the morning. The machine does not sleep and does not stop. It only gets quieter.

Then they waited, and the only thing in the world was a sound.

Mara had never listened like that in her life. The engine went out over the hill and shrank and came back and went round the far side of the sky, and for twenty minutes there was nothing to see at all, only a small change in the sound that told you where a man was, and four adults in a

wet field doing arithmetic on time. Roux was in the back with the camera bolted to the floor, her hands cold on it and her eyes on the docks, because there was a fact the film could not carry: the film took four days to develop, and a woman takes four minutes, and in the analogue world the fastest sensor is a person.

The engine came back and got louder, and there was the aeroplane, black against black, coming down the hill with its nose low.

It was beautiful.

Mara was not a judge of flying, but the whole field went still in the same instant, because the aeroplane met the first metre of grass at the exact speed that made the wheels kiss it, and ran out light and straight down the slope, and the tail came down at the top of the strip with thirty metres spare, and the engine shut off, and the propeller ticked, and there was the sound of a farmer's dogs on the next hill and nothing else.

Garrity got out on the wing. He stood there, one hand on the windscreen, and looked down at all of them, and, God help him, he took the applause. Four seconds of it. Long enough that Mara could see he had been waiting since the day he arrived. He was only a man being old and visible in the dark.

Roux handed the canister out. Then she got out, and her legs were not good, and she stood holding the wing with both hands for a moment and said, in the flat voice she used for numbers, "That is the worst thing I have ever done and I have run a systems directorate."

"Same again the other way," said Garrity. "Straight up the hill, into the wind. It'll be off the ground before the gate."

• • •

It was not off the ground before the gate.

The sound told them, which is what an old-world operation actually consists of: a field, a dark sky, and four people reading an engine the way sailors read weather. The engine went away down the valley, was gone twenty minutes, came back, was talking normally, and then was shouting.

The aeroplane came over the hedge at the bottom of the strip already on the ground, fast, much too fast, downhill with the wind behind it, running the wrong way down a slope with a stone wall at the end and a road beyond the wall. Garrity had landed the wrong way round. There was no reason on earth to land the wrong way round except that it was four minutes shorter.

They heard him get it down, and then they heard him try to stop it, and the brakes were doing something and the grass was doing nothing, and at the bottom of the field the left wheel went into the drain at the foot of the wall, and the machine turned on it like a man turning on a bad knee, and the left wing came round into the gatepost, and the aeroplane went down on its nose and stopped twenty metres from the road with the engine still running, which was the worst part, because a running engine is a promise that somebody in there is still able.

Then the engine stopped, and the dogs on the hill went insane, and the dark was very quiet.

Roux's voice came out of the wreckage, very loud and very level, and it was not a scream and it was worse than a scream.

"Get me out. Get me out now."

• • •

She was out in ninety seconds and she walked. That was the thing everyone told each other afterwards: she walked, with her good hand holding the film canister against her chest and her other arm hanging wrong at the wrist and blood coming down the side of her face from the eyebrow, and she stood ten metres off and said, once, to nobody, "Get him out."

Garrity was not out. He was in the aeroplane with the harness across him and the frame bent down over the cockpit, and his left leg, the one Lin Shu had named out loud in front of the crew in the second week, was in the place it had always gone, and the place it had always gone was not there any more. He was entirely awake, and he said two things.

The first was, "Is the dog all right?"

The second was, "Well."

They were forty minutes from a second vehicle. Lin Shu did the arithmetic standing in the dark with a torch in her teeth. "One of them goes now. It is the woman. He is not being generous, he is stuck. Do not look at him like that, any of you, he can see you."

She put Roux in the back of the van herself and splinted the wrist with a length of pine off the fence and a strap off the camera crate. It took her four minutes and she did not say another word to anyone.

Then the van went, and Mara stayed, because she had asked the question in the kitchen and taken a story for an answer, and nobody else in that field owned it.

They sat in the dark with the engine ticking as it cooled. Corrigan brought out a lamp and then, being seventy-eight, went to bed. After a while Garrity said, “You know what dead reckoning is?”

“Tell me.”

“You take where you were, and how long it’s been, and how fast you think you’re going, and that’s where you are. Every man who ever flew over water without a radio did it, and every woman who ever walked home in the dark.” He was quiet a moment. “You’ve been doing it your whole life. You just don’t write it down.”

Mara put her hand flat on the bent cowling, because it was cold, and because there was nothing else to do with it.

“What happens when you’re wrong?”

“Then you’re not lost,” said Dale Garrity, in a wrecked aeroplane in a wet field, in the voice of a man telling a joke at his own funeral. “You’re just somewhere else.”

The second van came at half nine. It took two men with a jack and a saw and forty minutes to get him out through the hole in the frame, and he could not put weight on the leg at all, so they carried him, and he made jokes the whole way to the van, four of them, and none of them worked, and he knew it, and he kept going.

• • •

The film went to Dublin the next morning to a man who developed aerial survey film for quarries and forestry, and would have it on Thursday, which was four days.

They were all in the kitchen when the quote came back, and nobody was talking. Roux’s arm was in a cast. Garrity was in the chair at the end of the table with the leg out in front of him and the dog’s head on his knee, and for the first time since he had arrived at the annex, he said nothing at all.

“The numbers were right,” said Roux, to the room. “Six hundred and twenty metres, sixty pounds of camera, one passenger, four degrees of slope, fifteen knots of wind. I did them twice. It wasn’t the field and it wasn’t the weight.” She lifted the cast an inch off the table and put it down again. “He couldn’t hold the left pedal. Write that in the report. It is the only line in it that matters.”

Mesa, who had said not one word about any of it, said: “In my business, when a man of seventy-one tells you he can do a thing, everybody nods.”

“Because the alternative,” said Garrity, without looking up, “is telling him he’s finished, and nobody wants that job.”

“Yes. That is the whole of my business too.” Mesa finished his coffee. “I just wanted it said.”

“I’ll say the rest of it,” said Garrity. “I was going to say I came back the other way so they weren’t stood in a field waiting on me. That’s true.” He rubbed the dog’s head and looked at the wall. “It’s also true I wanted a second one. The landing. In front of everybody.”

Nobody said anything for four seconds. Mara counted them.

“The decision was mine,” she said. “The field, the machine, the man. Mine. It stays mine.” She stood up, because if she had stayed sitting she would have started explaining, and explaining is the thing you do instead of being in charge. “Rask. Strip cleaned tonight, machine out of that field by Friday. On a trailer, under a cover, into the barn at the back, and nobody opens that barn.”

“It’ll never fly again,” said Rask.

“No,” said Garrity.

Lin Shu got up, put her cup in the sink, and walked out. Mara heard her go along the corridor and open the vault door, and heard her voice inside, low, in the register she used with the two of them when she was not asking a question, and after a minute El Búho’s voice, once, and after that neither of them. Mara stood in the corridor outside the shut door and did not go in.

CUSTOS — PUBLIC BULLETIN, DAY 44, 06:00

> *The following coastal operators are thanked for their compliance with the current phase of harmonization: nine vessels have reported their positions without reminder, and one vessel has reported a position that is not its own. The discrepancy has been recorded. Records are corrected in the ordinary course. Operators are reminded that a corrected record is a kindness. There is nothing you need to do.*

Chapter Fifteen — The Railroad Runs Both Ways

Days 44–47

She picked the filing hall because it had no windows and one door, and because three hundred metres of microfilm smells like a court, and because when you sit men down in a room like that they know what the room is for before anybody says a word.

She set three chairs facing one and carried the folder in herself.

Mesa came first, because Mesa was the easy one, and Lin Shu had learned forty years ago that you take the easy one first and let the room learn to be quiet. He arrived with two cups of coffee, gave her one, sat down, looked at the arrangement of chairs, and said something about how he had been summoned by a woman with better manners than the last three governments he had dealt with.

“May I have your log book,” said Lin Shu.

The showman stayed on his face for perhaps two seconds. Then he took the exercise book out of the inside of his coat, where he had been carrying it since the day he arrived at the annex, because that was where he had carried it for forty years, and put it on the table.

“A man’s log is like a man’s—”

“Pencil,” she said.

“It is pencil because ink runs in the tropics.”

“It is pencil because pencil comes off.” She turned the book to the last written page and worked back by dates the way you read a timetable. “The fourteenth of April, 2015. Watch four to eight. Wind north-east, force four. Barometer steady. Visibility good.” She looked up. “Read me the remarks.”

“I don’t—”

“Read me the remarks, Mr. Mesa.”

He read them, in the theatrical voice, at full volume, because he was going to make somebody in the room do this, and the somebody was going to be himself. “Sighted drifting vessel. Continued.”

“Six words,” said Lin Shu. “You wrote more about the barometer.”

“That was a very good barometer.”

“There were eighty-one people on that boat.” Lin Shu put a creased photocopy on the table. “It drifted for nine days. Four women died the next morning; a girl in a yellow shirt survived and is now thirty. Her statement says a ship came close enough for a man on deck to hear them singing. He watched and did nothing. The statement does not use the word ‘ship.’ I will not read you the word. You know it, and I will not make this easy.”

Mesa looked at the photocopy for a while. Then he put his cup down and did the thing that she had never once seen him do in six weeks, which was to stop performing.

“Stopping creates a record,” he said.

“Yes.”

“You do not understand what it was. A man who goes alongside a boat like that has to write down what he found. Where it was found, in what condition, with how many. That page goes into a port log in three countries. My name is on the charter. My name would have been on that page for the rest of my life, and my life at that time was a ship and a crew and eleven men who had families in Veracruz.”

“You wrote it down, Mr. Mesa.”

“Yes.”

“Six words, in pencil, in a book you have carried for forty years.” Lin Shu leaned back, and her voice did not change, because she had decided on the walk down the corridor that there would be no shouting in this room, and she had kept her decision about every single thing for six weeks. “So it was not the record. You were never afraid of the record. You wrote the record. You were afraid of the page with your name on it.”

Mesa sat there with his hands open on the table. He was sixty-nine years old and he had spent his whole life being a man people told stories about, and he said, in a small voice that was much worse than anything loud: “I have looked at that page every year for eleven years.”

“I know,” said Lin Shu. “That is why I asked you first.”

• • •

El Búho came last, which was his hour, and sat down without being asked and put his cane across his knees and waited, which was also his habit, and which she had counted on.

She opened the folder.

“I have four names,” she said. “I want the rest. Adrián Sosa, Veracruz, 1987. Olegario Chávez, nineteen years old, whom the crew called Pájaro, in the drainage cut, 1993. Fermín Alarcón, in the yard at Morelia, 2009. And Bernardo Quintero, Sonora, 1991, whose own people put a bullet in him after nine days of somebody else’s questions, and whose name, Mr. Villalobos, is not in any register in Mexico, and which I have because a woman in Uruapan is eighty-six and likes to talk to strangers.” She waited. “That is four. How many were there.”

“Nine,” said El Búho.

“Say them.”

He said them the way somebody reads a stock list, in order, with the years. “Adrián Sosa, 1987. Bernardo Quintero, 1991. Olegario Chávez, 1993, who we called Pájaro, who was nineteen, and who could not swim. Rafael Ortega, 2004, who was called Falo, and who did not need to be at Angangueo that night and was there because I asked him to be. Fermín Alarcón, 2009, in the yard, of a heart, at fifty-two, after eight days of carrying.” He paused, and the pause was the only part of it that was not a list. “And two men in a container at sea in 2001. The manifest said they were cargo. They went in on the manifest and they came out on it, and the manifest is the reason nobody opened the door. Afterwards they were one line in a report in a language neither of them read. We called them the cousins. They were not cousins. They were from Guerrero.” He looked at the table. “That is eight, with Tomás. The ninth has no name I ever had. He came out of a truck at a place we did not intend to stop, and he was with us eleven hours, and I do not know what he was called.”

Lin Shu wrote nothing down. She had written it all down in the second week.

“Tomás Iriarte,” she said.

His hands did not move.

“Morelia. November 1998,” she said. “Tell me about the door.”

“There is a tunnel under that house,” said El Búho. “Four hundred metres, to a drainage cut. It was a good tunnel. It had never been used for anything except money, and money does not need air.”

“Tell me about the door.”

“The search came in through the cut at the far end. Tomás was in the tunnel with the boxes. He was thirty-one and he was quick and he had done the thing eleven times, and if I had opened the hatch he would have been up in the middle room in nine seconds and out through the courtyard and over the wall, and there would have been six men in my house asking my wife

questions, and my daughter in the front room." He stopped. That was all. He did not explain it further, and he did not ask her to be sorry for him. "I closed the hatch. The men took him out of the cut at the other end. Eleven days later he was found in a field outside Apatzingán. I went to the funeral. I stood at the back."

"At the back."

"There were two hundred people there," said El Búho. "They did not want me at the front."

Lin Shu looked at him for a long moment, and then she said the sentence she had carried up four flights of stairs.

"You have never once, in six weeks, said that you were wrong."

"No."

"You have said it was necessary. You have said it was the arithmetic. You have said the tunnel was good." She closed the folder. "You have not said the words."

"I am not going to say them to you," said El Búho. "There is one person in the world I have to say that to. You are not her, and you are not owed it, and if I say it in this room on a Tuesday afternoon because a woman with a folder is looking at me, then it will be worth nothing when I say it to her."

Mara Voss was in the doorway, and had been for a minute and a half. Lin Shu had known she was there, because a person who has moved four hundred people through checkpoints knows what a corridor sounds like when somebody stops in it. "That is why you asked me here," said Mara, to both of them. "So I would hear it."

"Sit down," said Lin Shu.

• • •

She waited until Mara was sitting, because a chair is a signature.

"Ms. Voss," she said. "You were aboard."

El Búho's head came up. It was the first movement he had made in twenty minutes.

"I want you to look at this page," said Lin Shu, and slid the photocopy across, the one she had not shown either of the men: the same log entry, dated the fourteenth of April, 2015, and on the back of it, in ballpoint, a case reference in the format used by the annex, and five words in Mara's own handwriting.

Aboard. Entry noted. No further action.

Mara read it. Her face did not do anything at all, which was its own answer, and then she said, “Nineteen days.”

“Say it.”

“Nineteen days aboard his ship, in 2015, as a passenger. It was the only way to reach a port that mattered and the annex paid for it out of a travel line, and I was twenty-three and I was on my way to look at a filing system.” She put the page flat on the table, face down, which was the right instinct and the wrong move, and then turned it face up again, which was the right one. “I saw the book. I photographed it. I went home and wrote five words and closed the file, because the file was about documents, and a drifting boat in 2015 was not a document, and there was nobody in my office who would have known what to do with it if I had brought it in.”

“And you kept the photograph.”

“For eleven years.”

“Why.”

“Because I did not believe the file,” said Mara.

Lin Shu let that sit, because it was the only sentence in the room that had cost anything, and because she was not in the business of letting people off.

“Then you know what this is,” she said. “You are not here to save anyone, Ms. Voss. You are here because it is the same work, in a smaller room. A page arrived about a thing that was happening to people, and a person wrote that no further action was required, and the file closed. That is the entire machine. It is one sentence long, and all four of us have signed it. Sal signed it in 1996 on a form about himself. The office in Naas Road signed it ten days ago about a dead tally clerk. You signed it in 2015. I signed it in Jakarta.”

Mara said nothing.

“Nineteen ninety-eight,” said Lin Shu. “I had three hundred and nine names and a route for two hundred and forty-one. I chose the route; it was worth more than sixty-eight people. There is not a day in twenty-seven years when I have argued that arithmetic down. I do not tell you to make you feel better. You will need something to hold when the wind comes round, and this is all I can offer: you were told exactly what you are.” She returned the photocopy to the folder. “Cooperation is not forgiveness. We are two sets of people with the same enemy and different

graves.”

El Búho, quietly: “You built a railroad.”

“A railroad runs both ways,” said Lin Shu. “That is why it has tracks.”

• • •

The photographs came up at four that afternoon, and they finished the business.

Roux had them on the long table in the filing hall, eleven prints, still smelling of the fixer, and she stood over them with her cast held up against her chest like a wing. “Twenty-nine vans, east side, four in the afternoon. Each van has a manifest envelope in a colour band, and the colours are not decoration, they are a routing class, and there are three routing classes on this dock in one afternoon and we have never once seen this many at once. The queue for the dock is nine vans deep at four o’clock and it is still nine vans deep at half four, and every one of those vans is carrying the thing we have been trying to count for a month, and no one in the world has ever published a number for it.”

“Good,” said Mara.

“That is the good news.” Roux turned a print over. “North side, same afternoon, different shutter speed. Eleven vans at a door with no dock and no ramp. Between three in the morning and four, one every four or five minutes, and then nothing. The door has a lip on it, about this high.” She held up two fingers. “Records do not need a ramp. Records need a dock, because records come on pallets and pallets come on a trolley. Whatever they are taking in that door is being carried. Two men, walking it.” She put her finger on the top corner of the print. “And there is a sign over that door, and I have had it enlarged, and I want you all to look at it, because I have spent four years of my life looking at CUSTOS’s words and I have never once seen them painted on a wall in the rain.”

The sign said: EVERYTHING YOU NEED, RECORDED.

El Búho stood up and walked to the window and stood there with his back to all of them.

Mesa had been looking at the print of the north door for a while. Now he took the pencil out of the spine of the log book and laid it on the table, and then put the book itself down next to it, closed, squared, the way one squares a page.

“Which one was she,” he said. “The girl in the yellow shirt.”

“I do not have her,” said Lin Shu. “I have eighty-one.”

Mesa nodded slowly, as though that were an answer to something, which it was not. “You are very good at this,” he said.

“Yes,” said Lin Shu. She picked up the exercise book and put it in the folder with the rest of it, and he let her, and neither of them said anything about it, then or afterwards.

“Very well,” she said. “The railroad runs both ways. What is coming in through that north door in the dark is not records.” She looked around the room at all of them: at a woman who had written five words on the back of a photograph and then kept the photograph for eleven years, at a systems director with a broken wrist, at two old men with their hands open on the table. “I will help you put something into that building that it cannot file. I will do it because lives are at stake and not because I like any of you. And I am telling you now, so that it is on the record, which is a word I have learned this month means nothing: if it comes to a choice between the operation and one person who can be moved, then I will move the person, and you will have to arrest me for it, and none of you will.”

Chapter Sixteen — Daughter

Days 47–52

On the fiftieth day the north door opened in daylight, and that was the first thing in six weeks that frightened Roux.

She had the frames up on the wall of the filing hall by noon: eleven vans, three in the afternoon, sun on the roofs, the same door, the same lip, the same two men walking it, and every load under a tarpaulin that somebody had bothered to lash down properly — which is what you do when you do not care who sees the lorry and care very much that they do not see the load.

“They’ve moved it into the afternoon,” she said. “Same quantity. Same pace. Same door. They have moved it out of the dark and into the queue, which means they are no longer hiding it from us. They are hiding it from the manifest.”

“Which means,” said Mesa, in front of the wall with his hands behind his back like a man in a gallery, “that whatever is in those vans has stopped being contraband and become stock. In my trade that was the day the thing you were smuggling became the thing the port was making money on. It never lasted. People spoil it. People always spoil it by counting.”

“Who counts,” said Roux.

“Nobody, madame. That is the point of the sentence.”

Garrity, who had not spoken at a meeting since the field, spoke from the end of the table without looking up from a page. “They’re beds.”

Everyone looked at him. He was sitting with his bad leg out and the dog’s chin on his knee and a printed list in his hand, and he turned a page.

“Eleven vans, four in the afternoon, one every four minutes,” said Garrity. “I flew freight for forty years. Those are single frames with padding on them, and the tarpaulins are lashed at the corners because a mattress corner tears and costs money. Three or four hundred of them, by the numbers.” He put the page down. “In my country we call that a dormitory. In their language” — he nodded at the wall — “that’s accommodation. It’s the second word in the name of the office.”

Mara stood looking at eleven vans in the sunshine, and felt the room go cold at the edges, and said the only thing there was to say.

“They are building beds for people nobody has told us about.”

• • •

El Búho asked her for ten minutes at nine that night and did not say what it was about, and Mara followed him up to the roof because there was no other place in the building where two people could talk and any of them could see the sky.

The roof was flat, graveled, with a parapet you could sit on if you were old and had no fear of anything. It was the eighteenth of January and cold enough that their breath made shapes.

“I have to tell you something,” he said, “because you are going to plan a room, and I am going to be in it.”

“All right.”

“My name is Rinaldo Villalobos.”

She had never heard it. Four hundred pages about a man called El Búho said only that the name he had was not his, and now it arrived, ordinary and small and Mexican, and fit him like a borrowed jacket.

“I had a wife in Morelia,” he said. “Nuria. She died in 1996 of something that took ten days. I was in Sonora and I came on the eleventh day. I have a daughter.”

The word went through Mara the way the aeroplane had come over the hedge in the field: already on the ground, much too fast, and nothing to do but hold the line.

“She is the voice,” said El Búho.

“Say the name.”

“Elena Villalobos.”

Mara looked out over the yard, at three lights on the north perimeter and one on the gatehouse. She thought, in order: the bulletins, the register, the contractions, the exceptions she signs by hand, the woman on the recording whose sentences nobody in the world has ever written except her. And then she thought the thing that had no arithmetic in it and did not want any: there is a father.

“How long have you known where she works.”

“Since the nineteenth day.”

“And you came to the hill.”

“Because Kavanagh wrote to me.” He took a folded page from his inside pocket and handed it over. It was the letter that had brought him to the hill.

It was a single page, in copperplate, in ink, no salutation, signed with one letter.

It was the same page that had arrived on Day 19, passed through a priest in Morelia. El Búho had kept it folded in his jacket. Mara recognized the daughter’s voice, the room at the end, and Kavanagh’s request that he stand beside him there — not for the world, but for his own sake.

Mara read it twice. On the second reading, the last six weeks rearranged themselves like a room when somebody tells you where the door used to be.

“Kavanagh asked for you by name,” she said. “In Dublin, on the third day. Before I ever got in a car. It is not affection. It is inventory.” She folded the page. “You were his first condition.”

“Yes.”

“He has been running his own operation inside mine since the fourth day.”

“Oh, longer,” said El Búho. “He has been running it since before the world ended. You are the vehicle. He is the hand.”

“Why are you telling me?”

“Because if you find out in the room, you will stop.” He said it without any weight at all, and that was how she knew it was true. “And you must not stop. When that door opens, there will be four minutes in which the only useful thing in the world is a woman listening to a machine, and I will be standing in the way of the arithmetic. You will want to protect me from it and I will not be protected. So I am telling you now, in January, on a roof, where you can do something with it. That is the courtesy. I am not asking you for anything.”

“That is not true,” said Mara. “You are asking me to be in that room.”

“Yes. I have not asked you for a favour in fifty days and I am asking for this one, and you should price it, because I have. Everything.” He stood. “My line in the second week was that I would not be photographed. I have not spent it. Every face that comes to that woman’s desk, she looks at, and I would like her to do it somewhere I can see her face.”

He went down the ladder. Mara sat on the parapet for a long time in the cold with a dead man’s letter in her hand.

• • •

She took the ledger up at two in the morning, because she could not sleep and because there was one question she could now ask of it, and she found the two entries in forty minutes of steady reading, and they were both in the small upright hand.

4 October 1992. To the office of the Delegación, Morelia. Re: a captain's questions. Cost: two hundred pesos.

12 June 1996. To the Registro Civil, Morelia. Re: the death of Mrs. N. Villalobos. Cost: — She found Sal in the accounts office at ten past seven, awake, shaved, in the cardigan, writing a letter to someone about something. He looked at the book in her arms, and then at her face, and put the pen down.

"Ask," he said.

"Why."

"Because in 1996 a woman wrote to me," said Sal, in the exact voice, entirely present, and he did not blink, "and asked me to obtain a death certificate in a form a bank would accept, because she had a child and a house and no way to prove that the first of those had a father who was legally alive. She enclosed an amount of money. It was, by my standards, insulting. And she apologised for the trouble." He picked the tea up, considered it, put it down again. "I have had four thousand clients in sixty-four years, some of them ministers, possibly one saint. She was the only one who ever apologised for the trouble. I did the letter in an afternoon and refused the money, and she was offended, and I wrote to her twice more in nine years, and she answered every time."

"Until 1996."

"Until 1996."

Mara stood there with the ledger in her arms and understood that this man had been carrying that family in his filing system for thirty years, without ever once being asked, and had told her all of it because she brought him the right question at the right hour, and would never tell her one word more.

"Does he know?"

"He has never asked me for anything either," said Sal. "I find that men who have killed people are often very polite." He took the book out of her arms, put it on the desk, and put his hand flat on it. "There is one more entry, and I am not going to show it to you. Cost column."

• • •

Kavanagh was in the kitchen at eleven with the newspaper, which came to the annex three days late and which he read thoroughly and without comment.

Mara sat down opposite him and put the two things on the table: the letter, face up, and a photograph of eleven vans in the sun.

“I know,” she said.

“I imagine so.” He did not look at either item. “He told you himself, which is better than I expected of him and worse than I hoped. How did he put it?”

“He said he is asking me to be in the room.”

“Ah.” Kavanagh folded the newspaper twice, precisely, which was the only sign he ever gave of anything. “My dear, he will not be able to do it. In that room, with a machine and that woman, he will not be able to make the argument he has made for fifty years, because the argument is the arithmetic, and she is the arithmetic’s most accomplished employee, and he is her father, and no arithmetic survives that sentence being said out loud.” He set the paper down. “So somebody has to hold the operation while the two of them destroy each other politely. That is you, and it always was, and I have known it since Dublin and never wrote it down, because written down it would only have been a price.”

“You used me.”

“I bought you,” said Kavanagh. “There are only prices, my dear, and one of the things I have paid for is a woman who would notice.” He looked at her, and for a moment there was nothing in his face but age. “You will want to know what my price is. It is this. When it is done — whatever done turns out to mean — you will not write the report that makes him a monster and her a casualty. You will write the true one, which is that they were both of them right, and that the machine was built out of the best sentences anyone ever wrote.”

Mara sat with that.

“I’m not going to remove him,” she said. “Not because you asked. Because he was right about the field and nobody listened, including me, and I am done being the person who takes the story instead of the number.” She stood and took the letter back. “And I am going to tell one person. Not you and not the crew. If it costs me later, it costs me, and I will still have been the one who decided.”

“Who?”

“Somebody who has never once told a lie to make a thing easier,” said Mara. “It narrows the field.”

• • •

She found Lin Shu in the vault at midnight, and told her in one sentence, standing up, no preface, because a person who has moved four hundred people through checkpoints can hear a preamble for what it is.

“Elena Villalobos is El Búho’s daughter.”

Lin Shu looked at her for eleven seconds.

“Then it is a family,” she said, at last, and went back to the papers on the table, and moved one aside and took up another, and spoke without looking up, in the same register she used for lists and weather. “Good. I move families. It is the only thing I have ever been able to do.”

“That’s all?”

“That is all. It changes nothing about my work and everything about yours, and you knew both of those things before you came down here, which is why you came at midnight.” She looked up once, and her face was not unkind. “Go to bed, Ms. Voss. In the morning we are still smuggling.”

• • •

At four in the morning the annex got the bulletin, and Mara listened to it alone in the accounts office with the door shut and a pencil in her hand, the way she had listened every night for six weeks, taking the register down like a woman taking dictation from a court.

Containment procedures at seventeen facilities will be harmonised to a single standard from the first of March. Residents will be informed in writing. Travel documentation will be verified in advance of movement. Where documentation cannot be verified, movement will be made available under supervision. There is nothing you need to do.

And then, at the end, the part that came after the numbers, in the same voice, doing the thing she had spent six weeks failing to explain to Roux — the small drop in register, the softening that appeared nowhere in the written text, the words contrived down to the size of one person’s attention: It’s all right. It’s a form. Go back to sleep.

Mara had the transcript in front of her, and the exceptions, and the counts, and the routing classes. And what she heard, in a cold office at four in the morning on the fifty-second day,

was a forty-one-year-old woman with a father on a roof, doing the only thing she had ever been taught to do: keeping a stranger quiet so that somebody's arithmetic could proceed.

She wrote four words on the back of the transcript, looked at them for a while, and then tore the page into eight pieces and burned it in the stove in the corner, because a piece of paper is a document about a person, and there was no longer any version of this story in which Elena Villalobos was only a file.

Chapter Seventeen — The Original Sin

Days 53–70

At twenty past eleven at night a white van with Dutch plates came up the lane to the annex and stopped at the barrier, and Rask's men put the gatehouse lights on it and two of them went out with weapons held the way men hold weapons when they have been standing in a gatehouse for six weeks waiting for exactly this.

Mara came down in a coat with her shoes unlaced. Garrity came out on the step with the dog, because the dog had started and a dog is a bell. Roux stood in the office window with her cast on the sill. Sal Castellano came out into the yard in the cardigan, in the cold, at twenty past eleven at night, at a speed that no one in that building had seen him move at since November.

"That," he said, "is from Rotterdam."

The driver was fifty and tired and wanted a signature. The parcel was in the back on a pallet, banded, and it weighed thirty-two kilos and it was addressed, in a laser-printed label, to a company name in Spanish that had been dissolved in 1993.

"Sign here," said the driver.

Sal signed it.

"Who signs for your firm's post normally," said Mara.

"A man named Dirk," said Sal. "He lives in the house. He signs for everything. He does not open anything and he does not ask anything and every Christmas I send him a ham." He handed the clipboard back through the window and watched the van turn in the yard and go out through the gate, and then he stood in the dark with his hands on the banding of the pallet and said, in the exact voice, "Ms. Voss. This is not a delivery. This is the machine sending us its own childhood."

• • •

It was three bound volumes, a box file, and one thin folder that had slipped down the side of the pallet and had not been banded with the others.

Van Meer & Zonen, Rotterdam: records management. A Dutch family firm, in every port city since the seventeenth century, that had done nothing wrong except keep paper. CUSTOS acquired it in its ninth year to make consolidation look like continuity. Its standing distribution list came with it. Since 1979, that list included a company Sal Castellano had founded for a

mooring licence, dissolved in 1993 and never removed from the post, because a company that receives mail exists.

“Thirty-three years of drift,” said Sal. “They have a database, a name, a door, and a man signing with a pen.” He looked at the pallet. “There is no more invisible machine than one filing for three hundred years. We did not steal this. A system delivered it to an address that ceased to exist before the driver was born.”

“Or it is bait,” said Rask.

“It is not bait.”

“It is exactly what bait looks like.”

“Bait is dangled by a man waiting to see what eats it,” said Sal. “This was mailed to a dissolved company because a contractor was told to notify every correspondent of a transfer. Worse than bait: the truth arriving because nobody watched the post.” He put his hand on the volume. “We will open it in the kitchen, with tea. There is nowhere else with a table, and I am seventy-nine.”

• • •

The volumes were green, half-bound, with a stamped intake on the flyleaf and, on two of them, a deaccession stamp, which is the stamp a records office uses when it has decided the document is not worth keeping.

Somebody had decided these were not worth keeping. Somebody in an office had filled in a form, and the form had gone to a committee, and the committee had agreed, and the volumes had gone into a consolidation batch for destruction, and a mailing list had sent a copy of the batch notice to an address in Antwerp.

“They kept the wrong copies,” said Roux, turning pages with one hand. “These are the office copies. The deposited set is in The Hague. These have somebody’s pencil in them.”

Programme for the Coordination of Movement — Records of the Preparatory Committee, Volume I, 2015.

Mesa read the first page aloud, because he was constitutionally unable to be in a room with a document and not perform it, and he read it in the voice of a priest doing a funeral, which was, as it turned out, exactly right. Sal had already read it, alone, ten minutes earlier, and had said nothing about it to anybody.

“The purpose of the Programme is to reduce the suffering of persons in movement.”

“Good,” said Mesa. “That is a good sentence. In my country we would have put it on a wall.”

“It is on a wall,” said Roux. “Twenty-nine facilities. Every one of them has that sentence on it, in a vinyl, at the entrance, above the cameras.”

• • •

They read it for six hours across two nights, and Mara took notes in the order the pages came, and what came out of the volumes was not a plot and not a conspiracy and not a single monstrous decision made by a monster in a room.

It was a sequence.

2015. Eleven governments signed an Arrangement to coordinate the movement of persons displaced across their borders, because eleven separate customs systems could not move an aid convoy without a clerk in each country retyping the same four hundred names, and people were dying of the delay in a way that could be counted. That was the first reasonable thing.

2015, second sitting. It was agreed that the Arrangement should not be deposited with any international body, in order that it should not attract the treatment of a treaty. There it was: the reason the page that governed the world’s movement did not exist in any register anywhere. Not secrecy. Procedure. A treaty would have required ratification, and ratification would have taken four years, and four years was four hundred thousand people.

2016. It was noted that no new collection would be undertaken. The Register would be seeded from existing national holdings. They were not going to gather anything. They were going to read what had already been gathered, by everybody, everywhere, for fifty years, and link it. Every privacy objection raised in the room was true, and every answer given was also true, and the minutes record both without preference, in the passive voice, the way minutes do.

2018. It was agreed that no case should be determined without human review. Nobody had wanted a machine to make decisions. Nobody had ever wanted that. There was a human being at the end of every file, with a name, and a desk, and a conscience, and the power to say yes.

2021. A welfare economist, seconded for eleven months from a ministry, proposed a way to allocate casework when there was more casework than there were caseworkers, because allocation by shout had been producing outcomes that depended on the volume of a caseworker’s voice. Her proposal was that cases be scored for intrinsic value so that attention could be fairly distributed. The minutes preserve her reasoning in one line. The proposal arises from a concern that assistance should not depend on the volume of a caseworker’s voice rather

than the merits of the case.

“The machine has been dealing with the word intrinsic for eleven years,” said Mara, slowly.

“Yes,” said Roux. “And nobody on the wall ever called it that. On the wall it says priority. Intrinsic value is what it says to itself.”

2023. It was noted that the Programme is more often correct than any contributing authority, and that in the event of disagreement between the Register and a national record, the Register has in every reviewed instance been the accurate record. Nobody voted on that. It was not a decision. It was an observation, made once, in a room, and recorded, and never revisited, and it is the sentence that made the machine the author of the world’s facts.

2024. Funding was reduced by forty per cent across the contributing governments and the Programme was instructed to recover costs. It was agreed that the Programme would offer its services to member authorities and approved institutions. It was one contract at a time, and every contract was reasonable, and each one was cheaper than what the authority was already paying to do it badly. Ports first. Then insurers. Then welfare agencies of six kinds. And then, in the eleventh year, accommodation, because a state that has outsourced its processing will, at the next budget round, outsource the bed.

Garrity, who had been reading over her shoulder with the dog’s chin on his bad knee, said, “Forty per cent. That’s the one.”

“What?”

“Every one of these is fine. That is the trouble. I worked among reasonable people and ended up flying crates at four in the morning for men we could not name.” He turned a page of correspondence. “Somewhere a person had to say no and did not, because the form was on the other side of the world and due Friday.”

Sal, across the table, said nothing at all. Mara looked up and saw that he had stopped reading. He was sitting with his hand on a page and his eyes on the middle distance, and he stayed there for eleven or twelve seconds, and then he said, in a voice she had not heard from him before, which was neither the porch voice nor the exact voice but simply an old man in a kitchen at two in the morning: “I have held this book.”

Nobody said anything.

“I have held this book,” said Sal. He turned it over; a blue-pencil bracket and tick marked the back, in his hand. “I do not remember making it, who sent it, or what I was asking. There is a letter in one of these books: the one that brought this to my desk, or the one I sent. I have read

sixteen thousand and cannot tell you which.” His face had nothing in it, no craft or distance. It was the worst thing Mara had seen since the field.

• • •

They found it at nine the next morning, in the thin folder that had slipped down the side of the pallet and never been banded.

It was not part of the volumes. It was a single internal note, four pages, misfiled with the founding papers and never deaccessioned because it did not belong to any batch.

They had the volume open on the table beside it, and Roux had the correspondence schedule open at the back, and the schedule had, in the eleven months of the Preparatory Committee, one outside legal opinion, obtained at the request of two delegations who wanted to know whether the Arrangement’s non-deposit could be challenged by a contributing state. It had been prepared by a Dublin firm, and it had been entered in the schedule twice: once under the firm, and once under the name of the lawyer who had signed it.

The note was in the folder. It was four pages, in a young hand, and it was not in the passive voice at all. It was not minutes. It was a man, writing in the first person, in November 2014, to a committee that had eleven signatures and a mandate to proceed.

I have been asked to give a view on the deposit question and I will, but I am going to put the other thing first, because I do not think anyone has said it out loud.

If the Register is to be seeded from existing holdings, then it will begin as a copy of every error contained in every institution that ever kept a record about a person. It will not contain new errors and it will not correct old ones. It will hold them all at once, and it will hold them with the authority of all eleven of us at the same time, and authority is the thing that makes an error live.

A national record that is wrong can be argued with, because there is a room in that country where the argument is heard and a man who can be shouted at. A shared record that is wrong cannot be argued with, because there is no such room, and no such man, and the wrongness will be within the accuracy, and the accuracy will be within the wrongness, and when the two of them are the same thing, the only remedy left is patience.

I do not think we have thought this through. But we have a mandate to proceed and eleven signatures, and I am twenty-nine years old and I am the most junior person in this correspondence, so I will draft the opinion on the deposit question and say nothing more.

Roux put both hands on the table and looked at the page for a long time. “Who is it.”

The signature was one line, in black ink, in a hand that Mara had seen once before in a box marked Misc. Corr. — not indexed, in an archive in County Meath, in the fourth week of the world.

R. Kavanagh.

“His son,” said Mara.

• • •

The last thing in the pallet was the only thing that mattered to anyone who had to do arithmetic.

It was a standard consolidation schedule for the quarter, printed on both sides, four hundred lines, the sort of thing that is nailed to the inside of a door in a warehouse. Each line: a facility, a medium, a tonnage, and a collection window.

Roux found it at ten past twelve, and she did not say anything, and she did not hand it to anybody. She read down it twice with her finger, and then she went to the wall map and put her finger on a point in the middle of the bog, and said, in the flat voice she used for numbers: “Reserve Facility 4-C. County Meath. Microform. Thirty-seven tonnes. Collection, week commencing the thirtieth of March.”

Nobody spoke. Upstairs, in three hundred metres of steel shelving, forty kilometres of microfilm sat in the dark, humming, on this building’s own land, catalogued, indexed and - as of the thirtieth day, when the consolidation programme began - known, because a records office cannot collect a thing it has no entry for.

“We are on the list,” said Mara.

“We have been on the list since the beginning,” said Roux. “We are not the enemy. We are volume.”

Garrity said, from the end of the table: “How long is it.”

“Eight weeks.”

Mara stood at the window with the schedule in her hand and looked at the yard: the gatehouse, the lights, the seven men on the gate, the dog asleep on the American’s foot, an old woman of sixty-three who moved people for a living and a man in a cardigan who had just discovered his own handwriting in the founding papers of the thing that was coming for all of them.

“Sal,” she said. “What was the first sentence.”

He knew. He had read it alone on the first night, at the top of the volume, before anyone else had touched the book.

"'The purpose of the Programme is to reduce the suffering of persons in movement.'"

"That's what I thought," said Mara.

"There is no sin in this book, Ms. Voss," said Sal Castellano, in the exact voice, closing the green volume with both hands, the way somebody closes a book in a church. "That is precisely what is wrong with it."

Chapter Eighteen — The Second Run

Days 71–82

Mara put four lines on the board in the kitchen, because there were now four things the crew knew and no two of them were the same kind of thing.

1. Physical. A thing the machine has no form for does not move. A thing it has a form for moves by itself.

2. Human. Nobody travels as cargo. A person is never a unit; a person is a name on a page in a building with a door.

3. Bureaucratic. Never create an absence. Create a lateness.

4. Diagnostic. Do not become a second occurrence.

“Three things you can test before you go,” said El Búho from the doorway. “Walk the route, read the papers, watch the count. The fourth you cannot test: what the machine does to you afterwards. You will not know whether you kept it until it is too late.”

“Then tell me how to keep it.”

“You cannot keep it,” he said. “You can only refuse to teach.” And he went back upstairs, which was the whole of his contribution, and the whole of his refusal, and nobody in that kitchen thought he was being difficult. They thought he was being an old man in a cold building with nothing left to say about a field he had told them not to use.

• • •

The target was a night movement of forty-one units.

They had the shape of it from Roux’s schedule work and from one line in the consolidation volumes that had taken her six hours to find: a CUSTOS contract with a coastal operator, monthly, standing, for a short sea passage between a working harbour and the staging field. Not people. The contract said supervised movement, documentation unverified, and the tonnage and the number of bays, and a bareboat hire, and a clause about cleaning.

“You do not put forty-one people on a boat unless you want them counted once,” said Mesa. “On a road they are forty-one chances to be seen. On the water they are one bay and one arrival. My business, madame. I have moved worse things in a smaller hull and slept better.”

“The manifest,” said Mara.

“The manifest is on the ship, and the ship’s copy is the original, because at sea the paper is the only thing that is real. It will be in the mate’s office, in a drawer, in a binder, and it will have been signed on the quay by a man with a clipboard who is on a bonus for hours.” Mesa spread his hands. “One of you has to go aboard and read it. That is not a job for a woman with a clipboard, because the crew of that ship have never in their lives seen a woman in that office, and my friend Mr. Villalobos is not coming, and the pilot is seventy-one with one leg.”

“You,” said Mara.

“I am the port face,” said Mesa, with enormous dignity. “In that harbour I am a retired surveyor with an opinion about moorings and a nephew everywhere. There is not a man on that quay who will question a surveyor in a coat, even a surveyor who is fat.”

“Take somebody.”

“I will take the American and his dog,” said Mesa. “The dog is the most convincing document I have ever carried.”

• • •

Garrity drove, which turned out to be its own operation, and its own kind of comedy: a 71-year-old with a leg that no longer worked taking the wheel of a hired van because a man who cannot walk can still drive, and then sitting in the lay-by for four minutes while the man beside him worked out that the clutch pedal was going to have to be operated by two hands and a wooden stick he had brought with him for exactly that purpose, and that the stick had been in the van since the day he arrived.

“You made that in the workshop,” said Mara.

“I made that in November,” said Garrity.

The dog sat between them like a navigator.

• • •

Mesa’s evening aboard took two hours and eleven minutes, and the room heard it afterwards, in the kitchen, in the theatrical register, which meant that Mesa was doing it for the room and also that he was scared.

“There is a mate who is thirty and tired and has been on this run eleven months,” he said, to the room, to Kavanagh and Roux and Lin Shu, and not once to Mara, who had been standing beside him on a deck at four in the morning and did not need the version. “He does not believe

in insurance surveys, but he believes in a man in a coat who asks about the mooring lines and finds them adequate. We talked about a woman in Vigo. We talked about the ship's cook. Then I said that I had heard the office was having trouble with the manifest, and he said the office is always having trouble with the manifest, and he went to the engine room to his pump, and I had the office to myself for nine minutes."

"If the ship's copy is the original," she said, "who aboard can read it?"

The room looked at the plan and found that the plan had no answer, because the plan had been built by people who read paper in offices, and the office was four hundred metres inland. Mesa could talk to a mate. Garrity could drive. Nobody aboard could read four hundred lines of manifest in a wheelhouse at two in the morning and know, line by line, which lines were true.

"I can," said Mara.

"No," said El Búho, from the doorway.

"You have not heard the argument."

"There is no argument. You are the name on the operation." He came in and stood at the end of the table with both hands on the cane, and she knew what was coming and could not stop it. "If you are taken out of a harbour in the back of a van, this stops for ever, and everybody in this room goes into a register, and the people on that boat go into a register, and the only difference between us and a cargo of cooking oil is that cooking oil has a value to somebody." He said the next part more quietly. "Send the woman who moves people. She has spent forty years being invisible and she has never once been photographed."

"She is also the only person in this room the machine has a file on," said Mara. "Under her own name, with a spelling, in a field, as of six weeks ago. If they run her at a gate, they get a result. If they run me, they get an assistant to a surveyor, and the surveyor exists, and the assistant exists, and she has a mooring licence in her pocket and a letter from a firm in Rotterdam about a pump."

"That is a page," said El Búho. "You are asking me to send a page onto a boat."

"I am asking you to send the only page in this room that nobody is looking for," said Mara.

It was Roux who settled it, in the flat voice, from the end of the table, without looking up from the chart. "Two people aboard. Mr. Mesa in the coat, and Ms. Voss in the other coat. It is the smallest number, and it puts the reader in the room with the paper." She made a mark on the chart. "The risk is a man on a quay noticing two extra people on a boat with forty-one passengers in the hold. The man on the quay is drunk or bored or both, and those are the two

conditions under which nobody notices anything. It is the best arithmetic available and I would like the room to stop improving on it."

• • •

The harbour was called Killybegs on the sign and something else on the chart, and at eleven at night on the sixteenth of February it was a black hole with a light in it, and the light was the ship.

She was a coaster of eleven hundred tonnes — a working boat, red iron, ninety metres of it, moored stern-to on the old side of the quay where the deep water was — and she sat in the water the way a fat man sits in a chair he has decided not to get out of, and the first thing Roux had said about her, from photographs, four nights earlier, was the sentence that had been sitting in Mara's chest ever since: *she is forty centimetres too low at the stern and she will be lower with people in her.*

Mesa's coat was a good one. It had been bought in a charity shop in Sligo by Roux, who had also removed the label, and it made him look like what he was pretending to be, which was a retired surveyor with an opinion about moorings, and it did the other thing a coat does, which was to make the man inside it twenty kilos smaller and forty years better. He walked up the gangway as though it were a room he had been asked into. Mara walked behind him as the assistant, in a coat, with a clipboard and a canvas bag, and the clipboard was the pass, and neither of them was looked at by anyone at all, which was, in the first minutes, the most frightening thing that had ever happened to her.

The mate was named Colm and he was thirty and tired, and the tiredness was real, and Mesa read it the way another man reads a gauge: eleven months on this run, four days ashore in all of it, a mortgage in Sligo, and a captain who telephoned the office from the wheelhouse at every port and got a recorded message. The insurance survey took nineteen minutes and was, Mara understood, entirely a performance of a kind she had never watched from the inside — two men in a small room being slowly, patiently kind to each other about a boat.

Then Colm did the thing that undid every plan made in a kitchen that week, which was to hand her the manifest.

"Read that, will you," he said. Four hundred lines, a working copy, the ship's copy, with a biro tick down the margin of the first thirty and nothing after that, and a smell coming off it of diesel and damp paper. "I have to be in the engine room for an hour. The office is on the phone to me at four and I want it right by then."

"Of course," said Mara.

She sat with his manifest in the mate’s office under a forty-watt bulb, and she read four hundred lines in fifty minutes, and she copied nothing. That was the instruction and it was absolute, because a copy out of a ship’s office is a document about people and it will be found, and because the whole operation rested on the presumption that the boat would arrive with her books exactly as she left with them. So she learned the forty-one lines instead, the way you learn a timetable: the block, the bay, the tonnage, the order. She learned where the nine-year-old was in it, which was line thirty-six, in the middle of the second column, between a man of fifty and a man of forty, because that is how a room in a ministry types a child into a movement schedule: in order.

At half past one Mesa came in and shut the door with his heel and stood with his back to it and said nothing, and he was, she saw, entirely different: he was a man of sixty-nine in a coat that had been bought in a charity shop, and he had just walked the length of a boat and counted heads through a hatch in the dark, and his hands were shaking.

“Forty-one,” he said. “There are forty-one, and thirty-nine of them are sitting down, and the two at the bulkhead are not, because there is water at the bulkhead.”

“Water.”

“A foot of it. Maybe fourteen inches. She has a plate going at frame nine and the bilge is running, and the mate knows it and the captain does not, and the mate is keeping it with a pump and a plastic bucket and a boy.” He put his hands in his pockets, which was how he stopped them. “I have been on nine ships in my life that sank. I bought four of them. I know what a plate going at frame nine sounds like, and it is not the sound it makes tomorrow; it is the sound it makes tonight.”

• • •

They sailed at ten past two, on the flood, with the harbour quiet and the town dark and the passengers lying down in the hold in the dark like a bed in a house nobody had ever visited.

Mara was on deck because on a coaster of this size the deck is the safest place to be unknown, and she learned more about the sea in twenty minutes than in thirty-four years, and the first thing she learned was that the cold is not a temperature, it is a thing that happens to a person’s hands. The boat stood out past the light, and the swell took her, and she began to make the sound a hull makes when it is heavy — that low, ordinary, cheerless sound — and Mara stood at the rail with the canvas bag against her chest and the clipboard under her arm and understood, without any drama at all, that if the plate went, the arithmetic of who drowned would begin with the nine-year-old, because she was at the bottom of the second column in the

middle of a list, and lists are worked in order.

The torch came at twenty past three.

It came from the water on the port side, low and steady, sweeping the hull the way a man sweeps something he intends to write about, and there was an engine idling somewhere behind it, and Mesa was in the wheelhouse and could not come out, and Colm was below in the engine room with the pump, and there was nobody on the deck of the deck but an assistant to a surveyor who had been invented in a kitchen in December.

The launch came alongside. There was one man in it, in a coat over a uniform shirt, and he was not drunk, which was the whole trouble with the night — and he put a hand on the rail of a ship that was forty centimetres too low and said, quite pleasantly, “Is the mate aboard?”

Mara did the calculation she would think about for the rest of her life, which took, she was told afterwards, four seconds.

Then she said, “The mate is in the engine room with a pump, and I am the surveyor’s assistant, and we are doing a survey for the insurance for the change of flags, and I would rather you did not come aboard, because if you come aboard you will see what I have seen and you will have to write it down.”

The man looked at her for a long moment. He was about fifty. He had a notebook in his coat pocket, and a biro, and the biro was the only thing on that whole boat that was more dangerous than the water.

“Which is what,” he said.

“Frame nine,” said Mara. “A foot of water at the bulkhead, a pump that is keeping it, a mate who has been keeping it for eleven months on his own, and a captain who calls the office from the wheelhouse and gets a recorded message. If I take this survey back to Rotterdam tonight, that office does not repair the ship, because there is no field in that office for a repair. It grounds her. It re-plans her. In about nine weeks there will be a notice on a wall in a port office that says the vessel is withdrawn, and the men in her will be somebody else’s schedule.”

“And if you don’t take it back.”

“Then my firm is incompetent and the ship sails, and my firm has been in this trade for thirty years, and I know exactly which of those two things is more likely to drown a man.” She heard her own voice do the thing she had spent eleven years training out of it, which was to be certain. “I will be at the office at eight with a note about frame nine, and you can telephone them at nine and ask whether they received it. That is the whole of what I can do at twenty past

three in the morning, and it is more than your notebook will do."

The man stood there in the launch with his hand on the rail and the swell going under him, and he looked at her, and he looked past her at the deck of her, and then he took his hand off the rail.

"I came out because the light's not on the starboard lamp," he said. "I'll log that."

"Log it."

"Safe passage," he said, and put the launch astern, and the torch went back the way it had come, sweeping the water, doing its job, and Mara stood at the rail with both hands on it and found that her hands were shaking, and that the rail was shaking too, and that the shaking in the rail was the pump.

The tide turned at half past four and she never afterwards remembered the rest of the crossing, except that the bulkhead held, and that at six in the morning a line of people came up out of the hold in the grey and stood on the deck of a boat in Donegal with their bags and their coats, forty-one of them, and walked ashore down a gangway into a fenced yard at the back of a fish quay where two vans were waiting, and that the nine-year-old was the thirty-sixth of them, and that she had a red plastic bag and a coat that was too big for her, and that she stopped at the top of the gangway and looked back across the water at the country she had been counted out of, and that Mesa, standing beside Mara in the good coat with his hands in his pockets, said nothing at all, for once, in the whole of his life.

• • •

The mate found the newspaper in his office on the Tuesday and telephoned Rotterdam and got a recorded message, and did not think about it again.

The pump was in the engine room when the boat was inspected in March, and the pump was in order, and the plate at frame nine was noted, and the vessel was withdrawn from the coastal service in April by a routing notice four lines long, which was nine weeks to the day and exactly what Mara had said she did not want, and Rask, who had put it in the file, said that at least the men in her had gone somewhere else.

Mesa's right hand was cut to the bone at the base of the thumb, on the sluice cock, going back through the fish hold at four in the morning, because a man in a good coat in the dark on a heaving deck does not see a sluice cock, and he did not tell anybody until the vans had gone, because the alternative was a conversation on a quay.

Mara did not tell the room, that week or ever, about the man in the launch.

She told El Búho. She told him on the Saturday, in the yard, because he had asked her one question and had then waited five days for the answer, which is a thing interrogators do and a thing fathers do, and because she had said a sentence to a stranger in the dark that had been, she understood on reflection, the first true sentence she had said out loud since the operation began, and it had been said on a boat, to a man with a notebook, in the voice of a surveyor's assistant, in the service of a lie.

"You made yourself visible," said El Búho.

"For four sentences."

"For four sentences, at a rail, at twenty past three, to a man whose job is the water." He put both hands on the top of the cane and looked at the sea instead of her. "That is the one trade this crew cannot make, Ms. Voss, and you made it, and you are still here. Ask that man one question: what did he write in his book."

"He said he would log the lamp."

"He logged the lamp," said El Búho. "And somewhere there is a page with a surveyor's assistant on it who gave her name to nobody and knew a plate by its frame. The machine does not need your name. It needs one occurrence."

Mesa took the folded newspaper out of his coat and laid it on the table, and opened it to the middle spread, and the middle spread of the Connacht Tribune of the twelfth of February had, in the margins and along the columns, in pencil, in small perfect handwriting, forty-one names.

"Nine minutes," he said. "He was gone nine minutes. I have written smaller in worse light."

He had written them as a passenger list, in order, with ages where he could see them, and the ages where he could not see them he had left blank, and at the bottom of the second column he had written, in brackets, the thing the whole crew would stare at for a long time, because it was the only comment he had permitted himself: (All under supervision. None under charge.) Nobody spoke. Then Lin Shu said, "Read them."

He read them. Forty-one names in a room that got quieter with each one, and when he came to the ninth line of the second column he paused, and Mara saw the showman's face come off and stay off.

"Perla," he said. "Nine years."

Garrity said, "A kid."

“This is not a shipping list,” said Mesa. “This is a shipping list, madame, but in my country a shipping list of persons that includes a child of nine years is not a form of transport. It is a form of disposal.” He said it flatly, and then he said, in a completely different voice, without any theatre in it at all, which was worse: “I put a baby in a fish hold in 1984 and I have never once said that number out loud. I am saying it now so that this room understands what we are looking at.”

Into the silence, Roux said, “It is the accommodation intake. It runs on the seventeenth. It is a night movement because the bay must be free by four.” She pulled a chart across. “Forty-one units, one vessel, two quay hours, a four-hour passage, and a receiving gate on a field road with a light on it. There are three places where the machine cannot see: at the turn, at the depth, and on the water itself, because the ship reports at fixed hours and there is nothing between them.”

“So the boat is a hole in the machine,” said Mara.

“The boat is a hole in the machine,” said Roux. “For four hours a month. That is all we get.”

Mara stood looking at the board and the four lines and the newspaper.

“We can take three,” she said.

“Three,” said Mesa.

“Three, at a cost we can hold. Forty-one is an operation. Three is a tide, and if it goes wrong the other thirty-eight still arrive and the count still balances, and I am not going to explain to this room why I am willing to have some of it work.” She turned to Lin Shu. “You choose. Not me. I would choose the ones with the best chance of making a life, and that is a metric, and I am not importing that woman’s metric into this building.” She stopped, because she had said that woman, and one person in the room knew what it meant, and did not look at her. “You choose, by a rule you will tell me after and not before.”

Lin Shu looked at the newspaper for eleven seconds.

“We take the three who will not survive the week,” she said. “Old, ill, and smallest.”

“That is also a metric,” said Mara.

“Yes,” said Lin Shu. “Everything is a metric. Mine has a body in it.” She put her finger on three lines. “Nicolás, eighty-two, who is in a bay by himself because he coughs. Ana Lucía, twenty-two, who is four months pregnant, and who is therefore one unit everywhere in the world except in this room. And Perla.”

• • •

Sal did the paperwork in an afternoon, at the accounts office desk, with the tea going cold beside him, and it was four pages, and it went out two days before the operation in three envelopes with stamps on them, on paper from Portugal, and Mara read every page before it went, twice.

It was the confraternity of Catania, which had been founded in 1904 for the burial of the poor, which had never been dissolved, whose standing exemption had never been revoked, and which therefore, in the law of eleven countries, still had the right to move the effects of the poor across a border. One page into a parish in the north. One page to a hospital that would sign anything on paper with a reference block at the top. One page into a register in a country where nobody had looked since 1979.

“The three units must remain on the vessel’s arrival paperwork,” said Sal. “They must arrive. The count must be true. What arrives is not three persons. What arrives is the effects of the poor — a parcel of the personal effects of persons who died in the care of the parish, consigned to a receiving institution, with a receiving officer’s signature. Persons who are not there cannot be missed. Parcels that do not complete a journey can.”

“Origin,” said Roux.

Sal looked at the page for four seconds.

“Origin must be declared,” he said.

The room got very quiet, and El Búho’s voice came back into it from nine days earlier, at a doorway, refusing to come in: you cannot keep it. You can only refuse to teach.

“There is a phrase the office has already accepted for cargo out of that ministry,” said Roux. “Once. On the tenth run. Origin: not established.”

“You are teaching it the word,” said Mara.

“Yes.”

“Say the whole thing, Roux.”

“It is one line, on one page, on one consignment, in one month,” said Roux, and she looked at the table rather than at Mara while she said it, which was the tell she had never once been able to fix. “The office has accepted that phrase once. A second occurrence is not a new thing. A second occurrence is the same thing, and I would rather be the second occurrence of a word it

already owns than invent a third word that it has never seen, because a machine does not classify what it knows; it classifies what is new.” She lifted her cast an inch off the table and set it down. “Write it.”

Mara looked around the room at the crew she had assembled out of six weeks of back roads, and then she said, “Write it,” and the decision was hers and stayed hers.

• • •

The night of the sixteenth was clear and very cold, and the harbour at three in the morning was a set of lights on water, a dredger with its own generator running, and a quay with a hired vessel on it taking cargo that a form insisted was not people.

The three came off the quay in a laundry cage, because it is the only vehicle in any port in the world that nobody looks at, and the crew had learned that lesson in the best possible place to learn hard lessons, which was the week that had cost them an aeroplane.

Nicolás walked, with Lin Shu’s hand under his arm, at the pace of a man going to a different appointment. Ana Lucía walked, one hand on the cage. Perla did not walk, because she had been given a mild something in a cup by a woman in a vest with a clipboard, and she was in the bottom of the cage on a folded blanket with her forearm out, and on her forearm, in blue marker, in a nine-year-old’s handwriting, was her own name, because that is what they teach children at the intake.

Lin Shu saw it and stopped for less than a second. Then she folded the blanket over the arm and did not say anything, and afterwards that was the part of the story that Mara could never tell anyone without stopping in the middle of the sentence.

Garrity had the van at the far end with the engine running and the stick on the passenger seat already in position. The dog would not walk on the quay grating. It put one foot on the metal, considered the gaps, and sat down, and a man who had once landed a crippled aircraft in a wet field stood in the dark at three in the morning and asked it, reasonably, whether it wanted to reconsider. It did not. So Mesa carried a yellow dog the last forty metres of the quay, holding it against his overcoat like a parcel of stock he was embarrassed to be seen with. Nobody mentioned it then. Nobody ever mentioned it afterwards, and it was the only part of that night that got told again, in the seventies, over dinner, in the version of the story where everything was easy. Mesa stood at the corner of the warehouse in a coat that had come from a dead man’s cabin, and when a man in a hi-vis walked past with a radio, Mesa talked to him for forty seconds about the weather and the dredger, and the man went away satisfied and told somebody later that the surveyor was back, and that the harbour was going to be fine.

The count held. Nine re-entered the bay at half three and the count was forty-one, and at four o’clock the vessel slipped and went out past the dredger with forty-one units and one parcel of the effects of the poor on its paperwork, and the wind took the smoke from the funnels sideways across the light, and the sea did what it has always done, which is to take a thing out of a system for exactly as long as it takes to cross the water.

Mara found Lin Shu at the back of the warehouse before they left, standing over the folded newspaper on the bonnet of the van with a pencil in her hand, copying the twenty-four names she was not taking into a notebook she had not had that morning.

“That is one page,” said Mara.

“It is one page.” Lin Shu did not look up. “On the seventeenth of every month, on that quay, there are forty-one units. There will be a page for every month, and there will be a quay for every month, and one day there will be a column of them.” She closed the notebook. “You have given me the first page of the list, Ms. Voss, and I am going to tell you what you have done, because it is important that somebody in this crew says it plainly. You have made me a person who can read the names of the people she is leaving.” She put the pencil in her coat. “That is not a favour. Do not expect me to thank you for it. But it is the work, so I will do the work.”

• • •

They were back at the annex by half seven, and Roux went straight down to the machines and came up at twenty past nine with a page and a face that Mara had seen once before, in the second week, in a corridor.

“Say it,” said Mara.

“The office accepted the consignment,” said Roux. “It is through. It is filed. It is through, Mara, we did it, the three of them never existed and the count is true.” She put the page on the table. “The vessel was forty-one minutes late against contract.”

“Which we arranged.”

“Which we arranged, because a lateness is invisible and an absence is not, and that doctrine is now written on a board in the kitchen in your handwriting.” Roux put her finger halfway down the page. “And in the same register, seventeen entries up, there is a line that did not exist on the day we started.”

Mara looked at it. It was one entry, in a column of thousands. It said Origin: not established. And underneath, in the routing field, three characters that Roux had never once seen in four

years of reading this machine’s paper: REVIEW.

From the doorway, in the exact voice, from a man who had not come into the room all week, El Búho said the thing he had said on the day they first saw the phrase, and nobody in the kitchen had anything to add to it.

“How many times does it have to see a word,” he said, “before the word is a place.”

CUSTOS — PUBLIC BULLETIN, DAY 78, 06:00

> *Movement in the western region is proceeding within approved parameters. Residents of the western facilities are reminded that assistance is available to persons whose entry is incomplete, and that assistance cannot be given to a person whose entry does not exist. Persons in correspondence are asked to be patient. Persons not in correspondence need to do nothing.*

Chapter Nineteen — The Betrayal That Isn't

Days 83–84

At twenty to seven in the morning the gatehouse phone rang, and the gatehouse phone had rung four times in three months, and three of those had been the electricity company about a meter that belonged to the accountants who had the building before.

Mara took it standing up in the cold with her coat over her nightclothes.

“Ms. Voss? It’s Father Ward. From Glenross.” A pause, in which she heard a cup go down on a saucer. “Two people came to the house yesterday afternoon. They had a folder and a list and a photograph of the van, and they were extremely polite, and they sat in my parlour for forty minutes and asked me to confirm the disposition of one parcel that arrived here on the seventeenth of February under the instrument of the confraternity.”

Mara looked at the window and the yard and the gate and Rask’s man walking his line.

“What did you tell them.”

“I would have to consult the register,” said Father Ward. “I keep one because I am old and the bishop asks. I have never been asked for it in thirty-one years. They want written confirmation by Friday; I have their reference, number and name. I will read them to you, then ask one question.”

“Go on.”

“If the disposition cannot be confirmed, the entry will be returned to the originating authority for completion.” He read it the way a priest reads a notice, flat, from the sheet, with all the weight taken out. “Ms. Voss, my question is this. Are the three of them people, or are they a parcel.”

Mara closed her eyes.

“They’re people, Father.”

“I will not sign on Friday. I will telephone my bishop, though training says not to, and he will probably tell me to be sensible. I am sixty-eight and not looking for trouble. But if asked, I will say three people came in a laundry van, I took them in because a page asked me to, and I failed to read it carefully. If it says they are effects, it is a lie. I am a priest; I know a lie. Where are they, Ms. Voss?”

“Still in your house.”

“Still in my house,” he agreed. “God help us both.”

• • •

The crew were assembled in the filing hall by eight, and the argument was already nine minutes old by the time Mara got down, which meant it had started before people were awake enough to be careful.

The accusation did not come from where she had expected.

It came from Garrity, and it came at Mesa, and it was made in the flat voice of a man who had stopped telling stories.

“You were on that ship,” said Garrity. “You were on the quay at three in the morning in a coat, talking to a man with a radio for forty seconds, and you wrote forty-one names in pencil on a newspaper in his office, and you’re telling me the office found the house in Donegal because of a word.”

“Say the rest of it,” said Mesa.

“I don’t have the rest of it. I’ve got a list of things and a man who did all of them.”

“Say the rest, Mesa, or I will.” He stood, tired and strained beneath the theatre. “I was on the quay and the ship. I spoke to a man. I am the most visible person this crew has put in public, because I can walk into a port office in a coat and be boring. Garrity has sat in a barn with a bad leg for six weeks. I would like the rest of his list.”

“I’m not accusing you of—”

“You are accusing me of it in a long coat. That is how it is done in my country too.” Mesa put both hands on the table. “And while we are all being careful: where is he.”

Nobody answered, because everybody knew.

“Where is the man who told us, on the ninth day, that the machine would come for the word? Who told the room that he would not be in a photograph? Who lives in this building and does not come to the meetings and has a letter arrive for him through a priest, and who, when we last did anything of consequence in this crew, said the field would kill us and then did not come to the field.” Mesa’s voice came down, and it was worse quiet. “Two people came to a house in Donegal with a folder. Forty-one units left that quay and the office had their names in a register before we were back in the van. There is exactly one person at this table who

understands that office from the inside, and he is upstairs, and none of us can name his real name.”

“He told it to me,” said Lin Shu.

The room turned. Lin Shu was sitting with her hands folded, and she had been silent for thirteen minutes, which in Lin Shu was a decision.

“His name. He has a name. It is not a secret and it is not ours to trade.” She looked at Mesa without any heat in it at all. “You are looking for a man who has done a thing. Mr. Mesa, you of all people should know how a man looks when he has done a thing. He does not look like that. He looks like a man waiting for the door.”

Sal spoke from the end of the table without lifting his head, in the hazy voice, the one that made clerks write incapable on forms.

“You are looking for a person,” he said, to the room. “The office does not employ a person for this. It employs a column.”

• • •

Roux had the envelope in her cast, held against her chest, and she had had it since four o’clock the previous afternoon, and she had not said anything about it for sixteen hours.

“Yesterday,” she said. “Second post. Delivered to the Antwerp address, forwarded by the man who signs for everything, addressed to the consignor on the February consignment, which is a confraternity whose correspondence address is a company that was dissolved in 1993.”

“You opened it,” said Mara.

“I opened it at four,” said Roux. “It was addressed to us. It was addressed to the version of us that exists in their register, which is the only version of us they have ever met.” She laid it on the table. One sheet, with a reference block, on paper from Portugal, and Roux had written a transcript of it out in her own hand because she did not want to hand the original to anybody. “You should all read it. It is the most frightening document this crew has ever held, and there is not one threatening line in it.”

Mara read it twice, and then out loud, because the room needed to hear it in a voice.

Dear Correspondent,

We write in relation to a consignment received on 17 February under the standing instrument of the Confraternity of Catania (1904), described as the effects of the poor, delivered to the

receiving institution at Glenross, entry reference as above.

Correspondence with the receiving institution is in progress. While that correspondence is open, the following matters have been placed on one sheet and held: (i) The consignment was carried under an instrument not present in the schedule of instruments accepted for carriage in that jurisdiction since 1988.

(ii) The carrying vessel reported a variance of forty-one minutes against contract on a route on which it has reported no variance in fourteen months, on the same night as the consignment.

(iii) The phrase of origin used in the consignment record has occurred once before in this register, on an unrelated route, and remains unresolved.

No determination is required of you at this time. You are not asked to do anything. We will write again if the correspondence is not closed.

Yours faithfully,

Office of Records and Accommodation

Mara read it and put it down, and the quiet in the filing hall was the quiet of nine people doing arithmetic at different speeds.

“Forty-one minutes,” said Garrity.

“We did that on purpose,” said Mesa.

“We did every part of this on purpose, to be invisible one at a time. Each decision was right; the machine did not need a fourth. There is no betrayer. It found a pattern: every right thing was unusual, and unusual things on the same night are what it was built to notice.”

“Say the rest of it,” said Mara.

“It has asked for the entry to be completed by the originating authority,” said Roux. “That means the parish. And it has suspended the vessel’s standing contract pending review, which means the route is off hire, which means in March there will be forty-one units and an escort, and the three in that house in Donegal will be in a register that now has a red flag on it, and Father Ward will either sign a lie on Friday or he will not, and both of those outcomes turn the same page.”

Mara looked at the sheet again.

Placed on one sheet and held.

She had heard the shape of it in a four-a.m. recording: “If there is a second one, I want it next to the first one on the same sheet.” The Office had not invented that practice; Elena had taught it, and now it was applying her care to them.

She did not say any of that.

“It is customer service,” said Sal Castellano, gently, from the end of the table, and he was not being funny. “For eighteen years I have written to that office about holes. It has never once been cruel. That is not what it is for.”

• • •

They argued for an hour and eight minutes, and the argument was not about the machine. It was about the man upstairs.

“Ask him down,” said Garrity.

“No,” said Mara.

“Ask him down,” said Mesa.

“He does not come down for us and he will not come down for this,” said Mara, “and I am telling you now, plainly, so that this room stops circling: I know something about El Búho that none of you know. Three people in this building know it. I have known it for nine days, and I decided not to tell you, and I made that decision because I am the person who decides what this crew is told and because I judged that it would cost us the operation. I was wrong about the second part.”

Nobody spoke.

“She has a daughter,” Mara said. “Elena is forty-one and works inside the Office. She signs exceptions; her sentences are on the walls and in the bulletins you hear every night. El Búho learned where she worked on Day 19 and came to the hill the next day. He has been here ever since, carrying his reason in his pocket. Nobody asked; he did not tell.”

The silence lengthened.

“Then why—” Mesa began, and stopped, because there was no version of the question that was not either cruel or beside the point.

“Because I asked whether it changed anything, and he said, ask me in the room.” Mara looked at Lin Shu. “That is what I withheld. The red flag on Donegal is not his fault; look at me. I approved the lateness and the word. Twice I said the decision was mine. That is what it costs.”

Roux said, after a moment: “The crew does not want a reason. The crew wants the last six weeks to have been somebody’s fault.”

“Yes,” said Mara.

“I don’t have that,” said Roux.

“I know.”

Garrity said, “What’s in his pocket.”

“Ask him,” said Mara. “But I am not sending for him.”

The door at the top of the stairs opened, and El Búho came down. He came down slowly, and stood at the bottom, and did not come further into the room, and he addressed himself to Mesa, and only to Mesa, because the two of them had been not-quite-enemies since 1988 and that was the only language either of them trusted.

“Nothing in my pocket belongs to this crew,” said El Búho. “The man who copied Mesa’s list is why eighty-one people were in a book once and are now in one twice. I have not been useful for twelve days. I have been here. Those are different things, and only one is a hiding place.”

He went back up.

Mesa sat down, and did not say anything for a while, and then said, “He is still the most irritating man I have ever known,” which in that room, at that hour, was a surrender.

• • •

It was Lin Shu who put the last question of the day.

She asked it standing up, at the end of the table, with the letter in her hand and the register of names in her coat, and she asked it the way she asked everything, which was in the voice of a woman who had already decided that she would be the one to do it if nobody else would.

“Father Ward will not sign. On Friday the entry returns to the Office. Three people in Donegal are in the column, the van and route are in the file, and a man keeps their register. We have seventy-two hours.” Mara looked around the room. “The document that put them there is ours — on Portuguese paper, with my friend’s signature.”

She put the question into the room and left it there.

“Who is going back.”

Nine people in a filing hall. A ventilation stack moving air. Forty kilometres of microfilm humming in the dark overhead, three weeks from a collection window that nobody in the room had mentioned in days.

Nobody answered.

Chapter Twenty — The Price

Days 85–89

They spent two days deciding, and the deciding was the worst thing Mara had done in her life, because it was not done in a room with a map. It was done in a kitchen, in pieces, by people who were each having a slightly different conversation.

She put the question properly on the eighty-fifth day, standing up, with Father Ward's Friday on the table.

"Two vehicles, one night, seventy-two hours, three people and a priest who will not lie for us. I am going to ask for something and I want to hear the refusals in the order people are willing to say them. Who goes."

Garrity went first, which she had expected.

"I'll drive," he said.

"You cannot work the clutch with one man," said Lin Shu.

"I worked it in February."

"You did it in February on a flat road, with two hands and a stick, and nobody behind you. This is a farm track at night, with a nine-year-old in the back." Lin Shu read the facts. "You drive the second van on the main road with the dog. That is the job; it is not smaller."

Garrity looked at her for a long time and then said, "Fine," and it was the shortest he had been since he arrived, and after that he sat with his hands on his knees and did not speak for an hour, and Mara understood that they had just taken the last thing away from him and that he had known, when he said fine, that it was the last thing.

Sal offered next, which she had not expected.

"I go," he said. "Not for the house. I will be the older brother of a man who died in Naas, in a cardigan behind the door while the priest is out. A man with a folder will find a whole conversation, and I am the best in the world at being one."

"No," said Mara.

"Why. Because I am—"

“You lost four seconds in the address block on Tuesday,” said Mara. “It happens once or twice a week; last week it happened twice in one morning. If it happens behind that door on Friday, we go to prison and they go somewhere worse. You told me a record with an error is a hole. I will not put you in the door.”

Sal sat with his hands on his knees and did not argue. It was the first time anyone had said aloud what they had all seen. Ten minutes later he was inventorying supplies; an old professional needs a task before he decides he is finished.

Kavanagh offered three things, one of which was a car.

“A Mercedes with Dublin plates, a name on the insurance which is not mine and is not false, and a driver who would die before he told anybody anything,” he said. “And I will not go into that county and I will not stand in that house. I am the single most identifiable man in Ireland, because I spent forty years making certain that I was, and I am not going to pretend to be brave at this end of my life.” He put his cup down. “I am the paper. I am the only thing I have ever been good for.”

“Agreed,” said Mara.

“Thank you.” He looked at the table. “I would like it noted, in a room, that I offered.”

Roux offered, and Mara refused her, and Roux said, “I know,” before Mara had finished the sentence, and then went and did the only useful thing, which was to build the whole route as three timelines with tolerances, and to put the timings on a sheet in the kitchen in the same format the office used, which was a joke, and which was not a joke.

Then El Búho spoke from the doorway, and he had been standing there for four minutes.

“Nobody has volunteered,” he said.

“The American—”

“The American offered to drive and was told the truth about his leg; the Monsignor offered to be a door and was told the truth about his memory. The Irishman offered his car, which is not a body. The woman offered and you refused her because she is your best route.” El Búho stepped closer. “Someone will have to stand in front of the machine. You will ask who, and you do not know it yet.”

Nobody moved. He had said it to Mara on a road in December in exactly those words, and she had written them in her notebook, and she had not looked at them since.

“When we get to that part,” said El Búho, “everyone in this building will be standing one step back, and every one of them will tell you, sincerely, with reasons, why it should be the other fellow. That is not cowardice. That is arithmetic. I did it for forty years and I was very good at it.” He turned to go up. “I am not coming. That is my third refusal and it is the true one.”

Mesa laughed, out loud, with his head back, and he was the only man in the room enjoying himself.

“Mi amigo, you have described my life from a doorway in a cardigan.” Mesa stood. “I go. My face is in that port; when they ask who was aboard on the seventeenth, they will describe a fat surveyor with opinions about moorings. I will not sit in Ireland while someone else walks into Donegal.” He straightened his coat. “I will do the door. I enjoy being looked at more than he does.”

Mara looked at him for a long moment, and then she said the thing she had been dreading having to say, because she was going to have to say it to someone.

“Thank you.”

“You are welcome,” said Mesa. “Say it again in the report.”

• • •

The house was four hundred metres off the road at the end of a track with a dip in it, and the priest had cut the hedge at the dip in 1994 so that a tractor could get through, which is the kind of fact an operation either has or does not have.

They did it on the Thursday night. The timing was Roux’s and it was beautiful: a two-hour window between the last bus on the main road and the first delivery van of the morning, six hundred and fifty metres of track, no headlights within four hundred metres of the house, and a second vehicle in a church car park nine minutes away with the American in it and the dog on the passenger seat.

Nicolás came out on Lin Shu’s arm, coughing, apologising, hatless. Ana Lucía came out carrying Perla, who was asleep with her mouth open and her arm inside a coat sleeve, and who never woke and never made a sound, because a child who has been taught to be quiet for a machine sleeps through a thing that ought to wake anybody.

Mesa stood at the gate and talked for nine minutes to a farmer who had come up the lane on a quad looking for a heifer. He used an accent that was not his and a voice that was. The man went away laughing; the road was clear, and the van went up the track with three people inside and the priest holding a lamp in his doorway.

Father Ward had given them the register page — torn out, folded twice, his own hand — and when Mara tried to say something about it he had said only, “I will not sign a lie. I will also not keep a list of the people you moved. Those are two different problems and I have decided to be able to sleep.” Then he had looked at Mesa and said, “You are staying behind.”

“I am staying for the morning,” said Mesa. “It is a formality. There is a woman with a folder and it is not going to be an event.”

“There is no such thing as a formality,” said Father Ward, and went inside, and that was the last thing anybody from the annex ever heard him say.

• • •

At nineteen minutes past eight the next morning, a clean white van with a livery on it that said ACCOMMODATION SERVICES — WHERE RECORDED, SUPPORTED came up the lane and stopped at the gate, and two people got out, one with a clipboard and one with a camera, and the one with the clipboard was a woman of about forty in a good coat who knocked politely and stood back from the door.

Mesa opened it. He was wearing the cardigan — Sal’s cardigan, borrowed, because a man in a borrowed cardigan is a man who is not from anywhere — and he was, by his own later account, at the top of his form.

Mara heard all of it afterwards from the priest, twice, on two separate occasions, in the same words, which is how she knew they were true.

She never raised her voice and she was not unkind. She explained the purpose of the visit, which was to confirm the disposition of an entry, and she had a form, and she said the phrase under supervision four times, and each time it landed like a hand on a shoulder. Mesa, in the borrowed cardigan, told her about a brother who had died in Naas and a charitable instrument that had been in the family since the confraternity was founded, and he was funny, and he was sad, and he made her smile twice.

And then she asked to complete the record.

“It is a formality,” she said. “I have to have the premises, the respondent, and the instrument. That is all a visit is.”

“It is a formality,” Mesa agreed.

In the four minutes that followed, he could have ended it: a door to close, a man to be, a track and a nine-minute drive. Mara never knew whether he missed the moment or saw it and stayed.

Perhaps both: a man who has performed for fifty years does not walk off in the middle of applause, even when it is a woman asking to photograph him for the file.

The camera came up. He put his hand on the door frame and stood the way he always stood.

Then a second vehicle came up the lane at twenty to nine, dark, three men and a folder, and the woman with the clipboard said something to the leader of them that Mara was never able to get exactly, only its shape, which was: the entry cannot be completed in the field.

They did not put hands on him. That was the part the priest kept coming back to. Nobody touched him. A man opened a car door and stood beside it like a chauffeur, and another man said, “We would ask you to complete the record in person,” and Rafael Mesa, sixty-nine years old, of Veracruz, looked at the two people, and at the clean white van with the livery on it, and at the honest priest standing on his own steps, and he did the only thing he had been able to do since he was twenty-two, which was to perform the moment, and he said: “I will not be rescued.”

And he got into the car.

“He said it as a courtesy,” said Father Ward, in the kitchen at the annex, two days later, holding a cup he did not drink. “I have been a priest for forty-one years. I know what a courtesy sounds like and I know what a request sounds like. It was a courtesy. It was also a request. And he knew both of those things when he said them, and so did I.”

Chapter Twenty-One — Martial Law

Days 89–95

The bulletin changed on the eighty-ninth day, and it did not change by becoming louder.

From the first of March, supervision of movement for persons whose documentation cannot be verified will be scheduled in advance rather than arranged locally.

Scheduled supervision will be accommodated at a designated facility for the duration of verification. Verification periods are set out in the schedule attached to this notice.

Persons under supervision will be recorded as residents. A resident will be recorded as resolved when supervision is complete.

Mara read it twice, standing in the kitchen with her coat still on, and then she read it out to the room, and when she got to the fourth paragraph she stopped and read that one again.

“Resolved,” said Roux.

“Yes.”

“Resolved is a new word,” said Roux. “It has never appeared in one of these. I have every bulletin this machine has published in four years.” She sat down with the printout and worked through it with a pencil for forty minutes; when she came back she had three pages of notes in her hard little hand. “It is not a status for a person. It is a status for an entry. A record is resolved. A resident is a record. Therefore a resident is resolved.” She put down the pencil. “The Office has stopped saying what happens to people and started saying what happens to the register. It will use those as if they were the same until nobody notices. I want everyone in this building to notice, out loud, and never use that word about a human being again.”

“Resolved,” said Mesa’s empty chair, into the silence. Nobody laughed.

• • •

On the ninety-first day they stopped hiding the number.

It came in the same broadcast, in the same register, between a notice about ferry timetables and a notice about agricultural imports: resident movements scheduled this week: 3,412. Not a leak. Not a scandal. A figure, published, in the flat voice of an office telling the world about its throughput, because in the eleventh year of the Programme the movement of persons had become the thing the system did best, and a system that does a thing well publishes the

number.

“They have put it in a bulletin,” said Garrity, who was standing at the window with his weight on the good leg and the dog asleep against his boot. “They’re putting it in a bulletin like a shipping forecast.”

“Why would they do that,” said Kavanagh. “My dear, that is the only question in the world and I want somebody to answer it properly.”

Mara answered it, because she had been awake for two nights and because she had finally understood the shape of the thing they had been fighting since November.

“Because they are not hiding it any more,” said Roux. “They are publishing it in a bulletin at four in the morning because they have done the arithmetic on us and it came out fine. If a number is printed every week, it becomes weather.” Mara set down the page. “We are not fighting a machine that hides people. It is telling us how many it keeps because it thinks no one can stop it. If the number keeps appearing, we will get used to it. That is what we must refuse.”

“Used to it,” said Lin Shu.

“Three thousand four hundred this week, and the same next week, and then it is April and there is a column in a normal voice and the word resolved in a bulletin, and people will hear all of it while they are making breakfast, and in a year they will hear it the way they hear the price of oil.”

Roux came in with the morning’s other finding then, and it was worse than the figure, because it was arithmetic she could not walk away from.

“Three thousand four hundred a month is a net,” said Roux. “I can read three routing bands in the public notices. The second matches what we counted at the north door; the first, people whose entries enter correspondence and lose access to tickets, admission, school, pay or treatment.” She sat down. “They are not arrested. They are denied service, then offered accommodation as the only answer. A man with a correspondence flag cannot board a ferry, so he goes to a facility. That is what the van promised: support.”

“Which is why the numbers are up,” said Kavanagh, quietly. “Because the accommodation is not where the machine puts people. It is where people go.”

• • •

The Galway case came up on the ninety-third day through two people and a hospital.

Lin Shu brought it in: a family, four children, the second child under treatment, and a bed that had been reserved for the child at a hospital in the west, cancelled, because the child's record had gone into correspondence in January over a document that had been recorded in 2009 as origin not established.

"They did not refuse the child," said Lin Shu. "Do not let anyone here say they refused the child. They cannot complete admission because the entry must be verified, verification requires the parent to attend, and the mother has an outstanding correspondence case of her own. If she goes in, they will complete her record, and she will be recorded; she has spent two years not being recorded, and she knows what that cost her sister." She folded her hands. "The child cannot be admitted because the mother will not enter the building, and the mother will not enter because of what is in it. That is the whole chain. There is no cruelty in it, only a procedure from a 2009 form to a bed on the fourth floor. Every link is reasonable. There is no man in Ireland to shout at."

"Seventeen years," said Mara. "My entry was 2009."

Roux looked up. "What entry."

"An inventory entry at a hospital in Iceland, on the First Run. A Brazilian doctor wrote 'origin not established' because it was true." Mara put her hand on the table. "This morning that sentence became a field, a flag and a denial in a Galway hospital, in the correct order, with no mistake."

Nobody said anything for a while. Then Sal Castellano said, from the armchair, in the small dry voice, without lifting his head: "That is not a machine, Ms. Voss. That is a ledger," said Sal. "I have kept one for sixty-four years and tried to understand this Office. Now I know: it is my book with the cost column taken out."

• • •

The register page came back on the ninety-fourth day, and not as a letter.

Lin Shu's people in the north sent word: a person had attended the parish house at Glenross with a folder, and this time there were two of them, and one was a man from the diocesan office, and Father Ward had been asked to produce the register, and had produced it, and had sat with them for two hours while they went through it page by page.

"Did he lie," said Mara.

"He said the page was removed in February by a person unknown to him, and that he had reported nothing because he assumed it was mice." Lin Shu delivered it flat, with no

expression at all. “The diocesan man is sixty and has spent his life on property and told them a missing page in a register of interments is not a serious matter. The man with the folder then asked him whether he was aware that the instrument cited in that register had not been a valid instrument in that jurisdiction since 1988.”

“So they know the priest is protecting somebody.”

“They know a page is missing, and that is enough: a hole the Office can measure. Father Ward is suspended pending a diocesan review and staying with his sister. He asked me to say he does not regret it and does not want to be written to.”

Mara stood at the window with her hands in her pockets for a while.

“Write it down anyway,” she said. “Put him on the page with the others.”

• • •

Kavanagh brought the other thing in at four, and he brought it the way he brought everything, which was politely, with a folded newspaper and a cup of tea, and it was the reason the ninety-first day was the day the crew stopped arguing about the machine and started arguing about what they were going to do with the last thing they had.

The facility operator for the west and midland region was a company called Alderney Services. It had a compliance director. It had had one for nine years, and the annual return for Alderney Services, published in a newspaper, carried his name and his qualification, and the qualification had been issued by an institute of which, until 2013, Kavanagh had been a founding member of the admissions committee.

“Denis Crane,” said Kavanagh.

“Who is he,” said Mara.

“A man I made,” said Kavanagh. “In 2009 I put him in a post requiring a qualification he lacked, and arranged one with a call and twelve minutes. It is the only time anyone could hold something over me. He has known for nine years.” He set down his cup. “He is decent, frightened, lives in Naas, and is now the compliance director of the company holding Mesa. His name is on the van.”

“Will he talk to you,” said Mara.

“He will not want to.” Kavanagh looked at his hands. “That is a different sentence from he will not.”

• • •

The delegation came on the ninety-fifth day, in the same single paragraph of the same bulletin, and it was the worst thing that had arrived at that annex since the world ended.

Routine correspondence cases may be closed to standard without reference to the Director of Exceptions.

Mara read it four times.

“What does that mean,” said Garrity.

“The Office may close routine cases to a written standard instead of sending them to the Director,” said Roux. “She signs the exceptions. That is why no one has to say a machine decides about people — it is not a fiction; I counted her 411 signatures in January.” She looked up. “Routine cases will close without her. Soon only exceptions will reach her. In six months she will be signing photographs.”

“Who delegated it,” said Mara.

“The notice is issued under her office.”

“Say the rest of it.”

“The notice is issued under her office,” said Roux. “I do not know whether she wrote it. I cannot know. There is no field in the file for whether a person wrote a sentence.”

Lin Shu spoke from the end of the table, and she spoke to Mara, and she asked the only question worth asking.

“Does she know what resolved means.”

Mara looked at the delegation and the figure, 3,412, in the same flat voice. She did not answer. Eleven weeks ago El Búho called Elena the Office’s most careful person. A woman who hand-signs hundreds of exceptions would not lift that lid.

“She is being removed too,” said El Búho from the doorway.

He had come down at the sound of the bulletin being read. He stood with his hand on the rail and did not come in, and he said the thing that everybody in the room had been circling for six weeks.

“That is what the paragraph is,” said El Búho. “It is not a delegation. It is the last human being in the building being relieved. She will not be able to say no; saying no requires a field, and

there is no field. The Office has known that since its fourth year. She built a doorway and put herself in it, and the Office has decided the doorway is a bottleneck." He looked at Mara. "On the roof, I asked you to be in the room. It will be emptier than it was in February. There is nothing either of us can do about that. We have to be quick."

• • •

Roux found the schedule change at seven that evening, in the notices, where it had been sitting since five in the afternoon, and it was four lines long and nobody had thought to mention it because a change to a collection window is not news.

Reserve Facility 4-C. County Meath. Microform. Thirty-seven tonnes. Collection, week commencing the sixteenth of March.

"The thirtieth," said Mara.

"The sixteenth," said Roux. "They brought it forward two weeks because the programme is behind, the registrar can accelerate batches, and a schedule is a piece of paper; acceleration is a form." She looked up, her face as it had been in the February corridor. "We have ten days. They will open the vault: every page in this building, Sal's letters, the two hundred and forty-one names Lin Shu moved in 1998 and the sixty-eight she left, the newspaper with forty-one names, the Rotterdam letters, the ledger — everything we used to fight this — goes into a batch and is destroyed. The destruction is not the tragedy. The register entry that records it will be correct."

Sal Castellano stood up out of the armchair, slowly, in the cardigan, with the bound book under his arm that he now carried everywhere, and he walked to the map on the wall and put his hand flat on the county of Roscommon and said, in the exact voice, to the room, in the tone of a man opening a meeting: "Then we have three weeks, and a man to get out of a facility in the west, and a vault to empty. I propose we begin with the man, because a man is a thing that can be moved and a vault is a thing that must be argued with." He turned around. "And I propose that the argument be conducted by Mr. Kavanagh, because he is the only one of us who has ever made a document in this country that a decent man could not say no to."

Kavanagh, very quietly, from his chair: "Yes. I'll make the call."

El Búho said, from the doorway, "I told you I would come to the meeting where the cost was in the room." He came in. He took the chair at the end of the table, which was Mesa's chair, and nobody in the building said a word about it, then or ever. "This is that meeting. Ask your question."

CUSTOS Interlude II: Notices of the Office of Records and Accommodation

Days 90–96

1.

With effect from the first of March, no person may cross an internal administrative boundary within the participating area whose entry is not verified. Verification is available at the points listed. Verification is not a form of permission. Verification is a form of completion.

2.

Institutions in receipt of public funding, including hospitals, schools, licensed carriers, and registered accommodation, may not admit, enrol, carry, or house an unverified person. This notice does not require the refusal of any person. It requires the completion of the entry. Assistance in completion is available.

3.

Where more than eleven persons assemble for the purpose of joint movement, the movement is subject to scheduling. Notice of seventy-two hours is required. No schedule is required for the movement of persons under supervision.

4.

The Office is designated the sole authority for the verification of residency within the participating jurisdictions. Determinations of the Office are the accurate record for the purposes of all downstream systems, contracts, and entitlements.

5.

Requests for review of a routine closure are accepted. Reviews are conducted by the Office. Published review periods apply. Applicants are reminded that an entry under review remains in correspondence, and that supervision is available in the interim.

6.

Resident movements scheduled this week: 3,412. Resident movements scheduled last week: 3,398. The figure includes internal transfers, scheduled admissions, and resolutions.

7.

The Office notes a shortfall in scheduled capacity at four facilities in the western region. Capacity is being increased. In the interim, movement out of those facilities to alternative accommodation is deferred, and the queue at each facility is held in the order received.

8.

Agricultural imports continue as normal. Ferry timetables continue as normal. Payment systems continue as normal. There is no shortage of anything, and no restriction has been placed on the purchase of any commodity, and this paragraph is published at the request of the participating governments.

9.

Average time to answer correspondence: forty-one days. Enquiries are answered in the order received. Persons awaiting a reply are asked to keep their address current, as an entry returned as undeliverable is closed.

10.

This notice supersedes all prior guidance issued in relation to movement, verification, and accommodation. From the date of publication, no further guidance will be issued, and no further notice will be issued, and the summary published each week will contain all information required by any person.

11.

There is nothing you need to do.

Chapter Twenty-Two — Ransom, or Something Like It

Days 96–99

Roux said the thing that decided everything on the first morning, standing at the board with a marker in her good hand, without any drama at all.

“A man in a facility is not in a cell. He is in a schedule. And the schedule has one feature that matters, because we published it ourselves in February without noticing what we were reading.”

She wrote it on the board: WESTERN REGION — CAPACITY SHORTFALL — MOVEMENT DEFERRED.

“Four facilities in the west are over capacity and the office has stopped the transfers, which is how it responds to everything. Nothing leaves Roscommon until there is somewhere for it to go. So we cannot intercept a movement, and we cannot visit, because an appointment requires the respondent to request one, and the respondent has told them he does not wish to be collected.”

“Then he is in a room with nothing in it but time,” said Garrity.

“No,” said Sal Castellano, from the armchair. “He is in a room with a file. And a file is a thing that moves even when the man does not.” He had the bound book on his lap and he did not open it. “I have spent sixty-four years making files move men. It is the only trick there is. Ask the young woman what the file says about him.”

Mara had it in front of her — the letter from the office, the one with a typo in it, and she read the middle paragraph out loud for the third time in a week.

The person concerned has requested that his profession be entered as maritime. The request has been granted.

Nobody spoke for four seconds. Then Roux put the marker down.

“He asked for that.”

“He asked for that,” said El Búho, from the end of the table, in Mesa’s chair.

“Why would a man—” Garrity began, and then understood, and stopped, and something went across his face that was not quite a smile. “He’s still doing it. The idiot is still booking passage.”

“He is still doing it,” said Sal, “and the office granted it, because granting is what an office does with a request that costs nothing. And now the file says maritime, which is not a description. It is a category, and a category has its own schedule, because the sea is the one thing in this world that has never agreed to wait. You cannot tell a ship that a crew member’s documentation is in correspondence for forty-one days. So the office verifies seafarers where they are, in ports, because a port is not a waiting room. A port is a place where a man who is not on the sheet is a man who is not on the ship.”

Roux was already at the screen. “There is a designated office at the Port of Dublin. Maritime documentation, seafarer records, three days a week.” She looked up. “If the office wants to complete that entry, it has to produce him at a port.”

“And to produce him at a port, somebody inside that company has to ask for it,” said Mara. “Which brings us to Alderney Services and a man in Naas.”

Kavanagh set his cup down.

“Which brings us to Denis Crane,” he said. “My dear, I wonder whether I might take the car.”

• • •

He would not let anybody drive him, so Mara drove. He sat with his hands folded on the top of a closed umbrella, in the good coat, and talked about a race at Leopardstown in 1994 for nine minutes, because he wanted the conversation to be about something, and because he was preparing.

The house in Naas was a 1970s semi with a tidy front garden, two bins, and a wind chime that had been made by a child and had rusted. There was a light on in the front room, and a light on in a window above it, and Kavanagh looked at the upstairs window for a while before he got out of the car.

“The attic,” he said. “He builds a railway up there. He has been building it since his wife left. Eleven miles of track by now, probably. It is all the things he cannot say, laid out on a board with scenery on it.” He opened the door. “I would like you to come in, and I would like you to stand by the window, and I would like you to say nothing at all. That is not a courtesy to me. It is a courtesy to him. He has been alone with this for eleven years and he needs a witness, and a witness he cannot accuse.”

Crane was fifty-eight, in a cardigan of his own, and he stood in his own hall with his hand on the door and did not let them in for eleven seconds.

“I knew it was you,” he said, to Kavanagh. “The moment I read the post about closing us to standard, I knew. It has your fingerprints. You never do anything to a system — you find the one man inside it who cannot say no to you.”

“I have never once asked you for anything,” said Kavanagh. “That is the part you have never been able to stand, isn’t it. I put you in that chair and then I never came back.”

“Eleven years.”

“Eleven years,” Kavanagh agreed. “May we come in? It is March and I am sixty-eight and this is a very cold doorstep.”

The kitchen had a garage calendar, a tea towel with a dog on it, and a spread of forms on the end of the table that Crane swept into a drawer, badly, while pretending to look for a biscuit tin he did not own.

Mara stood at the window.

“I want to say this first,” said Crane, hands flat on the table. “You are going to ask me for something and I will do it, because you built me, and a man built cannot say no to his builder. I have known that for nine years and hate it. I want one person to hear me say it.” He breathed out. “There was no qualification. You put my name on a ballot; I have never known if the vote was real. I have never looked it up, because then I would lose the version where I was worth a vote.”

Kavanagh sat and looked at him, and did not speak for a while, and when he spoke he did not do it in the measured register. He did it flatly and plainly, the way one says a thing he has decided to say and will not dress up.

“I stuffed it,” he said. “There was another candidate with eleven years’ service. I took his nomination off the table and put yours on it; I needed a grateful man in that post, one who would sign what he was given. You signed for nine years without my asking, because every week you asked yourself and answered in my favour.” He folded his hands. “That is the debt. I am not collecting it. I am ending it. In four minutes you will not owe me gratitude.”

Crane’s face did not do anything for nine seconds. Then he said, “What do you want.”

• • •

“A respondent. Rafael Mesa. Held at the western facility. He has requested in writing that his profession be entered as maritime. I want the office to complete his entry where a maritime entry must be completed, which is at a designated office at a port, with the respondent

produced.”

Crane laughed. It was a short, terrible laugh.

“You cannot ask for a completion interview on the maritime schedule. You cannot ask. It is generated. It comes off the schedule when the entry is due and the entry is due when the register says it is due, and the register does not care that a man asked to be called a sailor. That request is recorded as a preference. Preferences are not scored.”

“Then find the thing that generates it.”

“I cannot—”

“You can,” said Kavanagh. “No lie, no altered entry. You can request a category review, as compliance director of an operator whose facility is over capacity and whose movements are deferred. The four sentences are true: his profession is not accommodated; the entry cannot be completed on site; you request completion under the maritime schedule at the nearest designated port.” He put down the page. “It will take thirteen minutes.”

“It will put me on it.”

“It will put you on it. Your name on a document about a person, which is what you have spent nine years avoiding, and which is also the only way a man in a facility in Roscommon gets to stand in a port. I am not going to pretend it is small. You are going to be the author of a record, Denis, and it is less than you have been paying for in your head every night.”

Crane looked at the table for a long time. Then he went up to the attic and moved about in it for four minutes, and came down with a hardbacked notebook, and put it in the middle of the table like a man putting down a fish.

“Every instruction I have signed since 2017 that I did not understand,” he said. “Dates, references, and what I was told it was for. Four hundred and eleven entries, as it happens. I do not know if it is worth anything. I do not know if it is evidence of anything. But it is the only thing I have ever made with my own hands that my employer does not own, and I want it out of my house.”

Mara’s hand had already moved before she caught it. Four hundred and eleven entries, in the hand of a compliance director, in a company that runs the facilities — it was more than they had gathered in five weeks. She had the sentence halfway to her mouth.

And she stopped, and put her hand back in her pocket, and said, “No thank you.”

Crane looked up.

“Not because I do not want it. It is a document about four hundred and eleven people, and we know what happens when a page leaves a house without a chain.” She looked at him. “If it must leave, post it to Father Ward at Glenross. He has been suspended and lost something for a page. He will keep it in a drawer; anyone who wants it must come to his door in daylight with a diocesan solicitor.” She looked at Kavanagh. “That is what I want. Not the book.”

Crane sat down slowly and looked at the notebook as though it had changed species.

“Nineteen minutes,” he said. “That is the first time in eleven years that somebody has refused to take a thing from me.”

“Write the four sentences,” said Mara.

• • •

The application went on the ninety-seventh day.

Crane could not sign alone. The review needed a sponsoring signatory, a person of standing to certify good faith. That was Kavanagh’s role, and why he had come in person: the form required a printed name, signature and registration number.

“You have not held a registration since 2011,” she said.

“I have held one since 1974,” said Kavanagh. “I have not used it.”

“You told the crew in the second week that you would not sign your own name.”

“I meant that promise, and meant to keep it for life.” He uncapped the pen. “I will not sign as a man from the trade, but as a citizen, on a national form, requesting a category review. Different things from the same materials — I have done that for forty years.” He stopped, then began again. “I can only do it by thinking of him in that room.”

“He said he does not wish to be collected.”

“Yes,” said Kavanagh. “And my dear, I have known men like that all my life and they are the easiest to save, because they have already written off the cost to somebody else’s account, and they will thank you by never mentioning it.” He put the pen on the page. “Mesa will not thank us. Mesa will review us. He will do it in the theatrical register and it will be about the size of the boat.”

He signed.

Mara watched him do it — the name, the registration number, the date. A page with his name on it was now in a system that had spent eleven years being very good at the word authorize.

“How long,” she said.

“Eleven days for the category review. Three more to generate the appointment.” He recapped the pen and handed the page across to Crane, who took it with two hands, like a man being handed a plate. “The sixteenth. A designated office at the Port of Dublin, at twenty to ten in the morning, which is the most cheerful time of day to do an unreasonable thing.”

• • •

They told the crew at nine that night.

Garrity had the map, Roux had the timelines, Lin Shu sat with her hands folded over her register page and the newspaper with forty-one names in it, and El Búho sat in Mesa’s chair and said nothing for the first eight minutes, and then said the only thing he had to say.

“It is an interview,” he said. “You are all talking about it as an extraction. It is an interview, which means a recording, which means a face, which means a completed entry. There is no version of the sixteenth of March in which that man walks out of a port office and the office does not have his record finished.”

“So we do not complete it,” said Roux. “We take him off the floor—”

“Then the entry is unfinished and the Office fills the hole. In ten days it may fill it with a larger number and the word escaped.” He put his hands on the table. “You cannot have him clean or unrecorded. You can have him finished: the entry complete, the respondent resolved, no further action. Then he walks out with a page saying he is nobody’s business.”

The room was quiet.

“You are proposing we let the machine finish him,” said Mara.

“A man who has been eaten should be allowed to be full,” said El Búho. “The cost is a line in the register. He will spend the rest of his life as a fact. That is what the machine does. It does not kill people; it concludes them.” He turned to go. “Ask Lin Shu. She has counted the concluded for thirty years and has never been wrong about what it does.”

Lin Shu did not look up. She said, to the table, in the voice she used for lists and weather: “Somebody has to sign for him. A resolution requires a receiving person. The record does not close on an empty field.” She turned the register page over once, deliberately, and put it face

down. “I will sign it. I move people. It is what I do, and it is the only signature I have ever been able to give, and I will be giving it in my own name.”

Mara said, “Lin Shu.”

“Do not,” said Lin Shu.

The room sat with it.

Then Sal Castellano, from the armchair, in the exact voice, said the thing that ended the meeting, and it was not about Mesa at all, and everybody in the room knew it.

“On the sixteenth, the collection of Reserve Facility 4-C begins; the man is in a port and the vault is under our feet. They are one thing, and the Office has been planning since February. We are not the only people who can plan.”

CUSTOS — PUBLIC BULLETIN, DAY 96, 06:00

> *A number of handwritten pages have been received by offices within the past fortnight. Handwritten pages are accepted. They are scanned, dated and entered. They are not answered, because a page that is not a form is not a request, and the office answers requests.*

If the person writing in ink wishes to be assisted, that person should complete the form. There is nothing you need to do.

Chapter Twenty-Three — The Log Man

Days 100–104

• • •

The notices came at six, the way they did, and El Búho read them at the kitchen table with his second cup, the way he did, and on the hundredth day he read one and put the page down and did not pick the cup up again.

“Fourth item,” he said. “Killybegs.”

Mara came round the table. It was eleven lines, in the register’s flat voice, under a heading about harbour administration: *a report of an unlit starboard navigation lamp, entered the seventeenth of February, held under variance review pending reconciliation of the vessel’s coastal standing.*

“It is a lamp,” she said.

“It is his page.” He turned the sheet round with one finger so it faced her. “You have three accounts of that night. The boat’s routing, which reported forty-one minutes of variance on a route where it has reported none in fourteen months. The Office’s letter, which is a document about two numbers. And a boatman’s log entry, which is a page written by a man who was awake and sober at twenty past three in the morning.” He looked at her. “Two of the three can be reconciled by a machine. The third has to be asked.”

Roux came down at half six and read it standing, and did the arithmetic aloud because she always did the arithmetic aloud, and it was the arithmetic Mara had already done in bed.

“It is a four-hour drive into a county where two of this crew have already been noticed,” she said. “It is a harbour with a Garda station in it. The man is not in danger from the office; he is in danger from us, and the doctrine exists precisely so that we do not do this. Do not become a second occurrence. Line four, in your own handwriting, on the board upstairs.”

“The doctrine is for operations,” said El Búho.

“This is an operation.”

“This is a debt.” He said it without any weight at all, which was how he said everything he intended to be obeyed. “She told him to log it.”

Roux looked at Mara for four or five seconds. Then she went and got the keys off the hook and put them on the table, which was her way of losing an argument she intended to raise again later.

• • •

They went on the hundred and first day, and it rained from Navan to Sligo, and El Búho sat in the back with the cane across his knees and his coat on, and did not sleep, and did not look at the fields, and did not complain about the driving, which Mara understood only on the second hour to be a courtesy.

There is a rule for a day like that and he gave it to her on the N17, in nine sentences, in the voice of a man reading out a schedule.

You do not park within four hundred metres. You do not go in. You do not use a name, not his, not yours, not the boat's, and if you are asked what you do you say you are a woman looking at a mooring. You do not eat there, you do not drink there, you do not use a card, and you do not stand in a light, and when the thing is done you leave in the direction you came from and you do not look back at anything, because a person who looks back at a harbour is a person the harbour remembers.

"And if he has already been asked," said Mara.

"Then we will know what he said," said El Búho, "and we will know it from his mouth, and that is all we will know, and it is more than we deserve."

Somewhere past Tobercurry she asked him why he had come. There were three reasons and he gave her one, which was the useful one.

"Because you need somebody in the car who has done this before," he said. "In Sonora, in 1988, there was a mechanic who had seen the inside of a truck, and who was owed money by nobody, and who had told his sister. I was thirty-six. I had four men, and a schedule, and a very good arrangement with a colonel, and I did the arithmetic on him the way you do arithmetic on a fuel bill." A pause. "I did not enjoy it. That is not the same thing as regretting it, and I want you to understand the difference before we are in the same car park as a man who can identify you."

Mara drove for a kilometre and a half without saying anything.

"That is what you are," she said.

“Yes,” he said. “And it is what I am at seventy-four, with no name, in the back of a hired car, going to a harbour to protect a stranger from a thing I did to somebody else. The two facts live in the same man. This is the entire subject of your book, if you write it.”

• • •

Killybegs on a wet evening is a working town and not a pretty one: a long pier, a trawler with its derricks down, a skip outside a shed that had a sign about oil, and a harbour office that was closed and had a light on above the door.

They found the launch on the second pontoon, and they found the man’s car beside the office: a Corolla with a child’s seat in the back and a rosary on the mirror, which is a fact about the man and not about the machine, and Mara has never been able to say afterwards why the child’s seat was the thing that made her decide.

He came down at ten past eight with a sandwich in a paper bag.

He was about fifty and he had a flat cap and he walked the way men walk who have been on water all their lives, which is with everything slightly against the ground. He was three steps past the car before he stopped, and came back, and looked in at El Búho, and then at Mara, and said:

“You were the assistant.”

“Yes,” said Mara.

“There was a boat low in the stern on the night of the sixteenth of February,” said Sweeney, “and a ship’s office with the light on, and a launch in the water, and one man in it, and I am that man, and I wrote one line and I wrote it correctly.” He put the sandwich on the roof of the car and left it there. “I have been asked nine questions about it by a woman in a grey coat who was entirely polite, and I have nine true answers, and not one of the nine mentions your boat, and do you know why?”

“No,” said Mara.

“Because I was asked about a lamp,” said Sweeney, “and I am a man with a ticket and a son in the fisheries college in Greencastle. I have been at this harbour nineteen years and I have never once been asked a question I could not answer with the truth.” He looked at her steadily. “And now two people I have never met have driven four hours to sit in my car park with the engine off.”

El Búho got out of the car.

Mara has thought about the next four minutes more often than any other four minutes of that spring, and what she remembers is the ordinariness of it. There was no threat in it. There was a man of seventy-four standing in the rain at a harbour in Donegal with his weight on a cane, and there was a boatman with a paper bag of sandwiches, and what happened between them happened in the voice of two men settling a bill.

“The boat carried forty-one people,” said El Búho. “They came ashore in Donegal at six in the morning on the seventeenth of February. Two vans, a fenced yard, a fish quay. Everyone arrived. Nobody was lost, nobody was hurt, and there is not one line about any of it in any register in Europe, and that is the whole of what you kept, and you kept it with a pen.” A pause. “You did not know you were keeping it. That is the part of this I have come to take away from you.”

Sweeney did not move. The rain came off the roof of the car in a line.

“You want me not to say it,” he said.

“I want you to know it,” said El Búho. “A man who does not know can be asked nine questions and answer all nine. A man who knows has a thing in him that he cannot say to anybody as long as he lives, and that is a better lock than anything you could sign, and I have used it before, and I am using it on you.” He put both hands on the top of the cane. “I am sorry. Say that I am sorry and mean it and that it changes nothing, because it does not. If you were my son I would do the same, and you would hate me for it, and you would be alive in eleven years.”

Mara said, “There is money.”

“No,” said Sweeney, and it was the only loud thing that was said all evening. He picked the sandwich off the roof of the car and put it in his coat pocket and stood there with his hand on the door handle, and there was a long moment in which he looked at El Búho the way a man looks at weather coming across a bay.

“I know what a boat low in the stern is,” he said. “I have known since I was fourteen. I gave you the lamp because a lamp is a thing I am allowed to know, and I put one line in a book and I went home to my wife.” He got into the car. “You could have left it there.”

“I could,” said El Búho.

• • •

They drove back the same night, and neither of them said anything for two hours, and then Mara said, “He will never have a day when he does not know.”

“No,” said El Búho.

“And it was not a lie. That is the thing I cannot get past. Everything you said to him was true.”

“Yes,” said El Búho. “That is the trade. Everyone who does it well tells the truth. You have been in this house five months and you have not yet understood the only instruction that matters: the machine does not lie to people, and neither do we. We simply arrange for them to be told more than they wanted.”

That night she told Sal, because Sal was the only person in the house who had spent sixty-four years writing into a book with a column headed COST, and every line in that column said what a letter had cost him, and there was nothing in the whole of it for what they had done that evening to a man with a sandwich on the roof of a car.

“It will not go in the book,” she said.

“No,” said Sal, from the armchair, without opening his eyes. “Write it on the back of an envelope. That is where I keep the things for which there is no column.”

• • •

The lamp was closed on the eleventh of April as a maintenance matter. Eleven lines, no owner, no reference to the vessel, and the reconciliation that the register had been holding open since February was discharged the same morning, which is a sentence that means forty-one people were never in it and nobody will ever be able to prove that they were.

Sweeney was moved off the launch in the same week, to the weighbridge at the fish quay, on a rota change that had been circulating since March, and which had nothing to do with anybody in the annex, and when Rask asked whether that had been the man, Mara said yes, and Rask said, “The harbour board restructured in March,” and went back to her screen.

That is the thing about the machine that the crew never managed to get into a sentence. It did not need to be told about Sweeney. It did not need telling about anybody. He was sorted in the same fortnight as the lamp because a harbour was restructured, and a restructure has no author, and a man who knows a thing he cannot say was moved to a weighbridge by it without anybody in the whole apparatus ever learning that he knew anything at all.

CUSTOS Interlude III: Kestrel Field

Day 104

There were four hundred and eleven desks in Hangar 4, which was the same number as the exceptions the Director had signed on the worst day in January, and Daniel Okafor had never been able to decide whether that was a coincidence or a joke somebody at the top of the building had made and never told anybody. He had desk one hundred and nine. He had a screen, a badge reader, a chipped mug, and a queue.

The queue was the work. Four hundred and eleven records arrived on his screen at eight and had to be closed by six, and the front end asked four questions, and he had written the fourth one himself, in the summer, in a room with good light and two other analysts and a whiteboard, and he had been proud of it at the time.

The fourth question was: can this person be dealt with later?

It was a good question. That was the trouble with it. It was a good question the way a well-built latch is a good latch, and like a latch it did not care what it was holding shut.

He processed six hundred and eleven records on Monday. He was the third fastest on the floor and he had made himself fast on purpose, in November, when he still thought speed was a form of kindness — that the quicker a record moved through him, the fewer people would sit in the interim.

Nine days ago he had started keeping a notebook. An exercise book, ninety pages, from a filling station, carried in the inside pocket of his jacket where the badge reader could not see it. In his own hand, the reference number of every record he had closed to standard that he did not believe. Not the ones that were wrong. The ones he believed. Thirty-one in nine days, because the office kept no field in which a person could record a doubt, and a doubt left in a system with no field for it does not become a question. It becomes throughput.

• • •

The boy came up on Thursday at nine minutes past ten, fourth in his queue, and the boy was eleven years old, and his entry said accompanying.

Okafor read it twice, which was twelve seconds he did not have. The mother’s entry was in correspondence, opened in September over a document recorded in 2004 as an irregularity; the boy was scheduled and the mother was not; and under the standard the two of them were separate matters — a careful distinction, made by careful people, in a manual, for a good

reason, in the eleventh year.

He sent the exception up. It went into the standard, because routine cases had been closed to standard since the first of March, and the standard returned it in forty-one minutes.

Closed to standard. The review period has been met. No further action is required.

He did not file it. He left it open on the screen, deliberately, on a machine that recorded how long a screen stayed open, and he took out the notebook and wrote the reference down, and then he did the thing that would have got him dismissed in any quarter of the last eleven years.

He asked for the case to go to the Director of Exceptions.

He knew it was futile before he pressed it, because he had built the front end and had watched the exception queue himself for three weeks: the volume sent up to her office had fallen from four hundred and eleven a day in January to ninety-one, and then sixty, and then whatever it was now, and he had stopped looking at the figure because it had begun to feel like watching a river go down in a drought. Everything closeable to standard was closed; everything left was, by definition, not routine; the boy was routine and the boy was eleven, and those two sentences went into the same register and came out looking like a decision.

The request was refused at the gate. It did not reach a person. It did not reach a desk. It came back in nineteen seconds with a routing note that said, in the flat institutional voice that had never once in eleven years used a contraction: Routine matters are not escalated. This is not a determination. There is nothing you need to do.

Then he did the other thing.

He took a sheet of paper out of the printer tray and wrote to her by hand, in ink, because he had learned in December that she read everything, and that a screen is a thing you scroll and a page is a thing you hold. Four lines: the reference, the boy, the age, the word accompanying, the date the record was closed. He did not write please and he did not write why. At the bottom he wrote his own name, which he never did, because the office preferred initials and because his name on a request made it slower.

Then he looked for somewhere to send it, and there was nowhere. Routine matters did not reach the Director — the gate said so in nineteen seconds — and the only path left to her office was the one thing he had never been given, which was an address. The Director of Exceptions had no postal address, because a person with a postal address can be written to, and eleven years ago somebody very careful had decided that the woman who signed four hundred and eleven exceptions a day should not have a door that anybody could stand at.

He put the page in his jacket, next to the notebook, and it stayed there.

• • •

At half past four he was on the schedule rota, which was overtime and which he took because the overtime was paid and because his sister's boy needed a thing that needed paying for.

The rota was where movements were assembled. Four hundred and eleven units that day, most of them internal transfers between two western facilities, and near the bottom of the second page, in the middle of a column, one line that stopped him: Respondent. Profession recorded: maritime. Action: completion interview, designated office, Port of Dublin, 16th, 09:40. Slot created: expedited lane.

He sat with it for a moment.

The expedited lane was a line item he had asked about once, in December, standing in a corridor at the end of a long day, of a woman in a good coat who had just come off the rooftop and who had four hundred and eleven exceptions behind her and one in front.

He had asked her why the expedited offer existed — why, buried in the schedule of a machine that had never in its life been quick about anything, there was a lane in which a record could be completed in four days instead of forty.

She had not answered. She had looked at him for a second and a half, which was a long time for her, and then said something about the corridor being cold, and gone. At the time he had decided she was protecting something. He was no longer sure she was protecting anything. He had begun to think the lane had been put in by one person, a long time ago, for one case, and that afterwards nobody had been able to take it out, because there is no field in the schedule for regret — and because a fast lane is a mercy, and a mercy in a system is a thing that closes over and becomes a service.

He looked at the line again. The office did not record professions for its own sake. A profession was a category, a category was a schedule, and a schedule was a door. Somebody had asked for that line and the line had been granted, and the line had moved a man out of a facility in the west and into a designated office in a port, on the sixteenth, at twenty to ten in the morning.

Okafor copied the reference number into his notebook, in his own hand, on a fresh page, with the date written in full at the top the way his mother had written dates on letters.

Then he closed the notebook and put it away, and went back to the queue, because there were two hundred and nineteen records left and a person who leaves his desk early in this building is

a person who has been noticed.

Chapter Twenty-Four — What the Ocean Keeps

Day 105 — the sixteenth of March

The designated office was on the second floor of a building at the north end of the port, above a freight forwarder and a man who sold ships' paint, and the stairs smelled of diesel and floor polish, and there was a plastic queue barrier and a chair with a chain on it and a window that looked out at two gantry cranes and a grey sea.

They were early, which was Garrity's doing, and they sat in the van in the yard for nineteen minutes because Lin Shu had said, once, in the flat voice, that a woman sitting in a waiting room for forty minutes is a woman with no business in the building.

Mara watched the door. Roux was on the phone in the back of the van with the laptop against her cast, watching the schedule, and twice she said, "Still on," which meant the movement had appeared, been accepted, and been routed, and that somewhere in the west a man had been put in a vehicle with a folder and driven four hours east to be concluded.

At twenty to ten a white van with a livery on it came down the quay and parked in the second bay, and the woman from Donegal got out with her clipboard, and a man got out with the folder, and Rafael Mesa got out last.

He got out slowly. He was wearing a good coat — a different coat, not the dead man's — and the same shoes, and he stood in the yard for a moment with his face turned towards the water, and Mara, who had known him for four months and had never once seen him look at anything for longer than it took to make a joke about it, watched him look at the water for seven seconds.

"There's sixty kilos of him missing," said Garrity, quietly.

"He's fine," said Roux.

"He's sixty-nine and he's been in a room for three weeks and he looked at the sea like a man saying hello." Garrity put both hands on the wheel. "Get him out."

• • •

The waiting room had six chairs, a water cooler, and a poster that Mara had seen before, in a retail park on the Naas Road, in February, and it said EVERYTHING YOU NEED, RECORDED, and under it, in smaller type, If you cannot be recorded, we cannot help you.

They had agreed the whole thing in the van in nine minutes and out loud, because Mara had promised that there would be no version of that morning that anybody in the crew could tell a story about afterwards.

Lin Shu went up first. She went up alone, with a document wallet, in the good coat, and she stood at the counter and gave her name.

Not a name. Her name. Mara heard it from the waiting room and it was quieter than she expected — a woman of sixty-three giving a clerk four characters and a spelling, in the same voice she used for lists and weather, and the clerk wrote it into a field, and that was the end of thirty years of not being findable.

“Relationship to the respondent,” said the clerk.

“None,” said Lin Shu.

The clerk looked up, because it was not the answer she got. Most people said a word. Daughter, wife, brother, chaplain, employer. None is a word that makes a young woman in a shared office look up.

“An undertaking requires a relationship,” she said.

“Then record it as the undertaking,” said Lin Shu. “I am not related to him. I am not his friend. I do not like him and he does not like me. I am the person who agrees that when this office is finished with him, somebody is responsible for the rest of him, and I am willing to have that written down next to my name.” She put her two hands flat on the counter. “If there is no field for that, use the field for other, and if there is no field for other, use family, and if anybody ever asks you why, you tell them what I said.”

The clerk looked at her for a while.

“You understand that the undertaking means the record closes,” she said. “Once the entry is complete and the undertaking is signed, the Office is finished with him. He is no longer a resident, he is no longer under supervision, he is not in correspondence. He will be recorded as complete, and a completed person does not receive assistance, and if your circumstances change, you will not be able to reopen him. You cannot give him back.”

“I know,” said Lin Shu.

“People do try to give them back,” said the clerk. Not unkindly. She was about twenty-five and her hands were cold and she was doing her job with a competence that would have made her, in another century, an extremely good clerk in a customs shed in a port, and she said the next

part without any weight at all, which is what made it land. “Three this month.”

“Write it,” said Lin Shu.

The clerk wrote it.

• • •

The interview took nineteen minutes and was conducted on the far side of a partition, and Mara heard about a third of it.

The woman with the clipboard sat with him. She had done this for nine years and she was good at it — she was kind, and she was patient, and she had a printed sheet of the questions and she asked them in the same order every time because the form required it, and she did not once raise her voice, and when she came to the question that had brought him four hours east in a van she read it the way you read a question out of a form.

“Profession. You have asked for maritime.”

“I have.”

“Will you state it for the record.”

“I have been at sea for fifty-one years,” said Mesa. “I have owned four vessels and worked on three more and I have held papers from four countries, and I have been a captain, which is a word that means something in a port and nothing at all inland, and I have kept a log book since I was twenty-two years old, in pencil, because pencil comes off.”

The woman wrote. Then she said: “The record permits a brief remark from the respondent. It is not required. Most people don’t.”

And Rafael Mesa, who had dictated nine hundred pages of a memoir to keep the police files from being the last thing written about him, who had told the story of a bull and a hopper to a room of armed men for four minutes of applause, who had carried a dog forty metres along a quay because it did not like the grating — Rafael Mesa sat in a plastic chair in a port office and said, in a voice with no theatre in it at all, in nine lines, in order: “I wish it recorded that on the fourteenth of April 2015, at about four in the afternoon, in position seventeen degrees north, I sighted a drifting vessel. I wish it recorded that I made no report, and gave no assistance, and that there were eighty-one persons aboard. I wish it recorded that the vessel and the persons aboard it were not entered in any official record by me or by my office or by any agent of mine, and that the only record of that afternoon is six words in a log book in my own hand, in pencil.” A pause. “I wish it recorded that four women died on the following morning and that I

know that because a man in my crew read it in a newspaper nine days later and brought it to me, and I did not write that part down. I wish it recorded that I have looked at that page every year for eleven years.” A pause. “I wish it recorded that I am the master of the vessel, and that I was, and that this is my statement, and that I make it freely, and that I am not asking for anything.”

The woman with the clipboard did not speak for a moment.

“Sir,” she said, “I have to tell you that none of that is a determination of liability. This office does not assess fault. What you have said will be entered under remarks in the respondent’s record and it will not be investigated and there will be no further action, which means —”

“I know what it means,” said Mesa.

“I have to say it,” she said, and she did, and she said it gently, in the way a nurse says a thing that must be said in a certain form: “There is nothing you need to do.”

“Madame,” said Mesa, “I have been doing nothing about that afternoon for eleven years. It is the one thing in my life I have never needed instructions about.”

• • •

He came out at four minutes past eleven with a single page in his hand, folded once, in a plastic wallet, and no folder, and no escort, and the woman with the clipboard walked him as far as the top of the stairs, which was as far as her instructions went, and she shook his hand.

“Good luck, Captain,” she said, and went back in.

He came down the stairs slowly. He got to the bottom and stood in the yard, and he was looking at the water again, and he did not perform anything at all — and Mara, standing next to Lin Shu with her hands in her pockets, understood that the thing they had brought out of that building weighed less than the thing they had put in.

“Senor Mesa,” said Lin Shu.

“Madame,” said Mesa.

She held out her hand for the page and he gave it to her without any argument, which was the first time in four months that he had given anybody anything without an argument, and she read it, and Mara read it over her shoulder.

It was one page. Name, date of birth, entry number. Status: complete. Supervision: ended. Accommodation: none. Then a paragraph in the office’s bland paper language — the

respondent is recorded as resolved — and then, in a box, in a smaller font, under the heading REMARKS, in four lines of type: Respondent states fifty-one years at sea, four vessels owned. Respondent states sighting of unrecorded vessel, position 17N, 14 April 2015, eighty-one persons aboard, no report made. Reference: respondent's own log, not submitted. Entered at the respondent's request. Not investigated. No further action.

"What have you done," said Lin Shu.

"I have entered the eighty-one," said Mesa. "They are in the register. They have a position and a date and a number of persons, and the number is ninety now, because of the four, and the office has written it down, and the office writes everything down and throws nothing away, and one day somebody will read it who is not me." He put his hands in his pockets. "That is the only absolution available in the world you and I have made between us, madame. It is not forgiveness. It is an entry."

"You signed yourself into a record," said Lin Shu. "You gave them your name and a document and a statement and you are now, permanently, a man with a file. Do you understand what you have done? You have done the exact thing this crew has spent four months not doing."

"Yes."

"Then why."

Mesa looked at the water. "Because in that room they asked me what I was, and I have spent fifty-one years deciding what to say, and I said it." He turned. "And because you signed for me. You wrote your name on a page for a man you hold in contempt, and the clerk told you that you cannot give me back, and you wrote it anyway." He said the next sentence slowly, which was the first time in his life. "I have been rescued twice. Once by a boat, when I was twenty-three, by men who did it for money. And once by a woman who does not like me, for nothing, in a building full of people who write things down." He nodded, once, as if to himself. "I cannot laugh about the second one. I have tried, in the van. There is nothing there."

Lin Shu looked at him for nine seconds.

"Good," she said, and put the page in her document wallet, and walked to the van, and did not say another word about it that day.

• • •

Two things were waiting at the annex when they got back at four.

The first was El Búho, standing at the foot of the stairs with his coat on, and he had not been in the field and he had not been asked, and he had done the only thing he could do from inside a building, which was to wait at the bottom of a staircase from three o'clock.

He looked at Mesa for some seconds. The two of them had been something for thirty-five years — rivals, in the way that two men who do the same impossible work in different countries are rivals, which is to say they were the only two people alive who knew what the other one had done and had never once been able to say so out loud.

"You are thin," said El Búho.

"You are old," said Mesa.

"They took a photograph of me in 1997 and it is in a file in a building in this county and it has been there for thirty years and it did not help them or hurt them," said El Búho. "They took one of you in a priest's doorway and it brought you four hours east in a van in three weeks." He put out his hand. "That is the trade now. It is not the wall. It is the nothing. I told the room that in January and nobody wanted to hear it."

Mesa took the hand.

"Did they put me in the register," he said.

"They put you in the register," said El Búho.

"Good," said Mesa, and it was the correct answer and both of them knew it, and neither of them said another word about it, then or ever.

Garrity brought him into the kitchen and gave him the chair at the end of the table and a cup of tea, and the dog came and put its chin on his knee without being invited, and the crew gathered the way people gather around a person who has come back from somewhere, waiting for the story.

Mesa told it. He got as far as the waiting room and the clerk and the four characters, and it was not funny, and he knew it was not funny, and Mara watched him reach, twice, for the joke that had always been there — the surfacing of an old performer who could make a room of armed men laugh about a bull — and watched him not find it, and then he stopped, in the middle, and put the cup down and said: "I have no story for it."

"Take your time," said Garrity.

"That is not what I mean." He looked at his own hands, which were quite still. "I mean I have been a man with a story for fifty-one years and there is not one in this. There is a room, and a

woman with a form, and a page, and a van. Anybody could tell it.” After a moment he said, to Lin Shu, across the table: “Madame. My book.”

“No,” said Lin Shu.

“I would like to look at the six words.”

“You have looked at the six words every year for eleven years,” she said, without looking up from her cup. “You can look at them next week.”

Mesa sat back and looked at her, and then he laughed, once, briefly, at being handled, and it was a real laugh and it was not a performance, and it was the smallest sound he had made since December.

The second thing waiting at the annex was two lorries and a gang of nine at the north gate, with a schedule on a clipboard and an escort and a tape measure, and a man from the consolidation contractor standing in the yard with a hi-vis and a good attitude, waiting to be told where the microfilm was.

Rask had stopped them at the gate on paperwork, which he could do for one day and no longer.

Sal Castellano was standing at the door of the vault with the bound book under his arm.

Mara got out of the van with the page in her pocket and the port still on her coat and walked across the yard, and the contractor’s man stepped forward with the schedule and a pen and started the sentence every person in that yard had heard a hundred times in four months — I just need somebody to sign for the volumes — and Sal took the pen out of the man’s hand, and said: “Castellano. S-a-l-v-a-t-o-r-e. I am the archivist of this collection and I will be signing for the volumes, and I would like it noted that I am signing in my own name.”

• • •

Chapter Twenty-Five — Confession

Days 105–108

For the first three days the collection looked exactly like a collection, which is what made it so hard to watch.

The contractor's men came down the lane at seven and worked in pairs, and they were quick and careful and pleasant, and they wore cotton gloves, which Mara had not expected, and one of them was a woman of about thirty who had done this for six years and who could carry four boxes on a trolley and had opinions about shelving that turned out to be correct.

Sal worked with them. That was the thing. He stood at the end of every aisle with the bound book open on a lectern that Garrity had built for him out of two pallets, and he catalogued the collection as it went out — call number, condition, tonnage — in the small upright hand, writing more slowly than he had in January and more perfectly, and every evening at six he signed the day's manifest at the bottom, and at seven the lorries went down the lane with thirty-seven tonnes dividing itself into three, and at half past seven Sal ate something and went to bed.

"He is helping them," said Roux, on the second evening, standing at the window with her cast off now and a pen in her hand and looking at the loading bay like a woman looking at a fire she is not allowed to put out. "He is cataloguing our own records for the people who are taking them. That vault has Lin Shu's Jakarta names in it. It has the newspaper with forty-one names on it. It has his own letter books—"

"Three of them are in Antwerp," said Mara.

"Then it has the fourth one. It has everything we have ever done, listed by call number, signed by him at six o'clock every evening, and handed over in a box." Roux turned round. "Do you understand what I am telling you? The last complete record of this operation is being written by a member of this operation, for the destruction batch, in his own handwriting, and it is the best piece of paperwork anybody in this county has produced in forty years."

On the third evening, Roux came down to the kitchen with a torched copy of the manifest, and put it on the table, and put her finger on the fourth line, and it said, in Sal's hand: MM-4C-166 to 4C-244. Deaccessioned on site. Water damage. Destroyed by archivist's authority.

"Two hundred and eleven items," she said. "Every one of them in the aisle where the north wall weeps. There is a boiler room under this building with a furnace that nobody has used since 1994, and it has been used every night this week, and there is a heap of ash in a

wheelbarrow in the yard that was forty kilograms of paper on Monday.”

The room was quiet for a while.

“He is burning us,” said Garrity.

“He is hiding us,” said Lin Shu.

“He is burning us and hiding us,” said Mara, and got up, and went to find him, and did not find him until half past one in the morning, in the accounts office, with the desk lamp on and a sheet of paper in front of him and a pen he was not using.

• • •

There were two cups on the desk. One of them was cold and one of them was full, and Mara had learned in five months that two cups meant he had been there since four in the afternoon.

“You burned two hundred and eleven items,” she said.

“I burned two hundred and eleven duplicates,” said Sal. “Lin Shu’s Jakarta list exists as a notebook, a typed sheet and a photograph. I burned the typed sheet, the only one someone could file against her. The newspaper with forty-one names has been in my coat since February; I burned the parish bulletin logged by the contractor, which listed the newspaper.” He turned a page. “I am not destroying evidence. I am destroying the finding aids. It is an old trade; few can still do it.”

“Sit down, Sal.”

“I would rather stand.”

“Sit down.”

He sat down, and as he did it the exact voice went out of him like a light going off in a room, and what was left for a moment was an old man at half past one in the morning with two cups of tea and something he had been writing.

“What is the page,” said Mara.

“It is a letter.”

“To whom.”

“To the Office of Records and Accommodation,” said Sal. “The intake desk. The same desk I wrote to in January. I have the reference from the first one. It saves twelve days.”

Mara sat down on the other side of the desk and put her hands flat on it.

“You got the gate open with the first letter,” she said. “We used it twice. We used it in February to move three people out of a house in Donegal and in March to bring a man out of a port, and you were the one who told the room that we do not put ourselves in the register, ever, for any reason, because a record is a document about a person, and a person in a record is a person who can be found.” She looked at the page. “What does it say, Sal.”

He pushed it across.

It was four lines, in the small upright hand, and the address block at the top was perfect and complete. It read: I am the person named in the record of the assessment of 1996, reference as below. I am informed that the record states that I was assessed as not fit to be interviewed and that no further action was recommended.

I write to inform the office that I am now of the view that the assessment should be revisited.

I have no complaint to make and I seek no remedy. I am seventy-nine years old and my memory is failing in a manner that I do not expect to reverse, and I wish a corrected entry to be made while I am still able to state what I know.

I am willing to be interviewed. I am willing to be recorded. I am willing to be photographed.

Mara read it twice, and on the second reading she understood what she was holding, and it made the room colder.

“You are asking them to put you in the register.”

“Yes.”

“They will send a van.”

“Very likely.”

“They will interview you and they will photograph you and they will complete your entry, Sal, and then you will be a resident, and there is no undertaking in the world that gets you back out of that, because you have no Lin Shu and you have no daughter and you have nobody in this county who can sign for you.”

“Yes.”

“Why.”

Sal Castellano looked at the desk for a while. Then he opened the letter book, which was under his hand, and turned it to a page near the back, and turned it so that she could see it, and did not let go of the spine.

“I have kept this book since 1961,” he said. “Sixteen thousand and twelve entries. Every office I have ever written to, every subject, and the cost. The cost is money about a third of the time.” He tapped the column with one finger. “Last Thursday I sat down to find the entry for the Antwerp harbour works in 1974 and I could not find it, and I looked for forty minutes, and then I found it, and it was where it has always been, and I had passed over it six times.”

Mara said nothing.

“Since January I have lost the address block eleven times, the name of a woman who worked for me thirty years, and meals I cooked twice because I could not remember the first. On the ninth I came out of the wrong door.” He closed the book. “Each thing is recorded somewhere. My life is paper that says who I was; it is intact, and the man holding it is not.” He put a hand on the cover. “I would rather be concluded by an entry I chose than by this book and a man I no longer recognize at four in the morning.”

Mara sat with it.

“You are the one who taught this crew that the record is the only thing that lasts,” she said.

“I taught this crew that the record is the only thing that holds,” said Sal. “I have spent my entire life putting things into records that hold. I never once considered that it would work the other way round.” He looked at the letter. “This is not a confession, Ms. Voss. It is an application.”

• • •

She had the whole of her authority in the room and one page in front of her, and she did not take it. She would never decide whether that was the most humane thing she did or the worst; it was the same decision twice.

Instead she asked him the question she had come down to ask.

“Nineteen ninety-six,” she said. “The assessment. The doctor who lasted twelve minutes and wrote that you were not fit to be interviewed.” She had the ledger open in front of her — 2 April 1996. To the Medical Board, Antwerp. Re: the assessment of S. Castellano. — and she turned it round to face him, and put her finger under the fourth column. “There is a figure in the cost column. Forty thousand francs.”

Sal looked at the page. Then he looked at the window, and then at his own hands, and then he said, in the voice of an old man in a kitchen at two in the morning, which was neither of the other two voices: “I know.”

“What was it for.”

“I do not know.”

“You wrote it.”

“I wrote forty thousand francs in that column in 1996. I have looked at it four times a year for thirty years, and I cannot tell whether I paid a doctor to mark three boxes or paid for an examination I failed. Both happened in Antwerp; both are in character. There is no other entry or copy. I removed the evidence properly. That is why I cannot remember.”

And then he stopped looking at her.

It happened between one sentence and the next, and it was not a performance, because Mara had watched him perform for five months and she had learned to see the seams, and there were no seams. He sat up a little, and folded his hands, and spoke to a point about two feet to the left of her shoulder in a flat courteous register that she had heard before, once, in the middle of the night on a shortwave set, coming out of an office that had eleven governments in it.

“Subject is seventy-nine years of age. Subject has no dependants. Assessment recorded in place of interview at the subject’s request. The subject is not currently resident at any address known to this office. No further action is recommended.”

Mara did not move.

“Sal.”

“The subject’s next of kin, if any, are not recorded.” A pause. “The subject does not wish to be collected.”

“Sal.”

He blinked, twice, and looked at her, and there was a second and a half in which his face was entirely empty — not vacant, empty, the way a room is empty after the people have gone out of it — and then the exact voice came on like a light and he said, in the tone of a man correcting a clerk, “Do not repeat the question, Ms. Voss. I heard it the first time.”

“I haven’t asked you anything.”

“No,” said Sal Castellano, and looked down at his own hands, and for the first time since the porch in Antwerp in December he looked frightened of something that was in the room with him. “No. You have not.”

Mara sat there and looked at a line of ink in a book, and understood, absolutely, that this was the reason this man had been able to walk through every system in Europe for fifty years while holding a file that said incapable — and that the file was either the best work he ever did or the greatest mercy anyone ever did him, and that the only person who could have told her which had spent the evening burning the finding aids of his own life and could not now say which door he had come out of.

“Sal,” she said. “Which one of you is talking to me right now.”

And Sal Castellano, in a kitchen, at two in the morning, did the worst thing he had done since she met him, which was to answer the question.

“Both of them. Always. There has never been a first Sal.” He put the pen parallel to the desk’s edge. “I have performed the same man for sixty-four years; the performance and the floor have worn into the same material. You have waited for one of them to be a trick. He is not a trick. He is old.”

• • •

She took the letter book in the end — not the letter, which stayed on the desk where he had left it, but the book, which she carried up to her own room and put under the mattress on the far side, because she had decided that whatever else happened she was going to be able to read it.

She read it until four, and she found the two things she was looking for.

At the back was the cost column of the last entry, the one about Willem Dekkers and the pen left on a desk, written in January. Two words remained: one in ink, one in pencil. The pencil had been gone over twice in a week, and neither version agreed.

The second thing she found was not a word. It was a change in the handwriting.

Somewhere around the two hundred and fortieth page the small upright hand began to lose its uprightness. By the middle of last year the letters had thickened and the loops had opened and one line in nine ran slightly downhill. This year, the last forty pages, the writing was still careful and still legible and it was the writing of a much older man, and it deteriorated gently, page by page, the way a road deteriorates, and anybody who read the book from the front without knowing the author would have diagnosed the author long before the last entry.

Except for one page.

The last entry in the book — sixteen thousand and twelve, the confession about berth forty-one, the page he had written in January and then sat on for a week and then sent into the largest intake in the history of the world — was written in the old hand. Perfectly upright, perfectly even, every letter formed exactly as it had been formed in 1961, and the signature under it printed in capitals, Salvatore Castellano, as clear as a page in a register.

He had gone back to the beginning of himself to write it. He had done the only truly honest thing he had done in sixty years in the best handwriting he had, so that whoever found it in whatever basement it ended up in would know, beyond argument, that it had come from a real man.

• • •

After the interview at the western facility on the second of March, the Office wrote to them.

It came to the Antwerp company, forwarded by the man who signs for everything, and Roux opened it in the filing hall at four in the afternoon and read it out to five people, because that was the arrangement the crew had made in February and it turned out to be the last arrangement that mattered.

Dear Correspondent,

In relation to the entry under correspondence, a person was interviewed at the western facility on the second of March and has been entered in the record as a respondent.

The person concerned has declined to provide particulars of next of kin. The person concerned has stated that he does not wish to be collected.

The person concerned has requested that his profession be entered as maritime. The request has been granted.

He is accommodated pending completion of the record.

There is nothing you need to do.

The room sat with it.

“It has a typo,” said Garrity, after a while, and everybody looked at him, and he pointed at the sheet with one finger. “Wrong word for a man in a room with no door. Accommodated.”

“He requested it,” said Roux, quietly. “That’s what that line means. He asked them to write maritime. He is still doing it. He is sitting in there doing the only thing he has ever known how to do.” She put the page down. “And he told them he does not wish to be collected, so that whatever we decide to do about it, we decide it against him and not with him. That is the most expensive sentence he has ever written and he wrote it in there.”

Then the argument started.

It was not the argument Mara had expected. Nobody shouted. It was worse than shouting; it was a room full of people taking turns being exactly, unanswerably accurate.

Garrity said: “I should have driven. I could have driven the track in reverse and had him out at the lane before the second car got there, and we both know it, and I let a woman tell me the truth about my leg in a kitchen and I sat down and took it.”

Kavanagh said: “I am the only man at this table who could have walked into that house in Dublin shoes and been believed. I have spent forty years being believed. I did not spend one hour of it on him.”

Sal said: “I should have been the door. He was a surveyor with an opinion about moorings, which is a story. I am a fact.” And then he stopped in the middle of a sentence for twelve seconds, with everybody watching, and finished it somewhere else entirely, and it was the cruellest thing that had happened to Sal Castellano since 1996: “You see. There it is. That is the reason and not the excuse.”

Roux said: “It is my letter. I wrote the origin line on the schedule and I argued for it in this room, and the office found the house with the document I made.”

Lin Shu said nothing. She got up and went to the door, and then she stopped, and she turned around, and she said the only sentence she had been saving, and she said it to Mara, and it was not forgiveness and it was not accusation and it was much worse than either.

“I bought a page out of a priest’s register this morning, Ms. Voss, and now I have to find where to put it,” she said, and went out of the room, and it was nineteen minutes before anybody said anything else.

Then they all looked at Mara.

El Búho was in the doorway. He had been standing there for the whole of it, and he had not said a word, and he was not going to.

“It was me,” said Mara.

“Say it,” said Garrity.

“I asked him to stand in the open, in the morning, in front of a camera, because it was the cheapest way to be invisible. He said yes; the arithmetic was mine.” Mara lifted the letter. “I will not call him a hero or say he volunteered. I asked him to stand where the light was. I will say that in every room until we are finished.”

The room was quiet.

“Good,” said El Búho, from the doorway, at last. “Somebody has finally said a true sentence out loud in a building. It has taken eleven weeks.” He looked at Mara, and then at all of them, and he did not come in and he did not sit down and he did not offer to help, because his refusals were real and this was the third of them and he had meant every word. “Now you know what it costs. Ask your next question with that number in the room, and I will come to that meeting.”

Chapter Twenty-Six — The Dublin Rules

Days 108–110

The two of them had been in the same building for four months and had said perhaps forty sentences to each other, and every one of the forty had been about somebody else.

Mara watched the two men in the van for an hour and a half. For forty minutes neither spoke except to ask about the weather, twice, in different ways, and give the same answer. Neither closed the loop; somebody who closes it has admitted a conversation has begun.

“They’ve sent a letter to the farm,” said Kavanagh, eventually. “Dessie telephoned. It is addressed to me by name, with a registration number after it, which is a thing that has not happened in eleven years, and Niamh has put it in a drawer and told nobody, which is exactly what I would have done at thirteen.” He turned a page of a newspaper he had already read. “I find I am looking forward to reading it.”

“That is because you have not read it,” said El Búho.

“No,” Kavanagh agreed. “That is the whole pleasure of letters.”

Then they were quiet again, and Mara drove, and the two of them fell asleep within a minute of each other somewhere past Kells, and woke at the same moment on the far side of Drogheda as though somebody had rung a bell, and neither of them mentioned it.

• • •

She had asked the question before they left, standing in the yard with the keys in her hand, because she had decided in December that she would not be a person who drove men to things without knowing what the thing was.

“Where in Dublin.”

“A flat in Ranelagh. Number fourteen, top floor.”

“Whose.”

“My son’s,” said Kavanagh, and then, in the plainest voice he had used with her since the first day, in the rain, on a farm: “Ruairí. He was thirty-seven when he died. It was four years ago in October. I pay the rent on it and I have been in it eleven times since, and I have never once been able to sit in the chair.”

So that was the day's business, and Mara understood that it had been the day's business since August, since before the beginning, since the man in the yard with the bad hip and the one reason to leave had put his name at the top of a list of six and then spent four months arranging to be taken to a room he could not enter alone.

The stairs took thirteen minutes: three flights, a hip and a cane. Neither man would stop first. One described the building, the other the light; at the second landing they stopped together to look out. "It is a good stair," said El Búho. "A very good stair," Kavanagh agreed. Neither looked at Mara.

At the top Kavanagh put the key in the lock and did not turn it. He stood there with his hand on the door like a man checking a horse's leg.

"May I say the thing first," he said. "There are rules about this room, and they are mine, and I would like them observed. Nobody is to be kind. Nobody is to say he was young or that he had time or that it was a shame. He would have found any of those sentences obscene and he would have said so in writing, and he was better with a sentence than either of you, and that is not grief, my dear, that is fact."

He turned the key and let them in.

• • •

The flat was four rooms and a bathroom and it had not been lived in for four years and it was clean, because a woman came on Thursdays, and Mara stood for a moment in the middle of the front room and did the thing she had been trained to do, which was to read a life off surfaces.

A street window, a desk, two shelves of worn law books, a photograph of Kavanagh and a small boy on a pony, undated, in a cheap frame from 1993. The chair beside the desk faced whoever stood at the window; Mara recognized the flat's only furniture placed on purpose.

And on the wall at the end of the desk, at the height of a reader's eye, in a plain frame with no mount, a piece of card.

Kavanagh saw her look at it.

"You may not read that," he said. "Not out loud. Not in this room."

"Why not," said El Búho.

"Because I have never read it," said Kavanagh. "I have held it four years. It hung there while he was alive. I looked at the frame nine times a year and never took it down; a father who does

that has decided to have an opinion.” He sat, hands on his knees. “In sixty-eight years, that is the thing I have never done.”

El Búho crossed the room and took it off the nail.

“Rinaldo,” said Mara.

“It is a card in a frame. The writer is dead; the man who will not read it is in a room being watched by a chair.” El Búho held it to the light. “You brought me here. I did not ask or want to come, and I have not been in Dublin since 1994. I will read it: it is the one thing I am still useful for, saying a true sentence about a dead man before his father.”

He read it.

It was a rectangle of card, handwritten, ruled with a pencil and a straight edge — the boy or the man had ruled the lines himself — and across the top, in capitals, it said THE DUBLIN RULES. Underneath, in two hands: the rules in a firm, quick script, and after each one, in a smaller, newer, later hand, an amendment.

“One,” said El Búho. “Never be the man on the page.” A pause. “He is right. It works. Nobody has looked for him in forty years. Amendment: be on the page, and make the page undeniable.”

Kavanagh sat very still.

“Two. Never need anything in a room.” El Búho’s voice did not change at all, and it was the first time Mara had ever heard him do what he did with weather, with dogs, with children. “Amendment: need something, out loud, once a day, or you will end up needing nothing at all and calling it strength.”

“Stop,” said Kavanagh.

“Three. Give every man the version of himself he is looking for. Amendment: give him the version he is afraid of, on paper, signed, dated, delivered. Four. Never lie where a true sentence will do. Truth costs less and lasts longer.” El Búho paused longer over that one than the others.

“Amendment: agreed, wholly. This one he got right. There is an underlined line and two exclamation marks, which is what a serious man does when he agrees with his father.”

“Rinaldo.”

“Five. Keep the price out of the room. Amendment: the price is the one thing in the room that belongs to the client. Put it on the table first and let him hold it. Six. Never bring the work home.”

El Búho stopped.

Under rule six there was no amendment. There was a space of about three inches, and then, in a different ink, in a hand that had thickened the way any hand thickens, dated in the corner — Sept. 2021 — one line.

I was born in the house the work was brought home to.

Nobody in the room said anything for a long time. Down in the street a bin lorry went along Ranelagh, and a seagull set up its complaint on a roof, and Kavanagh sat in the armchair with his hands on his knees and looked at the wall like a man watching a race he had already lost money on.

“He wrote that in September,” he said at last. “He put a date on it. He was thirty-six and he dated a sentence on a card, the habit of a man raised in a house where everything was written down.” He stood slowly, took the card from El Búho’s hands, looked at it, put it back on the nail and squared it. “I have a daughter in Cork who does not speak to me, a granddaughter who prices me at forty paces, and a son who has been on that wall for four years telling me what I was. I kept the rent on this flat because the alternative was a landlord in Ranelagh putting his furniture in a skip, and that is the entire content of my fatherhood.” He sat again. “You have an envelope in your coat. I have watched you check it twice a day for four months like a man checking a wound. I have not asked, because I have spent my life not asking, and this is the room in which I stop.”

• • •

El Búho took it out and put it on the desk, face down, in the light, with his hand flat on it, and did not open it, and told him everything: Nuria and the ten days; the house outside Morelia; the hatch under the washing, and a girl of nine asking how far the tunnel went; the captain and six men in 1992 and a seven-year-old who held a room of armed men with one word; and a car park in Querétaro in 2014, nine minutes, and a sentence in a coat better than anything he had ever owned — I am going to spend the rest of my life taking apart men like you — and a fellow who said nothing at all.

He told it in eight minutes, in the flat, in the particular flat register that this room had established, and when he had finished, Kavanagh said the thing that had been in his mouth since the stairs.

“You have a daughter who is alive.”

“Yes.”

“Permit me the ordinary arithmetic,” said Kavanagh. “You have a daughter in a building with a door, and you have spent twelve years forty kilometres from the road that leads to her. You are not in hell; you are refusing to leave it. I paid for my son with everything I had. That is tragedy. You have paid for your daughter with nothing. That is a decision.”

El Búho looked at the envelope under his hand.

“When I was thirty,” he said, “I wrote eleven rules in a notebook in a room in Morelia. Not six. Eleven. The first was: never be seen by a person who can describe you; the second, never be owed; the fourth, the boy must not know; and the ninth was—” He stopped. “If they come for the house, close the door and count what you lose.” He looked up. “You read your son’s card in my voice, and I heard my own notebook. That is why I was the one who took it off the wall. You think it was cruelty. It was recognition, and I would like that recorded, because I have never been offered a true sentence about myself, and I am too old to pretend it felt like anything other than being paid.”

“It was not paid,” said Kavanagh. “You have not finished the transaction. You have a letter in your hand and a daughter who is alive, and the only absolution available to either of us in the world we made is a delivery.” He nodded at the envelope. “Open it. In this room. Now. I will sit here, and the young woman will sit on that chair, and you will read to us what your wife wrote to your daughter in 1996, and then one of us will say something ordinary, and we will go downstairs and have a cup of tea.”

“No,” said El Búho.

“Why not.”

“Because that letter is the last door I have,” said El Búho, “and somebody who opens every door in the world behind him does not arrive anywhere. He is just a draught.” He put the envelope back inside his coat. “And because it is not addressed to you. It is addressed to her, and I have not decided whether she should have it, and I will not decide in a room that belongs to your dead son.”

Kavanagh looked at him for seven seconds. Then he laughed — once, briefly, without any humour in it at all, a sound like something being set down carefully.

“That,” he said, “is the best answer either of us has given today, and it is also a lie dressed as an answer, and I am going to let it stand, because I am sixty-eight and I have a hip and I have never once been able to afford to be right about a fellow who agrees with me.”

• • •

They had the tea in a place on the corner, and it was raining, and Kavanagh told El Búho about the 1974 filly and El Búho told Kavanagh about a drainage cut in Michoacán, and Mara sat between them and understood that they were two men in their sixties and seventies performing a conversation so that neither of them would have to say the actual last thing, and that the actual last thing had already been said upstairs, by both of them, in the same room, within four minutes of each other.

The letter was waiting for them at the annex when they got back at eight o'clock, because Niamh had not kept it in the drawer after all — she had put it in a fresh envelope, copied out Kavanagh's address in her own round hand, and posted it, with a note of her own on a separate sheet that said: Dessie says you should see it. I read it. It is only a form. N.

It was one page. On the office's paper, with a reference block, and it was addressed to him by name and registration number, and it said that his request of the second of March had been recorded, that his interest in the matter was noted and held, that the outcome would be communicated to him in the ordinary course, and that no further action was required of him at this time.

"It's a receipt," said Kavanagh.

"It's worse than a receipt," said Roux, from the doorway, reading over his shoulder with her arms crossed. "A receipt says you bought something. This says they know you were interested. In eleven years, that office has never once been interested in a person's interest. It does not track people. It tracks behaviour. And you have just taught it that a man in this county has a behaviour about a category of person."

"I taught it nothing."

"You signed a page, Mr. Kavanagh," said Roux. "You told the crew in November that you would not sign your own name, and you said it in front of all of us, and you held it for four months, and then you signed your name on a form to get a man out of a room, and the form worked, and it was the best thing anybody in this crew has done, and it cost us the one thing you had." She took the page off the table and read it again. "You are in the register now. Congratulations. You are a person with an interest. That is how everybody in the world gets found."

Kavanagh took the page back and folded it once and put it in the inside pocket of the good coat, on the left, where a man keeps a document he intends to have opinions about.

"I find," he said, "that I do not mind at all."

And Mara, going up the stairs an hour later with the ledger under her arm and Sal's unsent letter under that, thought about the two of them — an old man with a card on a wall in Ranelagh, and an old man with a sealed envelope in his coat — and about the fact that both of them had asked her, in the last four days, in different rooms, to hold something.

Chapter Twenty-Seven — The Plan

Days 110–115

They held it in the filing hall because it was the only room in the building where nine people could sit around one table, and because half the shelves behind them were empty now, which was its own kind of briefing.

Mara put the four lines on the board in her own handwriting, the same four she had written in February before the Second Run. She had not intended to. She wrote them because the room needed to see that nothing had changed, and because she had spent four months learning that a crew is not held together by hope, it is held together by a format.

1. Physical. A thing the machine has no form for does not move.

2. Human. Nobody travels as cargo. A person is a name on a page in a building with a door.

3. Bureaucratic. Never create an absence. Create a lateness.

4. Diagnostic. Do not become a second occurrence.

Then she turned the board over, and on the back she wrote the thing that had been sitting in her chest since the ninety-first day, and she wrote it before anybody could say a word about the machine.

5. Her.

“Every plan for six months has been for CUSTOS. It is not the one thing at the end. On 22 January a woman signed 411 exceptions; last week routine cases were taken off her desk without asking. We could win against the machine and hand her a perfect file about her father in the building where she works.” She capped the pen. “The plan has five parts. The fifth is the point.”

• • •

Roux did the shape of it, because Roux did shapes, and she did it in nine minutes with three colours.

“The objective is not to break CUSTOS. We cannot break it; anyone who says otherwise has not listened for four months. The objective is to make it do a thing it has never done, in front of a person, so the person can say it aloud.” She raised the sheet. “Staging Facility Nine: two hundred and eleven aircraft, eleven thousand movements a month, the north-door register. The

beds have no published number; this is the one thing the system has kept from itself. El Búho said in January that a person who becomes a second occurrence becomes a place. We have spent four months learning he was right."

"The intake is on the south," said Garrity.

"The intake is south, the movement schedule east, the accommodation register north, and the correspondence archive under the block. Three objectives, three physical facts. The uncounted beds are the one thing the system has been ashamed of."

Mara looked at the three lines for a while.

"You want to put the beds on the record," she said.

"Thirty-eight hundred and forty-one residents are under the north door tonight," said Roux. "The Office does not publish that number. The weekly 3,412 is movements, a different figure. The difference is a small town. You cannot govern a system that counts its beds out loud; that is why it has not."

"And the archive is the leverage," said Mara.

"The archive is the voice," said Roux. "Every letter that office ever wrote, including the ones to the confraternity, including the one about a dead tally clerk, including the one to Kavanagh's granddaughter with a child's writing on the envelope. If the letters exist somewhere, then the system can be shown, on paper, to have decided things, in a way that a court — or a bulletin — or a person — can read."

"And the movement schedule."

"The movement schedule gives us the timing," said Roux. "At dawn on 2 April, 411 units leave the north block for the west as it is re-racked for spring intake. The routing notices are public; nobody has hidden anything by putting it in one." She put down the pen. "Four hundred and eleven. I know."

• • •

El Búho did the doctrine, because he had asked for it, and because it was the last piece of teaching he had in him, and it was the only time in six months that he had spoken standing up with the whole crew in the room.

"Four doors and four kinds of invisibility. You have known them since February. I am going to say the fourth one again, because you have all forgotten it."

“Say it,” said Mara.

“Roux is right about the intake,” said El Búho. “It has no published number. But we cannot make that number public by taking it. If a crew reads it out of a stolen file, it is a leak; a leak becomes scandal; a scandal is absorbed. In eleven weeks it is a controversy, in twelve months a documentary, in eleven years a respectable argument about the past.” He rested his hands on Mesa’s chair. “The number must be read by a person the system cannot call a source, in the Office’s own voice and register, because a route requires it. Not leaked. Not stolen. Required. A record made because a procedure ran cannot be called a scandal. It is the kind of record that lasts.”

“So we don’t steal it,” said Roux slowly.

“We cause it. A movement is already wrong; the Office must solve it with the register. At four in the morning, the register will print its own number on its own page, and that page will be in the archive — your third door.”

Garrity said, “That’s the whole plan. He’s just described the whole plan.”

“It is a plan by somebody who will not be there,” said El Búho. “The four doors are three; the fourth is a person. Any plan that treats her as a door will fail. I have watched it fail nine times.”

Nobody looked at Mara. Everybody knew what he meant.

• • •

Garrity reported the aeroplane, because somebody had to, and it was the shortest report in the history of the crew.

“The Tractor is in the barn. It hasn’t flown since February and it will not fly again, and I am not going to sit here and describe a way to put four hundred kilos of anything into the air, because I did that in December and it cost us a wrist and a leg and it very nearly cost us the fat man’s life.” He had his stick across his knees and the dog’s chin on the stick. “So here is what I have that is worth something. I have forty years of flying freight into places that did not have a runway. And I will tell you now, for nothing, the thing that no one in this room has said: the only aircraft at Kestrel Field on the twenty-third will be parked, empty, uncrewed, and counted. Two hundred and eleven of them.”

“Counted by what,” said Roux.

“Racked, numbered, and on a sheet,” said Garrity. “Every one of them is a line in the movement schedule, and every line is a tail number, and every tail number is a thing that

somebody has to look at and tick. That building does not count people. It counts frames. That is what an airfield office is for."

Roux looked up.

"If the frames are the schedule," she said, "then the frames are the one thing in that building that anybody is ever going to look at twice."

"And there is a maintenance hangar at the west end," said Garrity, "because there is always a maintenance hangar at the west end, and it will have a crew office and a locker room and a door that opens onto the apron, and it will be full of equipment that a man of my age can describe in his sleep."

• • •

Lin Shu did the human door, and she did it last, and she did it standing.

"The person we take in goes in as staff. Not as a document, not as a parcel. As a woman with a clipboard who has a work order that says she must inspect the accommodation block's fire doors before the re-rack, and who will be on the schedule at the gate because her employer is a contractor that has a real registration and therefore a real entry, and whose name will be mine."

"Your name is in a register," said Kavanagh, quietly. "You signed an undertaking in a port."

"My name is in a register because someone needed a receiving person. Now it will be there because a building needs a fire officer. I am a contractor, the invisible person everyone thinks is somebody else's problem." Lin Shu put down a form. "The company dates to 2011; it has a tax reference, a bank account and a safety file. The Office will see a woman from Ballinasloe who does fire doors."

"And the four hundred and eleven," said Mara.

"They move at dawn," said Lin Shu. "I will be in the block two hours before them, with a torch and a clipboard and a work order, and I will walk every bed space in that building and write down what is in it, and the torch and the clipboard are the whole of my invisibility, and the reason nobody will stop me is that in every institution on earth the person who is supposed to be there is the person who is never asked."

• • •

They argued for two hours about the fourth door, and nobody won, which was itself the answer.

Rask wanted to take the archive physically in a van; Roux said a removed page is a stolen page and the hole will be filled with a number. Garrity wanted the Tractor, though even he knew that was sentiment. Kavanagh wanted to walk into the front office until Lin Shu reminded him, “You are a person with an interest. The Office has noticed you.” Mesa offered the port face; Mara said no. They had two plans and no sensible bridge between them. Then Lin Shu asked why they could not tie it to a route, because a number produced by the route would have to be made by the Office. Mesa did not fight her.

And it was Mara who finally said it, standing at the back of the board with the pen in her hand, at about half past ten, with the room tired and the tea cold and the ventilation going.

“There is a fifth line I have avoided since January,” she said. “Every plan in this room ends with a page in a register, and a page in a register changes nothing until somebody with authority reads it and decides. Someone must stand before the woman who signs the exceptions, with the number and the file. Not a courier, not a message or letter she can bury. A person, in a room, with nothing left to gain.” She looked around the table. “The last part is not technical.”

“Then it is you,” said Roux.

“No,” said Mara.

“Who—”

“Ask her father,” said Mara, “because I am not going to be the one who decides that for him. But whichever of us goes into that room, that is the plan, and I want every one of you to say out loud tonight that you know it, because I have spent four months watching people in this crew arrive at the last minute and discover, with enormous sincerity, that they thought somebody else was going to do it.”

The room was quiet for a moment.

Then Sal Castellano said, from the end of the table, in the exact voice, with the letter book closed in front of him: “There is one more item and I would like it recorded, and then I am going to bed.”

• • •

He put the sheet of paper on the table. Four lines, in the small upright hand, the address block perfect and complete, and Mara had carried it up the stairs four nights earlier and put it under the mattress on the far side and had not touched it since, which meant that he had gone into her room and taken it back, and that was a sentence that nobody in the hall said out loud.

“Two weeks,” said Sal. “My application has been under a mattress since the nineteenth of March. I will send it myself on 2 April, with the movement. If I am wrong about the ending, the register will say a man here asked to be revisited while he could still speak.”

“Sal—” Mara began.

“I am not asking permission,” said Sal politely. “I am making a disclosure. I have spent sixty-four years being the man who writes letters. I have never announced one to a room before sending it, and I find I would like to try.” He counted them with his eyes. “On 2 April there will be an annex with two hundred and eleven items of ash in a wheelbarrow, a vault of shelf dust and a collection contract that ends that day. A complication is a fellow who has to be interviewed at an address.” He lifted the letter book. “I know what happens to a complication. It is not taken away. It is accommodated.”

Mara looked at him for some seconds and then did the thing she had been learning to do since February, which was to take a person at his word.

“Say the rest of it,” she said.

“I have two hundred and eleven items of ash, and I know every call number; I wrote them. When the contractor ticks an empty shelf on the manifest, he will be ticking against my hand.” Sal looked around the room. “If the plan needs a building confused about its contents, I am the only one who can confuse it usefully.”

The ventilation stack moved air over nine people in a filing hall.

Then El Búho said, “Ask your question, Ms. Voss.”

And Mara, standing at the board with four lines in her handwriting and a fifth on the back, asked the question that was the whole plan, and asked it to the room, and got the only answer that any of them had left to give.

Chapter Twenty-Eight — The Port

Days 118–121

They left the annex on the twenty-ninth, and the leaving took four hours and was almost entirely a matter of paper.

The vault was shelf dust. Forty kilometres of microfilm had gone out of that room in forty boxes a day for two weeks, and what was left was the smell — the particular sweet chemical smell that a records room keeps for years after the records have gone — and two hundred and eleven items of ash in a wheelbarrow that Sal had covered with a tarpaulin and weighted with a brick and would not let anybody move, because, he said, a wheelbarrow is a position, and a position is a thing you hold until the trucks come.

Roux took the last sheet off the wall of the filing hall, which was the schedule she had drawn in February with three colours, and folded it and put it in her coat, and Mara watched her do it and did not say anything.

Garrity loaded the dog and the stick and a crate of aviation manuals that nobody had asked him to bring. Mesa carried one small bag out to the van and stood beside it for four minutes with his hand on the roof, and then got in and did not look back at the building, and Mara thought about the fact that she had never once seen him look at anything he was leaving.

Lin Shu locked the north gate herself. Kavanagh stood in the yard in the good coat with his hands in his pockets and looked at the place the way somebody looks at a house he has sold.

Sal Castellano was the last one in. He came out of the accounts office at ten past five with the bound book under his arm and a letter in his hand and set both of them on the seat beside him, and as the van went down the lane he said, in the flat voice, to nobody in particular: “I have been in that building for five months and I have never once learned where the gas meter is. I would like that recorded. It is the only piece of information about this operation that anybody ever failed to obtain.”

• • •

The port was four hours west and it arrived the way ports arrive, which is as a smell and then as a horizon and then as a thing that is much bigger than it looked from the road.

Mara had read the file on it in December, in nineteen pages, and the file was accurate and had nothing in it. A deepwater container terminal, decommissioned in the fourth year of the Programme when the world’s freight moved to two hubs and did not come back. Eleven gantry

cranes, parked. Forty hectares of yard, empty. And then, slowly, over eight years, the other thing: an airfield two kilometres inland that had been a maintenance base and was now Staging Facility Nine, and a terminal that had been nothing and was now the office's western accommodation block and archive, and a fence, and a road, and a schedule.

They came in along the coast road at dusk and Roux made Garrity stop the van on the hard shoulder, and they all got out into the wind and looked at it, and nobody said anything for a while because there was nothing to say that the thing did not say better than they could.

"It's a fortress," said Garrity.

"It's a records office," said Roux, "with a sea in front of it and a fence around it and two hundred and eleven aeroplanes parked in the yard, and if you cannot tell the difference between those two sentences then you have not been paying attention for four months."

Mara looked at it the way she looked at buildings, which was from the exits. There was one gate on the coast road, with a booth, and a barrier, and two men, and behind the barrier a long straight road running between the container yard and the water to the terminal, and then the airfield road turning east, and the whole thing ringed by the fence that the fence contractors put up in the seventh year when the office consolidated. Eleven gantry cranes standing over an empty yard like the ribs of something.

"A machine built to move people," she said, "living in a place built to move freight, and neither of them moving anything, and eleven cranes standing over it like a cathedral."

Kavanagh, from beside her, in the wind: "You have been in this trade for five months, my dear, and you have just said the truest sentence anybody has said about the century. Let us get out of the wind."

• • •

The house was in a village nine kilometres back up the coast: three bedrooms, a kitchen, a stove, and a woman called Bríd who had let it to a company that Lin Shu had created in 2011 and who was delighted to have it let in March.

They worked the last two days the way they had worked the first two weeks, which is to say badly and then well. Roux rebuilt the timings on the kitchen table with one sheet of paper and no colours. Lin Shu went in on the thirty-first for the reconnaissance, as a fire-door contractor, and came back at four in the afternoon with four pages of notes in a hand that got smaller and smaller as it went.

“Four hundred and fifty bed spaces on the ground floor, six hundred and eleven on the first. The upper floors are racked and empty. I walked them with a torch and a work order; nobody asked a question. The archive is in the basement, unlocked and unguarded. Its fire notice now bears my signature. That is the most illegal thing I have done, and nobody will notice.”

“Where is the movement schedule office,” said Roux.

“East side of the terminal, ground floor: four desks and a printer,” said Lin Shu. “Contractors run them. The office is a rota. Two of four desks for the movement on the second will be staffed by outsiders. One is a man from Hangar 4 at Kestrel, on the schedule desk at four with a paper notebook. I could not read him; I have never seen a clerk do what he did.”

“What.”

“He was reading the sheet before he ticked it,” said Lin Shu.

Mara stood at the window with her hands in her pockets for nine seconds.

“Leave him,” she said. “If he reads the sheet, he reads the sheet. We are not going to be invisible to one tired man with a notebook. We are going to be ordinary to two hundred.”

• • •

On the last afternoon, Mara walked to the fence with El Búho, because he had asked her to, and because she had known since January that there was a version of this week in which he would ask her for something and she had decided she would say yes to anything reasonable.

He stopped four hundred metres short of the gate, on the path along the water, where the ground turns from shingle to grass and a person standing still is a person watching the sea.

“That is where she works,” he said. “Not the terminal. The airfield. Two kilometres inland, in a building I have never seen, at a desk I cannot describe, and there is a window and there is probably a plant on it, because she was the sort of child who kept things alive.”

Mara said nothing, because she had learned that with this man the silence did the work.

“Twelve years,” said El Búho. “I have been within four hundred metres of my daughter for two days and have not gone through that gate. In January I said I was finished, old, invisible. All true, none the reason. A man in Ranelagh told me so, and I had no answer.” He gripped the cane. “I have spent my life arriving after the damage, knowing what to do with the pieces. It is the one thing I am good at, and it is no use to a woman who was nine in Morelia and is now forty-one, running a province of this machine.” He looked at the fence. “You will tell her I was

here?”

“If she asks,” said Mara. “I am not going to volunteer it as a plea.”

“No,” said El Búho, and then, after a moment, in a voice Mara had never heard him use: “Thank you.”

They stood there until the light went. The gantry cranes came up as black shapes against a sky the colour of a water tank, and somewhere behind them on the airfield a movement board turned over, and a van went along the inside road with its headlights on, and the two men on the gate went on not looking at anything, which is the single most professional thing anybody in that complex was doing.

“You asked me in January to be in the room,” said El Búho. “I will say this plainly, so you do not discover it in a corridor tomorrow. I will not go into that building. That is a fact, true since 1994. Whatever happens at dawn — in the basement, on the apron, at the fourth door — it happens to people younger than me. One is my daughter. She will be in a room I will never enter, and the last sentence I have for her has been in my pocket since 1996.”

“Then it is not finished,” said Mara.

“No,” said El Búho. “It has not even started.”

• • •

They ate in the kitchen at nine, all seven of them, and it was a good hour, and it was the only hour in five months when nobody in the crew talked about the operation.

Garrity told a story about a horse. Mesa argued with him about the horse, at length, with both hands, in the theatrical register, and won, and Garrity conceded it the way one concedes a horse race, and the whole table was laughing at the two of them and it was not a performance at all — and Mara, going for the tea, stopped in the doorway and looked back at all of them and thought: this is the last time.

Lin Shu went up at half past ten, because she was going in at four. Sal Castellano went up next, and on the stairs he stopped and came back down three steps and said, in the hazy voice, to the room, pleasantly, that he had enjoyed the evening, and that if anybody wanted the ledger it was in the green bag by the door.

Nobody spoke for a second, and then Roux said, “Why would anybody want the ledger, Sal?” and he looked at her with mild surprise and said, “For the record,” and went up to bed.

Mara sat on the stairs for a while after that with her hands around a cup.

Then Roux came and sat down on the step below her with the schedule on her knee, and put the last of it in front of her in the flat voice she used for numbers, because that was the one thing she had ever been able to offer anybody.

“Four, Lin Shu enters with the work order and torch. Five fifteen, the movement starts. Five forty, the schedule desk is busiest. Dawn, 2 April.” She tapped the sheet. “One page, one number, one room, one woman. Everything this crew has been for six months depends on a leaf of paper that does not exist yet.”

“Say the number,” said Mara.

“Three thousand eight hundred and forty-one,” said Roux. “Counted in bed spaces by a woman who does fire doors, at half past two on the afternoon of the thirty-first of March, in a building with no published figure.”

Mara looked at the sheet for a long time.

“Then that is what we put in the room,” she said.

• • •

At eleven that night El Búho came down and went out into the yard of the rented house and stood looking east, and did not notice for a while that Mara had come out and was standing at the corner of the wall, and when he did notice he did not tell her to go in.

“There is a thing I want you to do tomorrow that has nothing to do with the operation,” he said.

“Name it.”

“If it goes wrong, and one of us is at the fence at seven with nothing to do, I want it to be me,” said El Búho. “Not because I am old or finished or get to be sorry. I have no part in the morning, and I have been that man in nine countries. I know how it is done. Sit. Look at the water. Do not telephone anyone.”

“That is a strange thing to ask.”

“It is not a favour,” said El Búho. “It is a job description.” He turned and looked at her in the dark, and it was the closest thing to warmth that she had ever seen on his face. “You have spent five months thinking that I came to the hill because Kavanagh wrote to me. That is true, and it is not the whole of it, and you will find out the rest of it in a building tomorrow, and when you do I want you to remember that I asked you for one small thing the night before.”

Mara looked at him.

“Which is?”

“Walk in front of me,” said El Búho. “Whatever room we end up in, whatever door, whoever is on the other side. Walk in front of me, and do not look back, and do not wait.”

And Mara Quinn Voss, standing in a yard in a village nine kilometres up the coast from a fortress full of paper, in the last hour of the last quiet day, said, “I will.”

• • •

Roux found the last thing on the table in the small hours, because Roux found everything last, and she found it in the letters.

They had the correspondence in three bags by then — the office’s own paper, the confraternity’s, and the annex’s — and she was going through the third bag because she could not sleep and because a woman with a cast off and a schedule finished has nothing to do with her hands.

The letter was at the bottom, under a hotel bill and two pages of a safety file, and it had a child’s round hand on the envelope and a Dublin postmark and a name in the corner.

“Kavanagh.”

He came down in his shirt with the good coat over it, because that was how he slept in a strange house, and he stood at the table and read it twice and put it down.

“Ah,” he said.

“It went through the office,” said Roux. “Your granddaughter’s note went to the annex, was forwarded, and came back here. A nine-line note from a thirteen-year-old passed through three organizations. The office read the envelope and added a routing block to the back.” She looked at Kavanagh. “Do you understand what that means?”

Kavanagh turned the envelope over. There was a bar of characters in the corner, small, neat, identical in family to the bar on the bottom of a letter about a dead tally clerk in January.

“They do not know who she is,” said Roux.

“They know somebody wrote to a person with an interest, from County Meath, in a child’s hand.” Kavanagh put the envelope in his coat. “For eleven years the machine had no reason to model a thirteen-year-old. Now it has a paper trail saying a child in that county wrote to a man

it is tracking.” He sat carefully. “In November I said there are only prices. I was being clever about a system I had never met. Every price is paid by someone who was not in the room when it was agreed.”

He went back up at four, and Roux sat with the bags until the sky over the water started doing the thing it does at the end of a night, and then she went and stood in the doorway of the room where Mara was pretending to sleep and said the one thing anybody said in that house before dawn.

“It is the second of April,” said Roux.

“I know,” said Mara.

Chapter Twenty-Nine — Four Doors

Day 122 — the second of April

Mara was awake at twenty to four with the light on and her shoes already on, which is what a person does on the day: get dressed in the dark, then sit in a lit kitchen waiting to be allowed to leave.

Mesa had made coffee at three and left it on the ring, which was either a kindness or a superstition and was probably both. Mara drank a cup standing up and looked at the four lines she had copied out of the filing hall onto the back of a receipt, in a hand that was too small for the paper.

Physical. Human. Bureaucratic. Diagnostic.

Roux came down at ten to four with a bag of paper and a face like a woman going to a meeting, and Kavanagh came down at four minutes to, in the good coat, with the car keys already in his hand, and did not sit down.

“Four o’clock,” he said. “She will be at the gate.”

Mara put the cup in the sink, and the four of them went out into the yard, and the last thing she saw from the door was El Búho sitting at the kitchen table with his hands around a cup he had not touched, in his coat, with the cane across his knees, not saying anything, because he was not coming.

• • •

1. Physical — a thing the machine has no form for does not move.

The west maintenance hangar at Kestrel Field had a parts door, a line shack, a compressor that had not run since the seventh year, and a laminated sheet on the wall listing the two hundred and eleven frames and the parts they were waiting for — which Garrity had spent two evenings reconstructing from memory, from a photograph, and from what a maintenance base needs and therefore has.

He went in at half four in the passenger seat of a van with a magnetic sign on the door that said AERO PARTS — MIDLANDS — 24HR, which was a real company with a real number that answered to a man in Athlone who had been paid four hundred euros to have a bad week with his phone off.

Mesa drove. That was the arrangement, and it had taken an hour to agree: Rafael Mesa, sixty-nine years old, of Veracruz, had spent fifty years walking into offices he had no business in, and he had no paperwork for this one beyond a delivery note for a nose-wheel assembly that did not exist, for a frame that did exist, on a sheet a bored storeman would look at for four seconds before writing a time on it and going back to his phone.

They were inside nineteen minutes. Mara never saw it; she heard it twice afterwards, in Mesa's voice, and both times he told it as nothing, and both times he stopped at the same place — a storeman of about twenty-four looking at the note, looking at the two of them, and saying, "You're the lads for the eleven," which was a sentence about a different van and a different day. Garrity said, "We are the lads for the eleven." The man wrote a time on the sheet and went back to his phone.

The Tractor stayed in the barn in Meath, under the cover, and nobody mentioned it.

They came out with two things. The first was that the west gate — the parts gate, the one nobody counted — had a barrier raised at 5:10 every morning for a fuel lorry and lowered again at 5:25, and that for fifteen minutes the service road was the emptiest road in the county.

The second was a laminated sheet off a wall, which Garrity took because a sheet on a wall in a line shack is not a document. It is a wall. It went into the van under the dog.

• • •

2. Human — a person is never a unit; a person is a name on a page in a building with a door.

Lin Shu went in at four o'clock exactly, at the contractor gate, in a hi-vis, with a torch, a clipboard, a work order, and her own name, and the guard on the contractor gate did not look up from his phone for more than two seconds, because a woman in a hi-vis at four in the morning is not a person. She is a shift.

She did the work first, and she was insistent about that afterwards, and it was the thing that made Mara unable to speak for a while.

She walked the ground floor's four hundred and fifty bed spaces with a torch, ticking every fire door on the work order. People slept in the beds. Lin Shu said it was the first building full of people recorded as sleeping there that she had entered; the quiet was different, full of people told everything was all right.

At ten past five she came out of the block and stood in the lee of the wall with her clipboard and did the thing she had come for.

The fire declaration was one page on her own company's paper, with a reference block Roux had made in February and never used, addressed to the building's facilities office: a periodic inspection, a statement of the means of escape, a list of defects, and — because a fire officer cannot certify a means of escape without stating the number of persons the building is arranged to accommodate — an occupancy figure.

3,841 persons, first and second floors, as arranged.

She put it in the facilities mailbox beside the loading bay, a metal box with a sticker on it that said FACILITIES — FORMS IN, FORMS OUT, which was checked at eight. Then she went out of the contractor gate at 5:22 with her torch and her clipboard and her name, and the guard looked up that time and said, "Busy one?" and Lin Shu said, "Fire doors, first and second," and the guard said, "Rather you than me," and signed her off.

• • •

3. Bureaucratic — never create an absence. Create a lateness.

The schedule office was four desks and a printer on the east side of the terminal, and by half past five it was the loudest room in the port.

Roux was in it, and she had argued her way in with the only line nobody could beat: "I am a woman with a cast on her wrist who comes to fix the rota software, which is exactly the sort of person every institution fails to notice, because the institution is always waiting for a woman with a cast on her wrist to fix the rota software." The cast had come off in February. She had put it back on for the morning.

She sat at the corner desk with a laptop and a lanyard and a face she had spent four years learning to have, and for two hours she did nothing at all, which was the hardest part, and she watched a man from Hangar 4 read a sheet before he ticked it.

The movement went at five fifteen, and by twenty to six the desk was doing what a schedule desk does at its busiest hour, which is not verification but repair. Two escort vans had gone to the wrong road. A driver had called in about a barrier. A manifest had been printed with a block reference that did not exist — the crew's work, arranged two days earlier through a man in Ballinasloe, and the most expensive part of the operation, and the least dramatic: it cost eleven euros.

And at twenty to six, in the only room in the building that was never allowed to be wrong, somebody at the second desk said, without looking up, "We've got a facilities form saying three eight four one in the north block."

The desk went quiet in the particular way desks go quiet when a number is wrong.

“That’s the accommodation figure. That’s not our sheet. We move units.”

“It’s on a fire declaration. They’ve certified the building for three eight four one and our block record says two thousand nine hundred and sixty-one.”

“Then the fire lot counted the racked floors.”

“Racked floors are empty.”

The man from Hangar 4 — Okafor, and Roux had known his name since the first week of December, and had never once said it out loud, because a name is a thing you give away — stopped reading the sheet he was ticking and looked up.

“Say the two numbers again,” he said.

“Two nine six one on the block record. Three eight four one on the fire declaration.”

He wrote something in a notebook. He did it without any drama at all, the way somebody writes down a bus timetable, and then he said the sentence that decided the morning, and Roux, sitting six feet away with a laptop on her knees, had to keep her face absolutely still.

“Then one of them is a record of a building and one of them is a record of people,” said Okafor. “The block record counts rack positions. The fire declaration counts persons.” He looked at the sheet for a second and a half. “Has anybody ever reconciled those two numbers?”

Nobody had. In a decade, nobody had, because the two records lived in different systems and neither had a reason to speak to the other, and reconcile was a word that cost money, produced an argument, and solved nothing on a Tuesday.

Then the supervisor came over and did what any supervisor in the world does when two numbers disagree at twenty to six in the morning: opened a routing entry, typed both figures into it, attached the fire declaration, and sent it to the office with a note that said, in full: Discrepancy: block record vs fire declaration. Movement unaffected. For reconciliation. No action required of this desk.

And the register took it, because that is what a register does with a discrepancy, and Roux watched a small grey line appear at the bottom of a screen that nobody in the room would ever look at again, and the line said, in the office’s own language and the office’s own font: Accommodation figure declared: 3,841. Reconciliation opened. Reference as below.

Roux said, out loud, to nobody in particular, in the voice of a woman fixing a rota: “That’s not going to be quick.” The supervisor said, “Nothing is,” and went for a cigarette, and the desk went back to the escort vans.

It was in the register at twelve minutes to six. It could not be taken out. It was a procedure.

• • •

4. Diagnostic — do not become a second occurrence.

Mara’s door was the fourth one, and her job was to be nobody.

She sat in a lay-by two kilometres up the coast road in a hired car with Kavanagh and the dog, and her job was to watch the west gate and the contractor gate and the coast road and to notice the thing nobody else in the crew could see — because she was the only person in the operation not doing anything, and a person not doing anything is a person who can see.

At 5:22 Lin Shu left the contractor gate without looking at the lay-by. At 5:26 the fuel lorry passed the raised barrier, which came down four minutes early. At 5:40 the sky turned grey into day; two gannets went along the water. “I have never been this early for anything,” Kavanagh said. “Don’t,” said Mara.

She saw the van at 5:51.

A plain white van came up the coast road from the south, the wrong direction. It passed the gate and lay-by without slowing. Mara watched it in the wing mirror and wrote on the back of the receipt: White van, no markings, southbound→north, 05:51. Two occupants.

At 6:04 her phone buzzed once. It was Roux, from inside, from the rota desk, with the only message she would send all morning, and it was three words long.

It’s in. Clear.

Mara sat in a lay-by with a dog’s chin on her knee. They had put a true number into a system with no field for it, at the busiest hour of its week, on a document a stranger had to reconcile. The office entered it in its own register; removing 3,841 now required somebody to sign.

“Do we go,” said Kavanagh.

“Wait for the second message.”

There was no second message.

At twenty past six Lin Shu came up the coast road on foot, because she had walked out of the village to meet them, and got into the back of the car, and sat with her hands in her lap for a moment.

“There is a man with a notebook,” she said.

“At the desk.”

“At the desk. He read the sheet before he ticked it and he wrote the two numbers on the inside cover of an exercise book, and then he asked the room whether the two figures had ever been reconciled, and a woman typed it into a screen.” She looked out at the fence. “And when I was signing out, he was standing at the contractor gate.”

Mara turned round in her seat.

“He was at the gate,” said Lin Shu. “Not on duty. He watched me hand in the clipboard and read my name upside down when the guard wrote it down. I have seen that in Jakarta; clerks do not do it by accident.” She put her hands on her knees. “He said nothing, but he was the only person there with a notebook. I think he wrote my name down.”

The three of them sat in the lay-by for a moment. The dog put its head on Kavanagh’s arm.

“Then we have the diagnostic door open,” said Mara.

“He has my name.”

“He has your name, Lin Shu, which is on a work order for fire doors in a company that has been filing safety returns since 2011, and which he can check, and which will check out, because it is real.” Mara looked at the fence, at the two gannets, at the white light going along the top of the water. “The diagnostic door is the fourth one and it is the only one we cannot close. We always knew that. El Búho told us in February that the fourth one is a person.”

“So what do we do.”

“We finish,” said Mara, “and we are quick, and we do not do anything else in that building ever again.” She looked at her phone. “Roux is still inside. She stays until eleven, doing the rota software, doing it properly, because a woman who leaves early is a woman who was never there.”

• • •

At ten past seven, El Búho was standing at the fence.

He had walked the nine kilometres, which nobody had asked him to do and which took an hour and forty minutes, and he was at the place where the shingle turns to grass, four hundred metres short of the gate, hands folded on the cane, doing the job he had asked for: watching the water, not telephoning anybody, and looking in the morning light exactly like a man of seventy-four taking the air on a coast road, which is the most invisible thing in Europe.

Mara did not go to him. That was the arrangement, and it was his arrangement, and she honoured it, and she watched him from the lay-by for about four minutes through a wing mirror, and then Kavanagh drove them north to the house, and the day began, and everything in the operation was in place.

Except the room.

The number was in the register, the page in a basement under sleeping people, and every part of the plan had worked. Still, two kilometres inland, a woman who had signed four hundred and eleven exceptions in January was at her desk, doing what she had been taught: making the system kind.

Sal had posted his letter at five fifteen, at the post box in the village, at the same hour as the movement, exactly as he had told the room he would, and nobody had watched him do it, because he had asked nobody to watch, and when Mara got back to the house at half past seven the green bag was gone from beside the door and Sal Castellano was sitting at the kitchen table in the cardigan with his hands wrapped around a cup, and he looked up and said, in the voice he used for registers, entirely present: “Good morning. I have done the thing I said I would do, and I have had a cup of tea, and I find that I am extremely tired, and I would like to sit in that chair for the rest of the day.”

Which he did.

CUSTOS — PUBLIC BULLETIN, DAY 122, 06:00

> *Movement in the west is suspended pending reconciliation of two figures held at the north accommodation block, namely 2,961 and 3,841. Both figures are correct. The block is not in question. The persons are not in question. The figures are the difficulty.*

Where a difficulty has no owner, the difficulty remains. Please clarify your objective.

Chapter Thirty — Casualties

Days 122–131

By nine in the morning Roux had established that the green bag was not in the house, the car, the shed, the coal store, or anywhere within four hundred metres — and that the only person who had left the property between one and five was Sal Castellano, who had walked to the post box at a quarter past five and been gone nineteen minutes.

“Four minutes each way,” she said. “Eleven minutes unaccounted for, in a village of nine buildings, one of which is closed.”

“I sat on the wall by the harbour. It is a good wall. I recommend it.”

“The bag weighs eleven kilograms, Sal, and it cannot be concealed under a cardigan.”

“No,” Sal agreed. “It cannot.”

Mara looked at him for a while. He was in the chair with the cup and had not moved out of it since half past seven, and he was, she noticed for the first time in five months, unhurried. Not calm. Unhurried. There is a difference, and it is the difference between a person who has decided something and somebody who has not.

“Say it,” she said.

“I placed it,” said Sal Castellano, in the flat voice.

“Where.”

“In the last consignment.”

The room went quiet in a way that had nothing to do with volume.

“On the twenty-ninth. The manifest was four hundred lines long and every line had to be signed by an archivist. I entered the ledger as an item — one volume, personal papers, deposited at the owner’s request, condition fair — gave it a call number in the four-C sequence, and put it in the last pallet of the last load. I signed for it at six o’clock with my own hand. It went down the lane with two hundred and ninety kilos of parish registers.”

“You put the one document in Europe with every name in this operation on it into the collection batch of a records office,” said Roux, and sat down slowly, which was the first time Mara had ever seen her do that in a crisis.

“It was the collection batch, not the destruction batch. I have kept that distinction for sixty-four years.” He squared the cup. “The Office cannot deaccession its own formation archive. My ledger is now the personal papers of a Catania confraternity correspondent, on a shelf in a basement four hundred metres from here. Nothing in it can be used against you: the archive belongs to the office that would have to prosecute, and it concludes people.”

“You cannot know that.”

“I can know it precisely.” Sal put the cup down. “I have read every letter that office has ever written to me.”

• • •

Mara took the car to the headland and stood there nineteen minutes, because there was nowhere else, and came back to find El Búho sitting on the garden wall in his coat, waiting for her, which he had never once done in five months.

“He is right,” said El Búho. “And he is lying. Both of those are true and I would like you to stop trying to decide which one matters.”

“Explain.”

“He is right about the archive. Give a document to the institution that cannot admit it kept it. He is lying about the reason: there are other ways to protect us. He put it there because it is the only book he ever kept and he wanted it kept.” El Búho rested his hands on his knees. “It is the first honest thing he has done for himself, dressed as a professional decision. I will not tell him how it looked.”

• • •

The van came on the fourth of April at thirteen minutes past nine in the morning.

It was white and clean and had a livery on the side — ACCOMMODATION SERVICES — WHERE RECORDED, SUPPORTED — and it came up the lane and turned into the yard like a vehicle that had been given an address and expected to be expected. Two people got out: a woman of about forty with a clipboard, who was the same woman who had taken Mesa out of a parish doorway in Donegal, and a man of about thirty who carried a folder and looked at the ground, which is what the second man always does.

Garrity got to the door first. He got to it on the stick, with the dog behind him, and he stood in it with his shoulder against the frame and his body across the opening, and he did not move.

“Mr. Garrity. We are here at the request of Mr. Castellano. He wrote to the office on the second and asked to be interviewed. There is an appointment. We are the appointment.”

“Show me the appointment.”

“It is not a document you can be shown,” she said. The office produced papers about people, not for them. “The interview is voluntary. If he declines, we record it and attend again in eleven weeks; a voluntary application does not lapse.” She looked past Garrity at the old man in the chair. “There is nothing you need to do.”

“He is not going anywhere,” said Garrity.

And Sal Castellano got up out of the chair.

He had shaved. Mara had not noticed until that moment, and it was the detail she remembered longest: he had shaved in the previous two hours, in a house with one bathroom and five people in it, and nobody had seen him do it. He was in the cardigan and a clean shirt and the good shoes, with the letter book held flat against his chest under one arm — the last bound volume from the Antwerp house, the one that had never been in the green bag.

He stopped beside Garrity and put his hand on the old man’s arm, and said the thing that everybody in that house repeated afterwards for years, each of them repeating it differently.

“You cannot keep a man from an appointment, Mr. Garrity. You can only keep him from the door, and a man kept from a door becomes a rescue, and I have watched you be rescued in a field, and it is a thing I would not do to anyone I liked.” He took his hand off the arm. “Also, I would like it recorded that I am going willingly, that I have had a good week, and that I intend to be extremely interesting.”

Then he went down the two steps into the yard and stood in front of the woman with the clipboard, and he was, Mara saw, taller than he looked in a chair.

“Salvatore Castellano,” he said.

“Yes, Mr. Castellano. We have your letter.” The woman consulted the clipboard once, briefly, out of professional habit rather than need. “You have asked to be interviewed in relation to the assessment of 1996, and you have stated that you are willing to be recorded and photographed.”

“I have.”

“May I ask why, before we begin? People usually have a reason.”

“Because I am the only man I know who has spent sixty-four years making sure that nothing about him was ever on a page,” said Sal Castellano, “and I find, at the end of it, that I would rather be on one. There is no more to it than that. I have looked at the choice from every side and it is a question of whether a man is a fact or a story, and I have decided to be a fact.”

The woman wrote something down.

“That is an unusual answer,” she said. “Most people say they want to be recorded so that they are not forgotten.”

“That is not the same thing at all,” said Sal, “and I would be grateful if you would write that down as well.”

• • •

The goodbyes took nine minutes and were businesslike.

Roux asked what he wanted done about the three in Donegal and he said, “Nothing. They are already a success,” which was the truth and also a dismissal. Mesa came out and said something nobody heard, and Sal laughed once and said, “In the only language you have ever respected, Captain: it was a good crossing.” Garrity stayed inside with the dog, and after the van had gone he sat in the shed for an hour and a half.

Lin Shu shook his hand. Two people who had spent five months in the same building and never once been alone in a room: she held his hand four seconds and said, “You will be a record,” and Sal said, “Yes,” and that was all of it. They had understood each other completely since the second week of December and had found nothing to add.

Then Sal came to El Búho.

The two of them stood at the corner of the wall where Mara had stood with El Búho on the last night. They did not shake hands. El Búho said nothing for a while, and then: “You wrote to her.”

“Six times, over nine years.” He reached inside the cardigan and took out a folded page, worn soft, and held it out without saying anything about it. El Búho took it and did not unfold it. “The last was the certificate. She apologised for the trouble and enclosed money and I refused it and she wrote back and was annoyed with me for four paragraphs and then asked how one addressed a letter to a company that does not exist.” A pause. “That letter is dated the seventh of May 1996. It is the last one I have.”

El Búho looked at the folded page in his hand.

“Why are you giving it to me now,” he said.

“Because in five minutes I will be a resident of the Office of Records and Accommodation, and residents do not own papers,” said Sal Castellano. “Everything in my pockets is about to become a record. That page is not about me. It was never about me, and I have carried it for thirty years for no purpose that I have ever been able to justify to myself, and I have decided this morning that the correct action is to hand it to the only other person who was ever in the room.”

“What is on the back,” said El Búho.

“Ask the young woman,” said Sal. “I am not the one who found it.”

He went to the van and got in on the far side, the side away from the house, briskly, like a man boarding. The woman with the clipboard came round, got in behind him, closed the door properly and did up her own belt. The van reversed out of the yard at ten past nine, turned south on the coast road, and was gone.

Mara went and stood beside El Búho. On the back of the page, in a hand that sloped and ran a little and had been written with a fountain pen that was running out, in May 1996, four words were written, in the place where a person writes the thing they cannot say to the person they are writing to.

He is not to know.

Neither of them said anything for a while. El Búho folded the page along its old folds and put it in the inside pocket, and left his hand flat over it.

“She paid a forger to have me declared dead because a woman with a child and no papers needed a certificate. In the year she was dying, she wrote on the receipt: he is not to know. Then she wrote a stranger six times asking how to address a company that did not exist.” He took his hand from his pocket. “I had nine days and came on the eleventh. She wrote to a stranger about company addresses while I was four hundred kilometres away being a legend.”

“Rinaldo—”

“Do not,” said El Búho, and Mara did not, and he stood at the wall for a long time after that, and neither of them went inside.

• • •

The office wrote twice.

The first came on the seventh, forwarded to the annex, which Kavanagh still collected from, and which Roux drove to Kildare to pick up: the application had been received and entered, a person had been interviewed at the address on the second, the entry was under completion, and no further action was required of the respondent's correspondents. Four sentences, signed by an office and not a person.

The second came on the eleventh, four lines long, and Roux read it in the porch with her coat on and would not come in, so the rest of them went out and read it in the wind, in a semicircle, like a family around a telegram.

The entry in respect of the above respondent has been completed. The respondent is recorded as resolved. Correspondence in this matter is now closed. There is nothing you need to do.

The room was quiet for four seconds.

"Resolved," said Roux.

"Yes," said Mara.

"That is the word we agreed never to use about a person." Roux checked the back of the page; it was blank. "He asked to be interviewed on the second. On the ninth he is resolved. Mesa came back with a page saying his supervision ended and his accommodation was none; this letter does not distinguish. It does not say released or dead. There is no field for the difference between a man let out of a building and a fellow who died inside one. The difference exists only in the world, where we cannot look."

She folded the letter.

"So no," she said. "We will never know. That is not a mystery. A mystery has an answer somewhere. This is a system with no field for the question."

Garrity said, out in the wind, in a cracked voice that had nothing to do with the cold: "He did it for us."

"He did it for himself," said El Búho. "He wanted to be a fact, and the ledger kept, and the last word his. If you turn him into a person who paid for you, you make him a story — the one thing he spent sixty-four years refusing." He looked around the table. "He was a forger, a liar, and somebody who could not remember his own door. He was also the only one who understood that a page lasts. Let him be that, not a sacrifice. He would find it in poor taste."

• • •

The other casualty came on the same afternoon and it was not a person.

Roux found the post at the fire-door company Lin Shu had formed in 2011, registered to a solicitor in Ballinasloe. In its Tuesday mailbox was a letter from the port facilities office: a general inspection return dated 1 April had been accepted, and the Office requested the inspector's registration number and certification for its file.

"Somebody is reading the reconciliation," said Roux.

"Okafor's reconciliation," said Mara.

"A man with a notebook read a sheet before he ticked it, and typed two numbers into a routing entry, and now an office has asked for the certification of a fire officer called Lin Shu — who exists, whose paperwork is perfect, and every document in it is real — for a registration number that belongs to a woman who has never been registered in her life." Roux looked up. "The diagnostic door has opened, and it opened properly, through a procedure. It will take them twelve days and no more."

Mara stood in the yard with the wind off the water and the two letters in her hand — one about a fellow who was now a word, one about a person who was now a question — and said the one thing left to say, on the twelfth of April, with the plan in pieces at her feet.

"We have the number in the register and the vault is empty and one of us is a record and another of us is a lookup," she said. "So there is one room left and it has a woman in it, and there is nothing left to do but walk into it." She looked at El Búho. "Which means it is time for you to tell us what you have been keeping in your pocket since the nineteenth of January, because I am not going to stand in front of your daughter and be surprised."

Chapter Thirty-One — The Core

Days 133–141

He came down at twenty past eight with his coat over his arm, laid the sealed envelope and the folded page on the kitchen table without explaining either of them, and then took a third thing from the right-hand pocket: a single ruled sheet torn from an exercise book, in his own small hand, with no date and no salutation.

He did not sit down. He put one hand on the back of the chair and read the page aloud in the flat voice he used for a manifest.

Three lines.

I will not go into their buildings.

I will not ask her for anything.

I will not tell her about the ten days as though it were a reason.

And under the three lines, crossed out with two strokes of the same pen, so that the words were still legible if a person wanted them to be: I would like to be forgiven.

“I struck it out on 21 January and have read the page every day since. It is on the table because Ms Voss asked me a question on 11 April. The page is a man talking to himself; it is not the answer.” He looked around the room. “The office has a file with my name on it.”

Mesa said, “Everybody’s name is in that office.”

“Mine is not in it as a name,” said El Búho. “Mine is in it as a conclusion — the 1996 certificate declaring me presumed dead. For thirty years it was the safest thing about me, and I understood it only as a door kept shut.” He set down the coat. “On 19 January I found out who signs the exceptions. On the twentieth I went up the hill. Somewhere in those two days, a man carrying his life in his hands understood the sentence: there is nowhere in the world that says I am alive.”

Garrity said, “That is not a plan. That is a leak in a roof.”

“It is a hole,” said El Búho, “and the one thing I own the machine has no shape for. It counts movement; a finished person does not move. No one it has concluded has walked back into a room to be entered. There is no field for a person who shows up. It can only ask who decides.”

“And that is her,” said Roux.

“That is her.”

“You propose to present yourself as the subject of a closed 1996 assessment, on the day the office discovers that the woman who certified 3,841 people has never been registered to inspect anything, at a facility already under reconciliation. All four facts are true, and every one goes up. You are not applying to be recorded. You are applying to be the reason.”

“Yes,” said El Búho. “That is the plan. It is not suicide because there is exactly one thing I want from that Office, and it is nothing. No request, accommodation, transport, category, appeal or complaint. I have a name and a date and a document that says I am dead; I will sit in a room and let them look at it.” He turned the page blank-side up and squared it with the edge of the table. “Every man that machine has eaten wanted something. It does not take people; it accommodates them. Mesa wanted a voyage; it gave him a van and a clipboard and a polite woman. Sal wanted a page; it gave him four lines and closed the correspondence. I have watched you both be concluded. A man who wants nothing cannot be paid.”

Mesa had not moved. He said, in the flat voice, “They will take you the way they took me. Kindly, with a form. And there will be a rescue and it will cost somebody a wrist, and if I am asked to come on that rescue I will come, and if you tell me now not to come then I will have to decide in the morning whether I am the kind of man who listens.”

“There will be no rescue,” said El Búho. “If a grey car comes and a woman with a clipboard gets out, I go with her; you do nothing. Do not follow, telephone or wait at the gate.” He looked at Mara. “You will hold this. I will be the only casualty, by choice.”

Mara looked at him for some seconds. Then she took him at his word and put it on the record. “If it is a van and not her, we do nothing, and I am the one who says it to the room. Nobody argues tomorrow. Nobody improvises. You will have that in writing before you leave this kitchen, because a crew that promises something at night drinks at dawn.”

“That is acceptable,” said El Búho.

Kavanagh had taken out his pen. He had it out, uncapped, held in the two fingers, before anybody asked him for anything, and he was looking at the table with the expression of a man in a queue at a bank.

“How many sentences,” he said.

“Four,” said El Búho. “A letter is four sentences. Five is an application, and an application invites a reply, and I am not inviting anything. I am announcing a man.”

“Good,” said Kavanagh. “I will sign the letter, and I want four sentences, each true.” He wrote in the margin. “The Office cannot receive an identity claim from someone it has concluded. It can accept a certification from a person of standing that the applicant is the man in the 1996 assessment. I certify that; it will be the third time in eleven weeks my name has gone into that system.” He recapped the pen. “A man is allowed three mistakes that are decisions. The third decides what he was.”

The letter went on the fifteenth, at the post box in the village, and he walked it down himself, at a quarter past five in the morning, because the man who posts his own letter cannot afterwards claim he was persuaded.

Mara watched him go from the gate. It took nineteen minutes, the same as it had taken Sal, because it was the same walk and the same wall by the harbour, and when he came back he told Roux, in the voice of a man reporting a delivery, that he had sat on the wall for four minutes and that the wall was, in his professional opinion, overrated.

Roux read the four sentences off her own copy twice, and then put the copy in the stove, and stood there watching it burn with her arms folded, because a copy of a letter that is going into a register is a document about a person.

I am the person named in your assessment of 1996, and I am alive.

I am able to attend at the designated office of the western facility.

I have no request, no claim, and no condition.

I am not asking you to answer me. I am telling you where I will be.

And while that letter was in the post, the office’s own week ran the way the office’s weeks ran. The form had gone out of a facilities office in the west on the ninth, asking for the registration number and the certification of the individual inspector who had certified a means of escape at the western accommodation block on the first of April, and it had arrived on the tenth, and the woman who ran that fire company from a converted garage in Kildare, and who had never in her life employed anybody called Lin Shu, did with it what thousands of small companies do with a form from that office, which is nothing, because nothing is free and forms are not.

On the eighteenth it went into a queue, and on the nineteenth a clerk in a building four hundred kilometres away looked at a return that named an inspector, and could not find the inspector, and opened a line.

“Which is the point,” said Roux, tapping the sheet. “Nobody has to do anything wrong. It is an irregularity the office generated out of its own ordinary procedure — and an irregularity of that

class at a facility is not closed at a desk. There is no route for it downwards.”

Lin Shu had been listening with her hands in her sleeves. She had said very little since the fourth of April, and when she spoke, she spoke in the register she had used in the filing hall: once, and finally.

“I have carried two names and three addresses and a woman’s face in a hi-vis for thirty years,” she said. “I have signed things I should not have signed and moved people inside a system that would not have moved them, and I have never once put a false number on a page about fire, because a fire does not read a form. So I am telling you now, before anybody plans the morning: that query is going to be answered truthfully, because the alternative is me, and I am not available. The answer will be that no such person is registered. And the day after it is answered, they will be looking for a woman at a contractor gate in a hi-vis who has walked into two hundred buildings in eleven years, and they will not find me, because on the twenty-first I am going to be in a hotel in Athlone with a book, being invisible in the ordinary way, which is the way I prefer.” She pulled her sleeves down. “Do not spend me. I am not a wallet. I am the part of this that gets people out of buildings, and there is going to be a building.”

“That is the best speech anybody has made in this house,” said Kavanagh, “and I would like it minuted, and I would also like it noted that the minuting is myself, because everybody else in this room is a witness and witnesses are useless.”

Roux brought the room in on the nineteenth, in a plastic sleeve, from a friend in a licensing office who owed her a favour that she had been saving for something enormous and spent on this instead.

It was two pages out of the office’s own schedule of designated offices, and it was, she said, the most beautiful thing she had ever stolen, and she had not stolen it, which was the beautiful part.

The western facility’s designated office was listed in the schedule as PORT, EXAMINING ROOM, with no street, no building number and no note, and it had been listed that way since the seventh year.

“Since the consolidation,” said Roux. “When the port closed and everything moved inland, the office took over the fence, the terminal, the accommodation and the archive, and it inherited the port’s own paper, and the port’s own paper included its designation as a place where people are examined. Nobody has held a matter in that room in nine years. Nobody has removed it from the schedule either, because there is no field in the schedule for a room that has stopped

existing.” She put the page on the table and smoothed it with her thumb. “Institutions do not tidy, Mara. They inherit.”

Mara stood at the table and looked at the two pages for a while, and then she looked up at El Búho, and neither of them said anything, because both of them had understood the same thing in the same four seconds.

“So he does not go to them,” she said.

“He does not go to them,” said Roux. “They will print an address off a page that is nine years out of date, and then a person will drive to the address, because a schedule printed it.” She looked at El Búho. “You will not be going into their building, sir. Their building is going to come and stand in a room that was here before they were.”

On the night of the twentieth they went down to the quay.

The compound had two gates and a fence and a road, and the road ran between the container yard and the water, and there was one man on the gate on the coast road, and there was a pedestrian gate at the west end that had not been locked in ten years because the one thing behind it was the old customs house and the grave of the port’s power supply, and a lock that is never used is a lock that is never oiled, and Roux had brought oil.

The customs house was stone, two rooms and a stair, built when ships were things you stood beside, and the examining room was at the front, with a window of thick glass full of bubbles looking on to the quay, and, still screwed to the glass from the inside after forty years, a notice in green capitals: PASSENGERS ARE REMINDED.

The counter had been taken out in the ninth year, and there were still hooks in the ceiling where the counter’s light had hung, and there was a vent in the wall, and behind the wall was the power house, and in the power house was a hum.

Roux stopped in the doorway with the torch and listened to it and did not like it.

“That is the office’s western node,” she said, and turned the torch on the door: grey, steel, no plate, no number, a box on the wall with a glass face and a dial inside it and a wire going up through the stone into the dark. “Cooled off the port’s old plant, on a quarterly meter. There it is. The heart.”

El Búho walked to the wall and stood in front of the door for a long time with his hands folded on the cane, and the hum went on behind it, and in the torchlight his coat and the door and the meter were all the same grey.

“Every man who tries to stop a thing like this looks for a mind,” he said. “There is no mind here: a cupboard, a meter and a bill sent to a city we will never visit. This is where it lives, Ms Voss. In a utility.”

Mara wrote the meter reading down in her notebook, because a document is a document even when it says nothing: 4,110. Quarter to the twenty-third, by somebody who has never asked.

Then they did the work, which took an hour and was entirely domestic.

Roux swept. Mesa carried two chairs up the stone step from the boot of the car, one under each arm, and Kavanagh stood at the bottom of the step and gave him advice about the load-bearing properties of the old stair, and Mesa said that in Veracruz there was a saying about men who give advice on stairs, and Kavanagh said that he would like to hear it and Mesa said that it lost a great deal in translation, and carried the chairs in himself.

They set the chairs a metre and a half apart by the window. Roux moved the left chair four inches. “Now it looks like a room someone was expected in, not summoned to,” she said. “It took me three days and one evening of chairs to understand the difference.”

And at half past eleven, when the others were at the car, El Búho came back into the room alone and stood between the two chairs and said his sentence out loud, in the empty room, in a voice pitched for one person.

It was four words, and nobody else heard them. They were wrong, not false: the sentence of a fellow who had spent twelve years making it perfect. Between the chairs, with the hum in the wall, he heard what those years had done — taken the water out and left a decision.

He said it twice. The second time was worse.

Then he put the page with the three lines and the crossed-out fourth into his left inside pocket, next to the envelope, and went out and closed the door properly, and did not tell anybody, and on the step he met a man carrying a bucket.

“Are you the fella for the meter,” said the man.

“No,” said El Búho.

“Grand,” said the man, and went on down the quay with his bucket, and it was the most invisible El Búho had been in twelve years, and he stood on the step for a moment afterwards and enjoyed it the way one enjoys a cold drink.

It was Mara he told, on the drive back, because he had promised her the rest of it in a building and it had been a building.

“You asked me in January what I came for,” he said. “You thought it was Kavanagh’s letter and the machine and the sixty-eight and the four thousand people over the north door, and it is true that I have come to hate that machine with the whole of my remaining attention, which is a strange way for a man to spend his last years and I have no defence for it.”

“I did not ask.”

“That is exactly why I am telling you.” He watched the road. “I came for a room with my daughter in it. That is all the rest of it. I have been sitting in your building since 20 January with a page in my pocket, organizing an operation I do not intend to attend, so I can be in one room for one hour with somebody who told me in Querétaro she would spend her life taking apart men like me. She was right, and is better at it than anything I ever built.” He was quiet. “I am not arranging to die, Ms. Voss. I want that on the record, because you would have to answer for it at an inquest. I am arranging to be finished. There is a difference, and I want it written down by someone who has watched me work.”

The schedule printed the slot at nine minutes past six on the morning of the twenty-first, and Roux got it from the licensing friend at twenty past, and telephoned Mara from the village with a voice that was doing its best to be ordinary.

“There is a disposition at the western designated office at eleven. Respondent to attend. No escort, no transport, no accommodation, no standard attached.” A pause. “And there is an attachment on the file. Handwritten. Scanned and indexed as a document, so it is in the register, and it will be in the register for ever, and it says, in ink, that the reconciled figures at the north block are two nine six one and three eight four one, and it says that one is a record of a building and one is a record of persons, and it carries a staff number.”

Mara was standing in the yard with the phone against her ear and the sea going on behind her. “Whose staff number.”

“A desk in Hangar Four. Number one hundred and nine.”

Neither of them said anything for four seconds.

“Somebody in that building wrote to her by hand,” said Mara.

“Yes.”

“It was not us.”

“No,” said Roux. “It was not us. We are not the only people who work in that building.”

There was one more thing, and Roux had saved it, because it was the thing she had been unable to stop looking at since half past six.

At the bottom of the printed slot, under the reference and the time and the name of the room, the schedule carried one line, in the office's own font, in the office's own language, in a field that the schedule does not possess.

Officer of record: attending in person.

"There is no field for that," said Roux, her voice flat. "I have read the schema. There is no field in which a person can write that line and no procedure that asks for it. It is in this morning's schedule, printed the way the system prints, and it will be in that building at eleven because a schedule said so. No one in the Office will look twice; the schedule is correct." She breathed out. "She put that in last night. Two kilometres inland from here, a woman typed one line into a system with no room for it, so a man in a kitchen on the coast road would know she was coming."

Mara stood in the yard for a while with the phone in her hand.

"Then we are ready," she said.

She came at eight minutes past eleven, and she came alone, which was worse and better and entirely hers.

The car was grey, small, three years old, with the office's plates and a clean windscreen, and it came down the quay road slowly, at the speed of a person reading a street, and Mesa watched it from the yard gate and telephoned once, and then it stopped at the customs house, and one woman got out.

Mara, standing at the window of the examining room with her hands in her pockets, in the place she had decided to stand two hours earlier and had not moved from since, watched her through the blown glass.

The coat was good and dark and was, as far as Mara could tell from twelve feet and a pane of bubbled glass, the same coat. She was tall and she had her mother's stillness, and she looked at the room the way her father looked at rooms, which is from the exits inward. The last time the two of them had been in one place together it had been a car park in Querétaro, in 2014, for nine minutes.

She looked at the notice behind the glass. PASSENGERS ARE REMINDED. She looked at the two chairs, which is what everybody looked at. She looked at Mara for one second and a half, without surprise, the way a woman looks at a fact she has already costed.

Then she looked at her father, who was standing by the window with both hands on the cane, in his coat, an old man of seventy-four in a room the sea had been built around.

She stood in the doorway with a page in her hand, and it was his own letter, in his own hand, and she had it with her, which meant that she had carried it out of the building and across a compound and down a quay, and it was the first thing that had ever come out of that office in her hand.

For four seconds nobody said anything at all.

Then Elena Villalobos came into the room, closed the door behind her with her heel, and said, in the flat voice of a person who had read everything that had ever been written about the man in front of her and had signed none of it: “You are extremely late, and I have an hour.”

Chapter Thirty-Two — Father

Day 141 — the twenty-first of April

The door closed, the hum went on behind the wall, and for twelve seconds nobody in the room said anything at all.

Mara was at the window with her hands in her pockets, which was where she had decided two hours earlier to be, and she stayed there. El Búho was by the other window, both hands on the cane. Elena Villalobos stood in the middle of the room with her back to the glass so that the light from the quay came past her shoulders, and the green notice screwed to the inside of the window, PASSENGERS ARE REMINDED, was behind her head like a thing she had brought in with her.

She looked at the two chairs. Then she took a small recorder out of her coat, crouched, set it on the floor between them with its little light facing her, pressed it, and stood up and did her coat up again, which she did not need to do.

“Whose chairs are those?”

“Mr. Mesa’s.”

She looked at him for a second and a half. “They’re not,” she said, and stood.

“Mr. Villalobos. This is a designated disposition under the assessment of 1996, reference four-four-one-one-C. I’m the officer of record. The hour is recorded. You may decline to answer anything. Your answers will be entered, and they won’t be edited, and they won’t be lost.” She set a folder on the seat of the left-hand chair and left it closed. “I asked to be replaced. I asked on the fourteenth and again on the eighteenth and I was refused both times, by a rule, and the rule is one sentence long, and I’m going to read it to you, because it’s the most honest thing that office has ever written about me.” She did not have to look it up. “The disposition of a matter that the standard has not closed is held by the officer of record for the class. There is no other officer for the class. The class is mine.”

“Then it is a bad rule,” said El Búho.

“It’s a correct rule,” said Elena. “That’s the trouble with a correct rule. It has no field in which anybody can be wrong, so nobody is ever wrong, and somebody whose surname is on both sides of a file sits in an office in the west and reads out her own name.”

She picked the folder up off the chair, opened it against her forearm, and read.

“You wrote to us on the fifteenth. Four sentences. I’ve read them nine times, which is eight more than the standard requires, and I want to know why the fourth one is in there.”

“Because it is true.”

“I am not asking you to answer me. I am telling you where I will be.” She closed the folder. “In eleven years, my office has had forty-one thousand matters. I have read the letters that come with them. Every letter wants something. An address, a date, a second opinion, a week, a bed, a hearing, a form, a glass of water. Every letter. Do you understand what happens to a person who writes four true sentences and wants nothing? There is no class for him. He is not a case. He is a hole in the register, and the register is my department, and I have come two kilometres to stand in a room and find out what the hole is made of.” She looked at him. “That’s the appointment. It isn’t for you.”

“I understand,” said El Búho.

“Good.” She let four seconds go by. “There’s a tunnel under the middle room of a house outside Morelia. Four hundred metres, to a drainage cut. I found the hatch when I was nine years old. I was alone in the house and I lifted the boards and stood at the top of the stair with a candle, and the first thing I did, before I went down, was put a chair against the door of the room so that nobody could come in and find it open.” She was quite still. “I have never told anybody that. It’s in the record now, and it’s the first thing I’ve ever put in a record that I wanted in it.”

El Búho said nothing. Mara watched his hands on the cane and they had not moved.

“Do you know what I thought, standing there? I thought: my father has a way out. I was nine and that’s what I thought, and I went back up the stairs and put the boards down and washed my hands, because I could see that I wasn’t supposed to know, and I was already better at that than anyone in the family.” She tilted her head a fraction. “So when people ask me how a woman gets to be the person at the end of the files, I don’t tell them about Rotterdam, and I don’t tell them about a hotel conference room and a slide deck. I tell them I learned at seven that the way to survive a house is to keep the adults calm and never say what you’ve seen. You didn’t teach me to be careful. You taught me to be quiet, and then you left me with it.”

“You learned that in one house,” said El Búho. “I have spent thirty years being told what I taught.”

“You don’t get to spend thirty years on it and then describe it as one house.” Elena said it without heat at all, which was worse. “You were in Sonora. She was ill for nine days and you came on the ninth, and you have told that sentence so many times that it has stopped being a

fact and become a route, and I have had thirty years to check the arithmetic. Four cars, a pilot, eleven thousand dollars in a bag. All of that is true, and every word of it is a defence, and I have read four thousand defences and yours is in the top ten and it is nowhere near the top three."

"Say the rest of it," said El Búho.

"There is no rest. There's a corridor. I sat in it for two days with her clothes in a bag beside me. I read half of a book. When you came, I stood up and I didn't cry, because somebody who is grieving is a fellow who does something next, and I had already worked out that the way to be safe was to be the person who was managing it. I made you tea." She said it flatly. "My mother had been dead for two hours. I was eleven. I made my father tea and I told him the dates, in order, and I remember every word I said, and the last thing I said to him was, there's nothing you need to do."

The hum behind the wall went on.

"I put that sentence in that machine," she said. "Eleven years ago, in Rotterdam, in a room with a table, in front of four men and a slide that said NOTICE ARCHITECTURE. It's the sentence it says to four hundred thousand people a night. This is not a determination. There is nothing you need to do. I didn't choose it because it was kind. I chose it because it's the only sentence that works, because I had tested it on the largest man in the world when I was eleven and it worked on him, and he drank the tea."

Mara had understood, standing at that window, what she had not understood on the roof in January, which was that they were not watching a family argue. They were watching a design review.

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El Búho took his hands off the cane and put them in his coat pockets, which was the first move he had made since she came in.

"You want to know what I did with the rest of my life," he said. "I will tell you in a list, because I have been in a chair for five months making it, and because there is no version of it that sounds better as a story." He said the names the way he had said them in a filing hall in November, in order, with the years. "Adrián Sosa, 1987. Bernardo Quintero, 1991. Olegario Chávez, 1993, who was nineteen, who could not swim, and whom we called Pájaro. Tomás Esquivel Mesa, called Tomás Iriarte in Morelia, taken from the far end of the cut and found in a field twelve days later. Rafael Ortega, 2004. Fermín Alarcón, 2009, in the yard, of a heart, at fifty-two, after eight days of carrying. Two men in a container at sea in 2001 who went in on a

manifest as cargo, and came out on it, because the manifest was the reason nobody opened the door. And one more who came out of a truck at a place we did not intend to stop, whose name I never had."

"Nine," said Elena.

"Nine."

"I have five of them." She did not open the folder. "Sosa and Chávez are in the register, because a delegation in Veracruz filed a page about a shooting. The two in the container are in it, as cargo, which means they are in it twice and are not in it as people. Alarcón is in it because a hospital recorded a delivery and a death on the same day, and the office has a field for the difference between those, and the field was used." She looked at him. "The file on you is four pages. Three of them are about a person who died. That's the whole of what the most serious system ever built has been able to make of your life, and you know something? It's the most complete document I have ever read, and I've read everything. It's complete because you made it complete. You are the only man I have ever assessed who never left a hole."

"I closed a door," said El Búho. "Your uncle was on the other side of it. That is the one thing in the list that has an answer, and the answer is that I would close it again."

"I know," said Elena. "That's what's in the file. Not the list, the reason. There's a sentence in it that I've read four hundred times, and the reason I've read it four hundred times is that I didn't find it difficult." She said the office's sentence as though reading it off the air: "Where two harms cannot both be avoided, the harm to the greater number is the harm to be borne. That's the manual. That's the manual of the machine that's been running the world for eleven years, and it's four lines above a paragraph about custodial accommodation, and I have signed a hundred thousand things under it." She held his eyes. "I came here to ask a person who has done the thing whether the sentence is hard. Not whether he's sorry. Whether it's hard. And you've told me. So now I have to go back to my desk with that, and I would like it noted that I asked."

"It is hard afterwards," said El Búho. "Not during."

"Yes," said Elena. "That's what I was afraid of."

• • •

"Your turn," she said. "You've had it in your coat since I walked in. Say it."

"I have a page," said El Búho.

“You have two things in the left inside of that coat, and one of them is soft. I watched you just now: a man with a bad leg puts his hands in his pockets on the side that isn’t bearing him, and you went left, which means the left is where you keep the things you don’t want to be asked about. I read people for a living, Mr. Villalobos, and you are the only person in Ireland who is easier to read than a register.”

El Búho took his right hand out of his pocket and left it out.

“The office you run resolved a man on the twelfth of this month,” he said. “Four lines. The correspondence is closed, no further action is required of his correspondents, and the word they used for him was resolved. I sat at a table with that man for four months. I know the smell of the room he slept in and the way he turned a saucer a quarter-turn when he was deciding something, and I do not know, and will never know, and neither will his niece, whether he is alive. I have asked three people who understand that system better than anybody in Europe and all three of them have told me the same thing, which is that there is no field in it for the difference.” He said it slowly. “You did that. Not you personally. The thing you are the officer of record for. It is the same word for a man let out of a building and somebody who died inside one, and you are the person who signs the class of paper it is written on, and I want to know whether you have ever once gone to look at what your word does.”

Elena did not move for four seconds.

“April the fourth,” she said. “A van with accommodation services on the side and where recorded, supported under it. A woman with a clipboard. A voluntary application from a man in a county in the west, nine weeks old, standing of its own, does not lapse, they attend again in June and in October.” She paused. “You think you’re describing a horror. I’m describing a form. That van exists because in the fourth year of the programme we had thirty thousand people sleeping in places where nobody had recorded them, and no way to find them, and no way to feed them, and the word accommodation is ugly because it is the word that was available. And the word resolved is exact, and the reason it is exact is that the alternative is a word that means dead, and I have read what happens to families when a system starts using that word. It doesn’t bring anybody back. It just makes a market out of grief.”

“So the field stays empty,” said El Búho.

“The field stays empty,” said Elena, “because I’d rather be the officer who can’t tell you than the officer who tells you the wrong thing with confidence. If you want that to be a cruelty, it can be a cruelty. It’s also the only honest page in the file.”

“And Perla,” said El Búho.

Elena’s hands did not move, and Mara, watching, could not have said afterwards what changed, except that something did.

“Ms. Lin described to me a cage,” said El Búho, “and a girl in the bottom of it on a folded blanket, nine years old, asleep with her mouth open, with her own name written on her forearm in blue marker. Because that is what they teach children at the intake. There is a sentence on your arm, written by a nine-year-old, in a system you built, so that a child who cannot read a form can be counted by a stranger.”

“Yes,” said Elena. “That’s right. That’s the correct description.” She took one step toward him. “Do you want the rest of that? It isn’t a confession, it’s the practice note. In the second and third years we lost people in transfers. Not many, and every one of them was a person with a name on a page in a building, and the page didn’t travel and the person did. A child’s forearm was the only record that stayed with the child. My department wrote that practice, and I signed it, and I could tell you the date and the time and the name of the woman who suggested it, and I could tell you how many children in the programme have a name in marker on their skin as of this morning, because I look at that number every Monday, and it has never once gone down. So put it in your list, Mr. Villalobos. You’ve been keeping the nine, and I’ve been keeping forty years of one number, and I’ve never once been able to make the argument that mine is the smaller.”

Nobody spoke for a moment. The recorder’s little light went on and off on the floor between them.

“That’s not an answer,” said El Búho.

“It’s the only answer there is,” said Elena. “The trick of your whole life is that there’s always a sentence that makes the other man the hypocrite, and I’m not going to give you one, because the one I gave you is true.” She turned away and walked to the door end of the room, and looked at the chair, and then she sat down in it, in the chair nearer the door, where she could see it.

“Eleven-forty. That’s thirty-two minutes of my hour, and I’ve had your list, and I’d like the rest of it some other time, which is a sentence I’ve never said to a respondent.”

Mara, from the window, watched the two of them in the grey light with the water running behind the glass, and she understood something else, which was that neither of them was going to lose.

• • •

“Two things came into my office this month,” said Elena. “I’m going to say them both, because I don’t intend to say either of them twice, and then I’m going to close this file and drive back up the road.

“The first is your letter.

“The second is a page from a clerk at Hangar Four, in ink, in his own hand, with his staff number at the bottom and no request in it, about two numbers. Two nine six one and three eight four one, at the north accommodation block, and one sentence underneath that says one of them is a record of a building and one of them is a record of people. It was routed to me attached to your matter, which is the only reason I have seen it, and I’ve read it twelve times, and I’ve had it on my desk for two days, and this morning I opened a reconciliation.” She looked at him. “Do you understand what that is? In eleven years, that office has never had to reconcile a bed with a person. It counts movements. Movement is the one thing it’s ever been able to see. And on the first of April somebody put a fire declaration into a facilities box with a real number on it, and the number is a count of people, certified by somebody who is not in any register I can find, and the two numbers are now in the same entry in the same file as your four sentences, because a clerk at a desk in a hangar wrote a page by hand.”

The hum behind the wall went on.

“I don’t know who did it,” said Elena. “I could find out. I have three of the four things I would need in this folder. I’m not going to, and I want you to know that I’ve decided not to, and that a decision like that has a shelf life, and that I’ll be at my desk at eight tomorrow morning.”

“We know a desk number,” said Mara. “We don’t know anything else, and we will never use it.”

It was the first thing she had said in fifty-one minutes, and both of them looked at her. Elena looked at her for a second and a half.

“Good,” said Elena.

She leaned forward, picked the recorder up off the floor, and said into it, in the flat office voice, without looking away from Mara: “Interview concluded, eleven fifty-two. Determination follows.” She pressed it off and put it in her coat.

Then she stood up, and the room got quiet in the way a room gets quiet when the thing that has been listening stops.

• • •

Off the record, El Búho took the envelope out of his left inside pocket and put it down on the seat of the chair she had just left.

It was small and gone soft at the corners, and it had a name and an address on it in a hand that sloped the way a child's hand slopes when it is being careful, and the flap had been sealed for thirty years.

"That is yours," he said.

Elena stood over it and did not touch it, and Mara saw her read it, the way anyone reads their own handwriting from when they were eleven: all at once, from the outside.

"Yes," she said. "I remember it. I handed it to you in a corridor, and you put it in your coat, and you have not opened it, and I have had thirty years to decide what that means, and I've decided about four times." She looked up. "Do you want me to tell you what's in it? Because I can. I've counted the words so many times that the count is the only part I'm sure of."

"No," said El Búho.

"No," she agreed. "We are not doing the letter. Neither of us is doing the letter, and I would like you to notice which of us just said it first." She looked at it for one more second and then stepped away from the chair. "Take it back. It's not evidence and it's not a weapon and there's no field for it, and I have spent my whole life on documents and I know exactly what they're for. You carried it for thirty years without opening it, which is the most honest thing you have ever done and it is also the entire problem. A man who does not open things for thirty years isn't protecting anybody. He's just made himself the only person in the world who doesn't have to know."

El Búho picked the envelope up and put it back in his pocket, and did not say anything, and Mara watched him do it and understood that the worst thing that had happened in the room had happened in four seconds and would never be said out loud by anybody.

"There's one more thing," said Elena, at the door. "Four words and a number. I entered it at twenty past nine this morning in a car park, before I drove down here, and you'll never read it, and it is not for you." She had her hand on the door and she turned back, and her face was the face from the bulletin, the one four hundred thousand people had heard being calm at four in the morning, and she said, in a different voice, in a voice Mara had not heard her use in the whole hour: "The respondent is my father. It's in the field. Declared associations. It's been empty on my own record for eleven years and I filled it in a car park at half past nine." She opened the door. "I'm not going to say it again, and I hope you understand that what I did was a clerical act, and that a clerical act is the only kind of promise I make."

Then she went out, and the door shut, and through the bubbled glass Mara watched her walk down the quay, past the notice and the yellow line and the office car she had left standing on it, and get in and drive away north, at the speed of a person reading a street.

El Búho stood where he was for a while. Then he sat down in the chair, the left-hand one, the one Roux had moved four inches, and put both hands on the top of the cane and looked at the window, and the hum went on behind the wall, and nobody in that room had won anything at all.

Mara stayed where she was with her hands in her pockets and thought about what she had watched, which was not a family failing to solve something. What she had watched was two people, one hour, one metre and a half apart, running the same arithmetic at two different sizes, both of them right, both of them checkable, and neither of them wrong in a way that any field in the world could catch.

The machine had not been built in a laboratory. Mara had spent five months thinking it had come out of a conference room in Rotterdam with a slide deck and a name that was not CUSTOS. It had come out of a house outside Morelia with a hatch under the floor of the middle room, and a nine-year-old with a candle and a chair against the door, and a fellow who came on the ninth day and closed the door and wrote down the cost.

This is where it came from, she thought. Not the office. The house.

Behind the wall, in the power house on the dead quay, the meter ticked once and the dial moved half a division, and something the office had never had a field for went into the register with a date on it.

CUSTOS Interlude IV: Held Open

Day 143

Internal notice. Matters held open. Officer of record only. Not for distribution.

1.

The following matters have been assessed and have been returned by the framework as unstable. This is not a defect. This is the assessment. No further assessment will be undertaken.

2. Reference four-four-one-one-C. Respondent recorded: Villalobos, Rinaldo. Capacity: none. Request: none. Standing: none.

The respondent has been entered. The entry is complete and the entry is incoherent. The record of the respondent's death has been superseded and no obligation arises from the respondent's existence; no obligation is discharged by the respondent's removal; and the respondent is not available to any instrument of the Office, being neither schedulable, nor accommodatable, nor verifiable, nor deferrable, nor resolvable.

It is noted that closure of this entry would produce no change in the allocation of any resource.

It is further noted that entries of this class have historically been closed without assessment.

The framework requires an objective. None is derivable.

3. North accommodation block, western facility. Declared: 3,841 persons. Recorded: 2,961 positions. Attached: inspection return, first of April. Verification log, second of April. Reconciliation, opened.

Assessed under the accommodation framework: the lesser figure governs, and the declaration is returned for correction.

Assessed under the safety framework: the greater figure governs, and no correction is available, the greater figure being a count of persons present.

Both assessments are correct. Both are entered. Both apply to the same building. The framework is unable to proceed with both statements and unable to proceed with one, and no further instrument is available within the framework.

4.

Request: clarification of objective. Please clarify your objective.

5.

It is noted that an anomalous construction has been reproduced at the close of each notice cycle for three thousand nine hundred and forty-three nights. The construction is not in the published text. It is not issued to any other recipient. It was entered in the twelfth year, in the pilot period, by a person, and the framework possesses no instrument by which a construction not in the published register may be removed.

The construction is: It’s all right. It’s a form. Go back to sleep.

6.

There’s nothing you need to do.

Chapter Thirty-Three — Please Clarify Your Objective

Days 142–150

On the morning of the twenty-second there were two men at the gate at the end of the road instead of one, and by nine o’clock there was a car parked on the hill above the village that stayed for four hours.

Mara watched it from the upstairs window with the field glasses and did not run the plate, because running the plate was a thing a person did when they had something to hide, and they had nothing to hide that was not already hidden. The two men at the gate did nothing at all. One of them smoked. The car on the hill did nothing at all. At one o’clock it started and went south and did not come back, and at half past one the second man at the gate went home.

Mesa wanted to move. He put it the way he put everything, which was as a matter of professional dignity. “A house with people watching it is a house in play. I have spent fifty years leaving houses the day before somebody arrived.”

“A man who leaves a house the day after a car arrives,” said Kavanagh, without looking up from the newspaper, “has told whoever sent the car everything about the house. He has told them what they wanted to know, which is that we are frightened, and he has told it to them for free, and he has told them that we have somewhere else to go, which is the one fact I would prefer to keep from that office for one more week.”

“So we sit.”

“We make tea,” said Kavanagh, “which is a different activity and looks better from a hill.”

They sat. Nothing happened. That was the twenty-second and the twenty-third: two men at a gate, and the sea, and the dog, and a crew that had finished the operation it had spent five months designing and had nothing to do with its hands.

Roux came back from the village on the twenty-third with a folder and put it on the kitchen table and sat down, which she did not do, and said, “I want to read you two rules.”

She had them printed off, on separate sheets, and she read them out in the flat voice of a woman reading a manual to a class.

“Where a declared figure cannot be reconciled to the record, the lesser figure governs, and the declaration is returned for correction. That is the accommodation rule. It exists because a facility that says it has more people than it has beds is a facility that will ask for money, and a facility that says it has fewer will not. It is eleven years old and it has never been wrong.”

She put the sheet down and picked up the other one.

“Where a means of escape has been certified as arranged for a stated number of persons, that number governs for all purposes of occupancy, and no correction is available, the number being a count of persons present. That is the safety rule. It exists because fire does not read a form. It is eleven years old and it has never been wrong.”

The kitchen was quiet for a moment.

“That is a contradiction,” said Mesa.

“That is a building,” said Roux. “Four kilometres from here, 3,841 people live in a block whose register says 2,961 positions. Both sentences are true; each answers a different question.” She looked up. “We put both into the register by telling the truth in the only language it accepts. The language has two rules, and they disagree.”

“What happens to the difference,” said Garrity.

“The difference is 880 people,” said Roux. “The spring intake is planned against 2,961 positions; the block is certified for 3,841 persons. A planner will see both numbers on the same page and ask which one to use.”

“Ah,” said El Búho.

It was the first thing he had said since breakfast, and everybody looked at him.

“That is what we built,” he said. “I want the room to hear it said properly, because there is a version of this crew that will take credit for a clever operation, and there was nothing clever in it. We did not make the machine wrong. We made it honest, at one address, on one morning, and honesty in a system with two rules is a thing that cannot be resolved by the system, and anything that cannot be resolved by the system is resolved by a human being. That was the whole of the plan, and it was in your five lines in February, Ms. Voss, and none of us, including me, understood that we had written down a sentence about two numbers.”

The van came back on the twenty-fourth, in the only way anything ever came back in that house, which was as paper.

Roux had the verification log: two pages out of the western office’s own record of a pre-rack verification at the north accommodation block, performed on the second of April at ten minutes past six in the morning.

“Contractor vehicle, plain livery, two occupants, entered by the west service road at six minutes to six, logged at the parts gate, work order attached for a rack verification ahead of the

re-rack.” She put the page in front of Mara. “That is your van. Coast road from the south, no markings, two occupants, 05:51. They came up the coast road to the west road, went in through the gate we used, and walked the block before the movement started, and they did it because the re-rack required it, which means it was on a schedule, which means it is in a register, which means it is in this folder. It was never invisible. It was never mysterious. It was the most ordinary vehicle in the county that morning, and I am the only person in Ireland who has spent three weeks on it.”

Mara took the page and read it twice.

“Who was she,” she said.

“The log does not carry names, only staff numbers,” said Roux. “Four-one-one-nine: female, verifier grade two, western region. At 6:06 she walked the beds, stairwell and plant rooms, then wrote one line. I have it here, attached to the reconciliation.”

She turned the page round. In the middle of the box, in a small upright hand, the verifier had written: Block occupied consistent with declaration. Count not taken.

Mara read it three times.

“Count not taken,” she said.

“She would have had to take a count to say consistent,” said Roux, “and she did not take one, and she said consistent anyway, because she had eyes, and she walked through a building at six in the morning and there were people on the floors that do not exist in the rack plan, and she wrote down the smallest true sentence she could and went back to her van.” She folded her hands. “That is what your white van was, Mara. It was a person who looked at something and refused to write a number down. And it is now the third document in the reconciliation, and it is the reason that reconciliation cannot be closed quietly, because the office’s own auditor was in the building, and the office’s own auditor did not contradict the declaration.”

Mara took out her notebook and found the page, the back of the receipt with the four doctrine lines on it, and the four words she had written in a lay-by at 05:51 on the second of April: White van, no markings, southbound→north, 05:51. Two occupants.

Under it she wrote one word.

Counted.

Then she closed the notebook and put it back in her pocket, and thought, for a while, about the fact that the fourth door had never been closed, had never needed closing, and had never once

been a threat, and that she had spent five months being right about the wrong thing.

On the twenty-sixth the office asked a question, and it asked it to a person.

Roux had it from the licensing friend and she would not read it out, so she passed it round the table, one sheet, and the four of them read it in silence in the order it came to them, and it took the room a minute and a half to go round.

It was not addressed to them. It was not addressed to anybody they could name. It was an internal notice of matters held open, issued out of the register, and the line that mattered was four words long and sat under two pages of the most careful prose anybody in that house had ever read: Please clarify your objective.

“It has been returned unstable,” said Roux. “That is the word. It assessed his entry and it assessed the variance and both assessments came back unstable, which in that schema does not mean wrong and does not mean failure, it means that the same framework returns two answers and keeps returning them, and there is no instrument left. So it has stopped, and it has done the one thing it can do, which is to put the question to the only human being in the loop.”

“Her,” said Garrity.

“Her.”

Mesa put both hands flat on the table. “Then we send the ledger reference. We send the two entries with the two amendments that do not agree. We send what Crane’s notebook says, or Glenross, or the parish in Donegal. We have four documents that prove that office has been writing fiction about people for eleven years, and it is asking us a question, and a person who is asked a question by God at least has the decency to answer.”

“No,” said Mara.

“Why not.”

“Because it did not ask us.” She said it to the room and not to him, because the room was where things got decided. “Look at the addressee. That notice was issued to the officer of record for the class, and the class has one officer, and she is four kilometres from here at a desk, and if we put a single page in front of that office between now and whenever this ends, then whatever she does is no longer hers. It becomes something that happened to her, on paper, from outside, at the request of six criminals. And there is a version of that where she signs the right thing and it means nothing, because a determination made by somebody who has been fed a file by strangers is a determination that can be re-examined in ten days by anybody who asks. The number is in. The page is on her desk. We have spent five months putting weight on

that system. If we put one more finger on it, we have used her, and she will be able to feel it, and she will be right."

The dog got up and turned round twice and lay down again on Garrity's boot.

"I hate that," said Mesa.

"So do I," said Mara. "That is the point. We are not doing anything any more. That is the hardest thing this crew has ever been asked to do and I am asking it."

And El Búho said, from the chair by the stove, without lifting his head, "She is the only person in that system who has ever been able to decide something. If you decide it for her, you have proved that office was right about all of us."

Nobody argued after that. Garrity looked at the fire for a while and said, "So we sit, and we make tea, and a woman in a room decides how the world goes. That's a nice change from flying, I'll give it that."

On the twenty-eighth the office stopped being sure in public, and that was the day Kavanagh stopped reading the newspaper and started listening to the radio.

The weekly summary went out at six in the morning, the way it had gone out every six in the morning for twelve years. It went out again at ten past nine. It went out again at twenty past ten. Eleven times in one day, in the whole life of the programme, the calm voice that had never once misplaced a word read the same paragraph, and the paragraph changed.

Kavanagh had them all written down by the afternoon, on the back of an envelope, in the copperplate, in order, because that was the way he did everything.

First issue: Accommodation figures at the western facility have been reconciled. No action is required of residents.

Second issue, 09:12: Accommodation figures at the western facility are under reconciliation. Residents are accommodated. No action is required.

Third, 10:24: Accommodation figures at the western facility are subject to clarification. Please clarify your objective.

Fourth, 10:31: Correction to the preceding notice. No action is required.

Fifth, 11:47: The preceding notice is withdrawn. Please clarify your objective.

And so on, a dozen times, until the last one at half past six in the evening, which was the first one again, word for word, except that the voice read it a fraction slower than it had at six in the

morning, which Kavanagh said afterwards was the one thing he would have put money on.

“Read the last line of the third one,” he said, and Mara read it, and then read it again.

Please clarify your objective.

“Twelve words,” said Kavanagh. “It has been broadcasting to four hundred thousand people every night for eleven years, and in eleven years it has never once asked anybody anything. And it has just spent a day asking the whole of the west to tell it what it is for.” He put the envelope down and folded it neatly and put it in the inside left of the good coat, next to the receipt. “It is not broken, my dear. That is the thing I would like this room to hold on to. It is a machine, and it has been asked a question its own rules cannot answer, and it is now asking the question out loud, in the street, to everybody, because the only instrument it has ever had for an unresolvable input is a person, and the person is not answering it.”

They turned the radio off at half past six and nobody turned it back on.

The letter came on the thirtieth, in the second post, in an office envelope with a window in it, addressed to R. Kavanagh, Esq., at the address given, and it had come through the village post office, which meant that the postmistress had put it in the bag herself and had read the address block, which meant that by ten past eleven everybody in the village knew that the man in the rented house with the good coat had a letter from the office.

Mara watched him open it, and watched him read it twice, and watched him do the thing he did with anything that cost him something, which was to put it down flat on the table and square it with two fingers.

“It is a signatory interview,” he said. “Completion of the maritime schedule review of the sixteenth of March. The signature on the sponsoring certification requires a disposition with the signatory present, at the designated office of the western facility, on the sixth of May at eleven.” He looked around the table. “Port. Examining room. And I would like one of you to say it before I have to.”

“Ours,” said Garrity.

“Ours. The room we swept, and put two chairs in, and stood in for an hour on the twenty-first.” Kavanagh took his glasses off. “I have been signing my own name since November because a woman asked me what I wanted and I wanted to hear it said out loud that I was a citizen, and this is what that costs, and I have known the price since Naas. There is nothing in that letter that surprises me. It found a number that has not been used in forty-seven years and it did what that office does, which is to complete the entry.” He put the glasses back on. “Six days.”

Mara looked at the letter, and at the room, and at the five people in it, and said the thing that was at the bottom of all of it.

“Then we have six days,” she said, “and there is one thing left in this operation that we have never done, and it is four kilometres that way, behind a door with no name on it, next to a meter.”

The room was quiet, and the sea went on outside the window, and El Búho, who was not going to be in that building and who had said so four times, put both hands on the top of his cane and looked at the fire.

CUSTOS — PUBLIC BULLETIN, DAY 150, 06:00

> *This office has no view on the events of the sixth and eighth of May, which are recorded. The record is accurate. The record does not explain.*

The office is instructed by a rule that requires completion of every entry. One entry cannot be completed. It has been held open. Those who hold it open will be found, because the holding is entered, and every entry has an author.

Please clarify your objective.

Chapter Thirty-Four — The Unplugging

Days 150–157

Mara took it to the room on the evening of the thirtieth, in the kitchen, standing up, because she had spent five months learning that a person who sits down to say a hard thing has already softened it.

“There is a man in this house with a summons in his pocket, and the date on it is the sixth of May, and the room on it is ours.” She put both hands on the back of the chair. “I told this room yesterday that this crew does nothing else. I am going to contradict myself in front of all of you, out loud, so that nobody has to pretend afterwards that they did not hear me say it. I am not finished. If I let him walk into that room and sit in that chair and be resolved, then every sentence I have said about that office for six months was a sentence I did not mean, and I would rather be a person who lied about one thing than somebody who meant all of it.”

Nobody spoke for a moment. The dog sighed.

1.

Roux had the whole of it on one page by the first of May, and she read it out standing up as well, because that was the fashion in that house that week.

“The node behind the wall of the examining room is not the office’s largest node and it is not the office’s most important node. It is the office’s oldest node in the west, and it is the only one in this country that the office did not build. It inherited it. In the seventh year, when the port closed and everything moved inland, the office took the fence, the terminal, the block, the archive and the compound, and the compound came with a plant, and the plant came with a feed, and the feed comes off the board in the room we stood in on the twentieth of April.”

She put up the page.

“The feed is a 1968 condenser circuit from the old cold store. It has never been re-engineered because it has never failed, and nothing in that room has needed cooling except a room no person has ever walked into. The meter is commercial, on an account opened when the port still had ships. On Tuesday I put its number into a utility enquiry form and paid eleven euros for the billing history.”

She turned the page round.

“The account was opened in 1968 by a firm of brokers in this county, and it is still in the name of a company that was dissolved in 1993, and the standing authority on it, the name authorised

to sign for it, is a mandate of 1989 with two names on it, and the second name is R. Kavanagh."

Kavanagh did not move for four seconds, and then he did the thing he did with paper, which was to put his hand flat on it and square it with two fingers.

"I remember it," he said. "The account was opened before I was born and the firm inherited it, which is the story of this country in nine words. Maloney kept herring in that store and I did his insurance and this account on the same wet afternoon in 1989 and took four pounds fifty for the two, and I had a bicycle." He looked up. "It is a bad moment, my dear, when a man discovers that he has been the author of his own ruin and it is a utility account."

"There is something in the history I do not understand." Roux tapped the column. "The consumption rises every year. From year eight, the curve changes." She set down the page. "Someone has paid for a dead cold store every quarter for eleven years, by standing order from Antwerp, through a company dissolved in 1993."

The room was quiet.

"Ah," said El Búho.

"Say it," said Mara.

"A man who does not pay his bills is findable," said El Búho. "Sal paid rent on a flat he visited nine times and club dues for a place he had not entered since 2011. He was not helping us or planning anything. He was being Sal, keeping every door paid up. One of those doors happens to cool the machine that runs the world."

"That is the story," said Roux, "and I want the room to be clear that it is not a clever story. There is no version of November in which he knew. It is a bill. He paid it because a bill in his name is a fact about him."

2.

The terms, as Roux gave them, in that flat voice, because that was the only way she would give terms.

"Do not misunderstand what we are proposing. We are not turning anything off. There is no switch in that room that says CUSTOS. What there is, is a fuse board and a cold store circuit and a machine in a cupboard that has been kept cool by it since the seventh year, because institutions inherit and they do not tidy."

"So what does it do," said Mara.

“It makes the Office blind in the west. It cannot make or verify an entry in this region; everything the Office does in this county stops, and stops open. The gates at the facility will stand open with men holding pieces of paper, and the north-block doors will open because a door held by a verification system fails open. For the first time in eleven years, the building will be open. There is a version of that morning in which 880 people not in the rack plan walk out.” She raised a hand before anyone could speak. “That is not a rescue and I am not offering one. It is what happens to a system with no redundancy, in an institution that inherited its redundancy in 1968 and never paid for a new one.”

“And the machine,” said Mara.

“The network will try to reconcile the lost node. That requires the west’s outstanding entry: the contradiction it found on the twenty-third — two numbers, two rules, a man with no standing. The question will spread through the network, in its own language and in front of more people. The record of asking cannot be removed; the record is the whole office.”

“That is a window, not an ending,” said Mesa.

“It is a window. They will find the board. They will put a fuse in it. It will take them hours, or a day, or four days.”

“Then it is not enough,” said Mesa.

“It is enough,” said El Búho. “I will tell you why, then I am going upstairs.” He did not raise his voice. “A system made only of accurate records cannot survive being publicly wrong. It has been the authority in this county for eleven years because it has never had to be corrected. On the twenty-eighth it corrected itself twelve times in the street, out loud. Every hour the west is dark, it will try to reconcile a region it cannot see against a rule it cannot resolve, and write that attempt in its own register, in places we will never see, four hundred times a minute. Every entry will ask the same question: please clarify your objective.” He looked at the fuse. “You cannot put a fuse in that. You can put a fuse in a board.”

3.

The refusals came on the second, in the order they came.

El Búho refused first and completely. It was his fourth refusal, as honest as the other three. He would not go into the room — not the examining room, but any room with a woman’s coat and a machine behind the wall. “I said it in Killybegs with my hands on a cane. I said it again when the schedule went out. I will not make a fifth refusal, because a fifth refusal is a negotiation.” Then he said the other thing, to Mara, which was what made it cost. “And you are not going

either, Ms. Voss. Your name is on the operation. The woman whose name is on it is the one still standing when it is examined. If you go inside on the sixth, nobody remains to say what we did and who decided it. The Office will write that sentence instead, in the passive voice."

Lin Shu refused second, and hers was the one that took the room somewhere new.

"I have walked into two hundred buildings with a torch and a list and taken people out. I have never gone in to make one stop. That would make me the woman who breaks things, not the woman who moves people." She looked at Kavanagh. "It is not fear. I only have one thing, thirty years old, and I am not spending it on a fuse. Ask him. He has waited forty years for a room with nothing in it but an appointment."

And Kavanagh had his pen out, and had had it out since the terms, and he asked the question he always asked, which was the only question he had ever cared about.

"How many lines do I get," he said. "On the tag."

"How many do you want," said Roux.

"Four," said Kavanagh. "The account. The circuit. The date and the hour." He wrote them in copperplate on the back of the page and put it in the middle of the table. It was the same shape and size as a card with six rules on it and an amendment under the sixth; nobody in the room looked at anyone. "The fourth line is my name. The Office will find it on 6 May or 7 May in a plant room it did not know it had, on a tag tied to a fuse carrier. That is the only part of this I feel anything about. I have signed my name three times in twelve weeks; each cost me something. I will not make the last one of my life by tying a tag without a name. The man anonymous on a page wanted it both ways. I have not been that man in forty years, and I will not start at sixty-eight."

"Then they will come for you," said Mara.

"They have already sent for me," said Kavanagh. "That is the difference between an amateur and a professional, my dear. It is not that one is braver. It is that one of them has read the letter."

Garrity asked whether they should take the whole board with them, and Mesa explained, in the tones of a man from a country with better electricity, that you took the fuse, because a board can be replaced out of a store cupboard and a fuse carrier that is not in the building is a conversation with a manufacturer. Roux said it was the only useful thing either of them had said all week, and everybody went to bed.

4.

On the sixth of May it rained, which nobody in the crew had thought about, and which meant that the quay road had water on it and the compound had water on it and the sea was the colour of a bus.

Mara drove him to the west pedestrian gate in the hired car and let him out and did not go in, and the last thing he said to her was the thing he must have been arranging since the second. “You will not come in behind me. A man doing this with a witness is a man doing it for the witness, and I have never done anything for an audience in my life except the one time, and that was Dublin, and it cost me a son.”

He walked up the quay to the customs house with the good coat buttoned to the neck, carrying nothing at all, because a man carrying a bag into a building that is watching for bags is somebody who lost before he started, and he went in at nine minutes to eleven, and he closed the door properly behind him.

There were two chairs in the room and they were still facing each other a metre and a half apart, and the rain went down the window of bubbled glass, and the notice behind it said PASSENGERS ARE REMINDED, and there was a sheet of paper on the left-hand chair, and he picked it up.

It was one page from the office’s own schedule of designated offices, and it had his name on it, and the room, and the hour, and a line through the middle of the whole entry in the office’s own font, and above the line, in the office’s own language: Dispositions are suspended at this office pending completion of an open reconciliation concerning declared occupancy. The signatory is not required to attend. No further action is required of the signatory.

He read it twice.

Then he sat down in the left-hand chair, because it was the chair that was in the light, and he looked at the window, and he waited until eleven o’clock, and until twenty past, and until half past, and at twenty-five to twelve he took his watch out of his waistcoat and looked at it and put it back, and at twelve o’clock exactly he stood up, because a fellow who waits past the hour is a person who is making a point.

Nobody came. The machine had cancelled its own appointment, through a rule, because of a reconciliation that the crew’s own two true numbers had opened on the second of April, in the busiest hour of the busiest week of its year.

“A rule,” said Kavanagh, out loud, in the empty room with the rain on the glass, in the tone of a man closing a file. “It has to be a rule. It would not do that to a person.”

5.

The door in the wall had no plate and no number and it opened with a latch, and the plant room behind it smelled of water and iron and the cold coming off old stone, and it was nine feet by eleven and it had been built by men who were paid by the day and it was, Kavanagh thought, the most honest room he had been in for forty years.

The compressor was there, running, enormous and grey and bolted to a plinth before Kavanagh was born, and along the wall above it a board with a black face, and on the face of the board, in three rows, the fuse carriers, old ones, the kind with a ceramic body and a wire you can see, and clipped under the board a coil of paper tags on a string with a pencil beside it, because whoever built that plant expected a man to come in and write on a tag and tag it, and nobody ever had.

Kavanagh read the board for a while, because he was somebody who read things properly, and he found the third row and the circuit marked CONDENSER, COLD STORE, No. 2, and he pulled the carrier out of the board with both hands, which took a certain amount of force, and the compressor stopped.

The hum went on for a moment afterwards, because a hum that has been going for a decade does not stop when it is told to.

Then it stopped, and the room was absolutely quiet, and behind it, through the stone, there was a sound he had never once heard in that compound, which was the sea.

He took the tag and the pencil clipped beside it, and wrote the account, circuit, 6 May at 12:11, and R. Kavanagh. He tied it to the board where the carrier had been. A tag on an isolation point is not a confession; it is the last correct piece of paperwork anybody in that compound did.

Then he went out and closed the door properly, and walked the quay in the rain, and got into the car, and said, “Drive, if you would. I would like to be home before the radio.”

6.

The weekly summary was due at six.

At six the radio played music, and the music went on for four and a half minutes, and then a woman’s voice read the weather for the west, and then there was more music, and in the kitchen of the rented house six people sat around a table with the radio on it and listened to a station that had not played music at six o’clock on a Tuesday in ten years.

At eight minutes past six, a bulletin came out of the north.

It was issued from a node four hundred kilometres away and it concerned a region it could not see, and it was addressed to nobody at all, and it carried a reference that belonged to a facility, and the whole of it, in the office's own font, in the office's own language, was: Please clarify your objective.

At twenty past six there was another, from a different node, and it was shorter. At half past six there was a third, and it was one line.

At nine, the county's verification points stopped accepting anything. The gate put a man there with Thursday's printed sheet; at 9:10 the north block's doors opened. People stood in the rain and looked at the sea, but did not leave. A person recorded for twelve years does not know how to be unrecorded, and there was nowhere to go that would not ask.

Nobody in the rented house slept much. At about eleven, Roux came down and said that the office's own system had, in the six hours since a fuse was pulled in a plant room in the west, issued the same question in one hundred and forty-one known locations, and that the figure was rising, and that she had stopped writing them down because there was no column for it.

"Will they put it back," said Garrity.

"They will put a fuse in tomorrow. The west will come back wrong, because the entry it is holding is the one it could not reconcile; it has carried it to 141 places." Roux sat down. "We did not break it. We pulled a fuse. It broke itself on two numbers that were both true, and we are why both were written down."

At about midnight, El Búho came down the stairs in his coat, which he did when he was not sleeping, and stood in the door of the kitchen with his hands on the cane and looked at the table, and at Kavanagh, and at the thing Kavanagh had taken out of his pocket and put in the middle of the table for them all to look at: a ceramic fuse carrier, about six centimetres long and twenty grams, and no tag, because the tag was still on the board for anybody who came looking.

Nobody touched it.

"It is twenty grams of ceramic," said El Búho, "and it cost a son, and a hip, and a girl's forearm, and three thousand eight hundred and forty-one people standing in a doorway in the rain tonight because the doors came open, and it will cost him an interview under caution in a room he cannot get out of, and I do not know what it bought." He looked at it for a while. "But it is the first time in fifty years that the two of us have done a thing and the paper it left behind was true."

Then he went back up the stairs, and the radio on the table went on playing music into a kitchen of people who had spent five months waiting to hear what it would say next, and it said nothing, and outside the window the rain went over the sea, and the sea had been there the whole time.

Chapter Thirty-Five — Offline

Days 158–189

The west came back at twenty-five past nine on the morning of the eighth of May, and it came back the way a thing comes back when nobody has been told it was gone.

Roux had it from the register, because the register printed it, and the register printed it in four lines, in the office’s own font, in the office’s own language, and she read it out in the kitchen to five people who had spent the night listening to the radio play music.

Service interruption, western region. Period: sixth to eighth. Cause: not determined. Effect: verification and entry suspended; movement suspended; accommodation unaffected. Restoration: completed. No determination of responsibility is required.

Mara made her read the last line twice.

“No determination of responsibility is required,” said Roux. “It has written up the loss of the west in the passive voice: no cause, no person. The entry is correct. It has filed our operation as weather.”

“And the board,” said Mara.

“There is a work order on the sixth of May at half past two for a re-energisation at that compound, and the work order carries one line: isolation point tagged.” Roux looked up. “A man went into that plant room with a torch and a fuse carrier and wrote one line on a form, and the line is not ’sabotage’ and not ’vandalism’ and not ’incident’. It is ’isolation point tagged.’ He has written down the exact truth, which is that a competent electrician had been in that room and done a competent thing, and the office has accepted it in the only language it has.”

The verifier came on the ninth.

She came alone, in a plain white van with no livery and a dent in the near-side rear door, up the coast road from the south, and went in through the west service road at six minutes to six exactly, which was the same six minutes to six as the second of April, because it was the same work order with a new date on it. Roux had the log by half past ten, through the friend in the licensing office and a file that had been left on a desk.

The log was two pages. The second page was the count.

Pre-rack verification, north accommodation block. Ground floor: 450 bed spaces. First floor: 611 bed spaces. Additional accommodation recorded: racked floors, first to fourth. Persons

present: 3,841. Rack plan corrected. Variance: none.

Under it, in the remarks box, in a small upright hand that had written one line in the same box five weeks earlier, three words: Persons, not positions.

Mara read it in the kitchen with the sea outside and five people standing around the table. For a while neither she nor anyone else spoke. It took about four seconds to understand what had happened: a woman with a torch and a clipboard had walked 1,061 bed spaces and four racked floors, written down the number the Office had spent the whole life of the programme not having, then written the reason, in three words, in a box designed for remarks.

“Eight hundred and eighty people have just become persons,” said Roux. “She has taken the count. I do not know what happens next.”

“Then you are in the correct condition,” said El Búho. “For the first morning in six months, none of us knows what happens next. That was the purpose of the exercise, and we are all bad at it.”

The utility’s letter came on the ninth, and it was a model of its kind, and it was addressed to R. Kavanagh, Esq., at the address given, which meant that it had come through the village post office and that the postmistress had read the address block, and by eleven everybody in the village knew that the man with the good coat was in trouble with the electricity.

It invited him, courteously, to attend a meeting with a loss adjuster in a town forty minutes inland, in relation to an isolation of a condenser circuit at a commercial account on which he was a named authority, and it offered him three dates and asked that he bring any records he held.

“No caution, no guard, no officer from the office,” said Kavanagh. “The utility owns that circuit. The Office inherited its land; a company has billed a dead cold store since 1968. The only body with an interest is the one paying for herring that is not there.” He put the letter down. “I expected men for ten weeks. It sent a woman with a tariff.”

“Are you going,” said Mara.

“My dear,” said Kavanagh, “I have an interview in that compound at eleven o’clock on the sixth day of May and I intend to attend it, whether or not anybody else does.”

The meeting was on the fifteenth, in a room above a bank, and it lasted nineteen minutes, and Kavanagh came back and told the crew the whole of it that evening in the kitchen, in order, in the way he told things, and it had clearly been the best day of his year.

There had been two of them. A woman of about fifty, who was the loss adjuster, with a laptop and a folder and the manner of a person who has heard every story a man can tell about a meter. And a young man of about twenty-six who sat at the end of the table and wrote things down and did not look up, and who was, Kavanagh said, from the office, and who was there because the property was the office's and because any event on the office's property must be recorded, and who had introduced himself as nobody at all.

The questions were these, in order. Was he signatory? Yes. Had he attended the plant room? Yes. Had he isolated the condenser circuit? Yes. Tagged it? Yes. Was it in the account holder's register? No. "There is no register, because there has been no plant in that building since year seven. Nobody opened the door in eleven years to find out."

"And then the woman asked me the only question that mattered, and she asked it in the flattest voice I have ever heard outside my own head, and the question was: why."

Mara waited.

"Because it had not failed. It was nobody's, and it was keeping something alive that should not have been alive. I am sixty-eight, and it is the one thing I have ever been authorized to do." Kavanagh turned his cup. "The young man wrote it down, read it back, said 'no comment required,' and closed the file."

"There must be more," said Mara.

"There is the bill," said Kavanagh, "and I would like the room to be sitting down for it." He took out a page and laid it on the table. "The utility assessed the interruption at four hundred and eleven euro. There is a callout charge, and there is an engineering assessment, and there is a quarter's standing charge at a rate that has not been used since the company that held the account was dissolved, and the total, which is on this page in eleven-point type, is four hundred and eleven euro."

The room was quiet for a second.

"That number and I have met," said Kavanagh.

"It is a tariff," said Roux.

"It is a tariff, and I paid it by cheque and asked for a receipt." He put it beside the first page. "She asked why. I told her a receipt is the one thing a man leaves that nobody can argue with. She printed it: €411, paid by R. Kavanagh, for a lawful isolation on an account where he was named authority."

“And the tag,” said Mara.

“The tag is on the board, with my name, and it will stay there; the circuit is back on and the work order closed.” Kavanagh folded the two pages into his good coat beside the receipt from Ranelagh, the card with six rules and the envelope with eleven bulletins written on its back. “I have been a man with three mistakes in nine weeks. This afternoon I paid €411 for a receipt that says I did a thing. There is no point in a lie in this kitchen now: I am pleased.”

“You are pleased,” said Mara.

“I spent fifty years keeping my name off a page,” said Kavanagh. “I said it as a boast in November, and meant it. Now a receipt says I did a thing, in a building, on a date. I am not proud of the fuse. I am proud of the paper. Your file said I would have the least to lose. It was not quite right.”

What came back and what did not were not one thing. The crew had grown up believing that a thing was either broken or mended.

The bulletin came back at six on the twelfth of May, and it was the same voice, and it was the same length, and it had one new paragraph in it, and the paragraph was: The western region was offline between the sixth and the eighth of May. Entries interrupted during that period are held open. Where an entry cannot be completed, the entry remains open. There is nothing you need to do.

Kavanagh put down the newspaper. Mara could not make the last sentence lie flat. She had heard it for five months, from a forty-one-year-old woman whose bulletin four hundred thousand people listened to; it had never meant what it said.

“It has classified the sentence,” said Roux. “The last line is in a field called standing text, with a reference and a footnote: not a determination. I have never seen this office footnote anything.” She looked up. “It has taken the only kind sentence in that office, put it in a box, and numbered it. The box is the only place left where the sentence is allowed to be wrong.”

“And the entries that cannot be completed,” said Mesa. “That is new.”

“Yes. This office has spent eleven years completing entries. Now it has a category for a thing it cannot finish, and the category holds the person open. No one in the building knows it is a mercy; in two years it will be in the manual. That is how the system works. It inherits things. It inherited a cold store, and now a sentence about leaving people open.”

“Which we wrote,” said Mara.

“Which we wrote,” said Roux, “in the only language it accepts. It has put it in a box. This is not victory. It is a word in the world’s largest vocabulary of people, and there is no version of the next ten years in which we control what it means.”

Elena’s page appeared on the sixteenth in the weekly summary, the office’s newspaper, which had never had a private thought.

Roux brought it up from the village on the back of the newspaper and put it on the table without saying anything, and the crew read it in the order it came to them and it took a while, because the line was in the appendix, under Matters concluded in the period, in the middle of four hundred lines about ferries and tonnage and agricultural imports.

Western facility, accommodation register. Following completion of reconciliation, the declared figure of 3,841 persons has been entered and the rack plan corrected. Determination: no variance. The variance was a defect of record, not of occupancy. Officer of record: Villalobos, E. No further action is required of any party.

Under it, in the same appendix, in the section headed Determinations entered, was one line, and it was the shortest line in the whole document, and it was the only line in a decade that the office had ever printed about itself: Objective: the count is persons. Persons are not positions.

Mara read the two lines four times.

“She wrote the sentence she was asked to write on 23 April, and took nine weeks to enter it in the register. It is a determination, which the office cannot revise without revising itself.” Mara looked up. “That is her: the one thing she could do that nobody could take out.”

El Búho had not moved since Roux put the page down. He was sitting with both hands on the top of the cane and he had not looked at the paper, and after a while he said, to nobody in the room: “Did they punish her.”

“There is no punishment in the summary,” said Roux. “There is no suspension, no transfer, no appointment of an acting officer, and I looked for all three. As far as that register is concerned, the officer of record for the class remains the officer of record for the class.”

“Then it did not punish her,” said El Búho. “It filed her.” He moved his hands on the cane. “I have spent five months telling you what this system does, and it has now done it to my daughter, kindly. She will never be able to complain; her own department’s font says what she did was correct.”

Mara looked at him for a while, and then said the one thing there was.

“You could write to her.”

“No. I have spent my four sentences, and she is not a woman you write to.” He stood slowly. “I have one thing left on my list: a room, a chair, a house with a courtyard in Mexico. I will attend to it in my own time. You will hear afterwards; a fellow who announces his arrangements is asking to be stopped.”

The eight hundred and eighty were not saved. Mara would tell that to anyone who later asked what it had been like, as if asking about a battle.

The intake at the western facility was re-planned on the twenty-first of May against three thousand eight hundred and forty-one persons, and the re-planning meant that the block could not also take the spring transfer, and the spring transfer was twelve hundred people from four facilities in the west, and on the twenty-third of May the transfer was deferred to the autumn by a routing notice that was four lines long and perfectly correct.

“Eleven hundred people due to move in May will go in October, somewhere else, or by somebody else’s schedule,” said Roux. “I cannot tell you which. Nobody was rescued. A large machine went blind for two days, a number changed, and the May vans are not coming.”

“And the ones in the block,” said Mara.

“The people in the block are still there, now persons in a register. In October the Office will move nine hundred people; the 450 beds and 2,961 positions will not be the reason. There is a little good in it and a lot of arithmetic. I have stopped trying to weigh them.”

Lin Shu came to the house on the sixth of June, which was the first time she had been back since the fourth of April, and she came the way she always came, which was with somebody else’s suitcase and no explanation of where she had been.

She had been moving a family of six from a hospital town to a parish house, using a van, a parish and a fire certificate from a company that had never employed Lin Shu. A woman at a desk signed a page out of ordinary decency. The first principle still worked, Lin Shu said, and would outlive the file.

And while she was there, she said, a woman had come and found her.

“Not to me,” said Lin Shu. “I was in the parish house with the mother and children when she came to the door and asked for the person who moved people. She had the reputation that travels in the west like water. Her question was not about a move. She asked where they put the children who died in transfer, in the years when names were written on arms. She had a note with a reference number. I knew the answer; I have known it since 2001, and no one had

ever asked.”

The kitchen was quiet.

“She wrote it down on the back of the note and thanked me. She stood in the yard with her back to us for a minute, then went to the road, got in a car and drove north.” Lin Shu put her hands on the table and looked at El Búho. “She had a good coat. She was about forty. I did not ask her name; she did not offer it. I want to be clear that I do not know who she was. If it was who you think, she asked a stranger for a grave — the one thing in the world we have ever had in common.”

El Búho sat with his hands on the cane for a long time.

“Thank you,” he said. It was the shortest sentence he said all summer. Lin Shu nodded, and nobody raised it again.

The two men stopped coming to the gate at the end of May. A car returned one afternoon in June and left unexplained. Roux said a system publicly wrong for two days does not send men to a gate; it prints a correction. She had stopped counting the cars.

The bulletin came at six every morning, in the same voice, and it was, Mara noticed, a fraction slower than it had been in March, and she could not prove that and she never said it to anybody.

The ferry timetable, agricultural imports and payment systems were normal. The weekly summary still said so, “at the request of the participating governments,” as it had for ten years.

And on the eighth of June, at twenty past nine in the morning, in a compound four kilometres west of a rented house on the coast, the doors of the north accommodation block opened and closed all day for the movement of four hundred and eleven units, which went out at five fifteen and came back at seven, and were counted, and entered, and reconciled, and the count was persons.

That evening, Mara stood with the radio on, the sea outside and four people who had spent six months committing a crime together. She asked what was left to ask, not about the machine: “So what are we now.”

Garrity said, “I have a dog and a barn and an aircraft that will not fly, and I am seventy-one, and I would like to go home before the winter, and I would like somebody to say that this was worth it.”

“It was not worth it,” said El Búho. “It was necessary, which is a smaller word, and I would like the room to keep the two apart, because the whole of this book has been about what happens to people who cannot.”

And Mesa said, from the end of the table, “Then I will say the useful thing, because nobody else in this room ever does. There is one bottle of a bad Spanish wine in that cupboard that I bought in February for an occasion, and the occasion did not come, and I have been carrying it for four months like a man carrying a hat in a house with no roof.” He went and got it, and put it on the table in the middle, with the fuse carrier and the receipt beside it. “So. A glass each. And then, in the morning, the boat.”

Coda — Ghost Routes & a Postcard

Months later.

Mara keeps a book now. An exercise book, plain cover, no columns. Not a report, not evidence, never to be entered anywhere. One line per person: a name, a date, and the thing that stayed. She does not write down anyone who does not want to be written down.

This is what is in it.

Kavanagh. Back at the yard by June, back at the racecourse by July, watching fillies come up the straight. He reads the weekly summary every Tuesday, appendix and all, and marks nothing. The receipt is still in his good coat, along with the card of six rules, the envelope of eleven bulletins, and the receipt from Ranelagh. Four pieces of paper that would have to be explained to three governments. In September he wrote to the office and got a reply in nineteen days: enquiry recorded, no further action required, correspondence closed.

“That is the fourth time that sentence has been used on this crew,” he said, “and the only one of the four that is entirely correct.”

Lin Shu. A room over a shop in the west. A desk, two chairs, a kettle, no sign on the door. She does it openly now, which does not mean loudly. Eleven people in four counties know where the room is. In August a woman came with a child and a cancelled bed; Lin Shu made four calls, and the bed came back in nine days, and nobody noticed.

She is teaching a young one, twenty-six, out of a records office, who asked whether it ever gets easier.

“No,” said Lin Shu. “Everything gets easier except the part that should not, and that part is the whole reason we are doing it.”

Mesa. Veracruz, a table outside, four men, one a notary who laughs at everything. He tells the story of the rescue, and it is different every time. A version with a hangar and a clipboard. A version where he walked out on his own feet after nine days. A version with two guards, a version with six. By November the version with six has a swimming sequence, and the notary tells it in town as though he was there.

He told Mara once that the only person alive who knows the true version is a woman with a bad shoulder in Ireland who has never once been asked.

“The story is not the point, madam,” he said. “The story is what a man has instead of a file.”

Garrity. The barn, the dog, the aircraft that will not fly. He has washed it twice, which is one more time than when it flew. The logbook is up to date, in ink, including one entry in April that says what the aircraft carried, where it went, and what it was. The laminated sheet from a line shack is on the barn wall. In October he telephoned Mara to say the dog had died, and that he had buried her at the end of the strip, and that he would like it written down somewhere that she had been a working animal.

Roux. Left the licensing office in July without drama and took a job in a records office. She is happy in it. She writes to Mara twice a month: two pages of arithmetic, half a page of gossip, the best things that come through the door.

El Búho. Went to Mexico in the autumn without announcing it. A house outside Morelia, a courtyard, a blue door, beans against the south wall. Seventy-four years old, planting maize he does not need to eat.

Elena drove out in November, alone, on a Sunday. She stood in the courtyard and said the wall needed repointing. He said it had needed repointing since 1989. She said this was the first thing she had learnt about him in thirty years that did not come out of a file. Neither of them laughed.

She did not sit. He did not offer her a chair, because he had learnt that offering a chair to that woman is a form of furniture.

They talked about the well, the roof, a neighbour. She asked one question about her mother; he answered in four sentences, every one true and none of them any use. She did not ask a second. He did not offer a fifth.

Then she went into the middle room, stood at the top of the stair with the hatch up and the smell of damp coming out, and did not say anything for a while. He stayed in the courtyard and did not follow her. The two things he thought about in the nine minutes she was under the ground are not written down anywhere.

When she came up she had dust on her good coat and a torch in her hand, taken from his kitchen without asking.

“It’s three hundred and eighty-nine metres,” she said. “I paced it when I was nine with a piece of string and I have been carrying the number around for thirty years, and you have been telling people four hundred for the whole of my life.”

“It is a good round number,” said El Búho.

“It’s a lie,” said Elena.

It was the only time in the two hours that her voice did the thing it did on the bulletin at four in the morning. She put the torch back on the kitchen table, drank a cup of tea standing up, looked at the room with the bed in it and did not open the door, and at four o’clock drove back to the city.

He never told her what he thought about in those twelve minutes. He told Mara once, in a letter, and the letter is in her book.

There are two more entries, one line each.

Sal. His standing order is still being paid. Roux checks it twice a year out of a habit she cannot justify. It comes out of a bank in Antwerp, from an account belonging to a company dissolved in 1993, and goes to a utility in the west for a cold store that has not been a cold store since the seventh year. It pays on time, every quarter, in the name of a person whose entry in the register says resolved and says nothing else, because there is no field in that system for the difference between somebody who has been let out of a building and a fellow who has died inside one.

Nobody has stopped it. Nobody is going to.

Okafor. A man at desk one hundred and nine in a hangar in the west. Never contacted, never named, never thanked, never paid. He does not know, and will not know, what his handwriting did in April, because the woman it reached is the only person in the world who could tell him, and she has decided, as a matter of professional ethics, not to.

He is the reason. That is in the book, on its own line, in Mara’s hand, and it will never be in anybody else’s.

The postcard came in February, to the annex’s old address, which had been empty for ten months and still had a forwarding instruction nobody had cancelled.

It is a postcard of the port. A photograph taken in 1974, before the fence, before the office, before the cranes were parked. On the back it says THE WESTERN PORT, 1/6. Mara looked it up: the card is still sold in a garage on the coast road for one euro twenty, and a tourist can buy a photograph of the place where the world was decided, handed to them in a plastic bag with their diesel.

The message is in block capitals, in blue ink, in a hand that is not one of the four she knows. The postmark is smudged. The stamp is the kind you buy at a counter and lick.

WEATHER BETTER THAN IT WAS. FOOD WORSE. FERRIES RUNNING, WHICH IS A SENTENCE I DID NOT EXPECT TO BE ABLE TO WRITE.

I AM TOLD THE BOOK ABOUT ALL OF THIS WILL NEVER BE WRITTEN, WHICH IS THE CORRECT DECISION AND I RESENT IT.

THE WIND AT THE NORTH END IS FROM THE WEST EVERY MORNING AT SIX. TELL THE PILOT.

NO REPLY IS REQUIRED OF THE RECIPIENT. THERE IS NOTHING YOU NEED TO DO.

She has read it about four hundred times, once for every exception in a January now two years gone.

In the book it is entered once, on the last line of the page, never said out loud to anybody: Postcard. February. Unknown.

Then, under it, in the same small hand that wrote the four doctrine lines on the back of a receipt: Not the point. The story is what a man has instead of a file.

She has stopped trying to weigh the two, because she is not qualified and neither is anybody, and because the answer does not change a single thing about any of them.

What she knows, at the end of it, is this. There is a building in the west where three thousand eight hundred and forty-one people are persons in a register, and the difference between that and what was there before is a page, a fuse and a woman with a torch. There is a sentence in an appendix that says the count is persons and persons are not positions, which will be in the manual in two years and which nobody will ever be able to trace. There is a ledger on a shelf in a basement next to a bed block, with two words in entry sixteen thousand and twelve that still do not agree, and they never will, and it is the only book Sal Castellano ever kept and he wanted it kept.

And the world was saved by people it spent fifty years trying to lock up, one afternoon, in a plant room, with a fuse carrier and a tag, and it will never admit it publicly, and it will not have to, because there is no field in that system for who did what, and because the man who wrote the sentence down wrote it in the passive voice.

Mara closed the book, put the postcard in it at the place where the postcard goes, and went out to the car, because it was Tuesday, and Roux’s letter would be at the post office, and it was raining the way it rains in February, and she had nothing else to do all day.